An Unbroken Promise

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/29169432.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Catra & Scorpia (She-Ra), Adora & Scorpia (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Horde Adora (She-Ra), Slow Burn, Friends to Lovers, so much fluff for a Horde fic, Sharing a Bed, For Want of a Nail, Alternate Universe - Adora Remains with the Horde (She-Ra), Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Alternate Universe - Everyone Lives/Nobody Dies, Longing, Fluff, Eventual Smut, every cannon divergence you never knew you wanted

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by pencilxpaper

Summary

Adora has just been promoted to force captain. Before her, there is only the future she was always told she wanted. With her best friend by her side, she wonders if her perfect future is all that it was promised to be.

--
A Horde Adora AU where Adora stays, and she and Catra have to figure themselves out while the war is going on around them.

Notes

I wanted to write something fun, and try my hand at a slow burn.

Cuddle Guide (If all you want to read is the "good" parts):
Chapter 1 Past the middle, “A moment later, the door opened...”
Chapter 2 Third scene break *** until the end.
Chapter 3 Beginning until the first scene break.
Chapter 4 Beginning until the first scene break.
Chapter 5 Beginning until the first scene break
Chapter 6 Second scene break *** until the end (Also they dance here)
Chapter 8 Third scene break *** until the end
Chapter 9 Beginning until the phrase “And their moment was interrupted...”
Angst moment together at third scene break.
Chapter 14 No cuddling, but the whole chapter is a weird love confession with a kiss and some angst
Chapter 20- Smut

See the end of the work for more notes

Thaymor

"I *want* them to go with me," Adora said in a voice that betrayed how terrified she was of using the word want. It felt weird in her mouth, like something hinged on that word, and she had no idea what.

Shadow Weaver sighed. " *They* are not ready."

Adora stepped forward, putting a fist to her chest. "I'll be responsible for them." She paused, waiting for a response, but got none. "I've trained with them nearly my whole life. We know each other. I know how to communicate with them."

Shadow Weaver turned to her sharply. " *They* will be a *distraction* to you."

Adora blinked at Shadow Weaver, her brain trying to process why her commanding officer emphasized those words. "No, they won't. It's just like any other drill. We work well together."

Shadow Weaver clenched her fists and looked away. "Fine- If I must say it plainly- Catra will cause you problems. She's jealous of your success- and most likely will sabotage the mission."

Adora's face set in determination. "You're not giving her enough credit. She just wants to prove herself."

Shadow Weaver sighed. "Fine. You take her, and we'll see which one of us was right. You're the one putting your reputation on the line." She hesitated, then added, "The reputation you've spent your whole life developing- potentially squandering all that work and talent."

All Adora heard was the approval. "Thanks!" She ran off with a smile.

Shadow Weaver sighed and watched her hopes and dreams run off. "Fuck," she muttered to herself.

***

Adora was in full planning mode, with charts and maps. Her squad stood before her, ready to take orders. “Ok. Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio- you three will take the east.”

Lonnie cocked an eyebrow at Adora. “What about Catra? Isn’t she coming too?”

Adora was practically gleaming. “Yes. She is. She has a special assignment.”

Catra could not stop the slight rumble of a purr that started in her chest. No one commented. They had learned the hard way not to.

Lonnie folded her arms. “I’m *sure* she does. Any chance we all get to know what that assignment is?”

Adora stood up and handed a stack of papers to Lonnie. “No. It’s a mission that’s on a need to know basis, and you do not need to know.” She smiled. “Good luck, guys. Have fun, and enjoy the opportunity for real combat.”

Lonnie sighed and pushed Kyle and Rogelio toward the exit. She glanced back over her shoulder to offer a quick, “Oh no, Adora, you enjoy yourselves- and try not to get distracted.” They left.

Adora tapped the floor with her toe, her smile gone. “What do you think she meant by that?”

Catra’s purr got stronger as she jumped on the table in front of Adora, her tail twitching with anticipation like she was about to pounce. “Forget her. What’s my special assignment?”

Adora let a lopsided smile cross her face as she pulled up a pair of keys. “You’re driving my tank.”

Catra’s eyes dilated, and she nearly fell off the table. “Oh- you know what I like.” She regained herself for a moment, looking

Adora in the eye. “So, you got Shadow Weaver to approve this?” She took the keys from Adora.

Adora shrugged. “She approved your going- reluctantly- but not specifically this assignment. She doesn’t need to know. She’s left the planning of the whole mission to me, and I deem this important to the mission so-”

Catra shivered with excitement. “You know, for a goody-two-shoes, you’re kind of devious.” She leaned in, eyes half-lidded. “I guess I’m- rubbing off on you.”

Adora giggled and pushed Catra’s shoulder playfully. “You wish.” She grabbed her jacket from the back of the chair. “Now come on. I’ve got to show you the controls before we leave.” She darted for the door, and Catra lept of the table to follow.

Catra tossed the keys in her hand and looked up at the blonde rushing off down the corridors of the Fright Zone. She felt a warmth that was reserved only for when she was around Adora. It was addicting. She wanted to curl into it and stay there forever.

***

The tank controls were simple enough, and Catra was a quick study with Adora showing her the various buttons and levers. Once the mission got started, and Adora was sure that Catra had control of the machine, she sat back and focused on her communicator pad.

“What? You going to look at that thing through the whole battle?” Catra said as she navigated the machine forward past the trees of the Whispering Woods.

Adora shrugged. “Most of the work has already been done. I planned the supply routes. I ordered the ammunition and the extra armor for the soldiers. I’ve given everyone their orders and conditional orders if things go wrong.” She hit a few buttons on the screen and added, “I could be anywhere and watch the progress, make changes to the plan. The fact that I’m here in

person is really just a courtesy to show everyone that I'm not a coward."

Catra nudged Adora's shoulder with a smile. "That's up for debate."

Adora shoved back with a smile. "Shut up and drive."

The playful contact, and the feel of the machine under her fingertips, caused her chest to erupt in a rumbling purr.

Adora smiled big. "Oh, you're enjoying this are you?"

"Now you shut up."

"You had better not let that happen around other people, or they're going to think you like me."

Catra stuck out her tongue, and Adora stuck hers out in response before they both erupted in laughter. The good time was cut off with a voice from the force captain badge Adora wore. She turned away and talked into it and hit a few buttons on her communicator pad. "Odd. This seems to be going easier than expected. You'd think, with Thaymor being in such a strategic spot between the Fright Zone and Bright Moon that they'd- I don't know- beef up security a little." She tapped her finger on the communicator. "I may have overplanned this."

"That wouldn't be a surprise."

She put the communicator down and looked out the window at what looked like civilians running away from them. "I think our intelligence must have been wrong. I haven't seen a report of a single princess since we got here."

Catra scoffed. "Eh, don't worry about it. All Shadow Weaver cares about is success. All you have to do is win. It doesn't matter how hard or easy it is."

Adora forced a smile. “You’re right. Displacing a whole civilian population is nothing compared to the order we’ll bring to this place. It’s for the greater good.”

Catra stopped smiling at that. “You know, it’s one thing to say that stuff when Shadow Weaver or the others are around. You don’t have to pull that with me- not now when we’re finally alone.”

Adora’s eyebrows raised as she looked toward Catra. “What do you mean?”

Catra pulled a lever to increase the power as they slowly crushed a house. “The whole ‘greater good’ thing.”

Adora blinked.

Catra sighed. “You don’t have to pretend this is some kind of righteous war.”

Adora’s look turned to horror. “You don’t believe in the mission?”

“And you do?”

Adora stared straight forward at that. “Well- yeah. We’re supposed to, right?”

They both braced as the machine came down off the pile of rubble. Catra offered, “Supposed to in the same way the prisoners are supposed to get rehabilitated.”

Adora gasped. “Are you implying that they’re not being educated in how to be more orderly?”

“I mean, if you consider labor camps to be more orderly- then sure.”

Adora put her communicator down on her lap. “So- you think they’re lying to us?”

Catra let out a laugh. “Yeah- duh. Shadow Weaver’s been messing with our heads since we were kids. Lying and manipulation are her specialties.” Her laughter died, and her smile was gone. “Did you seriously not even think about this until now?”

Adora shifted uncomfortably in the tank chair. “I don't know.”

“Well, don’t think about it too much, or it’ll make you sad, and you know how I hate having to hold your hand when you get weepy.”

Adora pushed Catra playfully, a smile creeping back on her lips. “Oh, I’m sure you just *hate* that.”

Catra giggled and focused back on driving the tank.

***

The celebrations died down late, and before Catra could catch up with Adora, Shadow Weaver had taken her by the shoulder and led her away. Catra knew where she was going. Adora had a fancy new Force Captain room that she’d be staying in from now on.

The full weight of that fact didn't hit Catra until the squad was back in their bunks with Adora’s bed empty for the first time in their lives. Catra laid still on the top bunk, but her tail was moving like it was an extension of her thoughts.

Lonnie groaned. “Stop thumbing your tail, or I swear I will cut it off.”

Catra grabbed her tail and held it but moved to stare down at Lonnie. “Brave of you to threaten me.”

“Adora’s not around to protect you anymore,” Lonnie said casually, shifting to turn her back to Catra. “You’d better watch your back.”

The threat should have been hollow, but the truth of it nipped at Catra’s sanity. The empty bunk below her was only furthering her slight panic. She had never relied on Adora to protect her. Adora

did that out of her own dumb sense of superiority. Still, it heightened her absence.

She slid off the bunk in a practiced motion and whispered, "Fine. Don't go ratting on me if we get inspected." With that, she was out of the barracks and headed toward the Force Captain quarters hall.

"Where do you think you are going?"

Catra stopped in her tracks as she felt the first stings of Shadow Weaver's black magic on the tips of her fingers, toes, and the tip of her tail. She didn't even bother turning around. "Just going to pee. Is that a crime?"

Shadow Weaver moved to face Catra, her dark presence growing. "I assumed this would be too much of a temptation for you. Follow me, cadet." She turned.

Catra felt the magic leave her, and she snarled as she followed.

"I am re-assigning you."

"What!"

"Quite now. *Some* people are trying to sleep." Shadow Weaver stopped at her office door, opened it with a wave, and motioned for Catra to follow her in.

Inside, a huge woman with white hair and pincers for hands stood up and fumbled into an awkward salute and a stupidly naive smile.

Shadow Weaver, casually, gestured to her. "This is Force Captain Scorpia. You are being re-assigned to her squad."

Catra's mouth fell open, speechless.

Scorpia beamed and lurched forward to throw her arms around Catra, lifting her into the air. "Oh! Kitty!"

“Put me down!”

Scorpia put her down quickly but continued smiling. “Sorry. I get a little carried away.”

Shadow Weaver watched the exchange, breathed in, and added, “I do hope you find Scopria’s company to be- *satisfactory* .”

Catra pulled away from the large woman and glared at Shadow Weaver. “What was that?”

Scorpia interrupted. “Oh, we’ll have a great time. Tomorrow I’ll show you my little slice of the Horde. You’ll love it.”

Catra’s eyes went big, and her tail fluffed. She mentally forced it back.

“I do hope you focus on this new and exciting *friendship* instead of dwelling on others.” Shadow Weaver’s voice was full of amused malice.

Catra could have maimed her right there and then. She wasn’t dumb. She could read between the lines. She looked at Scorpia for what she was, Shadow Weaver’s mock replacement of Adora, meant to placate her. Honestly, it wasn’t even that bad of an idea- if it had worked.

Shadow Weaver turned to Scorpia. “Why don’t you show Catra your room tonight? It will help you complete your mission.”

Catra hated every word, every syllable that woman uttered.

Scorpia picked up on none of it. She was blushing and smiling. “Oh, sure! Absolutely! I’ll do that now.”

I hate you , Catra mouthed to Shadow Weaver as Scorpia scooped her up and carried her out into the hall.

“You will really like my room. I mean, there’s almost nothing in it, but it’s nice.”

Catra was glad no one was around to see this. She didn't need people thinking of her in terms of being carried. "What exactly is your mission?"

Scorpia's smile disappeared for a moment, then was back. "That she needed someone to look out for you- save you from yourself."

Catra rolled her eyes and started struggling against the hold. "Put me down! I can walk, you know."

"Sorry! You're just so small and pickupable!" Scorpia put her down and kept the march toward her room.

"Don't you think it's a bit odd to show me your room this late at night?" Catra felt sick to her stomach just thinking about it.

"Uh- I'm not tired so- now's as good as any time, right?"

Catra rubbed her head. This woman was a dumbass. Ah- that explains why Shadow Weaver picked her. Fuck. That woman knew her too well.

Scorpia went on. "Besides, Shadow Weaver told me not to let you out of my sight."

"For how long?"

Scorpia blinked. She tapped her pincer to her lip. "Let me see- I don't remember. I'm not sure she said how long."

"Why am I not surprised by that." Catra followed her brain working for how best to get out of this. "So- where am I supposed to sleep?"

"Uh- I haven't thought that far ahead on this. I kind of just was excited to have a mission."

Catra almost felt bad for the woman. Almost.

They reached the Force Captain Quarters, and Scorpia stopped at a door, opened it, and beamed as she stepped aside to let Catra in.

Catra, reluctantly, went inside. Her tail flicked back and forth as she realized, in an instant, she could smell Adora. She was close like she was almost in the room. She paused, realizing the scent was coming from the air duct. Her room must be near. Great. This was going to be torture.

"Here's my bed, and my bedside table- and here are my things." Scorpia, awkwardly, pointed to all these things before she finally ran out. She blushed and scratched her neck with her pincer. "I guess it's not much, but it's mine." she beamed back at Catra. "I'll sleep on the floor, and you can sleep on the bed. I don't mind."

Catra took a long slow breath and turned to Scorpia. She did her best impression of the way Shadow Weaver talked when she was at peak manipulation tone. "Look, I'm not sleeping in your room. It's- inappropriate. What would people think?"

Scorpia's face went bright red, almost as dark as the color of her exoskeleton. "Oh gosh. I didn't think of that."

"We wouldn't want the rumor mill to start churning about who's sleeping in whose room, would we?" Catra's read on Scorpia was dead on. The woman looked to be a complete mess at the idea.

"I- I guess that's a good point."

"So, thank you for showing me your room. If you're my new Force Captain- I'll see you tomorrow for orientation. How's that?" She added a wink for good measure.

Scorpia, still a blushing mess, just nodded.

Catra went to the door. "Before I go-" She looked back. "There was a new force captain. I wanted to stop by her room and- congratulate her on her win at Thaymor."

Scorpia had just then started gathering herself. “Oh, that’s nice of you.”

“Do you happen to know where her room is?”

“End of this hall on the left. The only empty room we had since- I forgot her name- since we lost the last force captain.”

Catra gave the woman her best smile. It was a charming smile. It did its job. The woman was helpless. “Thank you.” She ducked out and made sure the door was closed after her. She quickly went through the hall to the last door on her left. She extended her claws and tapped them on the door in a way that would let Adora know exactly who was on the other side.

A moment later, the door opened, and Adora met her with a smile but quickly checked both sides of the hall before grabbing Catra into the room. She gently closed the door behind them. “I knew you’d come!”

Catra couldn’t stop the smile on her face. “Of course, you dummy. I wouldn’t miss this for the world.” She turned to look at the room and gave out an impressed whistle. “Look at these digs. Enough room to-” She tried to think of something Adora might want. “I don’t know- have a desk or something.”

Adora could barely contain her excitement. “I have my own bathroom! And shower! Come here.” She grabbed Catra’s hand and pulled her to the bathroom in the corner. She flipped on the light and watched Catra’s reaction.

Catra stared in wonder. “Wow. It’s got tile and a mirror. Your own sink. I guess you won’t be using the community showers anymore.” She touched it all, a slight pang creeping in her gut. She crushed it as she forced a smile and turned to Adora.

Adora was giddy. “And the bed is huge!”

Catra got pulled back into the room, with Adora gesturing toward the bed excitedly, and it caused her to feel something- which was

always suspicious. She couldn't quite place the sensation, but it made her thinking slow. "A shame you're only one person." She nearly hit herself when she realized she said it out loud.

Adora's smile was gone. "Yeah, it's already been really lonely in here." She did that thing when she got insecure where she rubbed her elbow. "I'm going to miss you guys-" She paused. "Well, I'm not going to miss Lonnie's snoring- or Kyle's night terrors- but you know what I mean." With a look of resignation, she sat down on the bed.

Catra's tail was going wild, and she reached back to grab it before Adora noticed. "Well, that's the price of moving up I guess. I'm sure one of the other force captains would- I don't know- hang out with your or something." She sat down on the bed, not remotely touching Adora, but close enough that she could if she wanted to.

Adora shrugged. "I mean, a few have already offered- which is weird, right?"

Catra suppressed a growl. She repressed the urge to maim anyone who would go near her Adora. "You're everyone's favorite. You're the brilliant tactician who won us a foothold in the whispering woods. I mean, who wouldn't want to hang out with you?" She avoided Adora's eyes as she said it.

Adora smiled at the obvious attempt to cheer her up. "You think you could- I don't know- stay with me tonight?"

Catra looked back at Adora, eyes wide.

Adora didn't look away. She had a hopeful expression on her face. "I'll never sleep with it so quiet in here. Call it a favor to the Horde to make sure one of their force captains gets a good night's sleep." And then she did it. She gave Catra that stupid soft smile that made Catra's defenses just crumble. Not that she had any defenses against Adora.

Catra's tail flicked next to the bed, ever so slightly touching Adora's leg. Stupid tail. She hoped Adora didn't notice. "Yeah, if you're such a loser that you need it."

"I'll set the alarm to get you up before sunrise."

Catra winced. She hated getting up early, but if that was the price to pay- then so be it. "Sure."

Adora beamed, and then curfew hit. At the scheduled time, the lights went out, leaving only the faint glow in the room that the whole Firghtzone had. Adora's eyes needed to adjust in the lowered light, but Catra's didn't.

Catra took the time to just look at her, letting herself think for a moment how amazing it was to be here with her. She saw Adora blink, and then smile, which meant she could see her staring now. Catra moved like liquid into a ball at the foot of Adora's bed, as they had always done.

Adora found her eyes lingering on Catra's curled up form. "You know- it's going to get cold." Her throat felt dry, just to say it. "And it's not like anyone is going to see us, I mean you being vulnerable."

Catra lifted her head at that, looking at Adora in the dark.

Adora forced a smile and pulled her blue blanket back. "It will be warmer up here with me."

Catra swallowed and moved slowly just in case this offer was a trick. She got to the pillow and laid down, and slowly blinked at Adora.

Adora looked frozen at that but instinctively slow blinked back. She climbed in next to her, and pulled the blanket over them both while they faced each other. They were past the first hurdle of the night, and Adora smiled at herself for thinking of it. "This will be better- for both of us."

“Right.”

Adora could hear the familiar rumbling of Catra’s purr. She could never admit to how happy it made her. “You’re a dork,” she said playfully, hitting Catra’s shoulder.

Catra smiled, feeling the rumble in her chest go up two notches. “Ah! You’re making it worse. Just shut up and go to sleep!”

Adora stuck her tongue out.

“You're a literal child.”

Adora could hear the smile in Catra’s voice and smiled to herself as she closed her eyes and snuggled into her pillow. She could never admit how much she liked the sound of Catra’s purr. This was the closest she had been to it while trying to sleep, and she was pleasantly surprised by how fast it lured her into sweet slumbering oblivion.

***

Adora woke up to the mechanical beeping of the horde standard-issue alarm clock and hit it without thinking. The reason she couldn't think about the alarm was because she woke up with Catra’s legs and hers tangled up under the sheets, and her brain could feel nothing else- think about nothing else. It took her a long, hard moment to realize she needed to wake Catra up. She shifted to turn to her and felt herself go a little breathless as she saw Catra, fast asleep, hair tousled around her face, breathing slowly and peacefully. Oh, she did not want to do this. If she were completely honest with herself, she’d rather stay there looking at Catra asleep forever. “Catra,” She said while moving her arm to shake Catra’s shoulder. “Time to get up and go.”

Catra moved, half-awake, in that semifluid way she always did when she was not fully conscious. Her legs entwined with Adora’s more, and her arms reached out to pull herself into Adora’s side, her claws extended slightly to latch onto Adora’s clothes, and just barely prick her skin, just like they used to when she was young.

For a moment, Adora relaxed into it before she remembered what would happen if Catra was late. “You don’t have long. Maybe ten minutes. You don't want Shadow Weaver walking in without you there.”

Catra’s eyes shot open, and her face went through a myriad of different reactions before landing on displeasure. “She can suck it.”

“Catra-”

“Fine! Fine-” With reluctance, she started to untangle herself.

Adora watched carefully to see if there would be any response in Catra to finding their legs so intertwined. They had always had moments of closeness when they could manage it, but nothing like this. She kind of expected a freakout. She watched Catra yawn, stretched, roll over, and she realized slowly, that everything was fine. Catra wasn’t going to act like that was weird, so neither was she. She couldn't explain how warm that made her feel. “I’m sorry you have to leave.”

“You would, dummy.” It was said with a slight smile as she climbed up and off the bed.

Adora rolled over to watch Catra do her typical morning stretch, standing up- putting her arms above her head, and arching her back, her tail flicking back and forth. It was majestic.

Catra looked over her shoulder, eyes half-lidded, and winked. “Enjoying the view?”

“Shut up!” Adora grabbed the extra pillow and tossed it so it hit Catra square in the back.

Catra erupted in giggles at the reaction and went to the door. The moment her hand touched the handle, the giggling and the smile was gone.

Adora's smile was also gone, as they both seemed to realize the moment that door opened, the regular world, its rules and problems, would come flooding in.

Catra looked up to Adora with a forced smile. "No worries. I'll be fine. If I'm alive by curfew, I'll see if I can't come back and keep you company."

Adora took in a breath and gave Catra a small hopeful smile.

That smile made Catra weak. She forced herself to go through the door, but not without checking the hall first. She had to move fast. Adora, and her stupid little morning leg tangles that Catra wanted to stay in forever, meant she was later than she intended. She had to book it- which meant running- and for her, it meant running on all fours.

She skidded into the locker room, just as Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio were finishing up standing at attention.

Lonnie glared at her as she quickly took her spot at the far end of the line. "Have fun at your sleepover?"

Catra just smiled and quipped back, "Jealous?"

Before Lonnie could react, Shadow Weaver came in for the morning inspection.

***

Scorpia reported to Shadow Weaver's office as soon as she was summoned, and again awkwardly saluted. "Here as requested your- second-in-command-ness." She gave an awkward smile that completed the package.

Shadow Weaver focused her attention on the scorpion princess. "I want a report about your assignment with Catra."

Scorpia stood straight. "Oh- right."

“Did everything go as planned?”

Scorpia wasn’t sure exactly what the plan was. She just knew she had gotten really embarrassed as a girl she liked suggested people might talk if they slept in the same room together. Remembering that made her feel butterflies in her stomach. She blushed again, turning a dark red.

Shadow Weaver saw that reaction, and drew her own conclusions. She relaxed a little. “Good. Keep up the good work. *Distract* her as much as you can.”

Scorpia was not following the conversation, but she knew better than to contradict Hordak’s second-in-command. “Yes sir- I mean ma’am!”

Contraband

Catra arrived for orientation in the big open concrete space where they kept tanks and skiffs. The only instructions she had were to meet at the north end. She searched and saw Adora talking with a group of Force Captains. Catra slowed down, watching the interaction. Were they planning something? Adora didn't look happy.

She forced herself to move past it. Adora wasn't her problem for today. Her problem was the big woman with the tail.

"Over here!"

Catra stopped cold when she heard Scorpia call and looked up to see the woman waving her pincer. Scorpia was sitting on a flowery blanket set out on the tarmac in the open area between two tanks. She had a weaved basket and a pair of mugs.

Catra felt her whole soul leave her body. Someone, please just kill her right then and there.

"Catra! Over here!" Scorpia yelled louder, waving her pincer wider.

Catra rushed if only to make the woman stop drawing attention to herself. "What are you doing out here?"

"I made tea and brought snacks!" She grabbed the basket and held it out unopened.

Catra was about to protest when the smell of whatever was in the basket wafted out to her nose. Her mouth started to water, and she, reluctantly, sat down on the far end of the blanket with her tail tucked under her leg and her ears back.

Scorpia beamed. "I got contraband food for our orientation this morning." She set the basket down, and opened the lid, and tried to pull something out, but the opening was too small for her

pincers. She smiled apologetically. “Someone else packed it, so uh-” She held out the basket to Catra. “Can you?”

Catra rolled her eyes but took the basket and opened the lid. Inside, the most amazing smells came out. She reached in and found little off-white disks.

“They’re cookies,” Scorpia said with a look of anticipation.

Catra turned the cookie around in her fingers. “So- you just eat it?”

“Like a ration bar, yeah.”

Catra sniffed it, and her whole nervous system lit up. Her mouth started to water, and she bit into it almost on instinct. It was sweet and smooth. She stuffed the rest of it in her mouth then went for another.

“I could only get four,” Scorpia said with a faint smile.

Catra, out of respect for the peace offering, stopped herself from eating the second. “Can I- have one for a friend of mine?” She said, her voice almost cracking.

Scorpia’s face lit up. “Sure!”

Catra forced herself to think of how Adora would look eating this for the first time instead of thinking how good it would be to have another. She put it away in one of the many hidden pockets in her uniform.

Catra fished out the last two cookies to hand them to Scorpia.

Scorpia reached out to take the first one, which crumbled under her pincers. “Woopsie,” she said with a blush. “It’s hard to gauge how brittle things are.”

Catra felt an odd pain in her heart at the loss of something so precious and a sense of sadness on Scorpia’s part for missing out

on half of her own snack.

Scorpia readjusted and got the second cookie with a little more effort. “There we go.”

Catra watched, her ears pinning back.

Scorpia ate her cookie, had a moment of transcendence, and then picked up the mug of tea and held it out to Catra.

Catra took it and admitted to herself it was nice to have something warm on a morning this cold. That sent her mind back to how warm she was that morning tangled in bed with Adora. At that thought, she felt warm all over. “So, where’s the rest of your squad?”

Scorpia had just picked up her tea and froze. “My squad?”

“Yeah. Where is everyone else?” Catra started a cautious sip of the tea.

Scorpia blinked at her, then managed an awkward smile. “I hate to tell you this, but you’re it.”

The tea caught in Catra’s throat, and she spat it out in a spray as the content of that statement hit her brain along with the implications.

Scorpia, covered in lukewarm tea spray, just continued to smile like nothing had happened.

“Sory, wrong pipe.” Catra’s voice was hoarse.

Scorpia, still smiling, shook her head to get off the excess water. “No problem. It happens all the time.”

Catra put down the tea. “I’m your only squad member?” The disbelief came through in her voice.

Scorpia shrugged. “It’s not much, but you’ve got to start somewhere, right?”

Catra’s tail retreated further under her, and she sank lower. She started to wonder if Shadow Weaver had picked Scorpia to distract her or her to distract Scorpia. Catra frowned as she realized it was probably both. Leave it to Shadow Weaver to kill two birds with one re-assignment.

Scorpia wasn’t a total idiot. She saw Catra’s reaction, and it deflated her too. “I know I’m not the best Force Captain, but I am loyal, and I know we can make a great team.” She perked up instantly, her natural optimism taking over.

The hair on Catra’s back went up as she heard Lonnie’s voice in her head, making fun of her for being reassigned to the only Force Captain without a proper squad. She was leaking cred by the second. She looked around to take stock of who could see her, and her eyes landed on Adora.

Adora had stepped out from the tanks with the other force captains, but she had stopped when her eyes fell on Catra, then Scorpia. Adora had that look on her face where she didn’t know what to make of what she was seeing, and she quickly looked away.

Catra’s face was burning. She would have to explain this later to Adora somehow.

Scorpia scooted closer to her and tapped her shoulder with her pincer. “Hey, we’ll make the best of it, ok?”

Catra took a deep breath. “I’m going to get back at Shadow Weaver someday for all this,” she muttered under her breath.

Scorpia shuddered. “Oh yeah, that woman scares the living daylights out of me.”

“She’s not scary. She’s evil.” Catra pulled her knees in, wrapping her arms around them. She was trying to come up with a plan to

fix all this. Get back in Adora’s squad. Get in a real squad. Something.

Scorpia watched Catra’s body language and could tell this was someone in need of something. Scorpia didn’t know what, but she was there to try. She scooted closer, nudging Catra’s shoulder with hers. “Hey, if you need a buddy against that crazy evil woman, I’ll be there for you.”

Catra rolled her eyes and scooted away.

Scorpia moved closer. “I’m not lying. She may scare me, but I won’t let a friend down.”

“You don’t know what you're offering,” Catra said as she buried her head further in her arms.

Scorpia was careful not to crowd Catra, but she leaned over her with a smile. “Hey, we’re part of the same squad, so we’ve got to watch each other's backs.”

Catra looked up at Scorpia and kicked herself for how those words made her feel. They reminded her of someone who was probably trying to figure out what the hell she was feeling on the other side of the tarmac.

Catra tore her eyes away from the stupidly genuine woman beside her and looked for Adora. Adora was gone. A frantic look around, and she saw Adora leaving with the other force captains. Every hair on Catra’s body stood up as she saw one of them put a hand on the small of Adora’s back, and Adora flinched.

Catra got on her feet and nearly ran to take care of it right there and then. Adora was uncomfortable, but her stupid people-pleasing brain wouldn’t let her stand up for herself. “Where are they going?” She asked.

Scorpia looked back and around until she landed on the group of people leaving.”Oh, they’re going to the gym before lunch.”

Catra looked at Scorpia, her eyes burning. “Do you go to the gym before lunch?”

Scorpia scrambled to her feet and looked down at Catra. “I can.”

“Can I go with you?”

“Absolutely!”

***

The Force Captain Gym was a place Catra was aware of but had never actually seen in person. Once Scorpia let her in, it seemed magical. Weights, machines, water bottles, and clean, dry towels. Lots of open space for sparring mats and a running track that went around the outside of the room.

Catra forced herself not to gush over the accommodations, and instead, she looked for the blonde with the hair poof that needed saving. She found her, on the low end of a squat with a barbell on her shoulders. Catra’s legs felt weak at the sight.

Scorpia gently got Catra’s shoulder and started dragging her toward a corner. “Let me show you how much I can deadlift. I’m the record holder here.”

Catra looked up at her in shock. “You’re kidding me.”

Scorpia beamed at that look. “I’ll show you.”

Catra was, honestly, genuinely interested in that but found herself looking over her shoulder at Adora across the room.

Adora stood up, shuffled over to set the weight back on the bar, and stood back so someone else could have a turn. She went for her water bottle.

Scorpia pulled Catra to the deadlift station, where a massive barbell with what looked to be too much weight sat ready. She

grabbed a weight belt, started to put it on carefully, and had some difficulty with her pincers. “Just watch. It’s my specialty move.”

Catra positioned herself to be in front of Scorpia. It was a perfect spot because she could look over her shoulder and see Adora. While Scorpia got ready, Catra watched Adora start to take a drink of her water bottle, tilt her head back. One of the people around her moved forward, dumping their own water bottle on purpose over Adora’s chest while her head was tilted back. Catra’s claws were out without her even willing them.

Scorpia got in place and knelt. “This is nothing. I could do this amount in my sleep.”

Catra was breathing fast and shallow as she watched Adora flinch at the sudden cold, and then the asshole that dumped the water moved in with a towel and put his hands on her. Adora froze in a way that made Catra think of murder. It was Adora’s automatic reaction when things were happening too fast, and she was uncomfortable. Catra knew that look by heart, and it made her blood boil to see it. She nearly lost herself to rage.

Scorpia huffed, and lifted the massive weight to standing, breathed out. Her pincers held tight to the bar. Her biceps bulged, and she smiled at Catra.

Catra allowed herself a moment of distraction to watch, if only as a favor for the contraband food. Still, she was processing the complex set of emotions boiling in her about what was going on on the other end of the room. She had to slow down. She had to look for an opening to do something.

Scorpia put the weight down, threw her hair back, and adjusted her broad shoulders. “What do you think of that?”

Catra’s lip twitched. “It was majestic.” Her tone was flat. She glanced past Scorpia to see Adora quickly making an excuse to exit- which was about the only thing she’d allowed herself to do when she felt uncomfortable. Catra’s brain rushed. “Do they have

something to drink here?" She said, half-aware of the words as she focused her entire being on the group laughing at the other end of the room.

Scorpia blinked. "Uh- sure. Do you want something?"

"Yeah. Anything but water." There was water everywhere. It would take Scorpia some time to get something else.

Scorpia was all smiles and a slight blush that was either from the request or the massive amount of weight she had just pulled off the ground. She was also a little dizzy and sweaty, but all that could be chalked up to the lift as well. "Sure thing. Give me a moment." She rushed off, staggering a bit.

The moment Scorpia was out of sight, Catra moved. She was fast on her feet. She could move like lightning through any terrain. The weights and machines of a gym were nothing but perches and well-weighted places to jump off. Her claws came out as she reached the group still laughing behind Adora's back. Her eyes blazed with anger as the asshole turned to see her.

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Adora went to the sink to get some paper towels to dry herself off and stopped when she heard laughter through the bathroom walls. Her stomach twisted in knots at the sound. She knew enough to assume they were laughing at her. The thought of it made her feel sick, and she grabbed some paper towels to start getting the water out of her shirt when the laughter suddenly stopped.

Adora came out to find the group of force captains she had been talking to gone. Her shoulders fell in a relief that surprised her. She looked up to see Catra across the room, and her spirits lifted. She waved.

Catra gave her a big smile that made her eyes close and waved back.

Adora started walking over to talk, glad to have someone else there she knew, then the big woman she had seen Catra with earlier showed up holding glasses. Adora watched Catra turn to her with a big smile that made Adora's stomach turn over.

Catra took the drink, and they started talking. A moment later, Catra was laughing.

Adora turned away from that and headed to the cafeteria for lunch. She decided the painful feeling in her core was hunger- just hunger.

***

Adora spent the day doing what she was told. She said yes ma'am or yes sir when she was instructed to do something, and she avoided the group that had crowded around her in the gym. That was easy. They seemed to be avoiding her too. That was a relief. She ate her two ration bar dinner when she was told, and she went back to her room when she was dismissed.

She got to her room and laid down on her bed, unable to do anything but stare at the ceiling and think of the look of happiness on Catra's face as she looked up at- what was her name? Adora knew of her, recognized her from force captain morning meetings. Her brain got stuck thinking about trying to place this scorpion woman and trying to add up Catra's reaction and why it made her stomach feel so bad.

The only thing that dragged her out of it was the sound of nails gently tapping at her door. Her eyes closed. Catra had come. She couldn't express why she was so relieved, but she was.

Adora forced herself up and went to the door. She touched the door panel as her body started to relax. As the door slid up, she began to say "Ca-" and then saw who it was, and her brain did a hard reset. "Shadow Weaver!" She stepped back and threw her hand into a salute on autopilot while her brain reeled at what was happening.

Shadow Weaver hovered into the room. “I wanted to stop by and check how you were adjusting to your new position.”

Every word made Adora’s spine stiffen so she was standing straighter and straighter. “I can report I am adjusting well.” Her brain had not quite caught up with the situation, but her autopilot was working perfectly.

Shadow Weaver turned her attention to the area, her eyes landing on the unkempt bed and the socks on the floor. “I see you are getting *comfortable* in your new room.”

Without waiting for orders, Adora flew into action, picking up the socks and hastily trying to make the bed.

Shadow Weaver watched the frantic action quietly before instructing, “Just because you have a room of your own does not mean you can give up on cleanliness and order, Adora.”

Adora finished up her bed and stood at attention again. “Understood.”

Shadow Weaver moved in. “Hordak is impressed with your performance so far. On my request, he has assigned you to draw up the plains to invade Plumeria.”

Adora’s attention stance faltered for a movement as her brain processed those words. Plumeria was a nation led by a princess. A real princess. Her heart rate spiked at the possibility. “I would be honored.”

“Of course you would.”

Adora’s eyes were caught by a motion in the hall, through the open door, past Shadow Weaver’s shoulder. Catra had just stepped into the doorway when her eyes fell on Shadow Weaver’s back.

Adora’s eyes went wide. Shadow Weaver noted the reaction and started to turn.

Catra was a blur of motion as Shadow Weaver looked behind her shoulder to see nothing in the hall. She turned back to Adora. “He wants the job done quickly. The region has resources the Horde needs to increase weapon production.”

“No problem. I’ll get right on it.”

Shadow Weaver hesitated but nodded. “Good. I expect the plans by noon tomorrow.”

Adora saluted again.

Shadow Weaver looked Adora over and took a slow breath. “ I’ve put my name and reputation on the line for you. Do not disappoint me.” She turned sharply and out into the hallway.

Catra’s limbs shook as she dug her front claws into the ceiling, and her back claws into the wall, to ledge herself in the space above Adora’s door. Her jaw clenched as she watched Shadow Weaver float out of the door.

Catra’s muscles screamed at her, but she kept it up with the thought of waking up with her legs entwined in Adora’s. Any amount of pain was worth it. Her limbs started to tremble at the effort.

Shadow Weaver sulked down the hall slowly, then turned the corner, and Catra let all her muscles go at once.

Adora chose that moment to step out into the hall to find her friend.

Catra landed on Adora’s shoulders, and Adora yelped. Catra launched off Adora even with her legs burning. She threw herself back into the room with a flip.

Shadow Weaver poked her head around the corner. “Is everything alright?”

Adora smiled back a little dazed as she righted herself. “Yeah. I just- I stubbed my toe.” To try to sell the lie, she grabbed her foot and hopped back into her room, shutting the door behind her.

Shadow Weaver turned away, sure that Adora was acting strangely but unable to discern why. She convinced herself it didn’t matter, as long as Adora was playing her part and not getting distracted, nothing else mattered.

Adora leaned against the closed door, breathing heavily. “Wow. That was- that was really dangerous.” She stepped forward and locked eyes with Catra who was perched on her bed.

Catra was hyped up. Adora could tell that from her dilated eyes and the way her legs shifted. Catra lowered her head and raised her haunches without breaking eye contact.

Adora knew what was coming, and didn’t even brace against it. Catra launched at her, knocking her shoulders and sending her to the ground flat on her back. Adora giggled as the weight of Catra’s body settled on her and made a mocking attempt at swatting Catra away. “Stop it. You’re being ridiculous.”

“Me? I’m not the one who nearly got us in trouble.” Catra extended her claws, and playfully poked at Adora’s face in a way that she was sure she’d get a response.

Adora flinched at the poking and grabbed Catra’s wrists. “Cut it out. I didn’t do anything. She just stopped by.”

Adora didn’t let go of Catra’s wrists, and Catra’s tail flipped back and forth, hitting Adora’s thighs. She had to take a breath at the feeling before she pushed Catra up and let go. She sat up. “Maybe we need to come up with some kind of system.”

Catra practically swayed back and forth, a growing smile. “Oh, so you want to make this a regular thing do you?”

“You’re the one who came back.”

“Poor Adora, so desperate-”

At that, Adora swatted at Catra, and Catra giggled and launched back toward the bed.

The smile on Catra’s face wouldn’t go away as she started gathering up the blanket and rubbing herself on it. “Is it the warmth or the purring you like better?”

Adora got up, dusted herself off, and smiled as she approached the bed. “Certainly not the attitude.” Adora was expecting Catra to quip off at her, but that didn’t happen. Instead, Catra’s eyes went wide, and her smile was gone.

“Wait. We can do the whole banter thing later. I have something important for you.” Catra dug into her pocket.

Adora stopped in her tracks at the seriousness in Catra’s voice.

Catra pulled out the cookie from her pocket and held it out to Adora.

Adora stared at it. “What is it?”

“It’s contraband food. I got it from-” Catra stopped, her ears going flat and her tail flicking the bed. “-Scorpia,” Catra offered quietly.

“Oh, so that’s her name.” It was almost a relief since she had been trying to remember that name all day. Adora looked back at the food. “I shouldn’t. It’s against the rules.” Even as she said it, the smell of it hit her nose and made her mouth water.

Catra pushed it forward. “Screw the rules. Try it.”

Adora slowly reached forward to take the offer.

Catra’s whole body felt like it had to move as she held back her anticipation.

Adora held the food and looked up at Catra. “So, what were you doing with Scorpia?”

Catra moved back, unsure of herself and the tone in Adora’s voice. It sounded almost sad. “Shadow Weaver moved me to her squad.”

Adora turned the food over in her fingers, still considering the consequences of eating it. “She seems nice to give you something like this.” Adora held the cookie back out to Catra. “So you should have it.”

Catra pushed it back. “I had one already. This one's for you, idiot.”

“She let you have two? Wow.” Adora pulled the cookie back and held it under her nose for a good sniff before taking a small bite off the side. As she chewed, and it coated her mouth, her eyes fluttered.

Catra never felt so enraptured by anything in her whole life.

Adora took a bigger bite and made a noise that embarrassed her and made Catra feel some things she could not have put into words.

Catra watched in utter reverence.

Adora managed to swallow and tried to regain herself. “That might have been the best thing I’ve ever eaten.” She took a breath. “Thank you and thank Scorpia too.” She wasn’t sure how she really felt about the woman, but if she was being nice to Catra, that was something.

Catra felt small at that genuine sentiment and she moved to make room for Adora on the bed. “I’ll bring you more if she gives me more.” She tried to act cool by laying back down on the bed on her back. She chose the exact center just to be a nuisance. She watched Adora expecting her to laugh and make a comment about what a jerk Catra was being, but instead, Adora just watched her.

Without taking her eyes off Catra, Adora took off her boots and undid her jacket.

Catra's heart thumped hard at the way she was being watched. She realized with a start that she was vulnerable. Defense mechanisms kicked in. Time to deflect. She grabbed one of the pillows behind her head and tossed it toward Adora's stupid face.

Adora grunted but caught the pillow before it hit her. She giggled.

Catra could have died at that smile.

They both heard a click, and the lights shut off. Their moods plummeted. They had lost track of time.

Adora had to stand there a moment to let her eyes adjust to the dark.

Catra took a moment to drink the sight of Adora in the dark. This was becoming her favorite time of the day- when she had unfettered looking time. Still, Catra moved back to what could be called her side of the bed.

Adora put down the pillow and reached forward to feel the bed to see where there was room for her.

Catra watched, sorely wishing she hadn't moved because if she hadn't, then Adora's hands would be exploring her at the moment. That thought sent her whole body to alight with feeling, which was bad before bed time. She tried to squash it as Adora climbed into bed.

Just like the night before, Adora curled in to face Catra, and Catra turned to do the same.

For a moment, they laid there in the dark and neither would have guessed that they were both thinking the same thing. Both wanted to start the night where their last night had ended, entangled in every way. They both couldn't stop thinking about how comfortable and warm it had been. Neither wanted to be the

loser who asked for it, though. Neither wanted to be the weak one that needed the comfort.

They both waited for the other to ask for it.

The emotional standoff was too much, and both just closed their eyes in defeat.

Adora waited till she was sure Catra had to be asleep. Catra did the same.

Nearly simultaneously, the two of them acted like they were shifting in their sleep. Adora moved to lay on her back but scooted closer to Catra, sticking her leg out a little further than was necessary.

Simultaneously Catra moved in like she was just shifting in her sleep, putting her head on Adora's shoulder like it was just another pillow. Her arm landed on Adora's stomach, just like it was just a blanket. Her leg ended up on top of Adora's leg because- well- that leg was too close anyway.

They both relaxed into the position, happy to be able to blame the other one for it in the morning.

They both slipped into good dreams full of unlimited cookies, and soft morning cuddling.

The alarm went off with unrelenting regularity, and Adora only half woke up. In a morning daze, she tore her arm away from the warm space it had found itself. She hit the button to turn the alarm off.

Catra's chest erupted in a purr they shifted back into a comfortable position together. The soft rumble tugged at the sleepy part of Adora's brain and the part of her that craved comfort and warmth in an environment where she had been denied both.

With Catra’s head still on her shoulder, and their limbs entangled, Adora drifted off to get back to where she had left in her dream.

Consequences

Waking up was slow. Slower than it had ever been their whole life, and they both became aware of their position at the same time. They were on their sides, facing each other, with Catra's head tucked under Adora's chin. They were in each other's arms in an embrace that neither had ever imagined before.

Catra tried to fight the purr starting in her chest, but when she realized Adora had already felt it because they were so close, she let it go. It erupted between them, and Adora smiled big. "A little needy, aren't you?"

Catra adjusted herself but stayed tucked under Adora's chin. The rumble got louder, and Catra bit her lip. Her heart was always on her sleeve with her stupid purr and her stupid tail, and her stupid expressive ears. She hated it. She hated that the equation between her and Adora was so unbalanced. Adora had that stupid smile and those big bright blue eyes, and admittedly she often wore her heart on her sleeve anyway, but she didn't have to. She didn't have a purr that betrayed her.

Adora started with a hum in her chest and then let it come out as an 'rrrrrrrrr,' trying her best to replicate the sound.

It took Catra half a second too long to realize what Adora was doing. She smiled to herself but playfully pinched Adora's side.

Adora giggled and allowed herself the indulgence of scratching the back of Catra's hair. "Hey, if you're going to purr so much, I should learn to do it too." Adora went back to making the sound as best she could.

Catra's face felt hot as she did it. It made her rumble get louder.

Adora reveled in it for a moment. The fantastic knowledge that Catra's purr was responsive- that was new. She had never been

allowed to play with it so openly. She scratched Catra's hair a bit more, and the rumble just got worse. Adora practically beamed.

Catra hid her face into her friend if only because she was full on blushing now.

Adora smiled big and offered, "Oh, I think you like me."

"Shut up," Catra said, half meaning it, muffled against Adora's body.

It was an exhilarating feeling, having Catra that close. Adora stopped smiling as her brain started reeling with the thought of what would happen if anyone saw them like this. At best, teasing for being soft. At worse, if it was Shadow Weaver, then a harsher punishment for daring to be weak. "We probably shouldn't do this."

Catra made a half-hearted attempt to pull away before diving back in and snuggling into Adora. "Fuck it. No one can see us," she whispered.

Adora's eyes went wide as she realized what had happened, and her chest felt warm and not just because Catra was there. She blinked and discovered in a moment that this was more than she had ever wanted. Something she didn't even dare to ask for, dare to wish for. For all the times they had sought solace in each other over the years, made promises, and stuck together, they had never once been allowed the simple pleasure of a heartfelt hug. Adora had been sure, all her life, that Catra would claw her at the mere suggestion, but there she was, fully awake and choosing to be right there.

Adora, impossibly lost in the brand new world that had just opened up for her, wrapped her arms around Catra's body and her head and pulled her close.

For a moment, Catra was startled at the touch. It was so alien to her, but she melted into it and closed her eyes, and they both laid there with the rumbling of Catra's chest to bind them.

Whatever magic existed between them was shattered when someone knocked on Adora's door.

Adora flinched, pulling out of the hug, and rolled to look at the clock. It was well past the time the alarm should have gone off. All the warm, happy feelings she had drained out of her, replaced with pure panic. "Shit-" she muttered under her breath as she threw the blanket off and turned to sit on the edge of the bed. "Just a moment!" She called out.

Catra was bewildered until she saw the clock while Adora got up. Reality came crashing down on her hard.

"Force Captain Adora, it's Lonnie. Kyle and Rogelio are here with me." The familiar voice was muffled through the door.

Catra threw the blanket over her head and hissed.

Adora looked back at her, wanting to tell her to quiet, but anything she said would be evidence against them. Instead, she went to the door. "I'll be out in a minute!"

"Catra missed morning muster," Lonnie said casually. "Shadow Weaver's pissed. Sent us to go look for her and drag her back for punishment."

Adora froze in her spot as the idea of Catra being punished for something she had done drilled its way into her brain.

Lonnie continued. "Anyway, I wanted to inform our Force Captain that we're certainly going to look for Catra, but we'll be doing it in the rec room for the next two hours."

Adora blinked, still processing why Lonnie would have told her that.

"We will just tell Catra the next time we *see* her that she owes *us* . See ya', Adora." With that, they heard the squad walk down the hall.

Catra threw the blanket off her head. “Did they just do something decent?”

Adora looked back and locked eyes with Catra. “I got you in trouble. I didn’t get up with the alarm.”

Catra shook her head and got up. “You’re worried about the wrong part. Your squad just gave me two hours to figure out a way out of this.”

Adora stared at Catra for a long movement before blurting out, “Did they just automatically assume you would be here?”

Catra ignored that and stretched a bit. “Two hours is plenty of time to come up with an alibi.”

As she moved, Adora tracked Catra, her brain processing why the squad would assume Catra was with her.

Catra saw that poor helpless look on Adora’s face, and for a moment pitied her. Everyone loved Adora, but sometimes she could be as dense as the metal walls that surrounded them. “I’m going to go find Scorpia. She said a lot of shit about watching my back. We’ll see if she’ll keep her word.” Catra got a devious smile. “Shadow Weaver can’t do shit if I missed muster because I was following orders.”

Adora had a range of emotions. First, surprise. Who was this woman who so quickly offered protection? Then a moment of temporary relief as a solution presented itself. Then, a more complicated feeling that included her stomach, and not in a way she liked. Adora’s shoulders fell. She wanted Catra to be safe. She desperately wanted not to be the one who put her in danger in the first place, but the idea of this woman being the solution made her feel worse.

Catra moved in, taking Adora’s hand and squeezing it. “Hey, don’t worry. I got this. If Scorpia doesn’t pull through, I’ll just disappear for a week and pretend I got captured or something.”

Adora nodded as she processed all that information. The handhold was good. It was the one thing grounding her thoughts at the moment.

Catra smiled at her. “You’ve got to go about your life like normal. I know what a bad actor you are, but you’re going to have to pretend like you’re having a really normal day, ok?”

Adora nodded, still in a daze.

Catra squeezed Adora’s hand one more time before turning toward the door. “If I’m alive this evening, I’ll be back.”

Adora couldn’t stop the whine that came out of her as her stomach clenched at the idea of Catra dying, let alone because of her.

Catra winked back at Adora. “Wish me luck.” She hit the button to open the door and looked out into the hall to check for witnesses before she ran at full speed.

Adora stood in utter shock at how casual Catra was about all of this. Adora wanted to stop her- keep her from leaving. She wanted to hold her there all morning and just keep her safe. Instead, she had to let her go and pretend as if nothing happened.

The door slid back shut on its own, and Adora stood there lost. She looked back at the clock and realized she had only a few hours to develop a plan for the taking of Plumeria. She would have to skip breakfast. She grabbed her jacket and forced herself to go to the planning room.

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Catra moved fast with a mix of excitement and fear that always seemed to drive her. She hadn’t known Scorpia for very long, so she didn’t know her schedule. Her best bet was to look in the open area near the tanks where they had met the day before. She’d start there and then ask around.

She reached the tanks. Her ears twitched, turned. She heard Scorpia's voice, and her whole body reacted.

Scorpia laughed and jabbed someone with her closed pincers while they tried to excuse themselves when Catra skidded to a stop in front of her new Force Captain.

The person Scorpia was trying to talk to took the moment to make a hasty exit while Scorpia lost her smile, looking Catra over. "What happened?"

Catra breathed heavily, then stood up and tried to adjust her hair to look not so frazzled. "All that stuff you said yesterday about watching my back, well- I need you to pay up."

Scorpia's eyebrows lifted. "Sure. What do you need?"

Catra was not expecting it to be that easy. "I missed morning muster, and I need an alibi. If I don't have one-" She had managed to go the whole morning without thinking what would happen if she got caught. She knew Shadow Weaver too well. She would torture her to find out where she had been. Worst-case scenario, magic would be involved, and Catra would have no choice but to implicate Adora. That thought gave her the first spike of fear all morning.

Scorpia held up a pincer. "So- you just need an excuse, right?"

Catra nodded.

"Say no more. I got you. We can use my tail."

Catra's ears went down flat against her head. "What does your tail have to do with it?"

Scorpia had a proud smile as she moved forward. "I sting you, and you pass out. I tell Shadow Weaver it was an accident, and that's why you were late."

Catra flinched back a little. "You're going to sting me?"

“It’s not dangeru-”

Before Scorpia could finish, Catra felt a sharp pain in her thigh, and the world started to fade. The last thing she saw was Scorpia panicking. The last thing she heard was, “I’m so sorry! It’s got a mind of its own!” With that, Catra watched the world go black.

***

Shadow Weaver did not spend her time idly. She had paperwork to do. She had weapons orders to organize and reports to read, but she was also distracted by thinking of where Catra had been that morning. She had gotten lax with her attention on her most problematic ward. That thought made her eager to find the girl and use whatever power she had to exact an answer.

The door to her chamber opened, and she looked up.

Force Captain Scorpia walked in with a nervous smile and Catra on her shoulder. “Hey- so- I think I may have messed up.” She pulled Catra off her shoulder by her leg, dangling her in the air.

Shadow Weaver saw first the limp body and then the unfocused eyes. Her mask hid the face she made as a thought jumped into her brain that Catra was dead. Her hair stood up higher with growing magic as she pulled it from the black garnet. Her fingertips crackled as she prepared to end Scorpia with the magic from her own runestone. Catra had been an insolent brat, but no one was going to kill her ward but her.

Scorpia’s awkward smile was gone as she saw the growing magic. “She’s not dead! I just accidentally stung her.”

The magic dissipated almost instantly, and Shadow Weaver, for a moment, let herself wonder why she had reacted so strongly. She forced her voice to be calm. “You did what?”

Scorpia wasn’t trying to hurt Catra’s leg, so she wasn’t holding firmly, and her fur made her a little difficult to grasp. Catra slipped out of her grip and landed in a pile of limp limbs on the floor.

Scorpia laughed nervously. “I just accidentally stung her, and I didn’t know when it was going to wear off. I thought you might have been worried about her, so I brought her to show you she’s fine.” She gave Shadow Weaver a big awkward smile while trying desperately to get a hold of Catra in a way that wouldn’t hurt her. Trying to pick up a passed out Catra was like trying to pick up water.

Shadow Weaver stared at Scorpia, knowing her mask would prevent the woman from picking up the expression on her face. She tried to tamper her voice. “Force Captain, I asked you to keep an eye on her, not nearly kill her. I don’t need the scrutiny if one of the cadets under my authority were to be injured.”

“I get that. I’m sorry. It wasn’t intentional.” She wasn’t lying. She managed to get ahold of Catra’s middle and hoist her back onto her shoulder.

Shadow Weaver took a slow, steady, calming breath before declaring, “Get her out of my sight, and keep her hidden before anyone starts asking questions. Do you understand me, Force Captain?”

“No problem! Sorry for the trouble Ma’am!” She turned and left without needing to be told twice.

***

The plan was rushed. Adora knew that, but she had a deadline and couldn’t focus. She made up for a lot by putting herself up front so she could change the plan if things got too out of control.

In the plan, she specified that Scorpia’s squad would be in a tank on the eastern border in a moment of hurried worry and carelessness. It was a moment of hope, an offer to both Scopria and Catra if they managed to survive. Catra would get a kick out of the tank going over such rugged terrain, and Scorpia might appreciate the strategic importance if she cared about that kind of

thing. It was a little moment of hope in Adora's already horrible morning.

While she drew up the plans, all she could think about was what happened to Catra, and hoping beyond hope that this Scorpia was as good as her word. At that thought, another mix of emotions made Adora want to skip lunch because of the way her stomach felt.

That twisting stomach went with her to Shadow Weaver's chambers before noon to give her the plan and stayed with her as Adora wondered if this was the same room that Shadow Weaver would have punished Catra. She stood at attention, trying to smell the tell-tale scent of discharged magic or burnt fur.

Shadow Weaver flipped through the plan. "Commendable that you would put yourself on the front line. That's exactly the kind of initiative Hordak likes to see." She looked up. "You look very pale. Are you getting sick?"

Adora shook her head on instinct. Never admit weakness. Never admit defeat.

"Well, if you are, stay in your room. I don't need the other Force Captains sensing weakness in you. The moment they smell blood-" She paused, reading more of the plan. "I will take this to Hordak later this evening. I'm sure he'll approve it."

Adora felt a small relief at that. She had, at least, passed one hurdle for the day.

Shadow Weaver leveled her gaze at Adora. "We are at a critical juncture. I need this battle to be a success, Adora, and it all rides on your shoulders."

Adora saluted with all the excitement she could fake.

Shadow Weaver took a long slow breath before offering, "If this is a success, perhaps I can set up a mission for you and Catra."

Adora's face lit up, just for a moment, as she realized that meant Catra had to be alive.

Shadow Weaver noticed the look and continued. "It would be a collaboration with Force Captain Scorpia, of course."

Adora's heart was beating so hard she could feel it in her ears. She couldn't tell if what she felt was anger or excitement.

Shadow Weaver continued. "You should see how well they get along. It's good to finally see Catra finding other *friends* ."

Anger. The feeling was anger. That surprised Adora.

Shadow Weaver smiled to herself, safely hidden by her mask, glad to see Adora was so easy to control. "You are dismissed." She turned away, smug in her confidence.

Adora saluted and left to go figure out why she was angry. She should be happy. Catra was at least not in danger anymore.

Adora went to lunch starving, and sure that eating would make her calm down. She got a tray and got in line for a ration bar and something to drink. She couldn't help but overhear the women in front of her talking.

"-yeah, she was carrying that cat girl. She looked rough."

"What do you mean rough?" the other asked.

They had Adora's full attention.

"She looked dead or passed out or something."

"I guess Scorpia's taking her to the medic."

The woman got a look on her face like she was about to share the juiciest gossip. "Oh, no. Last I heard, she was taking the cadet to her room."

Adora's heart rate doubled.

The other woman made a face of scandalous shock before offering, “Well, I guess she’s gotta take what she can get.” And then they both started laughing.

Adora dropped her tray and ran. She didn’t care who saw her. She didn’t care what they thought. At that moment, she didn’t care about the Horde a single bit. All she cared about was the thought that Catra was in trouble and needed her.

Adora knew exactly where Scopria’s room was. She had seen the woman entering or exiting her room half a dozen times. Within minutes she was at the door her heart pounding in her chest and panic nipping at her. She would have broken down the door if she could, but she settled for banging on it.

The door slid open, and the tall white-haired woman looked down at her. “Oh- it’s you. What do you want?”

Adora saw behind her to the bed, where Catra was limp and motionless. Adora’s stomach clenched. “What happened?” She looked up at Scorpia. “What were you going to do to her?”

Scorpia’s eyes went wide, and she staggered back a bit at the accusatory way the new force captain had just talked to her.

Adora pushed her way in, tried to move past the large woman.

Scorpia stopped her with a pincer. “Hey! What do you think you’re doing?”

Adora shoved her back, and readied her fist for a fight. Adora didn’t care how tall the woman was, or how strong. “Let me see her!”

Seeing that the woman was ready to fight, Scorpia let her go.

Adora rushed to the bed, kneeling as she approached. Her hands halted before she touched Catra’s limp, motionless form. “What happened?”

Scorpia quickly closed the door and scratched her neck. She didn't know what to say. She didn't want to get Catra in any more trouble, and things were getting complicated. "She's fine. It will wear off in a bit."

Adora was on her feet, standing between Scorpia and Catra. "What were you doing with her?"

Scorpia put her pincers up and backed up against the wall. "Hey, I don't like the tone. I was doing as told and keeping her out of sight."

"In your room?"

"Yeah."

"In your *bed* ?" Adora's hands were shaking. She was running off instinct.

Scorpia didn't answer immediately, realizing she was dealing with someone who was on edge. "You must be her friend she gave the cookie to?"

That caught Adora off guard.

Scorpia chuckled a bit and relaxed. "I'm Scorpia, and it's good to meet you." She cautiously offered a pincer. Not everyone was ok treating it like a hand, but she had figured offering it to shake was better than not offering it.

Adora looked at the offered appendage, her rage and panic starting to mellow. With some trepidation, she shook the woman's pincer. "I'm Adora." Her voice was still a bit shaky.

"Catra was late and-"

"Did Shadow Weaver do this to her?" By now, Adora had tears in her eyes, expecting the worse.

"This? No. This was me."

Adora clenched her fists, and Scorpia was quick to add, "It was all part of the plan. I mean, it was going to be the plan. I didn't get the chance to make sure she was ok with it. The tail sometimes has a mind of its own."

Adora's eyes went wide as she saw the tail. "You stung her?"

"I know it sounds bad, but it just knocks people out. No harm done. She'll be fine." She laughed a little to herself. "It's funny. Shadow Weaver nearly killed me too. Thought she was dead."

It took a moment for all of that to go through Adora's brain, but it landed. She started to relax, or she started to crash. All that adrenaline faded and left her empty. She sat on the bed. "She got out of it then." She looked back at Catra, her tongue hanging out and her eyes looking in vaguely different directions. It was a disturbing sight, but it was better than what could have happened. Adora looked back at Scorpia. "Thank you. I'm sorry I accused you of-" She hesitated for a moment, trying to piece together exactly what she imagined was happening. It was hard to put into words.

"No problem." Scorpia cautioned a move forward. "You know, you're new, so people are going to notice if you're not at the briefing after lunch."

Adora had forgotten about the briefing. She had forgotten about everything in that panic.

"She'll be ok here on her own. Why don't you and I head to the briefing together?"

Adora looked up at Scorpia, surprised by the genuine smile. She knew what Scropia was doing. It was an unspoken act of good faith. Maybe Scorpia picked up on the protectiveness or the jealousy. Adora hoped Scorpia wasn't picking up on the jealousy. "You're sure she'll be ok?"

"Absolutely. She might have a headache, and she'll need water, but she'll be fine."

Adora stood up and managed a slight nod. “Sure. Ok. Let’s go. You and me.” Adora would not have left for the world if Scorpia wasn’t going to go with her. Something about leaving Catra alone with anyone while passed out bothered her immensely. Maybe, if people saw them leaving together, perhaps the rumors about this morning would fade. That made Adora calmer.

Adora and Scorpia left her room and started walking to the briefing room. Scorpia seemed in good spirits, and Adora was beginning to feel better.

“So, you and Catra are good friends, right?”

Adora nodded without really thinking about it.

“Great. I’ve wanted to talk to someone who knows her. What’s her favorite color?”

That caught Adroa off guard. “It’s blood red.” At least, that’s what Catra always said when they were growing up. Now that she started thinking about it, maybe it had been more of a threat than it was an admission.

Scorpia beamed as they entered the briefing room. “Does she like games?”

“Training simulations?”

“No, like board games.”

“Oh- I don’t know. We’ve never-”

“You’ve never played games?”

Cobalt looked up from the presentation and glared at the two of them. They were late. They quickly took their seats at the back of the room. Adora tried to focus on the screen.

Scorpia leaned in and whispered, “Ok, so games are a maybe. What else does she like?”

Adora couldn’t split her attention. The question bored a hole in her mind. What did Catra like? Head scratches. Apparently hugs. She learned that one that morning. Her face started to heat up.

***

Adora sat on the balcony overlooking the Frightzone where she and Catra had spent so many evenings. The sunset was a vibrant blood red.

She was distracted. Scorpia had followed her around all day asking questions, wanting to know more about Catra’s likes, dislikes, her past. Adora should have been the perfect person to answer, but most of the time, her mind went blank. She had barely escaped Scorpia at dinner time by skipping out, and she was so hungry.

She heard someone behind her and closed her eyes, thankful for the fact that it sounded like Catra’s graceful leaps up the metal pipes.

Catra came up behind her and poked her in the middle of the back with a claw. “Miss me?”

Adora turned and pulled Catra into a hug.

Catra froze at first but relaxed into it and cautioned a hug back. “What’s up with you?”

Adora pushed her head into Catra’s neck, half hiding in her hair. “I was worried about you all day.”

Catra smiled big at that. “You didn’t have to. Scorpia pulled through.”

Adora pulled back, looking Catra in the eye. “Do you like games?”

Catra blinked. “What? Like training simulations?”

“No. Like games you play for fun.”

Catra looked at her in shock. “Who the fuck plays games? We’re at war.”

“I know, right? It’s not weird that we’ve never played games. No one plays games.” She turned toward the sunset.

Catra sat next to her, dangling her feet down and leaning back a bit on her hands. “What was that about?”

Adora shook her head. “I don’t know. It’s been a bizarre day.” She waited a moment, and they both watched the sun dip past the dark gray clouds of the Firghtzone. “You should go back to the barracks to sleep tonight. It’s too dangerous for you to come back to my room.”

Catra laughed loud and hard at that.

Adora panicked a little, seeing some guards below them look up to see what was going on. “It’s not funny. Today was really serious.”

Catra sat up and nudged Adora back, giving her some wiggling eyebrows. “What? You trying to get rid of me now?”

Adora pushed back. “No. I’m trying to protect you.”

“From what? From Shadow Weaver? Fuck her.” Catra got up. “She’s an old lady who's on the way out. Once she’s gone it will be you and me running this place. We’ll be able to do whatever we want.”

Adora got up as well, if only to meet Catra’s unspoken challenge. The tone in Catra’s voice made her feel a bit better. She looked at her friend and felt a flutter in her chest. “So, even after everything that happened today-”

Catra shrugged. “I don’t care about this place. I don’t care about Shadow Weaver in particular.” She paused. “It’s always been you and me, Adora. No one else matters...”

Adora felt so many things at that moment. A warm growing pride in her friend. A feeling she couldn't quite place that felt kind of like butterflies in her stomach. She offered her hand.

Catra took Adora's hand without hesitation.

Adora smiled. "Ok. It's you and me, and everyone else can deal with it."

Catra smiled wide while she tightened her grip on Adora's hand. "Damn the consequences."

They were both, at that moment, clear about what they were. They were allies- allies against a world that gave them nothing. An ally is what they both needed. Being allies apparently included cuddling in bed because that was what they both also needed.

For a moment, they both got excited about the possibility of what else an ally could provide them that they needed. Just as that thought hit, they let go and tried to regain themselves.

Adora waited a long moment before the chill of the twilight started getting to her. "So- you want to go get warm?"

"I thought you'd never ask."

Flowers for Hordak

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora didn’t feel like she had slept. Not really. She spent the night tossing and turning, listening for the alarm. Catra cuddled up to her side every time she settled, and it felt good, and it hurt too. Her closeness was a constant reminder to Adora that she had very nearly caused her friend a lot of problems by being careless. She stopped and revised. Careless and weak. How else could she explain wanting- needing, to be cuddled in the morning like a child and neglecting her duty to her friend, nearly getting her in trouble. Those thoughts left her wide awake before the alarm went off. Catra sprawled out with her legs half over her, her body twisted in a way only she could manage, and she was snoring.

Adora loved the sound of Catra’s soft breathing, and the weight of her legs made her feel a bit calmer. It didn’t matter what happened the day before. The point was, Catra was fine and had chosen to come back to her. It didn't matter that Scorpia had to intervene. Sometimes, Catra needed a hero, and right now, Adora couldn’t be that for her without getting her in trouble.

A sharp pain went through her at that thought, and her hand went up to her face on instinct. Her fingers touched the almost invisible scars that young Catra had given her over her new friend Lonnie back when they were young. She wondered if what she felt for Scorpia had been what Catra felt for Lonnie- if that same pain in her stomach had made Catra lash out all those years ago.

Catra moved, groaning with the effort of waking up. She rolled over with a smile and settled on opening her eyes lazily.

Adora quickly put her hand down. She didn’t want to remind Catra of her scars. Even though Catra would never apologize, Adora knew she felt bad for striking her. She knew because of the way

Catra had fussed about the wound for weeks, making sure it was bandaged and cleaned, and hissing slightly at herself when she muttered how close it had been to Adora's eye. As much as Catra hated that time, Adora remembers it as the time she realized Catra cared. She cared in a way that she couldn't express openly.

Catra glanced at the clock, then back at Adora. "Did you sleep at all?"

Adora was sure she had to have slept because she kept having nightmares about being late, but she didn't feel rested. *Never show weakness* . "Yeah. Did you?"

Catra started stretching in that lythe way only she could do, arching her back and popping all her joints in quick succession.

Adora watched with rapt attention.

"I slept just fine with a tossing and turning blonde girl waking me up every few minutes." Despite her words, she smiled. She stopped stretching and moved to Adora's side, poking her with her nails in the stomach.

Adora couldn't help but smile as she flinched. "Sorry. I'm nervous."

"About the alarm or the next big horde win you're going to plan?"

Adora blinked, not wanting to admit either. She instead started to get out of bed.

Catra whined. "You could at least stay here until the alarm goes off. Kind of cruel of you to get me addicted to your warmth just to take it away."

Addicted to warmth . That turn of phrase turned over in Adora's head. It sounded like something Shadow Weaver would say. It didn't make her want to lay back down. She didn't want to be weak. She stood up instead.

Catra didn't react, except her tail beat on the mattress in protest.

“I’ve got a lot of things to do this morning. If Hordak approved my plans- then I don’t have a lot of time to prepare.”

Catra rolled over on her back, put her hands above her head, and stretched out. “You’re going to prepare for an attack before you even know if it’s been approved? Damn Adora, you really are a loser.”

Adora looked back to give a comeback, but her attention was arrested by how Catra looked on the bed, spread out like that. It looked like an invitation, but to what she wasn’t sure. She tried to regain her brain, drag it back to a witty comeback to play along- to counterpoint the verbal banter that both of them used to avoid anything real, but her stomach betrayed her. It growled long and hard.

Catra sat up, her ears alert. “Are you ok?”

Adora put a hand over her stomach. “I just need to go get breakfast before things get started.”

Catra narrowed her eyes at Adora. “Did you skip meals yesterday?”

Adora turned away to start putting on her boots.

“The fuck, Adora? You know how that messes you up. It’s not like they let you make up for it. They call them ration bars for a reason. They get *rationed* !”

“I’m fine. I’ll be fine. Don’t worry about it.” Her stomach betrayed her again by making a louder noise.

“Do you remember the last time you skipped meals? You passed out during training, and I had to drag your ass back to the barracks and steal food for you until you got better.”

Adora avoided Catra’s eyes as she buckled her boots and stood up.

Catra was out of the bed and glaring. “We watch out for each other, right?”

Adora nodded.

“Well, right now, I can’t be around you during the day, so I need you to take care of yourself. I need you to eat.” Her tail flicked back and forth erratically. “You and your stupid self-sacrificial bullshit.” She turned on Adora with her brows furrowed. She poked a nail into Adora’s chest, but her words stung more. “You’ve got to be selfish for me. You’ve got to take what you need and tell everyone else to screw it.”

Adora looked away, grabbing her jacket.

“I mean it. I need you to survive long enough for us to-”

Adora stopped cold, hanging on to those words. Maybe her face looked hopeful, or scared, or a mix of both.

Catra turned away, frustrated, before finishing, “We’ve got to survive this place so we can rule the world, right?”

Adora nodded.

“Then make sure you eat and sleep.” Catra watched Adora put on her Force Captain badge and felt a sudden pain at it before she added, “Or else they're all going to see that you’re not at your peak, and they’re going to chew you up and spit you out.”

That also sounded like something Shadow Weaver would say. It made Adora’s stomach feel sick. She set her jaw and looked Catra in the eye. “I’m not weak.”

“I know.”

“I’ll be fine.”

“I know.”

Her stomach growled again. “I’m going to get breakfast.”

Catra folded her arms. “You’d better.”

Just then, the alarm went off, and Adora hit it hard to quiet it. She didn’t want to say anything else. She didn’t want to betray any other feelings or weaknesses or admit how tired and hungry she was. She left her room without another word.

Catra followed and slapped Adora in the back before sprinting down the hall to get to the barracks in time.

Adora righted herself from the playful hit and watched Catra leave with an ache she ascribed to hunger, even though she felt it in her chest.

Her stomach hunger got worse when she was back in line for breakfast, holding an empty tray and her mouth watering for even the brown ration bars.

She was startled when she felt someone’s hand on her shoulder. The air crackled, and she didn’t have to turn to know who it was.

“Lord Hordak has summoned you, Force Captain,” Shadow Weaver said, her voice dripping with pride.

Adora stared at her, and for a moment, held on to her tray with Catra’s words from that morning echoing in her head. She needed to be selfish and tell people to what? Screw it? She couldn’t tell Shadow Weaver to tell Hordak to screw it.

“Well? What are you waiting for? You have an audience with Hordak himself.”

Adora never took her eyes off Shadow Weaver as she, against her stomach’s wishes, put the tray down and followed Shadow Weaver out of the cafeteria. There would be plenty of time for eating later. Destiny awaited.

She regretted it when she was standing in front of Hordak for the first time, stomach empty and feeling faint.

He didn’t look at her, which was preferable. He instead sat on his throne and looked at her paperwork. “Shadow Weaver tells me you think you can take Plumeria in a day.” He flipped through some of the papers.

Adora had to reach deep into her memory, past the hunger, the tiredness, to remember why in the world she thought that. “Our scouts have reported no buildings, no weapons, and no standing guards or soldiers. It seems they are confident in their Princess’s ability to protect them. That pride will be their undoing.”

He did look up at that. Adora straightened her back.

Shadow Weaver moved forward, gathering his attention. “As you can see in the plan, the whole operation hinges on a fast strike to overwhelm the princess, separate her from her people, and divide her attention. Really, a brilliant strategy.”

He closed the papers. “I don't care about strategy. I care about progress.” He tapped his finger on his throne. “I’ll authorize it, but it needs to be enacted immediately. I don’t want to give them time to realize what we’re doing. A decisive strike to get to the heart of Plumeria.”

“And take the Heart-Blossom runestone for our own.”

At that, he sighed. “I still fail to see how gaining hold of a runestone we can’t control will help.”

Adora wished, more than anything, that instead of being there listening to a strange fight she had no context for, that she was back in the cafeteria eating. Her stomach gave a small growl, and she was suddenly happy that they were talking too loud to hear her.

Shadow Weaver continued. “I can learn to tap it the same way I’ve learned to tap the Black Garnet, doubling our magic

potential."

Hordak stood up and threw the papers on the ground at Adora's feet. "I grow tired of this conversation. Just move." He turned toward the darker side of his room.

Adora bent down to grab up the papers, quickly re-arranging them back into the folder before Shadow Weaver touched her shoulder and led her out.

Once they were out of the room and the door shut, Shadow Weaver turned to Adora. "You have done well. You heard Lord Hordak- speed is of the essence. You are to deliver the orders to martial and enact this plan today."

"Yes, Shadow Weaver." Adora's brain was churning at high speed with everything that needed to happen. She felt overwhelmed. She pushed that down and ran to start delivering orders. Breakfast and lunch would have to wait.

***

Thaymor had been an exhilarating experience. Seeing her plan enacted. Getting to experience the marshaling of an army under her command. It had been one of the best moments of her life, and it was such a letdown to see that most of it wasn't even needed once they got there.

The revving up of the war machine for Plumeria wasn't nearly as exciting. Maybe it was her own lack of self-care or the fact that she knew her plan had been rushed and continued to be rushed as it was enacted. Rushing things wasn't a good strategy for winning a war.

She found herself in the front tank, intentionally alone, with everything she would need to capture a princess. If someone were going to get hurt, it would be her since she caused all this.

Catra's earlier words echoed in her ear about *self-sacrificing bullshit* . She shook her head. This wasn't self-sacrificing. This was

protecting everyone else from her stupid mistakes. Still, thinking about Catra made her miss her more, and she hit her communicator for the tank that Catra and Scorpia would be driving. “Hey, Catra- Scorpia. How are you two doing?”

She heard a laugh that sounded like neither of them. Lonnie’s voice came through loud and clear, “I think you got the wrong tank, Captain.”

Adora froze for a moment as her brain processed what had happened. “Lonnie, you and the others were supposed to be in tank 37, on the west.”

“That’s not what our orders said. We’re just doing what we were told.” Her voice cut out a bit, and Adora heard Lonnie yelling at Kyle about something.

Adora tried to focus back on the path, but her brain was elsewhere, trying to figure out where in the world Scorpia and Catra were.

Catra, on the other hand, was moping at the very back of the action. “What the fuck are we supposed to be doing out here?”

Scorpia, with a cheery smile and a can-do attitude, held up a crate. “We have the vital job of keeping everyone hydrated.”

Catra blinked at Scorpia, then looked at the crate. “You have got to be joking.”

“Fluid consumption is no joke. Without a well-hydrated army, everything falls apart.” She pulled out a bottle from the crate with some difficulty with her pincers and wiggled it to make a point.

Catra slowly looked away from the bottle and to Scorpia. “Do you ever get tired of people not taking you seriously?”

Scorpia lowered the crate, her smile disappearing. “What?”

Catra gestured toward the crate. “Bottles? They gave you the job of delivering bottles? Aren’t you the strongest Force Captain we have?”

Scorpia blushed a little. “I guess- but this is important.”

“No, this is stupid. Anyone can do this job.” She grabbed the bottle out of Scorpia’s pincer and opened the top. “We’ve got to work on your ambition.” She chugged the water, drank it halfway, and threw the bottle to the side.

Scorpia watched with a growing warmth in her heart. She was just enamored that Catra cared about her ambition. She could have died happy right there and then.

At the front, Adora started to see abandoned tents. The population must have had scouts. The people were warned. She dropped her communicator on the console and readied herself for the fight of her life. She grabbed the stun baton, ready to engage with a real princess for the first time. All her training led her to this moment.

Through the small window of the tank, she saw a woman standing, draped in loose clothes, covered in flowers, her arms outstretched.

Adora stopped the tank and grabbed her helmet. Her heart pounded in her chest. She’d take the princess down if it killed her. She opened the hatch and crawled out, fueled by adrenaline alone.

The woman was still and calm.

Adora slid off the tank and nearly tumbled to the ground in front of the princess. She righted herself and got in a stance, ready for a fight. “Surrender or else, princess!” Adora tried hard to make her voice menacing.

The sounds of the war machines coming up behind her, ready to strike, only fueled her adrenaline high.

“I surrender,” The princess said in a meek voice as she put her hands up.

Adora blinked. “What?”

“I surrender as long as you let my people go.”

Adora paused, looking around. The people were already gone. What looked like the runestone was unguarded. She looked back at the princess, expecting this all to be a trick. “We’re here for you and the stone. Nothing else matters.”

The woman breathed a sigh of relief and put her hands out in front of her. “Then I’ll go peacefully.”

Adora’s mouth dropped as her brain registered what was happening. She moved forward, taking the cuffs from the back of her belt. “Really?”

The woman didn’t respond and merely held her hands out further.

Adora already heard the hooting and hollering of the soldiers popping out of the tanks behind her. She took off her helmet and let it fall to the side, and that’s when they started chanting her name.

Adora didn’t know what to do. They shouldn't be celebrating yet. This could all be a trap, but what more could she do besides go along with it and be prepared for anything. “Ok. I’m going to cuff you now.” She moved in slow, held up the cuffs, and expected something to happen before they were clamped down.

Nothing happened.

The woman lowered her arms and her head.

The army behind them went wild.

As Adora helped the woman into her tank, she heard the chatter on the radio. Reports that the mission was a success. Embellished

accounts of what people had seen Adora do. She tried to stop being distracted by it all as she tried to secure the princess. “I don't get it. Why didn’t you fight us?” Adora asked as she attached the cuffs to a secure bar in the tank.

The woman sank to the floor. “We’re a peaceful people. We would have never attacked anyone, including the Horde.”

Adora stared at her in disbelief. “It’s a war-”

Adora was interrupted by the sound of her communicator going off. She heard Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio laughing and cheering her on.

She rushed over to turn off the communicator. Something about all this felt wrong. She sat down and started driving back. Her whole plan was useless. It was too much. It was all too much yet again. Why had the reports said anything about a completely passive princess? Who in their right minds would believe it? Her stomach growled.

The newly captured princess looked up.

Adora sank into her seat, focusing on the controls to turn the tank back and head as fast as possible to the Fright Zone. Her stomach growled again.

“Are you ok?” The woman behind her asked in a small voice.

Adora nearly bit back, but the words reminded her of Catra’s that morning. “I’m fine. Everything is fine.” She hesitated for a moment before adding, “And what do you care? I’m the invading force. I just ruined your kingdom and took you hostage.” She looked back and met eyes with the woman who should have hated her.

The woman held out her hands as far as they would go. In the middle of them was a red fruit.

Adora stared at it. “What is that?”

“It’s food.”

“How did you get it?”

“I control plants. I wouldn’t be a very good princess if I couldn’t make fruit.”

Adora blinked at it. Her stomach rumbled, and she whined as she forced herself to focus back on the path. The whole army was falling in line behind her, except the squads she had designated to stay and guard the newly acquired territory if they won. It still surprised her that they had won. She still didn’t quite believe it.

Adora stopped thinking as something rolled and hit her foot. She looked down to see the fruit there. She looked up at her prisoner. “How do I know you didn’t poison it?”

Her prisoner’s face looked shocked. “Oh wow. It’s an apple. They’re not poisonous.” She looked concerned. “Have you never seen an apple before?”

“Of course, I’ve seen an apple before!” She had never seen anything like it in her life. And Adora’s stomach betrayed her again and growled. She could somehow smell the fruit from where it was, and it only made her mouth water. She grabbed it and took a bite- telling herself it was in response to a challenge and not overwhelming hunger.

Her teeth broke through the skin, and sweet juices burst in her mouth. It was like the cookie, but different in texture, but so incredibly sweet. She ate it as fast as she could like she had never eaten anything in her life, and her stomach growled for it. She finished and took a breath, only to find something else hit her leg. She looked down and saw another apple. She looked back.

Her prisoner was giving her a soft smile. “My name is Perfuma.”

Adora was not going to dignify that with a response, but she grabbed the fruit and ate it. Afterward, she found another fruit rolled to her leg. This one was different. Orange. She didn’t care.

She swallowed it too. Shadow Weaver would kill her. Taking food from a prisoner, a princess no less, but Adora was starving.

"You're Adora, right? That's the name everyone was chanting." Perfuma held up a bundle of red things with little seeds that looked absolutely amazing.

Adora tried not to address that. They didn't need to exchange pleasantries.

Perfuma rolled the bundle of red things to Adora, and she ate it with reckless abandon.

"You've really never eaten any of this before, have you?" She produced another, this time green and shaped differently.

It wobbled toward Adora's foot, and Adora snatched it up before it could roll away. "I haven't, and don't patronize me." She bit into it and had a little moment of heaven that reminded her of Catra while she was trying to drive the tank straight. She wasn't doing a great job. "Hey um- Can you make more of the little red ones?"

The woman looked up with a sad look on her face.

"I have a friend who-" Adora hesitated. It was wrong to ask a favor of a prisoner. Before she could think about that too hard, she felt another bundle hit her leg, and she looked down to see more of them. She grabbed them up and stuffed them in her jacket for Catra for later. "Thank you." She hesitated and added, "I can't promise I can do anything for you, but I owe you one." She looked back to see the woman fall against the side of the tank, dejected.

"It's war, right? Don't worry about it. You don't owe me anything."

They spent the rest of the trip in silence.

Adora hated everything about handing the woman over to the guards to be taken to a particular cell they reserved for

princesses. Adora watched, feeling full for the first time in her life, and gripped with an uneasy sadness that made her hate herself.

Despite everyone cheering her no matter where she went, nothing about that day felt like a victory.

She retreated to her room, but not before grabbing a ration bar. She would never let herself be hungry in front of the enemy ever again. She opened the door to her room, turned on the light, and as the door shut behind her. She was tackled straight to the ground.

Catra laughed and slightly clawed at Adora's jacket, all smiles, and bright eyes. "Guess who figured out your password." her tail and her hips swayed as she talked. Catra tried desperately to get her fingers at the places that she knew Adora was ticklish.

Adora laughed back, defending her most vulnerable spots when she heard a squish and felt wetness on her chest.

Catra's smile was gone, and she looked down at the red liquid on Adora's chest. Her eyes went wide.

Adora realized in a moment what had happened and started laughing. "You've ruined the surprise." She reached into her jacket and pulled most of a bundle of fruit out to hand to Catra.

Catra smelled them and moved back a little. "Where did you get that?"

Adora pushed herself to sit up and grabbed Catra's hand with hers. She placed the red fruit in her palm. "Call it the spoils of war. They're amazing."

Catra blinked at her, then sniffed the fruit. "Is it poisonous?"

Adora shrugged but continued to smile. "I had two pounds of them earlier. If they were poisonous, I'd be dead already."

Catra cautioned a lick, and her eyes dilated. She started eating, and Adora watched with the warmest feeling in her chest. It felt good. Giving Catra food was the one good thing in her whole day. The only real victory.

Catra's mouth was a mess, and she licked at her own fur to get the juices off.

Adora laughed and reached forward with her thumb to smooth away some of the mess out of Catra's fur.

Catra froze at the touch.

Adora did, too, once she realized her thumb had touched Catra's lip. She quickly whipped some of the fruit off and pulled her hand away, unsure if what she had just done was ok or not.

Catra smiled and hit her in the shoulder. "You stupid sap. Cleaning my face. I can lick my own face, thanks." She made her point by sticking out her tongue, then licking the juices off.

Adora watched with a strange feeling that she attributed to the lingering sense of being tickled. She opened her mouth to say sorry, or retort or something, but instead got interrupted by a frantic knock at her door.

Catra jumped, landing on the bed, sliding under the covers, and curling into a hidden ball in the back.

Adora was left alone on the floor, her fingers covered in strawberry juices, as she tried to get up. She expected Shadow Weaver. She didn't expect the voice that came through the metal door.

"Force Captain Adora! You are needed in Hordak's sanctum immediately!"

Adora got up as she realized it was Cobalt. She opened the door to find him panicking. "Is everything ok?"

"No. Nothing is ok. You are to report to Hordak immediately. It's an emergency." He turned and ran.

Adora shut the door and looked back at Catra. "I guess I have to go."

Catra pushed the blanket off her head. "I'm going with you."

"You can't be seen with me."

"No, you idiot, I'm going to follow you secretly. If you're getting in trouble, I'm not letting you handle it alone, you loser."

Adora couldn't help but smile at that. She wanted to fight it, but the nerves about what was going on hit her hard, and the idea of having Catra there comforted her. "Ok. Sure."

***

The run to Hordak's room was surreal. The further they got, the more they started to see flowers. It was jarring to see light blues and yellows in a place that rarely got above a dark red for any color.

The closer they got to Hordak's room, the worst it got. Foliage-green and demanding, flourished out of every nook and cranny.

They reached the door to Hordak's sanctum, and Catra held back while Adora went in.

Catra listened and waited.

"Adora, you're here finally," Shadow Weaver said almost gently.

Catra knew that once their eyes were on Adora, they would look at nothing else, and she slipped into the room as the door was closing.

Hordak's sanctum had machines aplenty to hide behind, and today it had the extra foliage to conceal her. Catra got into a position

where she could see, and her natural fur and markings would camouflage her.

Hordak looked pissed.

Adora saluted, then looked panicked as someone else- must have been the princess, appeared out of nowhere holding a large bundle of flowers in her still cuffed hands. Catra's mouth fell open as she saw the princess drape a garland of flowers around Hordak's neck.

He moved to strike at her, and she flinched back toward Adora. Catra knew Adora too well. She could recognize that protective instinct in a second. In a moment, Adora had put herself between the princess and Hordak, guarding her the way she used to protect Catra.

He sneered at her, and Catra readied herself for the fight of her life. She got excited. This was going to be glorious. She'd go for Shadow Weaver while Adora took out Hordak. Her heart rate went up. Her ears flattened back against her head, so she nearly didn't hear what was said next.

Hordak turned to the rest of the room, pointing. "All of this is your fault Force Captain!"

Adora's face showed nothing but panic. "I put her in prison."

Shadow Weaver took a deep breath and offered, "Yes, we are aware, but she has gotten out. Something about breaking the walls with pansies."

Hordak growled. "She was obviously a strategic ploy by the rebels to undermine our base. You brought her in. I expect you to get rid of her immediately."

"Yes, Lord Hordak," Adora said.

Catra gave in to disappointment but got her adrenaline back when she saw Shadow Weaver leaning into Adora's ear. Catra's ears

moved fast, at full attention, aimed directly at the old crone.

Shadow Weaver wasn't stupid. From an early age, she had taught her wards a code that only they shared. They were simple commands, hidden in phrases that others wouldn't recognize as code. "Take her to the Whispering Woods, and give her the *royal treatment* ," Shadow Weaver said with a smile in her voice.

Adora's face flushed. Her eyes became pinpricks. Catra's fur stood up on end as she watched the life drain out of Adora as she forced herself to move the woman out of the room. Catra could kill Shadow Weaver right then and there for daring to ask Adora to do that. Adora was a soldier through and through but not an executioner.

Catra waited until Adora was out, and Shadow Weaver had turned back to Hordak to say something of the incident to soothe him over, and Catra slipped out just as the door was shutting again.

She found Adora frozen in the hall, her hand holding the princess's cuffs.

Catra stood up, dusted herself off, and strode over to Adora. "Come on then. Let's get this over with."

Adora didn't move.

Catra grabbed her hand and dragged her toward the skiffs.

Catra did the work of getting them to the skiff bay, getting a key with Adora's authority, and getting her to get the princess in.

Adora was gentle in helping the woman into the vehicle, like any amount of kindness now would make up for anything later. Or, Catra thought, maybe Adora was just kind, and she couldn't turn it off, even with the enemy.

The princess looked scared but quiet, and she wasn't struggling. She seemed resigned.

“Hey, you gotta show me how to drive this thing, ok?” Catra said to Adora, touching her shoulder.

Adora nodded in a daze and turned to take the rutter. She said nothing as she got it going and slowly led them toward the gate.

Catra moved to stand next to Adora, feigning interest in learning how it all worked. Adora muttered some useless facts about what buttons to push and looked up to the edge of the forest right outside the Fright Zone.

Catra leaned in, saying in a voice barely above a whisper. “Adora, you’re the kindest person I know.”

Adora froze at those words.

Catra grabbed the rutter of the skiff and looked Adora in the eye. “Don’t let Shadow Weaver have the satisfaction of making you cruel.”

Adora stared at the forest in the distance.

“That said, I’m here to help you do whatever you need to do.”

The woman behind them started making single flowers and letting them fly in the wind, leaving a trail behind them.

They drove faster toward the edge of the woods. Adora and Catra said nothing more. Everything that needed to be said had been said.

Adora slowed the skiff as they reached the edge of the woods.

For a moment, both Catra and Adora stared at it. It was immense and growing darker in the light of the fading sun. Full of dark purples and blues and faint greens. Faint lights appeared and disappeared in the depths of the trees. They had never actually been this close and had children’s stories told to them of all the dangers that awaited inside.

Adora stopped the skiff and grabbed the stun baton attached under the control panel. “Ok, we’re getting out.” Her voice was flat.

Catra’s eyes fell on the baton, and she prepared herself.

Adora helped the princess get out of the skiff and stood on the ground with the baton in one hand and the cuffs in the other.

Catra perched on the edge of the skiff, her eyes on Adora’s hands. She would follow Adora anywhere- any direction she wanted to go. Dark path, light path- it didn’t matter to her. She was ready to do whatever Adora needed- to support whatever she chose.

Adora took a deep breath and dropped the baton, using her free hand to undo the cuffs. “Leave, quickly. Brightmoon is directly south of here.” She spoke fast, nervous.

Catra felt a tension release from her body that she didn’t realize she was holding. It was, in a moment, an assertion that Adora was still Adora- that Shadow Weaver hadn’t broken her yet.

The princess stood momentarily in shock as her hands were free. She started to smile.

“Go! Before anyone sees you!” Adora’s voice was raw.

The woman smiled big as she made a ring of flowers appear. She gently dropped them over Adora’s head and declared, “You take care of yourself, Adora.” The princess turned and ran, disappearing into the dark of the Whispering Woods.

Adora fell to her knees, watching the princess escape. “This is treason isn’t it?”

Catra jumped down from the skiff, grabbing the baton. “Maybe.” She turned it up to the max power setting, pointed it away from the skiff, from the forest, and away from Adora. She hit the button, and a beam shot out, taking out a chunk of a tree. She looked back at the power indicator, pleased that it would be

obvious it had gone off. No one would have a reason to suspect anything once the equipment was checked back in. She turned around to Adora with a smile and an outstretched hand.

Adora took the offered hand, and Catra pulled her up.

They were close. Face to face. They were breathing each other's air.

Catra beamed. “That princess was the weakest anyway. We’ll never see her again.”

Adora breathed heavily, her eyes searching Catra’s face, landing on her lips. She forced herself to look Catra in the eye. “Yeah, you’re probably right.” Adora grabbed the ring of flowers, ripped them off her neck, and threw them on the ground. “Let’s get back and go to sleep. I’m exhausted.”

Chapter End Notes

Straight up based on an episode from the ’80s, which you can watch here if you want.
https://youtu.be/fP7d_AUy1D8

One's Fair Share

The alarm went off, and Adora extended a tired arm to turn it off only to hear the smallest sneeze. She blinked, unsure if that noise came from a dream or something else until it happened again.

Catra sneezed next to her in bed, and Adora's heart was so warm. "That's the cutest sneeze I've ever heard."

"Shut up," Catra said, rubbing her nose.

Adora started to get up, and Catra sneezed again. She couldn't help but smile.

Catra sat up and tried to clear her nose and couldn't. "If you say one more thing about it being cute, I will literally gut you."

Adora shook her head as she grabbed her boots. "It's probably all those flowers."

Catra groaned. "Maybe I can get Scorpia to- I don't know- make up a mission outside."

Adora stood up and smiled as she grabbed her coat. "I have an idea. If you and Scorpia aren't already busy-"

"Is Scoripa ever busy?"

"Then get a boat. I'll get it approved through Shadow Weaver first thing after breakfast."

Catra looked at Adora with all the curiosity she could muster. "A boat?"

Adora couldn't stop smiling. "Shadow Weaver said if the siege on Plumeria went well, I'd get a mission with you and Scorpia, and I think I have the perfect one."

Catra watched Adora with her near limitless levels of energy and shrugged. “Great. Anything to get away from this-” She sneezed, and Adora’s eyes dilated. “-hell hole. I was trying to say hell hole.”

“So cute!”

“Shut up!”

***

The flowers and plants left in the Fright Zone were not as vibrant as they were the night before. It seemed without the princess there, they lost their luster and started to go to seed. Adora walked through the halls, looking for Shadow Weaver, and heard more than a few sneezes.

She stopped abruptly in a hall filled with wilting flowers, where Shadow Weaver stood holding a pair of sharp scissors and a collection of small bags.

Adora approached her carefully. “Taking a sample?”

Shadow Weaver sighed. “It’s rare to have reagents grow so close to home. I thought I’d gather some for tea, or potions, or potpourri.”

Adora didn’t know what potpourri was and didn’t care to pry too deeply into Shadow Weaver’s dark ways. She instead stood at attention. “I need approval for a mission.”

Shadow Weaver gave a sharp, quick snip to a plant and let the dried chamomile flowers fall into a bag. “Oh, you do?”

Adora hesitated a moment, wondering if what happened with the princess would cause the mission on Plumeria to be called a failure. “The mission you said I could have with Scorpia and Cat-”

Shadow Weaver sighed heavily. “Yes. I suppose I did say you could have that.” She turned back to the wall of flowers, finding a hibiscus among them. She quickly snapped it.

Adora watched with a mix of feelings at seeing Shadow Weaver do something so domestic as gathering flowers. It seemed inherently wrong. "Salineas. For my mission with Scorpia- and Catra- I want to go to Salineas as a scouting group to see for myself what it's like to compare to the reports."

Shadow Weaver froze. She slowly turned to Adora, still holding the scissors open. "Now, why would you need to do that?"

Adora looked around to see if anyone was close enough to hear before she uttered her next words. "With Thaymor and Plumeria, the reports were not exactly correct. I think someone might have-"

Shadow Weaver closed the scissors quickly and sharply and moved in to whisper. "Be careful what you say out loud, Adora."

Adora froze at that threat.

Shadow Weaver relaxed her shoulders and tucked the scissors in her robes. She got close so that only Adora could hear her. "I will grant this request, but on two conditions. One, you will tell no one else of your suspicions or the reason for the trip. Top Secret. It is between you and me, and we will only talk about it in my chamber upon your return. Second, you will get close enough to make a report, but under no circumstances will you let Catra observe the kingdom herself."

Adora stared at her. "Why?"

Shadow Weaver pulled away. "I do not need to explain myself to you, Force Captain. You will do as I say, or you will not go on this mission with them."

"Yes, Commander," Adora said while saluting. Her heart was racing.

"You are dismissed."

Adora ran off half to rush to the docks and half to burn off whatever tension had been building inside her. Shadow Weaver was creepy on the best of days, but on days when there were unspoken accusations of falsified documents- she was even more terrifying.

The air at the docs smelled like dead fish and brackish water. Adora went to the attendant in charge of boat assignments and tried to get a boat checked out or figure out which one Scorpia had managed.

"Oh, Scorpia. Right." The attendant put down the trackpad. "Then you don't need approval. She's got her own ship."

Adora's brain scrambled for a moment. Those words didn't make sense. "What?"

The attendant pointed down the dock. "The red that looks like a giant bug."

Adora turned around. The ship was bigger than the others. "She gets a themed ship?"

At that moment, Adora had no idea what she felt. Shock. Horror. Disgust. Envy. All of them at once. On top of it all, Scorpia didn't need approval to travel.

She started walking toward the boat and feeling smaller and smaller as she went.

She got close enough and heard Catra calling her name. She looked up, and Catra waved excitedly from the ship's deck.

"Hey, Adora! Check this shit out!" She motioned toward the whole thing and laughed like a madwoman.

Adora's shoulders fell as they lowered the plank to let her get on.

Catra ran to meet her and nearly tackled her to the ground but managed to hold off. "She has a fucking boat, Adora! It's hers!"

“Yeah, I saw that.”

Catra was too excited to hear the dejection in Adora’s voice. Catra instead grabbed Adora’s jacket and pulled her to the front of the boat. “I almost don’t care where we’re going. Wherever it is, it’s going to be the farthest from the Fright Zone I’ve ever been, and this is going to be great!”

***

“Gosh! Don’t you just love the fresh sea air! All briny and slightly fish smelling?” Scorpia leaned against the side of the boat, smiling wide at the broad open ocean.

Catra hurled the last remains of her breakfast gray ration bar off the side of the boat.

Adora watched them both with a sinking feeling that she had miscalculated. She wanted a trip with Catra away from things, to be able to relax and maybe get some work done on the side. What she did instead was find out that Catra got seasick quickly. She watched Catra hurl again and came up behind her to plant a hand on her back. “It will get better once we’re closer to land. The waves won’t be as big.”

Catra groaned and collapsed onto the deck. “I’m going to die, Adora. Tell Shadow Weaver I hated her.”

Adora’s shoulders fell. “You’re not going to die. It just takes a while to get used to the motion.”

Scorpia scooped Catra up into her arms. “You just need a distraction and maybe some good old-fashioned home remedies. I have both!”

A small shot of adrenaline went through Adora at the sight of Catra being carried like that.

Catra caught Adora’s reaction and wordlessly told her it was stupid and to chill. All of that expressed in one eye roll directed at her.

Adora's jaw clenched. She was being called off like a guard dog. She hated it, but she backed off.

Scorpia rocked Catra a bit while she carried her to the middle of the deck. She cradled Catra in one arm while the other pulled a towel out of a box and laid it out before putting Catra down. "I brought board games and ginger candies just in case someone got sick."

Adora walked up to Catra and stood watching Scorpia pull out a basket. She and Catra made eye contact briefly, a silent question between them that Catra decided to voice. "Scorpia, where do you keep getting contraband?"

"Oh, it's a part of my family's agreement with Hordak. I get a share." Scorpia motioned for Adora to sit down.

Adora did, right next to Catra. Their legs were practically touching. Adora couldn't verbalize why she needed the contact. She needed to be close. She needed to show Scorpia that- Catra wasn't friendless. She needed Catra to accept the touch.

Catra didn't seem like she noticed.

Scorpia handed the basket to Catra with a shake.

Catra took it and reached in to find a box, which she pulled out and placed on the towel. On the front was a man with a mustache and a nice suit, and then drawings of the various kingdoms in Etheria.

"Oh, this game's my favorite. You buy property and charge rent," Scorpia said with an eager smile.

Next, Catra pulled out a bag of little gold balls.

"Those are ginger candy. Eat one- you'll feel better. Don't chew it, though. It's hard."

Catra opened the bag and smelled it before reaching in and grabbing one of the balls and putting it in her mouth. Her eyes dilated as her tongue was covered in sweetness. She handed one to Adora on instinct.

Adora took it and smelled it too before popping it in her mouth and making a noise of pure bliss.

Scorpia smiled. “See. They really take the edge off.”

“Like freakin’ magic,” Catra said around the candy as the haze of sea sickness lifted slightly.

“It’s not magic. Just an old trick my moms taught me.”

At that word, Adora and Catra both stared at Scorpia like she was some anomaly while they both sucked on the first bit of candy they had ever had.

Scorpia couldn’t quite place their reaction. “Did I say something wrong?”

In theory, Adora and Catra knew what a mother was. Someone who was like a commanding officer but different- weaker. In practice, the idea was a foreign concept. During their late-night talks back in the barracks, the two of them had mused about what it could mean to have a family. Mostly, it was jabs about how having people who care for you sounded like a ploy to make you weak.

Adora didn’t think Scorpia was weak, and she had two moms instead of one. Her brain reeled at the realization of how much Scorpia had. The contraband, the boat, and two people who cared for her when she was sick- taught her non-combat medicine. It broke Adora’s brain, and her defense mechanisms crept up. “Some of us are trying to fight a war while you play games and eat candy,” Adora muttered, still technically sucking on the shrinking candy in her mouth.

Catra glared at her.

Adora only then realized she had said that part out loud and instantly regretted it.

Catra stood up and grabbed Adora's ponytail. "Scorpia, if you'll excuse us- I need a word with my friend here." She pulled up until Adora scrambled to her feet, then dragged her out of earshot. "What the hell are you doing?"

"Let go," Adora whispered aggressively as she swatted at Catra.

Catra let go but pushed Adora into the railing before getting close. "What was that popping off about?"

"Nothing. It just slipped."

Catra was closer than she usually would get. Her face in Adora's face. Her look was soft. "Let's not try to antagonize the rich lady. She might keep giving us shit."

Adora's stomach clenched. Her whole body went rigid.

Catra saw Adora's jaw work. She smiled, happy for the subtle confirmation that Adora was getting competitive. "Slow your roll, and enjoy the benefits. Maybe we could get her to take us to other places outside of the Fright Zone, try new foods. Don't you want to see the world, Adora?"

Adora was agitated. While yes, that sounded fun, the idea of having to be reliant on Scorpia for it made her uncomfortable.

Catra saw all of that in Adora's face, and she patted Adora's shoulder. "Relax, Force Captain. It's not like you and Scorpia are competing for anything."

Adora blinked at that, not sure if that was true or not.

From the top of the ship, an announcement boomed that they were near Salineas. They would be passing by but not getting close enough to endanger an attack.

Adora turned around to see the shoreline of the sea kingdom coming into view. She pulled out a collapsible telescope she grabbed before they left.

Catra watched Adora scramble for the scope. “So, what exactly are you supposed to do here?”

“It’s top secret.” Adora extended it and looked through it. It took a moment to find the shore with the sight, but once she did, she found a kingdom that looked deserted.

Catra poked her in the side. “You look like you’ve seen something interesting.”

Adora said nothing as she got to the sea gate. It was dim. It had holes. She blinked in astonishment before the scope was gone.

Catra had snatched it away.

Adora looked up in horror. “Give that back.”

Catra started walking backward with the scope. “Oh- miss ‘I’m on a secret mission’ is going to try to keep me from looking? Oh, come on! I thought you knew me better than that.”

Adora rushed forward to grab the scope, and Catra dodged. A bigger lunge and a wider grip, and for a brief moment, Adora had Catra by the waist, and Catra giggled. Adora’s body reacted in a way that hurt- ached. She froze, and that gave Catra enough time to move her lithe body out and away and launched upward. Her vertical jump was unmatched.

Adora watched with growing horror as Catra started hopping up the side of the ship’s command tower.

With a grunt, Adora started climbing after her. “Catra! Give it back!”

Catra stopped jumping back and forth up the tower long enough to stick her tongue out at Adora and razz it.

Adora furrowed her eyebrows. She started climbing faster, the way Catra had taught her in all their years of playing.

"I'm going to throw you off the boat once I get you," Adora yelled up.

Catra reached the top and twirled the scope in her hand while she kept her eyes on Adora's ascent. " *If* you get me!"

Adora felt a rush of endorphins as she was able to find good holds to pull herself up faster. She kept an eye on Catra, relieved that she hadn't looked through the scope yet. "Curiosity killed the cat," Adora said with a smile as she just about reached Catra's foot.

Catra pulled her foot up and held up the scope to her eye in the same motion.

Adora froze.

"Hm- I don't see anyone."

Adora should have tackled her and wrestled the scope away before Catra could see anything else, but she was worried already they were tempting fate by being so high and so unprotected.

Catra smiled big. "Did you get a look at the gate? Looks like shit." She tossed the scope back down to Adora.

Adora barely caught the scope with one free hand before having to clutch back onto the ship's metal pipes to avoid falling.

"Looks like another place you can waltz right in and take over without much effort." Catra stopped smiling. "Actually, wouldn't controlling Salineas give us control of the ocean?" She blinked, putting it all together. "No more having to move tanks over land. Taking this would give us a big advantage in the war."

Adora watched in wonder at how fast Catra's mind worked. She had never considered that a sea-based war would be easier- that

the sea kingdom would provide them such an advantage. She looked back at the shore in the distance, wondering why Catra hadn't been promoted if what the Horde wanted was to win the war.

"Are you guys on top of the ship?" Scorpia called out from the deck. "That's dangerous. Shadow Weaver would kill me if one of you fell." She had moved to where she could just barely see them.

"We're coming down. Adora's done with her super-secret mission!" Catra called back mockingly. She turned back to Adora. "Do you need help getting down?"

Adora shook her head and then regretted it when Catra was out of sight and already addressing Scorpia while Adora just started to try to find her footholds in reverse. All the while, her brain was processing what had just happened. She had to find a way to explain all this to Shadow Weaver.

***

The trip back had been one long game of buying property and charging rent, and it had allowed Adora to process what she had seen and what it all meant. By the time they had gotten back, she was sure there had been some sabotage of the reports.

The moment they got back to shore, the smell of flowers seemed stronger. The plants that had looked wilted that morning were brown and husky by sunset. Golden yellow powder from their last burst of life covered everything, and Catra had started sneezing the moment they got close to shore.

Adora thought about that- Catra sneezing uncontrollably- as she wrote her report and found herself standing in the Black Garnet room with the report in her hand, detailing the many inaccuracies of the previous reports.

Shadow Weaver turned to her. "So, what did you find?"

Adora could think of no other way to start than to say it plainly. "The kingdom is practically abandoned. The sea gate is damaged." She put the report down on the table in the middle of the room. "I compared it to the last ten years of scouting reports. There's not a single mention of the sea gate as anything other than in perfect working condition. One of the most recent reports described it as magnificent."

Shadow Weaver's hair started to stand up from growing magic pulled from the Black Garnet. With a flick of her wrist, the room erupted in shadow spies with one red eye each.

Adora startled as they moved around the room, closing the door, checking and blocking the vents.

"Please excuse the theatrics. When talking of such heavy matters, it's best to make sure there are no prying ears or eyes." Shadow Weaver took a seat and motioned for Adora to sit down too. "So, what is your conclusion?"

Adora sat in the chair opposite Shadow Weaver with the table between them. It felt weird not to be standing at attention, but she was not going to question it. "I think my suspicions have been confirmed. Someone is falsifying reports. Now we just need to find out who has been doing this."

Shadow Weaver relaxed in her seat as one of the shadow spies grabbed a bottle and put it on the table. Another spy grabbed two long-stemmed glasses and put one in front of Adora, one in front of Shadow Weaver.

Adora watched, confused.

Shadow Weaver grabbed the bottle and popped the cork with one clawed finger. "I'm proud of you, Adora. I want to reward you for your excellent work." She poured the liquid from the bottle into the two glasses.

Adora may have been sitting, but she wasn't at ease. If anything, everything Shadow Weaver said just made her more on edge. She

didn’t like this at all. Everything Shadow Weaver was doing was breaking protocol, and that was never good.

Shadow Weaver pushed a glass of the liquid toward Adora on the table. “Drink with me.”

Adora hesitated.

Shadow Weaver said more forcefully, “Drink.”

Adora grabbed the glass and took a drink like a good soldier following orders. It was astringent and barely sweet. She had to force herself to swallow.

Despite saying they were drinking together, Shadow Weaver didn’t pick up her glass. “I made those false reports.”

Adora felt dizzy and put down the glass as she tried to make sense of those words.

“I have been using my shadow spies to keep track of the various kingdoms and territories. I have falsified documents to make those kingdoms and territories appear stronger and more aggressive than they are in an attempt to control the pace of the war. The Horde hasn’t officially sent out a real scouting unit since you were a baby.”

Adora’s vision started to blur. She held her head to steady herself. “I don’t understand.”

“And you don’t need to.” Shadow Weaver paused for a moment before adding, “Now, you’re going to remember this differently. You’re going to remember you confronted me about the reports, I seemed shocked and horrified, and you demanded a bribe to keep this information quiet or else discredit me as second in command.”

Adora shook her head. “I don’t-” She didn’t remember what she was going to say. She felt like she was underwater.

“And I was impressed at your ruthlessness, and I gave you the bribe, which you happily accepted. After you leave today, you will do everything in your power to keep the false reports hidden, especially when you’re planning any attacks I order.”

By now, the herbs and magic had taken their full effect, and Adora stared blankly at her.

Shadow Weaver took a deep breath and asked, “So, Adora, what is it you want for your bribe.”

“Catra.” She said it without hesitation.

Shadow Weaver rolled her eyes. “I know, and that’s the one thing I will never give you.”

Adora, separated from her regular filters, grit her teeth. Her jaw worked. Rage burned in her eyes.

Shadow Weaver sat forward as she thought she saw the faintest hint of glowing blue magic. “Interesting. I thought anger might do it.” She would have to make a note about that later. “I need you to pick something else. Something more reasonable.”

Adora’s fists clenched.

Shadow Weaver waved her hand. “Calm down.”

Adora reacted instantly. The rage was gone.

“Now, think of something else you want.”

Adora’s brain worked without her conscious thought. It waded through her memories and all the moments recently that she had felt inadequate. The image that boiled up was of Scorpia getting Catra cookies and candy. “Contraband,” Adora said flatly.

Shadow Weaver’s eyebrows raised under the mask. “Oh! I see Scorpia must have said something. Good. A share of the contraband distribution would be adequate. Enough that you’d be

satisfied you got something of value without raising suspicions. It could be easily explained with simple favoritism."

"And a boat."

Shadow Weaver deflated a little. "Oh, now you're just getting selfish. I just said a share of the contraband was perfect."

"And a tank."

"That's enough." Shadow Weaver waited to see if Adora would respond. The drink she took would be wearing off soon. "You'll get a share of the contraband and nothing more. *We* must keep this secret- especially from Catra."

Adora flinched at the word.

Shadow Weaver had to act quickly. It was starting to wear off. "She's too clever, too curious, and too spiteful to keep anything like this to herself. She has already nearly destroyed my plans more than once, without even knowing what she was doing."

Adora swayed a little in the chair.

Shadow Weaver changed tactics, knowing the effects were wearing off. "As it is, if this all fails, she will escape unharmed. I know how much she *means* to you. But now that you know- You can help me keep the truth from her and everyone else so that she can be kept safe from the consequences."

Adora nodded and put her hand to her head as it felt like she was emerging from water. Adora's eyes fell on the drink, and she pushed it forward. "I don't want any more."

Shadow Weaver leaned back, lounging on her chair. "It is an acquired taste. Someday you might appreciate it."

Adora very much doubted that.

"So, we are in agreement, are we not?"

Adora had to work hard to remember what that agreement was. It floated up into her thoughts as clear as if it had happened exactly the way she had been instructed to remember it. She had been- what was the word? Ruthless. That was new for Adora. She thought maybe Catra would be proud if she knew, but she would never ever tell her. "Yeah."

"You should probably use your share of the contraband to get more protein in your diet. Those ration bars won't give you much to grow on if you're to get stronger. You don't think Scopria got as powerful as she is off ration bars do you?"

Adora's adrenaline spiked at the name.

Shadow Weaver smiled to herself at a job well done.

"Am I dismissed?"

"Of course." Shadow Weaver waved, and the shadow spies dissipated.

Adora got up on shaky legs and left, still trying to piece together what had happened.

She made it to her room and opened the door expecting to get tackled. Instead, she shut the door and turned on the light to Catra in bed.

Catra sneezed and talked with a voice more gravelly than usual. "How'd your little top secret thing go?"

Adora walked to the bed. "You look miserable."

Catra buried her face in the pillow and mumbled, "You look miserable."

Adora sat down on the bed and put a comforting hand on Catra's shoulder. "I'll see if I can find some medicine for you tomorrow."

Catra looked up from the pillow, red eyes and all. “What are you going to do? Put a splint on my face and wrap me in gauze?”

Adora pinched Catra’s back and earned a weak defense. “I have a share of the contraband distribution. I can see if they have anything.”

At that, Catra sat up. Any sign of playfulness was gone. “What happened?”

“What do you mean what happened? My secret mission went well. I got a share of the distribution.”

“That’s not fucking likely.”

“What?”

Catra shook her head. “Shadow Weaver’s not an idiot. If she handed out contraband shares to anyone who did one thing well, she’d have no contraband to give out. That shit’s usually reserved for- I don’t know- arrangements.” Catra looked Adora over. “What did you agree to?”

“What?”

“She offered you a bribe to do something you’re not ok with. Based on where we were today, it’s probably got something to do with how unprepared they’d be for a Horde attack, and you looked shocked and-”

Adora put a hand on each of Catra’s shoulders and looked her in the eye. “I need you to stop.”

That took Catra by surprise. It was not Adora’s normal response. Catra’s brain raced to find the cause, and she caught a whiff of something on her breath. Catra leaned in, breathing in through a stuffy nose. “You smell like Shadow Weaver during her ‘me’ time.”

Adora backed off, self-conscious about her breath. “She offered me something. I only had a little.”

Catra knew, at that moment, something was wrong. Catra bared her teeth and shrank back. “Well, I guess I’m sleeping in the barracks tonight. Can’t sleep with that smell on you.” She hoped Adora recognized the offer to stop like she was asked, even if this whole thing smelled foul.

“I’ll brush my teeth.”

“Nope. Leaving you forever.” Catra settled back into the bed, pressing her face into Adora’s pillow.

The light shut off, and Adora’s hand found Catra’s back. “Thank you.” She said it quietly while starting to lay down, fighting for the barest edge of her pillow. It put their heads close.

Catra didn’t react because she was busy being angry at Shadow Weaver. Angry at the smell on Adora’s breath that she specifically was not brushing off. Angry at the whole situation. Angry that she was told to back off. She didn’t want to lose Adora, physically or mentally. She didn’t want Shadow Weaver tainting Adora with unscrupulous agreements.

Adora put an arm around Catra and pulled her body in. She needed the extra comfort that night, and no amount of shame was going to stop her. She suspected Catra needed it too but would never ask. She felt Catra relax in her hold, so she kept it.

Catra sneezed.

Adora tried to hold it back, but a giggle started to emerge from her chest.

Catra covered her head with the other pillow. “Just smother me already.”

Princess Scorpia

Scorpia made herself incredibly comfortable in Shadow Weaver's new chairs. "I love these. When did you get them?"

Shadow Weaver got right to business. "I want a report on your *mission* ."

Scorpia's face went blank.

"With Catra. The mission with Catra."

"Oh! Yeah. Sure. It's going great. What was it again? Saving her from herself- totally doing that."

"And *distracting* her."

"Sure- sure." Scorpia thought hard, and the board game came up. The trip on the boat. Working out. Sure she wanted to do more, but that was a pretty good little set of activities. "I'd say that's going extremely well."

The table between them had a dainty teapot and small delicate teacups. Scorpia smiled nervously as she started to try to pick one up with her pincer. It slipped, spilling some tea on the table. "Oh, sorry. They're so small."

Shadow Weaver didn't seem to be paying any attention. She was lost in thought. "I've noticed she hasn't been in the barracks."

Scorpia was distracted. She managed to get the teacup in a good pinch and barely lifted it off the table without spilling. Context is so important, and Shadow Weaver would have never realized what she said could be misinterpreted. "Yeah, because she's with me all the time now." Scorpia meant during the day. Of course, Catra wouldn't be hanging out in the barracks during the day because she was in Scorpia's squad. She thought it was odd Shadow Weaver would even point it out, but knew better than to ask for clarification.

Shadow Weaver then watched as Scorpia tried desperately to bring the tea to her lips.

Just a hair too hard. The cup broke in two, dumping the tea on her uniform. She dropped the cup pieces to the table as she gave up. She preferred mugs.

"If I find out you've hurt her-"

"Jeez! What is with you? You invite me to tea, give me cups I can't even pick up, and then accuse me of what? I don't even know, but I don't like your tone." She jabbed a pincer toward Shadow Weaver and then realized what she was doing and put her pincer down.

Shadow Weaver put down her full cup of tea. There was no point in pretending she'd drink it. "Catra is insolent. She's full of anger. She has bad impulse control. I suspect if you spend any amount of time *close* to her, that you will find she has a way of finding your buttons and pushing them just to manipulate you." Shadow Weaver couldn't hide the growing frustration in her voice.

Scorpia tried to wipe the quickly cooling tea on her uniform. "Are you and I talking about the same Catra? Because if I got the wrong one, then I take it back, my mission is going horribly."

"She'll be docile as long as she gets her way, which- if she is that way with you, then perhaps your mission is going better than you even know. Keep it up and distract her from her more destructive *obsessions* ."

Scorpia paused, contemplating something before figuring subtlety had never been her strong suit, so she should just ask. "Hey, I have a weird question about her and Adora."

Shadow Weaver bristled at the invoking of Adora's name, but her voice was calm. "Of course. Ask away."

"Are they ok?"

“They are both in perfect working condition.”

“Yeah, no, I get that- I mean like- they both seem kind of emotionally stunted. Did something happen to them growing up?”

Shadow Weaver didn’t even mean to pull magic from the Black Garnet, but it responded to her anger, so the air cracked with red energy. She tried to calm herself. “I assure you, their emotional wellbeing is none of your concern.”

“I mean- the mission and all- it kind of is.”

Shadow Weaver worked hard to push her anger down, package it, and tuck it away. “I raised them to be survivors in a cruel and dark world. I wanted them to both be strong, and I believe I have succeeded.”

Scorpia was very glad she spilled the tea instead of drinking it. Drinking it would have been a slight obligation to finish, and she got the sense that she didn’t want to be in the room with this woman any longer than she needed to be.

Scorpia’s question was answered. Catra and Adora didn’t have anything, in particular, happen to them. They had *someone* happen to them. In the context of the woman before her being their only guardian, their weird reactions to normal things made sense. Scorpia, being who she was, doubled down on her promise to be there for Catra, and as an addendum, added Adora to that. They were just two hurt, scared, and possibly abused horde kids who needed loyalty and hugs, and that’s just what Scorpia had in abundance. “I guess I’ll be on my way.” Scorpia started to get up.

“One more thing.”

Scorpia, reluctantly, sat back down.

Shadow Weaver waved a hand, and up from her desk floated a scroll.

All Scopria had to do was open her pincer, and it came to her. She looked it over and was disappointed to see the seal was small and delicate. She'd rip it into pieces just trying to open it. The world wasn't made for giant pincers, and not for the first time in her life she wished she had taken after her other mother. "What is it?"

"It arrived for you through a magical summons. It's from the kingdom of Snows. It's been ten years since the last celebration."

Scorpia's broad shoulders fell as all the pieces fell into place. "Oh. Princess prom. Great." Her voice was flat. She couldn't muster her normal positive attitude. This drained it out of her.

"If you choose to go, I am obligated to provide you with resources and time off, as per the agreement reached with your family."

Scorpia didn't wait to be dismissed. She stood up and held the scroll carefully but with no amount of joy. "Yeah, I'll think about it."

She left the room and, with a heavy heart, heeded to the gym where she was supposed to meet Catra. That thought lightened her up a bit.

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Adora did her twentieth pull-up when Catra jumped on top of the pull-up bar.

"Whatcha doing there?"

Adora relaxed a little to hang. "Can't you let me finish?"

Catra's ears went back. Her tail lashed from side to side. "I don't know. I was in here waiting for Scorpia, and then I saw you doing- not what you're supposed to be doing. Don't you have a briefing or something to go to?"

Adora groaned. The briefings were useless. They were half false information anyway. She considered going that morning just for

the optics of being seen at the meeting, but who cared. Her time would be better spent getting an extra hour in the gym. “I’m skipping it.”

Catra gave her a toothy smile. “Oh, I like this. What happened to turn you into such a rebel?”

Rebel. Adora hated that term. She had been taught to hate that term since she was little. She was slightly angry at Catra for using it. “Nothing happened. I just wanted to work out more today.” Her hands were starting to hurt.

Catra, playfully, stepped right on Adora’s fingers but not hard enough to actually hurt her- just hard enough to keep her from letting go. “Oh, come on. We both know you’re not the type to skip meetings without a reason.”

“Just working out.”

“Just working out or working out a plan to take over Salineas next? No one cares if you’re at some stupid meeting when you’re about to win the war.” Catra smiled like she knew she was clever.

Adora hitched her legs to pull up and then push Catra off the bar with her free hand.

Catra jumped with a squeal, and a laugh, ending up on the top of the next machine.

Adora let go of the bar and landed on her feet. She did a quick glance to see if anyone was near enough to hear. It was early enough that they were mostly alone. “We’re not going after Salineas, and I need you to stop talking about it.”

Catra’s smile was gone. She sat pitched on the top of the bench press machine. “What do you mean you’re not going after it? It’s an easy target.”

Adora focused on Catra and made sure it was a firm and unflinching glare. “Salineas is too powerful to take right now.”

Catra stared at her, wide-eyed and shocked. “But I saw it. It was-”

Adora cut her off. “Salineas is too powerful to take right now. Trust me.”

Catra’s eyes narrowed on Adora. Was she joking? Didn’t look like it. No, from the looks of it, she was serious. Catra’s claws reflexively extended and retracted against the metal of the bench while she worked through it. It had to have something to do with Shadow Weaver’s agreement with Adora, but that would make no sense if Shadow Weaver wanted to win the war. Catra’s claws came out and stayed out when it finally sunk into place. Shadow Weaver didn’t want to win the war. Catra’s brain reeled.

Adora watched Catra’s ears move and twitch, and her face go through several thoughts before landing on surprise and horror. “Nope! You thought a thing! Stop it. Don’t think that. Whatever it is!”

Catra’s heart sank. That reaction only confirmed it. What the hell? Who ends up second-in-command of a war machine when they don’t want to win the war? Why? What was her game then? She looked at Adora, and a thought flashed in her head. Whatever the game was, Adora was a part of it.

Adora started climbing the equipment and did the unthinkable of grabbing Catra’s tail while she was deep in thought.

Catra startled out of her thoughts at the touch and glared down at Adora. Her claws worked the metal again to avoid swiping.

Adora tugged it, knowing full well she was breaking many of their unspoken rules. “Whatever you think is going on is not what it is. Stop thinking that and get down!”

“You’re not my Force Captain. I can do whatever I want.” She reached for her own tail and paused as she stared Adora down.

Adora wasn’t trying to hurt Catra. She just needed to show she meant business, so she let go.

Once Adora let go even the slightest bit, Catra yanked her tail out of Adora's hand. She petted it to soothe the feeling of the rough treatment. "Also, fuck you for bringing my tail into this."

Adora took one more step on the equipment and managed a shaky sit on the top opposite Catra. "There are good reasons we're not going after Salineas. I'm just not allowed to talk about them."

"Right."

"Why do you two always go for the high ground?" Scorpia yelled as she came into the room. She walked up to the bench press bar, the scroll still in her pincer, and shook her head. "It's like you two are scared of the floor. Oh, wait! Are you playing the-floor-is-lava?"

Adora and Catra stared at Scorpia like she was a crazy person. "The floor is what now?" Catra managed.

"Old kids game. Anyway, get down before one of you falls, and I get skinned alive for letting it happen."

Adora immediately climbed down. Catra didn't. Her attention was on the scroll. "What is that?"

Scorpia let out a slow and long defeated breath. "An invitation to Princess Prom."

That made Catra jump down. She grabbed for the scroll, and Scorpia let her have it without any resistance. Catra broke the seal without asking and started unraveling it. The heavy part fell out of her hand, landed on the floor, and rolled- and rolled- and kept rolling until it hit the far wall. "Oh, wow. Who did they intercept this from?"

Scorpia had never looked so uncomfortable. "Intercept? No, It's mine." She was met with blank stares from both Adora and Catra. "There you two go again, being all weird. Did I say something wrong?"

Catra turned the edge of the scroll around and held it to Scorpia. "Hello? Did you get hit in the head during your meeting, or did Shadow Weaver do something to your memory? This is for Princesses."

Scorpia blinked at them, then shifted her feet, and her pincer scratched the back of her neck. She managed a smile. "Jeez, I thought everyone knew. I'm a princess."

Adora jumped back with wide eyes and a stance ready to fight while Catra's mouth dropped.

Scorpia laughed a little, then added, "Really, I thought you two would know the story- growing up in the Horde and all. My family lived here before Hordak showed up. My grandfather made an agreement- handed over the Black Garnet, this little chunk of land called the Fright Zone, and our family's princess. I'm obligated to be a Force Captain until I have kids or die- I guess."

Adora and Catra both stared at her like they had seen a ghost.

Catra quickly recovered and turned her attention to the invitation. "I have to admit, you know how to keep a woman on her toes."

Adora's brain finally relaxed as she realized that's why Scorpia had a boat and all that freedom. She was royalty. Adora looked back at Scorpia with a growing sense of helplessness. There was no way she could compete with royalty. Her whole life, she had hated princesses, but now she desperately wanted to be one, if only for the extra freedom- for what she could do for Catra. But- you didn't just become a princess. The rift between them was too great. She was tempted to just give up and hand Catra over right then and there, but the thought of giving up made her angry, and she was not a quitter. With a set of her jaw and a nod to herself, she jumped back onto the pull-up bar and started working out her problems on the steel. She would get stronger. That's how she was going to deal with this.

Catra rolled her eyes at her friend's obvious envy problem. She was determined to let Adora's little crisis work itself out. She focused back on the invitation. "So, are you going to go?"

Scorpia sat down on the bench press machine, and it creaked under her weight. "I don't know. It's not like I fit in. The fact that my family was the one that immediately joined up with Hordak- the other princesses don't like that. They didn't exactly like us before the Horde either."

Catra tried to read the first paragraphs of the invitation with Adora counting off her envy as pull ups. "You get a plus one." She blinked and looked up as an idea formed. "Scorpia-"

"Yeah?"

"You know when I said we needed to work on your ambition?"

"Yeah."

"You're going to this, and I'm going as your plus one, and we're going to raise hell. Shake up the rebellion a bit, and show the higher-ups here that you're not someone to be messed with."

Adora dropped from the bar, not sure if she liked the idea, but the look on Catra's face made her keep quiet. She looked up at Scorpia and found her beaming with pride. Fuck. "I mean, you're not going to get any of that approved."

Catra gave Adora a smug smile and held out the invitation. "Didn't you hear? She's a princess. She's got her own squad, her own vehicles. She's going to this, and she doesn't need anyone's approval."

Adora took the invitation offered, and her heart sank. "Look at all these rules. You'd need a whole team of people to help you sort through them."

Catra threw an arm around Adora's shoulder and ran a claw down her arm. "Or, one really detail-oriented Force Captain who seems

to not be engaged with anything at the moment."

Adora groaned as she looked back at the instructions. She knew better than to try to change Catra's mind at this point. Any attempt would only make her double down harder. The best thing she could do was help out to avoid an unexpected international incident. "Ok fine. I'll read through it and give you a battle plan." She hesitated then offered, "I'll investigate the various people involved and create flashcards for you."

Catra hit Adora in the back. "That's my girl. With the three of us, we'll get so much chaos done that our names will go down in the history books." She made intense eye contact with Scorpia. "You with me?"

Scorpia felt faint. "To the ends of the earth."

Adora glared at the text and gripped the sides to avoid saying or doing anything to reveal how much their chumminess bothered her.

Scorpia smiled big and grabbed them both in a hug. "Gosh! I'm so happy to have you two as friends."

Adora, for a moment, was stunned not just by the hug but by the realization that Scorpia called her a friend. Then she panicked. "People can see us!"

Scorpia hugged a little tighter. "So?"

"Displays of affection are strongly discouraged!" Adora had never in her life had a hug this strong. Her brain panicked at the contact, the closeness, the restriction.

Scorpia sighed and squeezed them both a little more. She closed her eyes, sad for the life these two had to live. "It's ok. No one's going to hurt you, not as long as I'm around."

Adora froze. She wasn't sure why Scorpia would say it that way. When the large woman let them go, Adora couldn't put into words

the confusion she felt. Half of her never wanted to be touched like that ever again- and half of her wanted nothing more than to make it happen. She turned back to the invitation to avoid the dissonance she felt.

***

Throughout the day, Adora read through the whole scroll and found no fewer than six hidden tabs. She also cross-referenced the files the Horde had on the princesses and the various kingdoms, and yeah, maybe the reports were falsified, but *some* of the information had to be correct, and it was all she had.

That evening after dinner, she had Catra sit on the bed while she dragged out a cork board she got from the contraband distribution and a pointing stick. "Ok, here me out. Plan of attack. All weapons have to be checked at the door." She tapped the board. "This might be our only chance to pick up any specialty weapons. The snow kingdom's guards are easy to impersonate."

"That's going to be you, right?"

Adora stopped. "Me?"

"Yeah. you're a part of this."

Adora took a long moment to mull that over. "I guess I could. I don't know if it's worth trying to get approval."

"Don't you want to?"

Adora put down her pointer and folded her arms. "I'd love to see places beyond the Fright Zone."

"And don't you want to compare the kingdom of snows to the reports?"

Adora felt sick to her stomach.

Catra took the silence as admission. “Then you’re coming with us. You can drive Scorpia and me as her chauffeur or something.”

Adora wanted to get back to the presentation.

“Come on! Don’t you want to see me all dressed up?”

That got Adora’s attention, and she looked back with keen interest.

Catra got up off the bed with a smile. “What do you think? Something form-fitting for sure. Maybe purple?”

Adora allowed herself to look at Catra’s body while she was showing off. “I think I saw clothes at the contraband pickup. I’m sure Scorpia could get you something that would look great.” Just suggesting it hurt. She should have gotten something while she was there earlier and not wasted her share on a corkboard.

“This is going to be awesome.” Catra sat back down, her ears tall and wide. Her tail was doing a roll that showed she was hyped up.

Adora grabbed her pointer and tried to focus back on the scroll. “There’s a lot of stuff you’re going to have to memorize, and there’s not a lot of time.”

“We’ll keep radio contact. You can keep track of everything for me.”

Adora glared back at her. “I haven’t agreed to go yet.”

“You should.”

“Even if I did, there’s other stuff- stuff I can’t just feed you through a radio. There are traditional dances.”

Catra groaned and fell back on the bed.

“You and Scorpia have to practice.”

Catra closed her eyes. “I don’t want to dance with Scorpia.”

“Why not?”

“Because she's-” Catra hesitated, then opened her eyes. “She’ll take it the wrong way.”

Adora’s heart never soared so high. She moved forward as the first bit of hope in all her life appeared. “I guess it would be better if you two could split up and cover more ground. Assume you’d both have to dance with someone else to do better intel gathering.”

At that, Catra smiled as she looked up from the bed. “I knew I could trust you with this battle plan.”

Adora, happy for the first time in weeks, turned back to the corkboard full of string and written out notes. “You’ll still have to practice dancing.”

“Sure. I assume you’ve already memorized the moves.”

Adora looked at Catra like she had been waiting her whole life to answer that question. “Backwards and forwards. I can talk you through it.”

Catra got on her feet, nearly bouncing with eagerness. “I promise I’ll remember if you show me.”

Adora felt a lightness in her heart, a quickness to her thoughts. She stood up and got in the starting position with her hand out. “Mirror me.”

Adora had known early that Catra was a kinesthetic learner. As long as it was physical, she rarely had to be shown something more than once or twice. Combat moves were boring for her because they came so quickly, and that led to her getting in trouble a lot during training because she was bored, but this- this was the exact type of thing Catra was good at.

At that moment, Catra casually mirrored Adora’s stance and position like it was second nature. Adora watched with wonder at

how easily it all came to her. Adora had to think through the lists- back straight, hand out, toe pointed toward your partner- and there Catra did the whole thing without reading a single word of it. Adora got a devilish smile. "The basic dance is all mirrored. Let's see how fast you can keep up." Challenges were a great motivation.

She moved to the next position, and Catra smiled as she got it perfect. Adora sped through the next three moves until the spin away, and Catra stayed with her. Adora turned back, so impressed and proud of her friend. "Now do it on your own. Show me you remember."

"Easy!" Catra went back to the starting position, and point by point, laid it out perfectly. Perfect posture. She was a natural.

"The spin away is to a few new partners, then come back to the original. There are variations."

Catra beamed. "Lay it on me."

They went through it all again, this time stopping at what was optionally a lift. "If your partner is someone you can pick up, and you're on the right side, then this is a lift."

"What do you mean by lift?" Catra stood ready, but her face displayed confusion.

"Here. If I'm in position-" Adora moved to be on the lifting side. "Then you kind of hitch into my arms and -" Adora huffed, and lifted Catra up, and did a gentle spin before setting her down.

Catra beamed. "Do it again."

Adora's heart skipped. "Ok." They rushed back into the beginning position and started. Adora should have expected Catra to remember it perfectly, but it still surprised her how easy it was- how their moves seemed to be perfectly timed- and how damn good it felt to lift catra up.

Catra landed again and couldn’t stop smiling. “It’s not often I get carried.”

“Scorpia sure does it a lot.”

“Leave Scorpia out of this.” Catra pushed Adora away a little rougher than she intended. “What’s next?”

Adora turned back to the scroll. “The optional dip.” She paused for a moment. “Let me show you real quick what it's supposed to be.” She motioned for Catra to come to her. Adora adjusted her to be in the right position, then quickly tipped her.

Catra let out a gasp of surprise before she realized where she was- gripping Adora’s shoulders half way on her back. “Oh, I like this. My turn.”

Adora pulled her back up and swung her out into the final position before they readjusted. Adora got into the receiving end of the dip, pulling Catra’s back to her chest. Her heart was beating.

Catra rolled her shoulder into it and swung Adora into a low dip, firmly holding her back. Adora’s arms were supposed to be holding on to her partner’s neck, so she was, and their legs were supposed to be that way, so they were, and Adora’s heart never beat so hard for so little work. “You’re really getting the hang of this,” she managed to say through the fact that she was out of breath and only partially from the physical exertion.

Catra swung her back up and out, holding her at arm's length, not even winded, but breathing deeply regardless. “I could do this all day.”

They didn’t let go. For a moment, they were both struck by the other one- reeling from the intimate positions the dance had brought them to and dealing with the complicated feelings that caused.

Then the lights shut off, and they let go of each other.

In the dark, Adora tried to get a hold of herself and still her beating heart.

Catra watched, unsure if Adora's reaction was panic in a good way or panic in a bad way. Her heart hurt at the thought that it had been the bad panic.

They both took a breather, and Adora managed a laugh. "I guess we lost track of time."

"It was fun, though."

"Yeah." In the dark, standing there helpless in more than one way, Adora tried not to think of how much she wanted to be on that dance floor with Catra at this prom thing. The idea that people would see them and be jealous of how good they were- how well they worked together. The fact that it wasn't going to happen only made her sad.

Catra watched that gorgeous face turn sad in the dark, and there were so many things she wanted at the moment. Instead of getting any of them, she got back onto the bed and offered, "We'll practice again in the morning and at lunch. All the variations."

Adora smiled to herself, slightly hopeful. "Yeah. That sounds great." She put her hands out to find the bed.

Catra moved forward and took her hands to lead her back. "Don't want you stubbing a toe before we've practiced."

And there it was again, that sad face, then a hopeful smile. "Yeah. Thanks." Adora stopped at the edge of the bed, kicked off her boots, took off her jacket, and felt around for where to get in.

Catra moved to provide Adora space and stared at her while she climbed in. Catra waited to see if Adora would pull her in like last night, and when it didn't happen, she sighed and laid on her back. "It's stupid to get excited over a dance, but literally- it's the most fun I've had since you and I started racing to the forge."

Adora laid on her back too and stared at the ceiling. She understood. It was like learning a complicated chokehold or a wristlock, only way less painful on the receiving end. “We haven’t raced in years. I bet I could still beat you.” Nothing like cutting the tension with playful banter.

“In a fair race, maybe, but when have I ever played fair?” Catra breathed deeply and decided if she was ever going to say it, she needed to say it now. “So, Shadow Weaver is bribing you not to reveal that she’s been holding the Horde back through false reports.”

Adora’s body stiffened. Her eyes shot open in the dark. Her brain raced about what to say. It was wrong, the reports were falsified, but Adora didn’t know why or who had done it, did she? She couldn't remember. Her head hurt every time she thought about it.

That lack of a response was all Catra needed for confirmation. “Use it against her. Tell her you have to go to this prom thing as backup to maintain the secret. Tell her I’ll probably learn something I shouldn’t, and you’ve got to be there to make up some excuse for what I’ve found out.”

Adora, for a moment, did nothing and said nothing. That long stretch of silence continued. Instead of addressing it, she rolled over with her back toward Catra like she hadn’t heard anything. Still, the idea wasn’t bad. If Shadow Weaver couldn’t stop Scorpia from going and taking Catra, then Shadow Weaver would want someone there to keep tabs on them. It might as well be her.

Adora yelped when she felt a hand snake around her waist.

“What? You can hug me one night but I can’t hug you back the next? Tough. I want cuddles, so deal with it.” She pressed herself to Adora’s back and put her nose in Adora’s hair.

After a moment, Adora relaxed.

Apparently, this was how things were going to go from then on. Hugs in the dark when no one was looking. If Scorpia could do it out in the open, then they could at least do it when they were alone.

It was going to make it hard to sleep. Adora's heart was beating so hard, she was sure Catra could hear it. She was overwhelmed with the idea that Catra would know how helpless this made her- how weak. What an imbalance. She closed her eyes and tried to calm down by telling herself it didn't *mean* anything. It was just a hug- something they both wanted and needed. That thought calmed her down and brought tears to her eyes as she closed them in the dark. She didn't know why that thought hurt- but it hurt more than anything.

Catra was surprised that Adora didn't stop her. She felt the same excitement she had at the dip- just another moment of closeness to someone she desperately wished she could hold onto and never let go.

Getting to sleep was hard for both of them that night.

Princess Prom

Days' worth of prep all came up to this moment. While Scorpia was in the back of the hovercraft touching up her outfit, Adora motioned for Catra to come closer.

Catra adjusted her blazer top and presented herself to Adora.

Adora looked her over, put her hands on Catra's undone bow tie, and started tying it.

Catra squirmed a bit as the tie got tighter on her neck. "Oh, come on. It looks cooler untied."

"Stay still," Adora said gently as she tried to follow the invitation's instructions for tie tying. Once done, she stood back a bit and realized in a moment how good Catra looked in a suit. Too good. The bow tie was too much. Too clean and nice for suit pants Catra had slashed the knees out of and too nice for an antagonist. She sighed and gave Catra a soft smile before undoing the tie and also undoing the top button of Catra's shirt. "Just enough to be out of regulation, but not enough to get kicked out."

Catra was frozen at the casual way Adora had undone her first button. Her heart was pounding from such a small touch so casually done. She watched Adora's face, painfully aware that Adora had no idea the effect she had.

Adora started pulling her hands away but stopped. "Remember, find someone the exact opposite of Perfuma. A weaker power set- more aggressive. Someone easy to rile up."

Catra nodded as she tried to recover from the button. "Yeah, yeah." She forced herself to think through the night, working through the options they had discussed together. She was not thinking of the feeling of Adora's fingers on her shirt.

"We're kind of relying on you since I don't think Scorpia could antagonize someone if she tried."

Catra visibly shivered with excitement. “I won’t disappoint you.”

Adora was, for the moment, struck by both how Catra looked and the fact that she was worried- of all things- about disappointing *her* . She smiled and hit Catra’s lightly in the shoulder. “Careful, or someone might think you care.”

“Not likely,” Catra said with a lopsided smile, her tail constantly flicking behind her.

Adora got close and took off her badge. She gently took Catra’s lapel in her hand and pinned it to her. “I’ll keep an eye on you through this. We’ll be able to communicate. I’ll have a video feed from it to my communicator.” She hesitated, her fingers lingering on the fabric as if letting go would be letting go of Catra herself. “Be careful. You’re about to go into a room with all the most powerful people on Etheria.”

Catra seemed entranced by the way Adora touched her suit, the look in her eye. “You’ve got that wrong. They’re about to be put in a room with me.”

“I don’t want to have to pull out the medical kit, so at the first sign of real trouble- you run.”

Catra’s good mood was gone, and she pulled away. “I can handle myself. Besides, I’ve got built-in weapons that can’t be checked at the door.” She held up her hand and flexed her claws to make a point.

“I know- I just-”

Scorpia emerged from the back of the hovercraft, decked out in a black dress and heels. “I am so excited about tonight!” She offered her arm to Catra.

Adora turned away, grabbing the Kingdom of Snows guard mask and fur-lined coat so that she wouldn’t see Catra take Scorpia’s arm so casually.

“Let’s go cause some chaos!” Catra was purring with excitement, and Adora realized as they walked out together that it was the first time she had ever seen Catra purr with anyone else. She stood for a moment, watching them leave as the full weight of the pain hit her.

Adora took that feeling and buried it. She had to focus. Her job was to find a way to take over the weapons drop-off and get something good. She grabbed her communicator tablet and headed to the drop-off with a lot on her mind.

The weapons drop-off was a small building out front. Adora went to the back door of the building quietly and tested the doorknob. It turned easily. She stopped and stared at it in wonder. What did these people think they were doing? It wasn’t even locked. She opened it.

Inside, a man dressed in the traditional fur coat and mask quickly took weapons and uttered, “Yes. You’ll be able to pick it up afterward. Don’t worry. Top-notch security. Name please?” He said it all in a droning monotone. He was bored and scribbling down names on tags to toss weapons into a pile.

“I’m here to relieve you,” Adora said with a salute, then quickly put her hand down as she realized she had no idea what the salute for the Kingdom of Snows was.

He didn’t seem to care or notice. “Finally!” He didn’t ask for her orders or credentials. He didn’t even barely look at her. He just left.

Adora stood in shock at the lax security before someone came up and held out a bundle of weapons that Adora ran forward to take them. She took in mostly swords and axes and a few bows and arrow quivers. She was stunned even as she pretended to take names and carefully tuck weapons away. These people were still fighting with swords- in a world where stun batons and tank cannons existed. How in the world had they not lost yet? A pain

shot through her temple, and she paused to shake it out before going back to work.

Between people, she fired up the communicator. The audio and video feed loaded immediately. She split her attention between taking weapons and watching Scorpia and Catra approach the local princess. The hostess was dressed in blue and white, with black hair. She was- ten years old? Adora looked up from the feed as someone was coming up, but her mind was reeling. The Horde reports said nothing about a child ruler, but then again, that wasn't surprising.

"Are you even paying attention?"

Adora looked up to find a short, angry, pink and purple-headed woman holding a big sword. "I'm sorry. Can I help you?"

The woman slammed the sword down on the counter. "Don't put it with the other swords. It's super important. I don't want it getting lost."

"Name?"

"Glimmer of Brightmoon."

Adora's eyes grew wide behind the mask. The Commander of the rebellion was standing in front of her- had handed over her sword. Adora had to recover quickly. "We'll take good care of it, Commander!" And she saluted. She should not have saluted, but she did. It was a habit.

Commander Glimmer narrowed her eyes- then just as quickly relaxed. "I don't suppose you want to be my plus one? I have a friend I'm trying to make jealous."

Adora felt like she was going to die. "I'm sorry. I have a job and-"

Commander Glimmer huffed and waved her hand. "No. It's fine. It was a long shot anyway." She turned and walked toward the castle.

Adora breathed deep. She was never going to get over the rush of seeing a princess in real life- let alone the Commander of the Rebellion in the flesh- Did she just get asked out? Fuck. Her face felt hot as she turned her attention to the sword in front of her.

It was majestic. Golden hilt. Blue stone. Broad and shining blade. Out of all the weapons she had picked up, this one was the best. She had the sword of Commander Glimmer. With her hands still gloved, she picked it and the communicator, opened the unlocked door, and ran toward the hovercraft. Her whole career with the Horde rested on getting that thing home.

Once inside Scorpia's scorpion-themed hovercraft, she stuffed the sword in one of the few storage boxes and breathed easy. With a job well done, she could relax. She took off her gloves and the mask and sat down. She pulled out the communicator and fired it up to watch the rest of the party through the feed. What showed was a surprisingly mundane scene of people dressed up, casually talking to each other. She hit the talk button. "How are things going?"

Catra heard Adora's voice come out a little too clearly from her badge, and she tapped it to respond. "Shockingly boring. No one has tried to stop us or even approached us. It's like they don't even realize there's a war going on."

Scorpia was distracted by the food in front of her, and she was stuffing everything she could manage into her face. With a half-full mouth, she muttered, "Oh wow, I don't even know what this is, but it's amazing." She looked to Catra, her cheek sticking out. "You should try this."

Catra rolled her eyes. "We're not here to enjoy the food. We'll have some when we take this place in a few months." She looked around the room desperately, trying to find someone who looked like an easy target.

Adora could barely contain herself. "I got a sword from Commander Glimmer!"

Catra had to cup the communicator in her hand. Adora was benign so loud. She hit the button. “Whisper, Adora. Now, who?”

Adora knew the flashcards had been useless. Catra couldn’t keep the names separate. She had given them all nicknames. “The Rebellion's Commander Glimmer- She’s a princess of Brightmoon. Short- pleasantly plump- purple and pink hair. Angry... I think she asked me out.”

Catra’s jaw clenched. *Pleasantly plump? What the hell, Adora* . “Power set?”

Adora mentally ran through her memory of the Rebellion's leadership. “You nicknamed her Sparkles. She can teleport and throw light balls at people.”

Catra started to smile as she scanned the crowd. Her eyes landed on someone staring at her- no glaring at her. She matched Adora’s description perfectly, and out of a room full of princesses was the only one who stopped to take note. Catra smiled smoothly. “Target acquired.” She let go of the communicator. “Scorpia, get ready to go outside.”

Scorpia nodded with a mouth full of shrimp and her pincers full of more.

Adora nearly boiled over with excitement. They were going to go after Commander Glimmer. The thought of it made her head hurt, and she ignored it and focused on the video feed.

Catra pushed her way toward the angry princess.

The angry princess, in turn, pushed towards Catra.

They met in the middle of the floor as the other partygoers rolled their eyes and gave them room.

Glimmer poked a finger into Catra’s chest. “You’re a Horde soldier, aren’t you?” She glanced at the badge. “A force captain no less.”

Catra, with a smooth smile, oozed confidence. “Such powers of deduction. Was it the badge or the good looks that gave me away?”

Adora smiled big at that and allowed herself a dorky laugh because there was no one else around to judge her. She sat back, focused on the screen and the absolutely furious face that the princess had.

Commander Glimmer had to get on her toes to get in Catra’s face. “Everyone else might not care, but I know scum like you- You’re up to something, and you made the mistake of bothering me on a bad day. From this moment on until the end of this thing, I’m going to keep my eye on you.”

Catra’s thoughts were awash in dopamine and adrenaline, a rare mix for her that was instantly intoxicating. Something about being so close to winning- so close to someone so dangerous. This was exactly the kind of thing she wanted- dreamed about- getting to use all her cunning on the enemy without having to hold back. “Well then- I’ll give you something to look at.” She winked, then turned while her tail made a swish to accentuate the point.

Glimmer reacted with shock, then blushed- then turned to furious rage.

Adora couldn’t sit still as she readied herself to see her friend unleash her full potential on this poor rebel. She was so proud. She wished so badly that she could be there to witness it in person.

Catra moved through the crowd easily with light feet and fast reflexes. She occasionally turned so that Adora’s badge would catch the sight of the princess. She wanted to give Adora a show.

Adora pulled her feet up on the bench she was on, pulling in so that her trackpad was close and her knees would fit under the fur-lined coat.

Scorpia stood at the edge of the action, tall enough to get a good view. She still ate from the buffet but tried to follow Catra and the small angry one following her.

“Is your tail real?” A high-pitched voice asked.

Scorpa broke her vigil to look around and locate the source of the question. She startled when she realized someone with purple goggles was looking at her from under the table cloth. “Oh- you scared me.”

Purple bands of hair moved the cloth aside and propelled the woman forward until she was lifted up and in Scorpia’s face. She pressed the button of a recorder. “I asked if your tail was real or if it’s some kind of robotic appendage. Please, speak clearly for your answer.” She held the recorder toward Scorpia’s face.

Scorpia blinked, looked at the recorder, and offered a cautious, “Yes?”

Catra pretended to drop something in a trash can, only to have the hot-headed princess drop to her knees and dig through it like an animal. Everyone around them stared. Some put their hands over their mouths in shock at the behavior. Catra couldn’t stop smiling. This was too easy. The moment Commander Sparkles realized there was nothing but trash, she got even angrier. Catra moved fast, acting like she was trying to get away.

Adora couldn’t contain it, and she whispered into the communicator, “You’re a natural.”

Catra soaked in the pure adoration in Adora’s voice. It only fueled her resolve. She’d do anything to hear Adora talk about her like that again.

A few more twists and turns and Catra stopped cold and turned to find Commander Glimmer right on her heels- in the middle of the floor. Adora had been very clear about the timing of everything. The whole event was run off by the music, and if Catra could stay

attuned to which songs were on, she'd be able to use it to her advantage.

The lights went down. The child hostess announced the first dance. Glimmer's face froze in shock as Catra put up her hand. With all the smugness Catra could muster, she offered, "Care to dance?"

Glimmer looked around for any other option and grit her teeth when she realized everyone else around them had paired off. With a sneer and set of her jaw, her hand met Catra's, and the dance music started.

Adora managed a little squeal of delight that all that practice was going to pay off. Before she knew it, she was out of the seat, mirroring the moves with the communicator in one hand.

Glimmer's brows were furrowed, and she glared at Catra throughout the moves. "Whatever you planning-"

Catra wouldn't let her get too far. "Me? You seem like the one planning something. How far did you go to try to get me on the dance floor like this, Princess?"

Glimmer's mouth dropped, and her face turned red. Still, she never lost focus and kept up with the moves.

Adora did the spin away just as Glimmer did. She had given up the ruse of pretending to check Catra's memory. She just acknowledged to herself that dancing alone in the hovercraft was pure indulgence to try to remember what it had felt like. She reveled in the memory of how easy it all was and how nice it felt to have their bodies working so perfectly together.

She came back to the position with Catra just as Glimmer did, and she was lost in the memory of how it felt to have Catra's back leaning into her like that. And how it had felt to- She squealed as she landed on the floor, realizing in a moment she had tried to dip herself without Catra there. She blinked and looked at the communicator still in her hand, only to realize in horror that Catra

had dipped Glimmer too. Adora froze not just at the pain of falling but a new and sudden pain in her chest. Sure- they had practiced the variations to prepare, but for some reason, Adora hadn't considered Catra would do *that* with anyone else.

Catra was hyped up and held Glimmer there for a moment longer than she was supposed to. She wanted to revel in it- enjoy it, and she could tell every second she took only made the girl angrier. She spun Glimmer out at arm's length.

Adora forced herself to bury that feeling as she got off the ground. She had no right to feel jealous. It wasn't like she had a claim- and Catra was just trying to rile the enemy up. She took a breath and got mentally ready. It was almost action time.

From the video feed, Glimmer looked royally pissed. Her cheeks were red with anger. Was she blushing? Adora gripped the edge of the communicator before she tried to calm down.

Catra gave Sparkles the most devilish smile as everything seemed to be falling in place. Now time for the kicker. "Oh, are you lonely? Is that it? Don't you have any friends helping you out?"

Catra guessed. She couldn't have possibly known that this was Glimmer's worst night. That particular dig was going to hit Glimmer so hard in her angry little center that her thoughts would switch to murder. Bow was ninety percent of her self-control, and he was with someone else that night. Glimmer's far hand sparked into a ball of light, and she yelled as she flung it towards Catra's face.

Catra laughed as she dogged and heard the crowd gasp in shock.

From across the room, a boy yelled, "Glimmer! No!"

Glimmer didn't care and produced another ball in her other hand and threw it hard.

Catra slipped her hands into her pockets and laughed as she dodged every attack. She trained her whole life for this, and every

one of the princess's movements were telegraphed. It was like she had never really seen real combat before.

Glimmer didn't care. She made up for her inexperience with pure rage. She pulled back her hand to throw another ball when it was caught by one of the palace guards.

The snow princess stood up from her throne. "How dare you! You are both banished for breaking the rules and ruining my party!"

Glimmer was about to argue back, make a case for the Horde being scum when she was hooked under both arms and roughly dragged toward the door. The only thing that made her not fight was that the Horde scum was also being dragged out.

Glimmer glared at Catra the whole way. "Great. This is exactly what I wanted- to take this outside."

Catra smiled and stuck out her tongue as she let herself be dragged out.

Adora went for the stun baton under the dash. She had to be in place just in case. She paused, considering the sword in the storage unit. She shook her head. Who in their right mind would pick a sword over a stun baton? She dropped the communicator and ran out of the door. Catra needed backup. She would be there for Catra's big moment.

The guards threw Catra and Glimmer out of the door carelessly, and they both tumbled into the snow. Catra rolled and landed in a ready position on all fours, and Glimmer stopped her roll with a fist already glowing.

Glimmer growled and threw a flashy punch.

Catra laughed and rolled out of the way, only to find a new fist flash and appear near her face. Catra's smile was gone as she just barely dodged. "Scorpia!" She yelled. She looked up, expecting Scorpia to have been there. She was supposed to follow her when they got kicked out. "Scorpia?"

Scorpia was inside, realizing in a frantic hurry that she had lost track of Catra. She tried to move toward the door but was stopped by a firm band of purple hair.

"You secrete a venom, right? Is it deadly?" The girl in goggles and grease-stained overalls was in Scorpia's face again with the recorder.

Scorpia glanced past her to see the guards closing the front door. "No time! We'll talk later!" She pushed the woman aside and ran toward the exit through the crowd.

"Damn it!" Catra had no time to react to Scorpia's failure. She had an angry princess in front of her. She frantically got to her feet- cold in the snow from lack of footwear, and readied herself.

Glimmer started to smile as she blinked in and out of existence, first surprising the horde scum from behind and then a flanking blow. Sure, the cat could keep up, but she was just barely able to dodge- and she no longer had that smug look on her face. "What's wrong?" She flashed and teleported and threw a light ball at the cat's face, "Is this too serious for you?" Another jump in space, and she went for a kick to the back of her enemy's leg.

Adora ran as fast as she could up the stairs with the baton ready. She only saw a flash of Catra's surprised face as her leg got kicked out from under her. It made Adora's insides boil. She threw herself into the fight, helping Catra up while flailing around at an impossible-to-hit sparkling princess. Adora and Catra and her fell back-to-back as, for a moment, the princess was out of sight. "You ok?"

Catra breathed heavily, eyes going wild to see where they'd be attacked from next. "Do I look ok?"

Adora scanned the surroundings, determined to die before letting any princess hurt Catra.

A flash of light and Adora had a princess in her face screaming and throwing light balls that she barely dodged. She tried to get

the baton down, but the commander was no longer there before it could make contact. The momentum of the attack left Adora slightly falling forward.

Glimmer flashed in front of Catra- a full force sparkling glittering ball of light ready in her palm while she threw her whole body into it.

Catra dodged the ball of light but couldn't dodge the princess herself. Glimmer slammed into Catra's front, throwing Cara's body into Adora's back. They all ended up in a pile on the ground.

Catra looked up in horror as she saw what she assumed was the last thing she'd ever see. A princess- hands blazing with light- straddling her with murder in her eyes. Catra threw her arms up, assuming she and Adora were going to go down in a blaze of glory against the top-ranking rebel- when the girl suddenly slacked.

Glimmer's eyes rolled up in her head. Her hands fell. She slumped forward onto Catra. Catra looked over her unconscious shoulder to see Scorpia standing out of breath. Her tail was poised after having dealt a severe blow. Catra nearly cried.

Scorpia threw her hair back and gave a confident smile as she locked eyes with Catra. "You ok, Wildcat?"

Catra breathed and smiled big. "You're my hero!"

Adora groaned from the bottom of the pile.

Scorpia scooped Glimmer up into her pincers and over her shoulder and offered her other pincer to help Catra up.

The moment the weight was off Adora's back, she scrambled to her own feet in frustration at her own inability to land a hit. Years of training- all for what? To be entirely outmatched by a single princess in her first real encounter?

Scorpia dragged Catra by the hand back to the hovercraft, and Adora followed.

Scorpia ducked into the vehicle, and Catra- laughing, stopped at the door to offer her hand to Adora.

Adora took her hand, and for a moment, forgot everything except the smile on Catra's face and the lightness of her laugh. Catra pulled her in, and for a moment, they were close and breathing heavily as the door shut.

Scorpia dropped the princess unceremoniously on the floor and took a seat at the controls. The engines started, and the vehicle pushed up.

Catra and Adora braced together against the wall at the vehicle's momentum. Neither of them would know who it was that broke that moment because neither of them wanted to do it, but both felt compelled. At the same time, they turned away and collapsed against the wall.

"You ok?" Catra asked as she pulled off the force captain badge to hand it back.

Adora took her badge and fastened it back to her jacket. "I'm alive, and you're alive. That's all that matters."

Catra's smile was genuine and tired, but her eyes were alight with something. "I've never felt so alive."

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Shadow Weaver heard the radio call-in and had guards waiting for the party when they got back. "Take the prisoner to my chamber," she ordered as she recognized who it was. As they dragged her away, she turned her full attention to Catra. "No one said anything about abducting a princess."

Catra was riding a high that she had wanted all her life. She stood up to Shadow Weaver and stuck out her chest. "Just doing what

none of you had the guts to do."

Shadow Weaver's hair stood on end as the air crackled with magic.

Adora was about to throw herself between them- in the only role she had ever known- when a wall next to them turned on and stuttered with static before displaying the visage of their leader.

Shadow Weaver stopped pulling magic and turned to the screen that had lit up behind them.

Hordak sneered. "I have heard reports that you've captured the Rebel commander."

Catra started to step forward, ready to take and give credit where credit was due. She had been mentally rehearsing this on the flight back. She'd talk up Scorpia and Adora and save her own heroics for last. She barely opened her mouth before-

Shadow Weaver put herself between Hordak's vision and Catra. "Absolutely, Lord Hordak. A successful mission- for our honor."

Hordak's face twisted into a rare and evil smile. "I will send Queen Angella a ransom for her daughter. If she doesn't turn herself in by the next moonrise, she'll never see her daughter again."

Adora was the only one who turned to see Catra's reaction. Catra's face drained of color. Her eyes turned to pinpricks as she mouthed the word, "Daughter?"

Shadow Weaver turned up the charm and managed a shallow bow. "As you wish, Lord Hordak."

Hordak looked pleased, which was a disconcerting look on him. " You have once again proven your value, for now." And with that, the feed cut out.

Catra was reeling with several different realizations and feelings. "You took credit?"

Shadow Weaver turned around sharply with her magic filling the air. “I’m your superior. Anything you *manage* to do correctly is within my right to claim. Now go to the barracks and take off that ridiculous outfit!”

Scorpia moved forward to stand up for Catra and got a glare.

Shadow Weaver narrowed her eyes at Scorpia. “That goes for you too, Force Captain!”

Scorpia was going to say something but looked up to see Catra already running at full speed down the corridor. She gave a sheepish smile and ran to catch up with Catra.

Shadow Weaver turned her attention to Adora.

Adora immediately stood at attention and saluted.

That seemed to make Shadow Weaver relax. “I expect a full report- and do not leave anything out to protect Catra.”

Adora felt sick to her stomach. She didn’t understand why she would need to protect Catra from doing what the Horde was supposed to do.

“Did you end up with anything useful?”

“Yes, ma’am. We got Commander Glimmer’s sword.” Adora’s voice was shaky. She wasn’t even sure why.

Shadow Weaver paused. “That’s odd. I don’t remember her having a sword.”

“I can go get it-”

“No- You’ve done enough. I’ll have someone retrieve it.” She moved in, leaning close to Adora’s face. “I do not like surprises, Adora.”

Adora tried to breathe slowly to stay calm.

“I sent you to make sure something like this wasn’t going to happen.”

Adora’s head hurt, and she knew she had messed up but didn’t know why or how.

Shadow Weaver backed off. “But I can’t blame you for falling for Catra’s harebrained schemes. She always knew how to lure you into the worst of situations.” She turned and took a breath. “You are dismissed for the evening. Go to your room and think about what you’ve done.”

A pain of failure struck through Adora, and she didn’t even know why. She ran as hard and as fast as she could. She got to her room, made the door shut. She closed her eyes and leaned against it- finally alone and able to relax for the first time that day to sort through all the messed up feelings she had about everything.

“Adora, I hate to interrupt your little pity party-”

Adora opened her eyes and flipped on the light.

Catra stood at the foot of the bed frantically pulling off the blazer and the tie.

Adora blanked. “How did you get here so fast? Where’s Scorpia?”

Catra kicked open the trunk at the foot of Adora’s bed and pulled out a backup skin-tight uniform. “I got away from her and came here.”

Adora’s face heated up as she realized, in a moment, that Catra had started unbuttoning her purple shirt. She turned around and focused on the door. “When did you start keeping backup uniforms in my room?”

“I don’t know. A few days ago?”

Adora could hear Catra's clothes going off and on, and she desperately tried to focus on the door and not think too much about that. "Don't you think that's dangerous? They could find it in a search."

Catra scoffed. "They don't search Force Captain's rooms, Adora."

A moment later, Adora felt a hand on her shoulder, and she turned. Catra's nice clothes were strewn about the room, and she was back in her standard uniform, but her face was set with horror.

Catra looked between Adora's eyes. "Why didn't you tell me she was the Rebel Queen's daughter?"

Adora blinked. "I thought you knew."

"How was I supposed to know that?"

Adora felt a fire she didn't expect. "How was I supposed to know you didn't know what a princess was?"

Catra's eyes turned to pinpricks. The color drained out of her face. "We've condemned the Horde."

"What?"

"The Queen has been the one avoiding battle. Between her and Shadow Weaver holding us back, we're practically at a standstill. If she turns herself in- then that princess we nearly died fighting is going to be the head of the rebellion."

Adora blinked as it finally landed on her. "We're all going to die."

Catra pushed Adora's shoulder to get her out of the door. "I've got to go let her out. I have to stop this."

Adora grabbed Catra's wrist firmly. "No- we both have to go stop this. I'm not letting you do this alone."

Catra froze for a moment, looking into Adora's eyes, and she started to smile. "As an added bonus, if Shadow Weaver wants to take credit for capturing her- then she'll have to take the fall when the princess escapes."

Adora nodded and reached back to open the door. She was dedicated to making up for her failure to protect Catra earlier.

Catra watched Adora with awe. The way her face was set- the sternness in her eyes. She wanted to kiss Adora right there and then before their conspiracy had started, but she had to settle for Adora grabbing her hand and pulling her out of the room and down the hall at a full-tilt run.

A Development

Glimmer had no idea where she was when she woke up. The room was dark except for the red glowing magic emanating from the rock next to her and the extension that was binding her. There was a constant low-frequency hum like they had built machinery into the walls. That all meant this was probably the Fright Zone. Shit. The sword- her sword- the one she and Bow had found in the Whispering Woods, was laying on a table between two chairs only a few steps away.

Glimmer took a deep breath and tried to teleport.

For a brief moment, it felt like she succeeded. She was able to move- and then it all collapsed back down to her being stuck between two rods and a force field of magic. Her heart sank. She messed up. She lost her temper and got caught. What was her mother going to say?

She tried to teleport again, this time dipping into more of her magic. Her movements got further, but she still collapsed into captivity.

Stupid catgirl luring her out with a fight. The sting of tears started in the corner of her eyes as she realized she let her temper get the best of her, and now she was alone in the Fright Zone. She closed her eyes and hung her head, allowing herself just a moment of self-doubt. She really messed up this time, and she didn't have a plan to get out of it. Bow would know what to do. That thought stung even more. He wouldn't have let her throw that first punch.

The door opened.

Glimmer looked up. Even in the dark, she could see someone poking their head in through the doorway and look around before waving someone else in. Through the door and into the red light, the catgirl appeared with a smile. Behind her, the blonde that had

joined the fight in the Kingdom of Snows tried desperately to look intimidating by folding her arms and scowling. She was a terrible actor.

The catgirl knelt down to get on Glimmer's level, so their faces were close.

Glimmer sneered. "Come to gloat?"

The girl kept a steady smile but watched unblinkingly. "You put up quite a fight there, princess. I have to admit, I'm a little impressed."

"Let me out of here, and I'll show you what else I can do." Glimmer said it with all the vitriol she could manage. She meant it. If she got free, she'd wreck them both.

The catgirl shook her head. "See, that's the problem. Adora and I want to let you go, but we're both pretty sure you're going to try to kill us if we do."

Glimmer's anger switched off as she heard the name. She blinked and looked between the blonde and the cat as the pieces came crashing together in her brain. "You're the two who let Perfuma go!"

The blonde's eyebrows relaxed, and she dropped her folded arms. She gave up on the act that wasn't fooling anyone.

The catgirl shrugged. "So, maybe we did. Maybe we have good reasons for not keeping princesses around here."

Glimmer, through the pain of the magic holding her, blinked with astonishment. "You're going to let me go... For real?"

The catgirl stood up, putting her hands on her hips. Any hint of a smile was gone. "I mean, we could leave you here if you want- but something tells me you'd rather get back to your mom before she even knows you're gone."

Glimmer strained against the magic. She didn't know if she could trust them, but at the moment, she didn't have much of an option. She nodded.

The catgirl smiled slowly. "Ok. Then we're going to cut the power to these, and you're not going to fight us. Just teleport out like you're supposed to."

Glimmer glanced at the sword.

The catgirl smiled big. "Oh! You think we're going to give you your little weapon too? No. That's ours."

The blonde- Adora- hit the catgirl in the shoulder with a far too casual motion. "Actually- no one is going to believe she got out on her own if she doesn't take the unprotected sword that's right there." She gestured to the table.

The catgirl groaned and rolled her eyes. "Oh, come on! We don't even get to keep the fucking sword?"

The blonde made a face that Glimmer knew from Bow's many apology faces. She confirmed for herself- these were friends who knew each other well- like her and Bow. It struck her as odd. She hadn't really thought of the Horde soldiers having friends.

Catgirl turned back. "Fine! You get the sword- but nothing else. You use your little teleporting powers to get the fuck out of here as fast as possible so this looks like you escaped on your own."

Glimmer met the girl's eyes with grim determination. "Deal."

Adora moved to grab a cable connecting the forcefield to the stone and held it up to her friend.

The catgirl seemed to instinctively know what was being asked, and she extended her claws. A swipe was all it took to slice the cable in half, and Glimmer felt the forcefield dissipate and she fell to the ground as her limbs refused to hold her up.

The catgirl moved forward to get an arm under Glimmer's shoulder to help her up to her feet.

Adora reached for the sword's hilt on the table next to her. She didn't even look while she reached. She was instead looking at Glimmer, her mouth open about to say something when her hand grabbed the hilt.

The room exploded in white light. The blonde collapsed to the floor with the sword in her hand.

The catgirl dropped Glimmer's shoulder to rush to her friend's aid, and Glimmer barely stayed standing.

"What did you do to her!" The catgirl yelled.

Glimmer blinked. "Me? Nothing. I found that sword in the forest and it's done nothing for weeks."

The cat's breathing was short and fast as she hovered her hands over her friend's motionless form. "Adora? Adora, answer me!" She reached for her friend's face.

Glimmer blinked as she realized she was free but not moving. She should leave, but her eyes were glued on the two before her.

The catgirl shook her friend's shoulder, slapped in her face to wake her up- nothing worked.

Glimmer took a shaky step forward. "Come with me."

At that, the catgirl looked back at her and Glimmer saw the terror in her eyes. "What?"

Glimmer took another shaky step forward. "You and her. My mom knows a lot about First One's tech. She can figure out what's wrong- She can help."

The cat girl's chest heaved, and her hands gripped her friend's jacket. Her tail jumped erratically. Through her current panic, she

was considering it.

Glimmer didn't have time for thinking. She held out her hand. "I can't get both of you at the same time, but I can take you then come back for her."

The hair on the cat girl's tail puffed out, and she looked back with eyes wide and teeth bared. "I'm not going anywhere. I'm not leaving her!" Tears pricked the corners of her eyes.

"Then I'll take her first."

Claws were out, teeth bared. The catgirl growled. "You're not taking her! Just go!"

Glimmer hesitated before there was a sudden swipe of claws in her face, and she teleported.

In an instant, Glimmer traded the emotionally and magically charged middle of the Fright Zone for the Whispering Woods' quiet edge. She still had some teleports in her, and she knew the direction to go to get to Bright Moon, but she stopped to look back. She could have used a Horde defector- someone who knew the inner workings of her greatest enemy. Instead of gaining intel, she just lost the stupid sword. Her mother was going to be pissed. She groaned. She would have to explain things to Bow too- and he would never let her hear the end of it.

Glimmer turned her back on the Fright Zone and focused on getting home. She disappeared in a cloud of purple sparkles and headed home.

***

Shadow Weaver was filing paperwork in the vast filing room of the Horde's command center. No one in this organization had any idea how much paperwork was required to keep the place running. After Thaymor, it had taken her nearly a day to get through all the paperwork of ordering more fuel for the tanks, recording the rations that were expended in the effort, and turning in orders for

the contraband distribution. Something like this- a covert operation to kidnap a princess? The paperwork was surprisingly small but annoying since it was an unexpected covert operation and threw a wrench into her plans.

She sighed to herself. This was problematic. The princess was one of the few rebels itching for a fight- and if Angella turned herself in... Shadow Weaver shuddered to think of the casualties that would ensue.

The Horde was ready for an all-out war thanks to her decades-long effort... but she wasn't ready. Not yet.

She hovered through the halls back toward her chamber while she calmly contemplated ways to let the princess go without the blame landing on her. It could be a glitch in the power. The Black Garnet often had moments of stubbornness.

The badge she kept hidden in her robes crackled to life unexpectedly pulling her out her thoughts as Catra's voice came through.

"Shadow Weaver-" She sounded scared. That was never a good sign. "-Adora's down, and the princess is gone."

"What?" Her thoughts raced.

"Please! She won't wake up!" Catra's voice cracked.

Shadow Weaver felt the electric shock of fear as she pulled magical power and surged through the halls uncaring of who she knocked over in the process.

The door to the Black Garnet room was open, and she burst in to see Adora on the ground and Catra kneeling before her. Shadow Weaver pushed Catra aside to get a better look.

Adora was unconscious, her hand gripped a First One's weapon so tight her knuckles had gone white. From the hilt, tendrils of magic were already starting to spread into Adora's hand. Shadow

Weaver could sense them going up her arm, and for a moment, she contemplated severing the connection.

“What’s wrong with her?”

“Quiet!” Shadow Weaver ordered as she hovered a hand over Adora’s fingers. It wouldn’t take much. A simple severing spell aimed at the spot just up Adora’s arm where the tendrils hadn’t reached yet was all it would take. Adora would lose the arm- but that was hardly a high price to pay.

Shadow Weaver hesitated as her eyes found the blade’s stone. It was pulling magic at a rate she had never seen. It was a runestone and a very powerful one. She blinked as she realized the stone was forging its connection to a new princess- which was unexpected. Adora was not of Etheria- she shouldn't have a connection there to forge. Regardless of the feasibility of what was happening, the connection was happening and severing it now might kill her.

The moment that thought struck Shadow Weaver, she stopped drawing magic from the Black Garnet. She stood up as she watched her Adora be taken over by someone else’s purpose. A long-forgotten purpose of an ancient and dead civilization, but a purpose that lived on nonetheless in the technology they left behind.

Catra looked between Adora and the closest thing they had to a mother. “Do something!”

Shadow Weaver couldn’t respond immediately. She was, in a word, helplessly watching a decade and a half of work get stolen from her. All those years of trying to draw out Adora’s natural magical power, and in an instant, it was being claimed by someone else. “She’s not dying. Get a hold of yourself.”

Catra visibly relaxed. “Then what happened?”

Shadow Weaver scanned the room. Her eyes landed on the cable cut in two. Beneath her mask, she bared her teeth as rage started

to swell in her. She turned to Catra, eyes landing on her claws and the faint smell of magic left on them. She started drawing magic again. "You tell me-"

Catra's eyes got wide as she saw what was happening. She scrambled to her feet and extended the claws on both hands, ready for a fight.

Shadow Weaver knew what those hands were capable of, and she didn't care. "I had things under control. Now- Now I've lost everything, and it's all your fault!" Shadow Weaver breathed in to pull energy, and it started gathering as black smoke around her. She'd give Catra a punishment that would ensure she would never meddle in her affairs ever again. She'd hurt for weeks, and every day of it, she'd regret getting involved and dragging Adora into it- ruining her future.

Adora stirred on the ground, and both Shadow Weaver and Catra stopped cold and looked down at her. Her eyes were rolled back, fluttering open though, as she muttered, "For the honor-" It was like she was talking in a dream, and the last words came slowly. "- of Grayskull."

Shadow Weaver felt the magic in the room shift and a massive hand at her throat. As her airway constricted, she was lifted off the ground by a glowing mass of magic. A goddess. She was being choked by a goddess that she had only read about in books. After all this time, she finally saw the bright blue magic glowing in Adora's eyes. Shadow Weaver had always known Adora had power in her, but she had no idea it was *this* power. In that moment- the sheer awe of it- Shadow Weaver almost forgot she couldn't breathe.

The Black Garnet dimmed, and the lights in the Fright Zone went off, but that room stayed lit with the intense glow of what Adora had become.

Lack of oxygen started to burn Shadow Weaver's lungs, and she grabbed She-ra's- Adora's- arm in a silent plea for mercy. The

goddess didn't let go of her neck, and Shadow Weaver half expected divine retribution right then and there- when she tapped Adora's arm. It was a simple movement that all cadets were trained to use when they had failed in combat. To tap out- to avoid being killed during practice was a concept she had instilled in Adora since early childhood.

It touched something deep in Adora's memory and pulled her out of whatever magical well she had been dropped into. Her conscious came full force into the body, and she realized with a sudden terror whose neck she was holding. She let go immediately.

Shadow Weaver collapsed to the ground, coughing and gasping for breath as Adora looked at her own hand. "What happened?" Her vision wasn't perfect. Everything was doubled, and she felt like she was wading through water to think. She had a sword in her hand. The last thing she remembered- the princess- Catra. She turned around.

Every hair on Catra's body stood up, and she jumped back onto all fours, ready to fight or run. She took the sight of the thing before her and made a snap decision.

Adora saw nothing but the panic in Catra's eyes before she ran- ferial and animalistic- on all fours out of the room and was gone.

Adora's heart broke.

Shadow Weaver slowly got up off the floor and felt her neck for any actual damage before she offered, "Forget her. You need to try to calm down."

She turned back to her commander. "What happened?"

"I'll explain- but first try to breathe deeply and slowly."

Adora couldn't understand the command. Why was breathing important when she was several feet taller than she was supposed to be and glowing? How could she care about breathing when her

best friend ran away looking at her like a stranger or worse- an enemy?

“If you don't calm down, your magic won’t stop causing problems.”

“My magic?” It was only then that she saw the Black Garnet wasn’t glowing anymore and that the lights were off.

In a smooth and calm voice, Shadow Weaver instructed, “Breathe slowly and deeply.”

It was the tone that did it. It was the tone of every lesson in her whole life. It was the tone Shadow Weaver used to instruct her not to pick her nose or how to tie her shoes. She tried to stop her racing mind and tried to focus on breathing.

“There you go. Just relax.”

Adora had never relaxed in her whole life, and trying under these circumstances wasn’t helping. Still, she tried. As she breathed, the Black Garnet revved back up, and the lights came back on.

Any chance Adora had of getting an explanation was destroyed as the screen in the room lit up with Hordak’s angry face.

“Shadow Weaver! I have said many times my experiments cannot handle intermittent blackouts. Explain yourself!” He then stopped and looked at Adora. “Who is that?” He then saw the empty force field. “And where is the prisoner?”

Shadow Weaver, after years of raising orphans and running a small country, sighed like she was finally going to lose it before calmly offering, “I’m afraid it couldn’t be helped. There has been a development.”

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Moments later, In Hordak’s sanctum, he walked past Shadow Weaver. “Let me get this straight. The princess is gone, and this-”

He paused in front of the seven-foot-tall blonde wearing white and gold in front of him, "-is Force Captain Adora?"

Shadow Weaver was the picture of calm. "The Brightmoon Commander obviously escaped. I assume, in the process of trying to stop her, our Force Captain came in contact with a sword that has brought forth-" She hesitated, aware of the weight of what she was about to say. "-She-ra."

He narrowed his eyes while staring at Adora, who was trying her best to remain at attention even though her limbs felt out of place, and her clothes felt wrong, and she realized with him so close how much taller than him she was. It made everything feel off- wrong.

Shadow Weaver sighed. "You can be forgiven for not understanding. You didn't grow up here, so you never heard the legends. She-ra is supposed to be a guardian spirit of Etheria. They call her the Princess of Power-"

Adora startled at the word princess.

"-A being of pure magic-"

Hordak growled. "I don't care about your local superstitions. Is it dangerous?"

"Very, but not to us." She touched her neck. "I have at least proven that Adora still has control of herself in this form. She is still a member of the Horde. Still a force captain under your command."

He paused at that, looking Adora's tall frame over. "And the sword- Can anyone use it?"

"I'm afraid it only works on her-" Shadow Weaver cleared her throat, "-unique physiology."

Adora worked hard to maintain a straight face as her brain reeled. Her what?

Hordak made a sound of appraisal as he turned away, touching his chin. "This *is* an interesting development."

Shadow Weaver continued. "I need time to study the magic involved to identify how it can be used safely."

Hordak shook his head and leaned on the counter where the sword had been placed. "It's not fully magic- it's advanced technology."

"That it is."

"In order to use it, we will need to understand both the magic and the technology involved."

"There are some on Etheria who have a rudimentary knowledge of the technology. They can be- *persuaded* to help."

Hordak put his hands behind his back and turned to Shadow Weaver. "Fine. I expect a full battle strategy plan regarding this from you by tomorrow night. Make it good and I'll forgive the fact that yet again, a princess capture has gone horribly wrong under your watch." He got in close. "Do not disappoint me." He stepped back. "You're both dismissed."

"She needs the sword."

Hordak growled.

"There will be plenty of time to study it later. Separating her and it could be detrimental not just to her, but the Horde as well."

He sneered but grabbed the sword off the table. "Fine." He tossed it.

Adora reached out and caught it like it was meant to be in her hand- like it had flown to her. Holding it felt like second nature.

Shadow Weaver bowed slightly and turned to leave. Adora followed even though she had to adjust the length of her steps to

stay behind her commanding officer.

They both waited to be out of the room and the door shut before Adora started in on the questions. “A goddess? What do you mean a goddess?”

Shadow Weaver glided down the hall, “Old children's stories with apparently a bit of truth to them.”

“What did you mean by my physiology?”

“Don’t worry over the details. Instead, focus on trying to change back.”

Adora clenched her fists, gripping the sword harder. “How do you know this isn’t permanent?”

“Because I am a sorceress- and I know how these things work. Magical transformations are rarely permanent as they require too much magic to sustain. You will stay like this as long as you are agitated. You must relax.”

“I can’t relax!” She couldn’t stop the anger in her voice.

They passed a guard, who startled and immediately saluted Shadow Weaver before staring at the thing walking next to her.

Shadow Weaver let out a long-suffering sigh. “The next few days will be hard for you. The news of this will spread quickly. Keep the sword with you at all times. We will start practice tomorrow after lunch.”

A few more shocked guards later, and Adora reached her room. She stopped in front of it and wondered if Catra was inside or if she had run to the barracks, or even worse- Scorpia’s room. She turned to ask Shadow Weaver another question, but her commanding officer was already walking away.

Adora paused, watching what she could only imagine was disappointment in the set of Shadow Weaver’s shoulders- her lack

of interest. She had grown up sensitive to Shadow Weaver's disapproval, and avoided it at all cost. Now- she had no idea what she had done wrong, and that thought nagged at her as she turned back to her door.

She fumbled with the keypad to try to put her code in without mashing the buttons too much. After a few failed tries, she got it, and the door slid open. The lights were off, but her natural glow meant she could see someone hiding under the covers on the bed. Relief flowed through her. If Catra had returned there, then there was some hope to correct this- to talk through it.

Adora stepped forward, "Catra?"

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Catra controlled her breathing as the door slid open and the glowing woman stepped in. As expected, she saw the bundle on the bed and assumed. Adora knew better than to assume.

The door slide closed, and in a moment, Catra came out from the shadows and was up the woman's back with her claws on the woman's neck. Catra's breathing was ragged from the adrenaline, but her brain was sharp as a knife. "Drop the weapon," she commanded.

The woman dropped the sword. It hit the ground with an unnatural clang.

"Catra, it's me." Adora's voice came out of the woman.

Catra flexed her claws on the woman's neck to show she meant business. "You're going to have to prove it." She managed a small smile. "If you're really Adora, then you know what you're going to have to do."

One side effect of growing up in the Horde with a sorceress as a commanding officer was that impersonators were a real and persistent danger. From a young age, they had both decided on their strategy for sussing out fakes. Something only they knew,

and something Shadow Weaver or any of their other terrifying adult figures would be horrified to try to replicate.

The woman groaned, but started humming the tune before singing, “Dinner bells, Hordak smells, Weaver laid an egg-” She even did the little finger motions, wiggling them in the air as she finished. If she didn’t do the finger motions, she would fail the test. They had both agreed on it. “-and the princess got away.”

Catra’s claws retracted as she smiled. “That was worth it. That sounds even stupider than when we were kids.”

Adora managed to relax just a little at the simple act of proving herself to her friend that she was still herself.

Catra’s touch on Adora’s neck changed to be more gentle, and she adjusted herself higher on Adora’s shoulders before tilting Adora’s chin back to look her in the eye. Catra was, at once, captivated by the glowing blue that had replaced the gray in Adora’s eyes. “What happened?”

“I don’t know,” Adora said, finally letting her confusion and inner turmoil bubble over into her voice. “Shadow Weaver said a lot of things- Something about a goddess- a princess?”

Catra tapped the tiara on her head. “Well- I have to admit- it makes you look stupid like a princess.”

Adora frowned.

Catra, feeling more comfortable with the odd warm static electricity of this magic that clung to Adora, settled on Adora’s shoulders and played with her hair. “Is this permanent?”

“Shadow Weaver doesn't think so. She says I need to relax and I’ll turn back.”

Catra laughed out loud, wrapping her finger in the glowing golden locks of this weird new shape. “You’ve never relaxed a day in your life.”

Adora's broad shoulders slacked, and she moved to sit down on the bed. It creaked under her weight, and Catra happily balanced on her shoulders as she moved. "This is what I get for trying to let a princess go. This is a punishment from the universe."

Catra used Adora's new long hair to pull her face back up to look her in the eye again. With a glowing smile, she added, "We saved the Horde from near-certain destruction and got a cool magic sword in the deal." Her eyes looked Adora over from the high vantage point. "This is the best thing that ever happened to us. You're powerful. You're *strong* ."

Adora blinked. Her own misgivings about all of this melted away under Catra's interest.

"You just have to learn to control it." Catra absentmindedly tapped the tiara while she was thinking. "Hey- lay down on your stomach. I have an idea."

Adora hesitated.

"Come on. I think I can help you change back."

Adora moved, and Catra adjusted as she did so that when Adora went down, she straddled the larger woman's lower back. Adora was far too big for the large bed, and her feet hung off the back while her arm dangled off the side. With her face smashed into her pillow, she mumbled, "How is this supposed to help?"

Catra placed her palms onto the muscles in Adora's back. "Remember when we were little- you used to love it when I did this." She started kneading Adora's muscles, back and forth with her hands.

Adora closed her eyes as the feeling pulled up old comfortable memories of good moments that happened between the harder ones. When Catra had been small, she'd kneed Adora's arm or stomach before curling up to go to sleep. It always felt good, but right then and right there- after everything that happened- it felt amazing.

Catra started purring as she saw Adora's muscles relax into the bed at the touch. She didn't even try to hide it. "Too bad you didn't finish Shadow Weaver off while you had her."

Adora's eyes went wide as she turned her head to the side. "I nearly killed our Commanding Officer. I don't know what came over me."

Catra chuckled and moved her hands to a spot that felt like the muscles were pulled tight. "You were thinking clearly for the first time in your life."

At the new motion, Adora closed her eyes again and moaned a little.

Catra savored the sound, and it only made her kneed more deeply. That sound, and the position she was in, sparked the dry kindling already in Catra's core. Her face felt hot, and she tried to get a grip on herself. When she couldn't tamp down the feelings welling inside her, she had a thought. Maybe she could relieve her own pressure that had been building for a few years and help Adora relax by suggesting they... She blinked as the very thought of what she was going to ask for made her blood pool in places that she wasn't used to. She swallowed. "Hey, Adora?" Her voice was shaky- pleading- and very unlike what she was used to. Still, she didn't care. She had worked herself up to being just a bit desperate. She waited with bated breath for Adora's response.

Adora snored, and almost instantaneously, Catra felt the body beneath her shrink to its normal size.

Adora was asleep. Of course, she was asleep. Catra bit back the bitter taste of disappointment. She had come so close to asking for something she wanted desperately, thought about constantly. It was stupid. Adora would never say yes anyway. She would think it was weird. It was just the moment that made her consider it.

Catra forced herself to crawl off Adora's back. She pulled the covers over them both and then forced herself to close her eyes.

“Nevermind.”

A hard day

The alarm went off, and Adora reached out to turn it off and just barely made it as Catra pulled her back into the bed.

“How is it you’re already so tense?” Catra said, half-awake, as her hands gripped for Adora’s jacket and then started kneading.

For a moment, Adora relaxed in the thought that it had all been a dream until she saw the sword on the floor and her stomach clenched. She looked away from it, and blinked as she realized Catra had started kneading her chest through her jacket. All thoughts left her head.

Catra purred, half in a dream about kneading Adora’s back, except softer.

Adora didn’t stop her. It felt good. Warm. Warm in places she wasn’t normally. She knew Catra was mostly asleep. She knew it wasn’t on purpose. She didn’t want Catra to be embarrassed, so she decided the best thing to do was try to wake her up with-
“Catra?”

The pleading, helpless tone in Adora’s voice woke Catra right out of the half-sleep she was in, and her hands froze. “Oh... Sorry.”

“It’s ok.” Adora’s voice was higher than she expected it to be.

Catra removed her hands and curled into a ball against the wall while pulling the blanket to cover her smile.

Adora started to get out of bed.

Catra’s hand shot out to stop her, grabbing her arm. “Oh, come on. After last night, you don’t think you’ve earned a little extra sleep?”

Adora pulled her arm out of Catra’s grasp gently and sat on the edge of the bed. “It doesn’t change anything.”

“No one’s going to get angry at you. It’s not like there are protocols for what to do if you magically become a princess.”

Adora shot Catra a glare over her shoulder, and Catra responded by giggling. Adora shook her head. “You’re probably right, but you’ll still get in trouble if you don’t get up.”

Catra, cautiously, reached out to touch Adora’s arm again. It was a plea to come back to bed. To lay back down. “I don’t think I need to. Didn’t you see how scared Shadow Weaver was of you?”

Adora did remember. She’d rather forget.

“What is she going to do? Try to kill me? After that?” And Catra laughed like she hadn’t laughed in years.

Adora stood up and walked over to the sword.

Catra stopped smiling and pouted as she realized her plea had been rejected.

Adora picked the sword up and made an effort to look distracted by it. “I don’t know how to use it yet. You shouldn’t rely on me to protect you- not until...” She really didn’t know what to say. She didn’t know what conditions would need to be met for someone to rely on her. She had no idea what she was doing with this.

Catra laid out on the bed and stretched in the way that only she could.

Adora’s attention on the sword was stolen by watching her friend’s spine curve back, her arms reach over her head, and throwing her head back in a yawn. Catra’s legs entangled in the blankets as it seemed she was stretching every muscle in her body at once. It was a magnificent sight. Normally, she would look away but not that morning.

Catra noticed and added some early morning stretch moans for Adora’s benefit.

Adora’s face flushed, and she finally did look away and tried to focus back on the sword.

The moment Adora’s eyes were not on her, Catra gave up the exaggeration. She sat up and ended up looking at the sword too. “Fine. I’ll go, but we can’t keep doing this forever. We shouldn’t.”

Adora looked back with a sad expression.

“At some point, we’ve got to take what we want.” She got off the bed and moved toward Adora. “Stop playing by everyone else's rules.” She ran a clawed finger on the blade of the sword in Adora’s hand. “You shut off the Black Garnet with this last night. Without that, Shadow Weaver is-”

“I know.” The word was helpless. Catra was going to say helpless. Adora looked at her reflection in the sword and realized how sad she looked.

Catra grabbed Adora’s face, pulling her to look her in the eye. “Just a bit longer, ok? Figure this thing out, and we’ll be running this place, and no one will be able to tell us we can’t sleep in if we want to.” She squeezed Adora’s cheeks a little tighter. “Just imagine it. We could sleep all morning if we wanted.”

Adora nodded, but her thoughts were on the hands on her face. It was not a touch she expected, and the only other person who touched her like that was Shadow Weaver. She was struck by the feeling of it. She couldn't stop looking into Catra’s eyes.

“We can do this, right?”

Adora nodded.

And their moment was interrupted by a knock at the door.

Lonnie’s voice came through. “Force Captain- Shadow Weaver sent us to escort you to breakfast.”

At that, both Catra and Adora froze. “Escort me?” Adora asked as she turned toward the door.

“Yeah. She said something about you needing some extra protection. Said something about a sword.” There was a pause as Rogelio said something. Lonnie added, “And we’ve heard some rumors that we wanted to ask you about.”

Adora looked back at Catra slowly retreating to the bed, covering herself with blankets, and managing to lay flatter than Adora had ever seen. Adora opened the door and forced a smile but their eyes were instantly on her sword. “Tell me about the rumors while we go.” Adora stepped out and made sure her door closed firmly behind her.

Catra threw the blankets off her head once the door was closed. Her brain was busy processing timelines. Shadow Weaver had been in the barracks before morning muster. Shadow Weaver then must know she wasn’t in the barracks. That was bad. She was definitely not going to the barracks now. She needed Scorpia.

She waited long enough for Adora and the others to be well gone before she opened the door to an empty hall and moved quickly toward Scorpia’s room.

She knocked on Scorpia’s door while thinking of what exactly to say.

There was a slight rustling inside, and Catra knocked again. “Scorpia, it’s me. I’ve got- something to report.”

“Just a moment,” Scorpia called from inside.

Catra took a breath and relaxed. She was at her Force Captain’s door before muster the morning after shit went down. That was expected.

The door opened.

Catra turned to start her report, only to find Scorpia- hair tousled- wearing nothing but non-standard issue black underwear.

Catra froze as she realized, Scorpia was ripped. Fuck- she was cut. Nothing but muscle and chitin. Fuck.

Scorpia blinked with puffy eyes. “Oh- Catra- Is everything ok?”

Catra’s mouth fell open. She really should say something... She couldn’t.

Scorpia blinked for another moment before she looked down, then dared to smile. “Sorry. It’s hard to- uh- get in my uniform. Usually, I sleep in it- but I was in the dress last night, and I had to-”

Catra shook everything out of her head and pushed Scorpia into the room, hissing, “You idiot! People will see you!”

Scorpia stumbled in.

Catra was already digging through Scorpia’s drawers to find a new uniform and turned her head to avert her eyes as she handed it over.

Scorpia, tiredly, took it with her pincer. She sighed. “This is going to take a while.”

Catra winced. “I can-” She hesitated. She was going to regret this. “I can help if that will make it faster.”

“Oh, sure.” Scorpia would have never said no. No matter how much it made her blush.

Catra worked quickly, moving to scrunch up the uniform’s legs without looking, and helping Scopria’s foot in.

Scorpia did everything to make it easier. “What did you want to report?”

Catra started the first leg, laughed to herself at her situation. While Scorpia finished pulling it up, she started scrunching up the second leg. "Shit went down last night. I have to- I have to tell you- Also- there's a problem." There was so much to explain. The missing princess. The sword. How was she supposed to explain that?

She didn't get an opportunity. Someone knocked on the door, and Catra yelped.

"Force Captain Scorpia," Shadow Weaver's voice was leveled. Calm.

That calmness scared Catra more than anything. She looked up at Scorpia, still half-dressed. Shit. Shit!

Scorpia saw the look on Catra's face and winced before she called out, "Just a moment. I'm getting dressed."

Shadow Weaver continued. "I need to talk to you about your squad member."

Scorpia looked at Catra, panicked, before adding, "Can this wait?"

"So she's in there with you-"

Catra's face drained of color.

Scorpia held out her pincer.

Catra snapped out of it and helped the sleeve of the uniform on over the woman's sharp spiky exoskeleton.

Scorpia was also blushing furiously. "Uh- No- she's-"

Catra shook her head. She cringed, but she needed this alibi.

Scorpia looked at Catra in surprise as they got the last arm through. "I mean- yes? She's here?"

Catra hated herself but nodded to Scorpia.

“She’s here! I’ll let you in!” Scorpia, surprised, got up and went to the door, finally fully dressed.

Shadow Weaver stood there, practically triumphant, while Catra wished she’d be struck by lightning. She still managed a half-hearted salute. “I was just reporting to my Force Captain the events of last night.”

Shadow Weaver’s smile came through in her voice. “I’m sure you were.” She moved into Scorpia’s room and let the door close behind her. “Then I’m sure you told her why you were in the Black Garnet room last night with Adora in the first place.”

Shit. Shit! “I didn’t get to that yet.”

Shadow Weaver, gleefully, opened her hands wide. “Then we both get the benefit of hearing your explanation.”

Catra hated her so much. She knew what she was doing. Scorpia looked so confused. So lost. Catra hated to drag her into this. She cleared her throat. “Adora and I-” She cleared it again. “We went to go gloat.” She used the princess’s word- hoping Adora would answer the same thing if she was asked. She realized too late they should have spent the morning coming up with their story rather than half-asleep chest kneading.

Scorpia stared at her in mild surprise. “I could have gloated.”

Shit. Catra could see the hurt in Scorpia’s eyes. She’d have to fix this later- somehow.

“And you ran- and came here?” Shadow Weaver’s voice oozed with self-satisfaction like she was winning at a game Catra had no idea how to play.

Catra was between a rock and a hard place. She blushed- It was a genuine blush- and looked away. She knew what it was implying. She knew what it would mean- and she had no other explanation for why she wasn’t in the barracks. She had to have been in someone’s room, and it couldn’t be Adora’s.

Scorpia’s look of hurt was replaced with confusion. She blinked and then found Shadow Weaver had turned to her.

“I’ll admit, I thought you were lying before,” Shadow Weaver said with a voice like honey. “I didn’t think you’d have made so much progress in such a short time.”

“What?” Scorpia’s voice cracked, and she looked between Shadow Weaver and Catra, completely at a loss as to what had just happened.

Shadow Weaver turned to Catra. “I will be telling Hordak that you were the one who caused the princess to escape. I wanted to warn both of you of that in case there are any *repercussions* .”

Catra growled. Her claws extended on their own at her side.

Shadow Weaver was about to say something more when there was another knock at the door.

Scorpia lost it. “What is up with this morning? What is it?”

Someone called out, “Scorpia! Come watch! There’s a fight!”

Shadow Weaver opened the door, and a group of Force Captains shrank back, saluting and apologizing. She glared at them. “What do you mean a fight? Between who?”

***

The cafeteria was crowded with all the tables pushed to the outside of the room. Everyone's attention was on the center, and Scorpia, Catra, and Shadow Weaver fought through them to get to where they could see. Once people realized Shadow Weaver was there, they parted, and what they saw was Adora as She-ra with Grizzlor in a headlock. “Yield!” She-ra demanded with a smile.

“Never! On my honor, I will-”

He didn’t get the chance. She hoisted him up over her head, holding him like a trophy- and then she saw Shadow Weaver and dropped him.

He landed with a thud. He wheezed to get a breath in. The cheering stopped instantly, and all eyes turned to Shadow Weaver.

She strode forward. “What do you think you’re doing?”

She-ra flinched back. “He challenged me!” She pointed to a line of people. “They all challenged me.”

Shadow Weaver turned to see the strongest Force Captains shying away from her. She next saw Lonnie, holding Adora’s sword on the edge of the mess with a pleading look. Kyle and Rogelio stayed by her side.

Shadow Weaver turned her attention to the towering glowing goddess. “Combat was not something I wanted you to engage in until you had been through training.”

She-ra’s shoulders fell. She looked wounded like Adora always did when she was told to stop playing as a child.

The whole room had their eyes on their commander.

Shadow Weaver adjusted her robes and turned to Cobalt. “I’m disappointed you let this fight break out in the cafeteria. Move it to the arena immediately.”

He managed a smile and a salute. “Yes, ma’am.” The room erupted in cheers and started moving toward the arena, pushing She-ra as they went.

Lonnie looked like she would pass out with relief as her squad gave her reassuring half hugs.

While everyone started filing out, Shadow Weaver turned back to Catra and got close. She touched the lighter tufts of hair on the side of her head. “I’m glad you’re finally getting over your little- ”

Catra's jaw set.

"-crush." Shadow Weaver said that part quiet enough that no one but Catra could hear it.

Catra hated this. She hated Shadow Weaver. What right did she have to name it like that? She hated everything about what was happening, but she stood still.

Shadow Weaver pulled away, and all Catra wanted to do was wipe the smile off her smug little masked face.

Shadow Weaver left as the crowd parted for her.

Catra grabbed Scoripa's arm and dragged her. "If we don't hurry, we won't have good seats."

They didn't need to rush. Of course, Scorpia had a seat reserved upfront near the judges. All she had to do was sit down, and the person next to her jumped up to let Catra take his seat.

The room buzzed with excitement. Catra could hear Cobalt talking to the other judges in front of her. Still, she was focused on the way Adora rolled her shoulders and did her patented nervous-before-a-fight stretches. She may look different, but this was absolutely Adora.

"So- do you want to talk about what happened this morning?"

Scorpia's voice was an intrusion into Catra's thoughts. "No."

Scorpia frowned. "I'm going to be honest- I don't really understand. I feel like I'm missing out on the details. It would be nice to- you know- understand?"

Catra offered a quick, "I'll tell you later, ok?" before Cobalt stood up to address the crowd.

"We'll be going by the rules. No weapons. No chokes. Nothing below the belt. Is that understood?"

She-ra and Octavia nodded but didn't stop looking at each other. Adora managed a cocky smile that resulted in a wave of swoons.

Catra rolled her eyes. This whole organization was childish.

"Did you imply to Shadow Weaver that you spent the night in my room?" Scorpia wasn't even looking at the fighters. She was close, in Catra's face.

Catra grit her teeth. She sank in her chair. She was not having this conversation here. Not now. "Just go with it. I'll explain later, ok?"

Cobalt turned to the crowd. "Next fight- Force Captain Octavia and Force Captain Ad-"

Adora held up her hand.

He stopped. "Excuse me?"

"She-ra. Shadow Weaver said it's-" She cleared her throat, horrified by how loud her voice was at this size. "-it's She-ra."

He cocked an eyebrow at her.

She shrugged.

"Fine. She-ra vs. Octavia. The fight starts at the bell. Any questions?"

"Just get on with it," Octavia groaned.

Catra settled in to give her full attention to the two idiots about to fight. They rushed toward each other. The fight was short like with all fights with Adora. She was always so efficient, and in this form, she was stronger.

They called the fight in She-ra's favor, and someone behind her started to chant, "She-ra! She-ra!"

In a moment, the gathered Horde started to follow the chant. They didn't often get a hero. They desperately wanted one, and

Adora was there to soak it up. She was smiling like a fool, puffing her chest out in a way she never normally would. Catra rolled her eyes at the whole ordeal.

The next opponent stepped into the ring. Catra sat forward to watch. Something tickled at the back of her brain.

Scorpia didn't care about the fight. What she cared about was Catra, and Catra acted like something was interesting. "What is it?"

"Give me a moment." Catra paid close attention to Adora's movements. The next fight was short, but she got enough of a view to see what she wanted. "She's slower."

"What?"

"It must be the size difference." Catra blinked, and her ears went back. She started to get up.

Scorpia tried to stop her. "Hey there, Wildcat. Where are you headed?"

"I want to fight her."

Scorpia's face filled with panic. "Her? But- she's just defeated three Force Captains- and not like- normal ones. The good fighters."

The chanting had gotten louder, and Catra had to move around Scorpia. "Trust me, ok?"

Scorpia didn't want to let this happen, but she sat resigned. It had already been a confusing morning, and it wasn't getting any easier. She could trust Catra. That's what good friends did, right?

Catra maneuvered her way to Cobalt and got him on the shoulder. "I'm next."

He startled and glared at her. "You're a cadet."

By then, the crowd had become aware that Catra- the brat little kid who blinded Octavia- Shadow Weaver's other ward- talked to the judge, and the room started to quiet down.

Adora saw it too and stopped egging the crowd on. She was as interested in what was happening as anyone else.

"I'm next," Catra demanded.

Shocked silence, then the arena erupted with screaming approval.

Cobalt glared at Catra. "Shadow Weaver is going to kill me if either of you gets hurt."

Catra gave him a cocky smile. "Better stop it if she gets too beat up, then."

He frowned, considering his options and doing the risk assessment. "No claws."

She smiled wide. "Fine."

"Ok."

The crowd went wild. Scorpia was the lone Horde soldier who wasn't standing, wasn't screaming. She was pretty sure she was about to watch her two new friends destroy each other.

Lonnie gave Catra a disapproving glare while she gripped the sword. "What are you doing, Catra?"

"Watch and learn." Catra stuck out her tongue at Lonnie as she stepped out into the ring, and the crowd started chanting She-ra's name again.

Adora turned out the crowd's chanting as they faced off. She had Catra's full attention in front of everyone. That thought alone made her spine buzz with adrenaline.

Cobalt called their names and hit the bell.

Catra launched forward.

What everyone thought they saw was a real fight. Whatever friendship had existed between the two before was obviously gone as they clashed. There would be speculation at lunch that years of living under Shadow Weaver's constant disapproval, her favoritism for Adora, had finally driven them both to finally hate one another. That was the only thing that could spur that kind of fight.

What they were actually watching was the closest thing Adora and Catra allowed themselves to come to openly flirting. Affection wasn't allowed, so the two had accidentally developed a whole love language based on combat. Catra's claws were in, but her fingertips would graze She-ra's body. Adora would punch, and Catra would dodge, and there would be a look in Catra's eye of pure bliss at it. Every attack was an act of devotion. Every counterattack was an admission of long-held feelings that couldn't be expressed in other ways. They acted their feelings out as acts of violence because it was the only thing they knew. The only way they could each show they cared was by giving it their all.

The crowd got on their feet, screaming for the best fight they had seen in years.

Catra launched herself, feet first, at the right moment into She-ra's stomach, and Adora knew it was over. She couldn't move fast enough to get out of it. She had been one step behind Catra the whole fight, and she knew Catra was just waiting for the right moment. With the air knocked out of her, she fell to the floor on her back.

Catra stood over her, planting a firm foot on She-ra's stomach. It was an intimate touch for them. It spoke volumes in a language only they understood. Catra licked her lips and winked as She-ra shifted back to Adora under her foot. Adora was stunned in more than one way.

The crowd was in shock. No one was screaming. No one was chanting.

"Woohoo!" Scorpia called out, standing up throwing her pincers in the air. "Catra! Catra!"

Catra walked off the mat slowly, and every eye in the room was on her, including Adora's.

Adora was dizzy, looking up from the floor at Catra's tail swish- the confident sway of her hips. In Adora's addled state- a thought came to mind. *I think I'm in love* .

***

I'm in love?

Adora was not sure what it even meant. She had only ever heard people talk about it who were outside her immediate chain of command. It was always something someone else had. Something someone else was worthy of.

The fact that it had floated to her brain while there on the mat- it was concerning to her. She wanted to make sense of what she felt. She wanted to fight Catra like that forever in a never-ending battle. That wasn't right. People described being in love as like- good things. If it was love- she should want something else. For the life of her, she couldn't think of what that would be. She couldn't picture what love was.

"You're not focusing." Shadow Weaver's voice came sharp.

"Sorry."

"I don't need apologies. I need you to focus." Shadow Weaver put her hands on Adora's face in a manner not unlike the way Catra had done it that morning. "I was worried you'd have problems transforming, but it seems you've figured it out."

“Mh hm.” Adora’s mind was already back to the puzzle of love. It was replaying the fight to try to identify what exactly it was in that fight that made her feel like the word love was appropriate.

“Transform now.”

Adora didn’t react. She didn’t even register the command.

“Adora?”

“Sorry. What?”

Shadow Weaver let go of her face. “What exactly is distracting you?”

Adora did not want to answer that truthfully. She had to come up with something. “I lost the last fight.”

“You’ve had this for less than a day.” She tapped the sword in Adora’s lap with her nail. “Of course, you lost your last fight. You have a nearly infinite source of power at your disposal, but you don’t even know how to draw it yet.” She put her hands back on Adora’s face. “Now transform.”

Adora held the sword hilt tight and said the words that had come to her. She didn’t know what Grayskull was, or why its honor was so important to this She-ra, but she said the words regardless. She grew and transformed, and for a moment, she saw Shadow Weaver differently. She had never fully understood magic. She knew Shadow Weaver was a sorceress. She knew that Shadow Weaver needed the Black Garnet for her power- but she had never seen any of that until that moment. Everything around her was vibrant with magic, especially the Black Garnet, but Shadow Weaver was a magical black hole in the universe.

“I am going to try something. It might hurt.” Shadow Weavers' voice was quiet and calm.

Adora felt a shock of pain, like her insides were being pulled toward her face, toward Shadow Weaver’s hands. The magic black

hole that was Shadow Weaver was trying to fill itself, but the magic wouldn't flow.

Shadow Weaver broke contact, heaving as smoke came off her fingers.

Adora nearly asked if she was ok, but such questions were never acceptable to commanding officers, so she waited.

Shadow Weaver shook her hands. “You’re as stubborn as that thing is.” She gestured to the Black Garnet.

She-ra glared at her. She was not stubborn. She was trying her best.

“Not you. Your runestone.”

“My what?”

Shadow Weaver pointed to the blue stone on the sword. “That is your runestone. Through it, you draw magic even if you’re not touching the sword.”

Shadow Weaver talked about magic for some time, and Adora’s thoughts strayed back to the fight. Back to Catra’s near caresses that were supposed to be stand-ins for claw strikes. Back to the feeling of elation that maybe was love. Was it love? Was that what love felt like?

I’m in love... with... Catra...

The moment she thought it, her chest bloomed with a warmth she had rarely known. The thought of those words together felt good. Maybe it was love. It felt right. She blinked, unsure of what that would mean for them. She had no instruction in love. No scripts for what to do- what to say when it appeared. Maybe she should ask for another fight so she could study the feeling more.

Shadow Weaver stopped talking and stood back as she watched Adora draw magic like it was second nature. Adora wasn’t even

paying attention. She gave up on the instruction. “Hordak wants someone who can study the technology of the sword. We’re going to send you to Dryl.”

That brought Adora out of her thoughts, and the magical draw stopped cold. “What?”

Shadow Weaver sighed. Adora’s attention problems were not new, but they seemed particularly bad today. “The kingdom of Dryl. Hordak and I are sending you there to recruit their princess.”

She-ra’s face was Adora’s confused face. Shadow Weaver would recognize that look anywhere. It was disconcerting to see the face of a goddess with the expression of a hopeless child on it- at once foreign and familiar at the same time. “The princess of Dryl only cares about science. We won’t even get her attention if we don’t send something to catch her interest. If you and that sword don’t catch her interest, I don’t know what will.”

“Can Catra and Scorpia come?” Adora had a one-track mind. She couldn’t help it.

Shadow Weaver didn’t respond immediately. She weighed her options. “Fine. Having another princess there, even if it’s Scorpia, might help.” She hesitated. “But you must also know they have grown quite close.”

She-ra looked confused again.

Shadow Weaver wished Adora would stop making that face. It was distressing. She turned away and sat down. “Catra is growing closer to Scorpia. It will hurt- but you must let this happen and encourage it. It’s for her own good, and yours- and all of Etheria.”

She-ra’s face had a moment of pain. A moment of unexpected hurt.

Shadow Weaver tried not to look upon it. She averted her eyes. It was too much. The woman before her was Adora- the child who scraped her knees and got her face gouged by careless friends

and was also the glowing embodiment of the purest magic of Etheria. “I can’t impress upon you the importance of your-position as the bearer of this power. You must eschew emotional entanglements. The documents that have been translated so far were very clear that emotional connections were the downfall of the last She-ra. Emotional connections to others- *especially* strong ones- will weaken you and put the whole planet in danger.” Shadow Weaver looked up to see the effect her words might have.

Adora said nothing, but she made tears start at the edge of She-ra’s eyes.

Crying. Adora was making the goddess of Etheria cry. Shadow weaver couldn't stand it.

“You are dismissed. Practice transforming and drawing magic like you did just now. Once you get back from Dryl, we’ll start working on how to use it.”

Adora didn’t make the body move. She was hurt. She was confused.

Shadow Weaver waved her to leave. “You're dismissed. I am tired.”

Adora shifted back to herself but hesitated.

“I said I’m tired.”

Adora got up and left.

***

Catra was in a great mood. Scorpia had forgotten about that morning’s confusing implications and spent the day telling everyone who would listen that Catra was part of her squad. It was the first time in her life someone else was excited to have her on the team- to brag about her. Scorpia was a great hype woman, and she made Catra feel proud of herself.

She loved this feeling. Now she understood why Adora tried to please everyone so hard.

With dinner over, she headed to Adora's room and typed in Adora's passcode. The door slid open, and she walked in expecting the room to herself. Adora always came in late- except this time, Adora was lying on the bed staring at the ceiling. Catra let the door shut behind her and walked up to the bed. "How about that fight?"

Adora blinked as if she didn't even notice Catra come in and then looked at her. Her eyes were slightly bloodshot- like she had been crying.

That made Catra pause. "Are you ok?"

Adora gave a quick nod but said nothing. What was running through her head was that last thing Shadow Weaver had said. Eschew personal entanglements- or the whole planet would be in danger.

Catra waved a hand in front of Adora's face as it seemed she spaced out again. "You're freaking me out a little. Did she drug you or something?"

Adora shook her head and forced herself to sit up.

I thought you were amazing. I'd like to be locked in combat with you like that forever. I think whatever love is, I might feel it for you, and apparently, that might destroy the planet.

She pretended like she hadn't been crying. Pretended to be strong, like she always did. "That fight was epic. You were amazing," was all she managed out of a tired throat.

Catra gave her a smile, but not a full one. She reached out to tuck a stray hair of Adora's behind her ear.

Adora visibly startled at the movement.

The planet will be in danger .

Catra froze. She knew Adora better than anyone. This was panic on the level that was straining the edges of Adora's ability to ignore it. Adora's hand was shaking.

The planet will be in danger .

"You should sleep in the barracks tonight." Adora's voice shook with barely contained stress made all the worse by her attempts to hide it.

Catra's focus was on Adora's face. Adora wasn't looking her in the eye. "Like hell I am- not with you acting like this."

Adora's stomach growled.

Catra knew then that Adora had skipped dinner. She doubted Adora had stopped to eat lunch before going to Shadow Weaver. Maybe she forgot. Maybe she was punishing herself. Maybe she was too nervous to eat. Catra made slow movements like she was dealing with a wild animal. She put her arms around Adora and pulled her into her chest. "Hey, it's ok. You're ok. I'm here." Catra whispered it, like Adora used to do for her.

I think this is love ... *it might destroy the planet* .

Adora started to cry.

They would never talk about this. They would never breathe a word of it to each other or anyone else. Everyone had a breakdown at some point. The Horde was just a harsh place to live, and sometimes it all got to you. They all knew the signs even though they never talked about it. Adora's were rare and far between because she held everything in until it was too much for one body to hold, so Catra did her best to just be there and share the burden.

Adora wrapped her arms around Catra and shook as she sobbed into her chest, finally letting go of everything that had been

bottled up.

After a while, Catra knew Adora would stop crying. She would wait for that and then help Adora take her jacket and boots off and try to get Adora to lay down. She would try to make her comfortable. Get her some water. Catra dedicated herself to waking up early and stealing some ration bars so Adora could eat something. She'd make an extra effort because apparently, today was a hard day.

Confession

Scorpia didn’t need an alarm. No one ever cared if she was on time or not, but she woke up early that morning because she was excited.

She sat up and took a deep breath.

It was yesterday, showing off Catra to everyone who would listen and seeing how happy it made her, that Scorpia decided she was going to confess to Catra. She was going to ask Catra to go out with her. For real. No qualms about it. No dancing around the subject. Relationships started with trust, and you gained trust by being honest.

She got up and went to the mirror. She brushed her teeth. She combed her hair. She went to the picture of her and her mothers and smiled. “I’m going to do what you taught me to do. Be brave. Be loyal, and be forthright.”

She was nervous, but she pushed down her doubts and insecurities. No matter what happened, she would still be a friend to Catra. She would make that clear. She had the speech all lined out. She’d even talk to Adora first to get her blessing. Which- was a little weird, right? But it felt right. They seemed so close. And Adora would know if Catra had feelings for someone else- wouldn't she?

Scorpia left her room full of hope. It was like the universe was paving the way for her. The three of them would have a three-day round trip out to Dryl. Plenty of time to find a time to get Adora alone and talk to her. Then plenty of time to get Catra alone to make her confession. She’d spend her contraband share on good food.

She walked down the hall with a smile. Confident. Building herself up.

I'm strong. I'm brave. I'm loyal, and I give great hugs. I'm going to tell a girl I like her.

Down the hall and around the corner, Adora woke up to a tray of gray ration bars, and Catra was gone. She must have woken up early to steal some breakfast. Adora's stomach growled, and she sat up and ate the food provided. It made her feel cared for, and that made that warm feeling bloom in her chest again.

She tried to tamp down that feeling. She couldn't imagine a life without Catra, so she decided she wasn't going to. If the problem was her emotions, then she'd just deal with it. She'd just not have those complicated, world-ending feelings for Catra. Simple as that. Nothing could possibly go wrong with that plan.

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Adora was surprised to see Scorpia's good mood. Maybe that was good. Maybe she should emulate it. She tried to smile. As they started their walk, each with a backpack that held the standard-issue camping gear and rations, she began to feel lighter. As she stole glances at Catra, she caught glimpses of happiness. She was finally getting to get out of the Fright Zone without getting seasick or in danger. Just getting to see the world. That made Adora smile for real. That's what she wanted for Catra. For her to be happy.

I can want her to be happy without being emotionally entangled, right?

She forced herself to take a deep breath as her chest felt tight. She forced a smile. She was going to be happy for Catra.

Catra didn't notice because her ears and eyes had been trained on the many birds in the trees around them all day. At that moment, she spotted one sitting on a lower branch with its back turned. It tugged at a deep part of Catra's instinct, and she slowly put down her backpack. "Just a moment. I have to do a thing."

Scorpia and Adora stopped walking as Catra burst into a run and scaled the tree, swiping at a bird that took off at the last moment.

She cursed and climbed higher.

“I don’t think I’ve ever seen her have so much fun,” Scorpia said, astounded.

Adora managed a smile at that. “There’s not a lot of birds in the fright zone. If you want, I can get her to stop.”

Scorpia beamed. This was perfect. Perfect timing. “Let her have fun. There’s no rush. Besides, we’ve been walking for a while. I could use a break.”

Adora took off her backpack and sat down on the ground. She put her sword next to her, as close as she could, before trying to get out her water bottle.

Scorpia put down her pack and sat down beside Adora, still smiling. “Catra’s great, isn’t she.”

Adora felt a pang in her chest but nodded.

Scorpia watched Catra giggle and jump from branch to branch, now having completely lost herself to playing with a flock of birds that seemed more annoyed by her than scared. “What do you think she’s going to do if she catches one?”

“Eat it, probably. They’re better than ration bars.” Adora took a gulp of water and sighed. “When we were little, she’d bring me her catches and put them next to my bed so I would step on them when I woke up.”

Scorpia cringed at the thought.

Adora tried to focus back on her water, realizing that she had probably shared too much.

“So, you two are close, right?” Scorpia couldn’t stand how stupid she sounded but marched on anyway.

“Yeah.” Adora looked up to watch Catra giggling to herself as her back legs moved back and forth before she launched herself at another few birds that took off at the last moment.

Scorpia scooted in. “Is she- ah- you know-” She felt her stomach drop. She felt like she was on a roller coaster and had just gone over the edge, “-seeing anyone?”

That made Adora look away from Catra and to Scorpia. “She sees people all the time.”

Scorpia blushed and then fumbled a little and recovered. “Not like actually seeing people but like-” Scorpia felt like she couldn’t breathe enough. “- dating?” Her voice cracked.

Adora’s eyes got wide. The color in her face seemed to drain.

They heard Catra laughing maniacally at a very close call as a flock of birds took off from the branches to get away from her.

Adora’s chest hurt. “Dating?”

Scorpia watched Adora’s face flush with confusion. “You know- romance- hanging out but like not in a friend way- in a- want to be more than friends way.”

Adora tried to hold herself together. Tried to pretend like this wasn’t the last thing she wanted to be talking about. “Oh, I- uh- I don’t think so.” Adora looked forward so she wouldn’t have to look Scorpia in the eye.

“Does she have feelings for anyone else?”

Adora heard the hopefulness in Scorpia’s voice, and it hit her like a ton of bricks. Scorpia *liked* Catra. This whole time, she was worried about Scorpia and Catra becoming friends and pushing Adora out because Scorpia had so much more to offer Catra than she did. But oh no- this was much worse. Scorpia wanted to be something more than friends with Catra. “I- I don’t know.”

“You don’t know? Aren't you her closest friend?”

Catra cackled in the distance as another flock of birds took off.

Adora forced herself to breathe because she felt like she wasn’t getting enough oxygen. In that moment of anxiety, Shadow Weaver’s words came back to her. It would hurt, but Catra and Scorpia were getting close. She was supposed to encourage it. She blinked as she finally understood what that meant. “She’s never talked about anyone that way- at least not to me.”

That made Scorpia smile too big. Too hopeful.

Adora couldn’t look at her.

“Oh, great. I’m going to ask her out.”

“Out?”

“Like on a date.”

Adora swallowed.

“But only if you think that’s ok.”

“You’re asking me for permission?” Adora’s voice broke.

“Of course. You care about her more than anyone else.” And Scorpia gave Adora a charming smile. She was nervous but putting her best foot forward. She could be charming no matter how nervous she was.

Adora felt sick. Despite the feeling, she knew this was what was supposed to happen. This was what Shadow Weaver said needed to happen. It would help Adora not have any of those complicated, world-ending feelings, right? If that was true, why did she feel like her heart was being ripped apart? “I think that’s great.” She forced herself to say it. She wanted Catra to be happy. Scorpia could give her the world. A world that would still be there because Adora managed not to have any selfish feelings.

Scorpia reached forward, shaking Adora's hand with both her pincers. "Great! Thank you so much!" She let go.

Adora wasn't listening. She wasn't there, really. Her mind had left along with her heart, and she felt numb. But numbness was good. It was better than the alternative.

***

Adora woke up in her sleeping bag with Catra pressed up against her side. She moved away slightly, hoping Catra wouldn't make a fuss about it while she was half asleep. She relaxed only when the cold of the morning was back on her, and she could feel the chilly absence of her friend. This was for the best. She kept telling herself that.

Scorpia sat up, smiling like she loved mornings. She even started whistling a little tune as she got out of her sleeping bag.

That woke Catra up completely, and she groaned and pulled her sleeping bag over her head. "Just let me sleep in. We don't have alarms, or commanding officers, or muster."

"Sleep in all you want, Wildcat." Scorpia got up. "I'll start a fire and make breakfast for all of us. I've got eggs and bacon."

That made Catra peek out of her bag. "You've got what now?"

Adora watched Scorpia, also curious.

Scorpia didn't explain and instead showed them. She pulled out a frying pan from her larger backpack and gathered some wood. Soon, the morning was full of wonderful smells and the sound of sizzling fat and eggs.

Both Catra and Adora were helpless to that smell. It was unlike anything they had ever had.

Adora smiled at Catra. It was a pained smile. She knew what Scorpia was doing. She was making her case for why she was

worth something. Making a case for how she could provide for Catra, and this is what Adora wanted. She wanted Catra to be well fed with exotic foods like bacon and eggs, to be taken on trips and adventures with someone who could keep her safe and who would let her be herself.

Adora had that same pained smile all morning as they ate and then as they rolled up their sleeping bags and packed their bags to head off to Dryl. She smiled because she was waiting for Scorpia to ask. Waiting for her own heart to break. Waiting for the moment she would have to show bravery, and honor, and dedication. She could do this. She was sure she could do this.

***

Dryl was in sight, and they put their backpacks down and hid them in the bushes. Adora straightened her jacket and her belt to make sure she was presentable. She grabbed her sword and called on the honor of Grayskull, and summoned She-Ra.

Catra watched the whole spectacle with suspicion. “You’re going to meet her like that?”

She-Ra shrugged. “Shadow Weaver said to sell her on the technology of the sword. This is the best way to sell it, right?”

Before Catra could answer, Scorpia pointed a pincer up toward the top of the kingdom of Dryl. “I might be mistaken, but isn’t that an emergency beacon?”

They all turned and watched the light spin on the top of the highest tower.

“Should we cancel the trip?” Scorpia looked back at her two travel companions.

Catra got a deviant smile. “We’re supposed to win this princess over, right?”

Scorpia stared blankly. “Well, yeah. I guess.”

“Then saving her from distress has got to be the number one best way to win her over, right?”

Adora walked forward, glad to avoid an awkward walk back full of confessions. “Sounds good to me.”

The other two followed.

As they got close to the gate of Dryl, Adora winced with pain as she heard a high-pitched sound that cut into her thoughts. She stopped in her tracks and held her head for a moment.

“You ok?” Catra eyed her.

“There’s an odd noise. Can’t you hear it?” Adora was sure Catra had better hearing than her.

Catra shook her head.

That was unexpected. She tried to ignore it while Catra scaled Scorpia like a ladder and launched herself off Scorpia’s shoulders onto the side of the wall before climbing it with her claws.

Scorpia and Adora watched with wonder at the near-seamless way Catra moved.

Scorpia smiled and blushed a little. “She’s-” She cleared her throat “-quiet athletic.”

Adora rolled her eyes.

“Oh, wow. It’s robots.” Catra called back. The robots in the court all looked up at her with red eyes and started shambling toward her. Some began to try to climb the wall helplessly. “Murder robots,” she clarified.

“How many?” Adora yelled up.

The robots stirred and started trying harder to get up the wall. A few started climbing on others. “From what I can see, about

twenty."

Adora rolled She-Ra's shoulders and did her anxious pre-fight stretching. "Ok. We'll open the gate and take-"

Before she could finish, Catra had jumped back down.

Adora hesitated. "What are you doing?"

"I'm getting ready to fight some murder robots with you."

"No. Scorpia and I will do this. You just stay on the wall and wait until it's safe."

"Like hell I am. I beat your sorry ass, so I can hold my own against some robots. Besides, we've trained against robots all our lives, and those don't even look like they're designed for combat."

The robots on the other side began to beat against the gate.

Adora's jaw set. "Fine, but don't get in trouble. Stay close to Scorpia."

She-Ra bent down to get her fingers under the solid metal gate, and Scorpia moved to do the same with her pincers. Adora counted down, "Three- two- one."

They both gave it their all and threw the gate upward. It jammed in the mechanism.

A horde of murder robots fell toward them, with shambling metal and glowing red eyes. The three reverted to their training and stuck close. Scorpia's pincers slammed into robot faces and snipped off robot libs and necks. Catra laughed as she tore through soft wires with sharp claws and gouged sensory devices.

She-Ra had her sword. At first, she didn't rely on it because she was too close to her companions, so she kicked and used the hilt to smash in weird robot faces. As robots went down, and they were able to spread out, she swung the blade, and it lodged deep

into a metallic chest. The robot powered down and slumped. She tried to pull the sword out, but it was jammed. She put her foot on the robot to get leverage to pull, and that's when she saw the magical red tendrils moving up the blade. They hit the blue runestone, and Adora instantly felt hot fire in her veins. Her vision went red. She lost herself to a feeling she rarely had. Rage.

Scorpia bulldozed through the robots like they were aluminum cans and proudly looked over to Catra and Adora to see how they were. Catra looked happy. That made Scorpia's heart swell. She couldn't imagine what it was like growing up the way they did, but she got a sense Catra was never allowed to let go, to have fun, and to maim with impunity. Past her, Adora seemed to be reveling in the fight even more. Like really going at it and laughing maniacally. *Good. She's enjoying herself* , Scorpia thought and went back to smashing.

She-Ra swung the sword wildly, laughing in a voice that was ever so slightly off.

Catra hissed as she had to jump out of the way as She-Ra ran into her side. "Watch it!"

She-Ra only laughed and continued smashing until between the three of them there were no more active robots in the courtyard.

Catra pulled back and watched with growing concern. Adora was never that reckless. She never laughed while fighting. "Hey, Adora- You alright?"

She-Ra turned to her.

Catra saw She-Ra's red eyes glowing with magic, and red veins on her skin. "Shit!" She jumped back toward Scorpia.

She had already gotten She-Ra's attention, and the corrupted goddess started running toward Catra with a wild smile.

Catra heard the sword swinging and jumped just in time to miss it. Despite how the situation looked, Catra wasn't scared. She

could fight Adora any day. She did a flip over She-Ra. That flip would have worked on Adora, because Adora was always focused on doing things the right way. She never fought dirty. Catra didn't expect to feel her foot get grabbed mid-air, and jerked forward. Catra went face-first into the dirt and slid. With a mouthful of dirt, she knew this wasn't Adora. That thought kicked her adrenaline into high gear. She scrambled off the ground, ready for a real fight.

She didn't need to. Scopia jumped and slammed into She-Ra, knocking the sword out of her hand, and the two of them tumbled to the ground. She-Ra struggled for a moment against Scorpia's strong arms before she shifted back into Adora and passed out.

Catra couldn't believe what she had just seen, and dusted herself off. "What the hell was that?"

"I don't know, but she seems-" Scorpia shook Adora a little. "Dead?"

Catra ran forward to put her fingers on Adora's neck. "She's alive, just out cold. Which is good for us." Catra turned her attention to the sword on the ground and picked up a heavy piece of robot over her head.

Scorpia watched. "What are you doing?"

Catra carried the heavy piece and headed to the sword. "I'm ending this bullshit right now."

"Wait!"

Catra hesitated.

"You can't. It's hers."

Catra turned back, murder in her face. "You saw what it did to her."

Scorpia started to get up and held a limp Adora as she did. “Yeah, but I think the robots did it. The point is, you shouldn't break her stuff without her permission, you know?”

Catra sneered but tossed the heavy machinery aside. “Fine.” She grabbed the sword and held it firmly. “The moment she’s back to herself, we’re having a whole fucking conversation about it.”

Catra and Scorpia both startled as a loudspeaker flickered on, and a high-pitched voice called out, “Welcome to Dryl! Normally things here are a lot more fun, but we seem to be in the middle of a little experimental mishap here.”

Catra’s ears flipped around to get a sense of where the sound was coming from. It seemed to be coming from everywhere.

“We’ve been surviving here for a few weeks. I figured out that if I use all the speakers at once, then the robots head toward the speaker closest to them and it allows us to communicate with the outside world. So far, you’re the only people who’ve responded to our emergency signal.”

Catra sneered. “Jokes on her. No one responded. They’re just lucky.”

Scorpia blinked. “Can she hear us?”

“If you’re wondering if I can hear you, I can’t, but I can see you. I have the whole place rigged up with cameras. Let me open the door and lead you to my lab where this all started.”

The main door to the building opened up for them.

Catra looked at Adora passed out in Scorpia’s arms. “This isn’t exactly what I pictured when I imagined us storming in to save the kingdom.”

Adora’s eyes fluttered open, and she smiled. “Hey! Catra! Did you know there are two of you? Hmmm- oh good.” She closed her eyes again and relaxed so hard it looked like she passed out

again. It was a disturbing sight. Adora never relaxed. It was unnatural.

Catra just blinked at her, unsure of what exactly to make of what just happened. “Do you think you can carry her and fight?”

Scorpia stood up and put Adora on her shoulder. “Sure, as long as she’s not too wiggly.”

Adora startled again and giggled. “Wiggly. I can be wiggly.”

“No, don’t be wiggly. Wiggly is bad.” Scorpia adjusted her shoulder to make her point.

Catra sighed as she started dragging the sword tip on the floor as she walked toward the building’s entrance. “Let’s get this over with.”

As Scorpia fell in behind her, she offered, “Don’t get so down. Things aren’t that bad. We all survived the first attack, and now we have someone helping us stop it.” Scorpia sounded chipper not because of what she said, but the realization that this might be the perfect alone time she needed to tell Catra. Her heart rate went up. She even blushed a little.

They went into the building, and down a hall.

“Turn right,” the high-pitched voice called from all of the loudspeakers.

They could hear robots moving, but they seemed to be moving away.

“So- Catra- I’ve been meaning to ask you-” Scorpia couldn't finish as her throat went dry, and she coughed.

Catra stopped. Her ears flicked from one side to another to listen for any robots that might have heard. She waited a moment before whispering, “Keep it down. I’d rather not fight if we don’t have to- not with Adora like this.”

"Right. Sorry." Scorpia swallowed and was very disturbed by how shaky her pincers were. Damn it. This was harder than expected. Maybe it would be easier to start without making it so direct. "So Catra- I wanted you to know that I think you're great."

Adora sputtered to life. "She *is* great. Isn't she? So great she could destroy the planet." Adora giggled before seemingly passing out again.

Catra turned to glare at them. "What is up with you two?"

Scorpia stopped and stood up straight. This was it. This was the moment. She opened her mouth to say the whole speech she had been planning, despite the fear in her gut and the nerves eating at her confidence. Despite the weird robot situation they were in. She was going to say it. She really was.

Adora interrupted her. "Shadow Weaver says I shouldn't be entangled, but I wake up *entangled* with Catra every morning, so- that shows what she knows."

Catra's eyes went wide.

Scorpia's eyebrows lifted.

Adora laughed and muttered, "I love sleeping with her- she's so warm and nice- so dangerous..." She passed out again, draped over Scorpia's shoulder.

Scorpia's breathing became shallow.

"It's not what it sounds like-" Catra started to say.

Scorpia blinked. "You two? Have been-"

Catra took a breath and looked around to make sure they weren't about to get ambushed. "She asked me to stay with her in her room because she's never slept alone before, and when she got promoted-"

Scorpia blinked. “That’s why you haven’t been in the barracks.” She breathed sharp and fast and looked away. “You were using me so you could- what? Sleep in the same bed as your friend?”

Catra didn’t know what to say other than the truth. “I never lied to you.”

“You never told me the truth either, and a lie by omission is still a lie.” She tried to breathe through the complex feelings she was having in the moment. “Are you two a thing?”

Catra froze at that. She didn’t know what to say.

Scorpia tried to take a deep breath and tried again. “Answer me.”

“I don’t know.”

“What do you mean you don’t know?” She tried to hide the hurt in her voice, but it came out anyway.

Catra hated this. Hated having to address stuff she had been avoiding. “We’ve never talked about it, ok?”

Adora giggled, and Scorpia and Catra fell silent as she settled herself back into a nap.

Scorpia gathered herself. “Do you- do you want her like that?”

Catra’s ears pinned back. She instinctively backed away. “What?”

Scorpia took another breath, forced it because her chest felt tight. “I’m asking what you want. Do you have feelings for her, even if you don’t know how she feels about you?”

Catra felt backed into a corner. “I-”

“I need to know, Catra.” That last bit was begging. She knew it.

Catra was not prepared for this kind of talk. She had no plan. No one had ever actually just asked her flat out. She didn’t know how easy it would be to just say, “I do- I have- ever since I was old

enough to know what that was. She's-" Catra glanced at the semi-conscious woman on Scorpia's shoulders. "She's everything to me."

"And you've never told her?"

"How could I? Shadow Weaver would kill me. We could never be anything more than what we are with her around. I was- I was waiting until she was out of the picture and..." And what? She didn't really know. She had never really gotten that far in her plan. The first step seemed so impossible.

Scorpia winced as her heart broke. She took a deep breath and tried to make her voice steady. "Ok." Scorpia fought the instinct to cry. It hurt. It hurt bad, but she had to go on. The girl she liked was into someone else- someone who apparently was too dumb to relize it herself. She started moving again if only to distract herself from what she felt.

Catra fell in behind her. "Scorpia-"

"It's ok." And it was. She told herself that. This was a small moment. A little heartbreak for a relationship she hadn't even taken any steps to move toward- but it didn't matter. She never had a chance. "You're not sleeping in her bed until you tell her how you feel."

"What!" Catra couldn't help the volume of her voice. Emotions were already running high, and holding back was never easy.

They heard the sound of metal moving against the floor and the groans of the bots as they headed their way in the dark.

Catra got the sword ready, more than willing to use its edge to take what she could out. She turned to make a strategy with Scorpia when she saw her running forward. "Scorpia, wait!" She ran after her.

Scorpia slammed into the robots with her pincers and bashed through the group like they were toys. She came out the other

side, heaving and glad to have some distraction. “Now who can’t keep quiet?”

Catra followed. “I’m sorry I reacted to the crazy thing you said.” Her tone showed she wasn’t sorry.

Scorpia’s jaw worked as she walked.

The loudspeakers crackled. “Turn left.”

Scorpia turned and clarified. “I thought what I said wasn’t crazy at all. You’re not sleeping in her bed anymore until you can tell her how you feel.”

Catra reeled. “Why?”

Scorpia stopped and turned on Catra, bearing down on her. “Because it’s not fair to her.”

“She asked me to stay with her.”

“And you’re acting like just a friend when what you want is to be more. That’s not honest. That’s not forthright. That’s not going to make either one of you happy.”

Catra felt that in her chest. It hurt.

Almost as a response, Adora giggled and snorted before mumbling something to herself and passing out again.

Catra’s body was tense. Her muscles were coiled. Her claws were out. “You don’t have the right to lecture me!”

“Yeah, I do. I’m your Force Captain, remember?” It was a fact that Scorpia had tried to downplay in her own mind. She turned away and started marching into Dryl’s halls.

Catra breathed heavily. Her heart raced. She was angry. She fought back the tears. “You expect me to tell her? What?”

Scorpia almost laughed. “That you love her, and you want something more. Then let her decide if she still wants you in her bed. You got me?”

Catra’s shoulders fell. Saying those words, as simple as they seemed coming from Scorpia, felt impossible. Saying them would put her friendship at risk, and she couldn’t risk losing Adora. The sword tip dropped to the ground, and she cursed herself before running to catch up with Scorpia. “I can’t. I can’t risk it. She’s the only person I have. What if she says no? Then what?”

“What if she says yes? If you don’t say anything, then she’s going to assume you just want to be friends, and someone else is going to come around and she’s going to fall for them.” Scorpia was speaking from experience. Recent experience.

Catra had, honestly, never considered that.

“Oh! Stop! You’re there!” The loudspeaker voice surprised both of them.

Scorpia turned to face a door.

“There are forty-one robots on the inside of those doors. All gathered around a computer. At the center is a glowing red chip. Destroy that chip, and I believe this will all end, and I believe your friend might get better too.”

Scorpia looked down at Catra as she got her pincers into the cracks on either side. “You got that sword ready, Wildcat?” The pet name hurt. She realized she should stop using it.

Catra was a wreck emotionally, but she got the sword up and in a firm grip. She had never practiced with it, but she had just watched She-Ra use it and didn’t look that hard. Just as easy as learning to dance with a big sharp weapon. “As ready as I’ll ever be.”

Scorpia hesitated. “Look, Catra- I’ll help you confess to her.”

Catra started. “What?”

This hurt, but Scorpia promised herself she would be a friend to both of these girls, and this is what friends did. “Growing up the way you two did- I can see why this would be hard for you. I can help you. In fact, it’s my new mission.”

Catra was struck by that. She watched Scorpia with a wonder she had rarely experienced. The feeling of uncertainty in her gut lessened a little.

Scorpia took a deep breath and turned back to the door. “On the count of three then. One, two- three.” She pushed with all her might.

The door screeched as it tried to stay closed before the mechanism failed, and she pushed until the gears squealed then broke.

All the robots inside turned their glowing red eyes on the intruders.

Scorpia charged forward, ready to be distracted by a fight.

Crossing Paths

Trying to think felt like wading through water, which was precisely how Adora's brain interpreted it. She had never spent that much time at the beach. The beaches at the Horde docs were filthy, but she knew of clean beaches with sand, and so she created a nice beach next to some clean water that hardly had dead fish in it. She swam away from shore, dangerously close to being swept out to sea, but she didn't care. Thoughts tickled her brain like fish. Consciousness was like waves, where she would hit a crest and come out of it enough to hear something and then sink back down below.

She giggled as she felt herself slipping below the waves. This was nice. It was fine right up until she hit something.

It was like she had been washed ashore in her own mind, and there, standing over her, was She-Ra. She was tall. Real tall and very bright.

"Come here often?" Adora said while wiggling her eyebrows before snorting and falling into a fit of giggling.

She-Ra just watched her through unfeeling, unblinking white eyes.

Adora frowned. "You're no fun, you know that. You're just like Shadow Weaver, all serious." Adora waited for a response and got nothing. "Actually, you're *just* like Shadow Weaver. Everyone says I'm her favorite, but I don't think she likes me very much... I doubt you do either. But it looks like you're stuck with me! Bound to this struggle, am I right?" She laughed hard, hitting the water with her open hands to splash, playing with it the way she would play in a bath as a kid.

She felt herself ebbing and flowing. Her body must be being carried.

She looked back up at the planetary Goddess before her and decided to get some clarification, “So- are you real, or am I dreaming?”

At that, the woman held up the sword with both hands, the blade pointed down dangerously close to Adora’s head.

“Careful with that thing. It’s dangerous. It might lock you into some kind of destiny that might destroy the planet.” Adora laughed hard at that, even though she knew it wasn’t a joke. It was a laugh of desperation. It ended suddenly, as a new thought came to mind. “Can you at least tell me why emotional entanglements are bad?” She really expected the vision to just continue doing nothing, but instead, light began to beam out of She-Ra’s eyes. Her mouth opened as if she was screaming, but no sound came out. Magic tendrils in shimmering rainbow colors spread over her limbs. She looked to be in pain. She lifted the sword up.

All of Adora’s giddy, half-drunk feelings were gone. Fear. Adora felt fear. Panic. Something was wrong.

Adora dodged just as She-Ra brought the sword down too hard, too fast, with a strength and speed only a being of pure magic could manage, and the blade shattered.

Shards flew out in slow motion, twirling and sparkling as they tumbled through an imaginary space shattering her own vision of her idealistic beach.

This was wrong. Very wrong. Adora forced herself to wake up, if only to get away from this nightmare.

She emerged on Scorpia’s shoulder to an entirely different nightmare. First, it was loud. Very loud. There were metal sounds and the frantic movements of a fight. Second, she realized in a haze that they were surrounded by robots with glowing red eyes and pulsing red cores. She could feel that pulse in her head, like

something worming its way in. "Scorpia, stop. I don't like it." She put her hands on her ears.

"No can do. Just hold on." Scorpia moved a little to keep Adora on her shoulder before she bashed the face of another robot in a slow march to the computer at the center of the room.

Holding her ears shut didn't stop the pulse, and she took her hands down only to realize she could hear Catra. She was yelling and hissing. Adora tried to move to look back and nearly slid off Scorpia's shoulder.

Scorpia used her arm to hold Adora on while she bashed through the face of another robot.

That moved them closer to the glowing red chip in the center of the computer.

"Hold on tight," Scorpia warned before she let go of Adora and grabbed the chip with both pincers.

Adora grabbed Scorpia's neck and used her legs to wrap around Scorpia's waist. She held on for dear life as Scorpia put her feet on the computer and got ready to deadlift the chip out. Behind them, Catra was swinging the sword like a tornado of death and destruction. She was just barely keeping the robots at bay. Her whole body was engaged in the fight.

Damn, that's hot .

Adora felt a little shame through the haze in her brain. Her friend was in a real fight, fighting for her life, and all she could think about was how hot she looked.

Shit. Get yourself together, Adora. Focus on the chip. Maybe Scorpia needs you.

Adora forced her attention back on Scorpia and the chip. She realized in a moment that no- Scorpia didn't need her for anything.

Scorpia closed her eyes and took a breath. Back at the Fright Zone, her record in the deadlift had gone unbroken for years. That didn't stop her from making a new record every few months. All that work, which many dismissed as just a hobby, paid off.

The chip moved, then pulsed, and grew its tendrils into the computer deeper, bigger, so Scorpia pulled harder.

The chip pulsed again. Scorpia pulled hard and fast. Her pincers, which so many people made fun of, which made living in a world made for hands so hard, those pincers wrenched the chip out of the computer.

Scorpia and Adora fell back. Adora had the air knocked out of her as Scorpia landed on her. The chip firmly in Scorpia's grasp as the robots went wild before she gave it a quick and decisive pinch.

The chip shattered.

No one would know that the virus could have taken over all Etheria using their own technology against them. No one would have to know because they lucked out that instead of a sonic arrow, there was a strong set of pincers made all the stronger by a woman just trying to find her place in a world that wasn't made for her.

Adora certainly couldn't take in the magnificence of the moment because she couldn't breathe. She wheezed, "Scorpia-"

Scorpia rolled off. "I am so sorry! Did I break anything?"

Adora's brain slowly cleared of the fog, and she could do a mental check of her body. She could wiggle her toes. She could breathe without pain. So, her spine and her ribs were ok. "Just- out of breath."

Catra dropped the sword and turned to Adora. Her hair was a mess. She was half-covered in what looked like motor oil and grease. "Thanks for leaving the hard part to us, dumbass." She reached a shaky hand forward to help Adora up.

Adora managed a smile and took Catra's hand. "Payback for all the times you did it to me during training."

Catra pulled her up with a smirk. "Ok- so we're even." Catra's eyes were then back on the sword. "Adora, I think we should destroy that thing."

Adora blinked as the overwhelming dread of watching the sword break in her dream or vision came back in full force. She started to shake her head. She opened her mouth to explain the unexplainable, but she didn't get the chance.

"Destroying something so perfect would be a travesty!"

They all turned to see they had a purple-haired, grease-stained princess with a welding mask on, studying the sword on the floor next to them.

***

The first impression of Dryl was that it was inhabited only by Entrapta and her robots, but the three Horde soldiers were greeted by the non-robot staff. The staff gave them towels, fizzy drinks, tiny food, and their thanks. They then left their guests and Entrapta to her experiments. She, apparently, preferred it that way.

Adora looked broken, clutching the sword and barely eating, which was unusual. Catra kept an eye on her. They would have to talk later about what happened but now was not the time. She patted Adora's shoulder in a show of solidarity and support.

Scorpia nudged Catra in the shoulder. Gently, but in an encouraging way.

Catra glared at her.

Scorpia lifted an eyebrow and tilted her head towards Adora.

Catra shook her head and mouthed, "Not now."

Scorpia rolled her eyes and drank from the slightly larger mug the staff had given her to accommodate her pincers.

Catra couldn't stand it. Couldn't Scorpia see this was not the time for fucking confessions? Especially risky ones. Fuck. Adora looked like she was about to have another mental breakdown, so maybe she should lay off on the confessing-your-feelings thing.

Catra got up in a hurry to avoid being goaded into gushing her feelings all over the place. She instead focused on Princess Entrapta. Catra ran a claw along the computer's console. "You're pretty clever, aren't you?"

Entrapta pulled up her recorder. "Log: First day free of the chip, and the computer is nearly back up and functioning. Systems seem to have been completely taken over by an artificial intelligence that was malignant. Truly fascinating."

New tactics were needed. Catra moved closer. "You seem to know a lot about all this stuff. Can you tell me what happened to my friend over there?"

Entrapta stopped everything and turned her covered face to Catra. "Are you asking me about my work?"

Catra shrugged. "Sure."

Entrapta's hair pushed her up, and she flipped up her welding mask so she could get in Catra's face. "It's fascinating. Weeks ago, we found a chip in the mines under Dryl. An unbroken piece of First One's tech, with the most complete code I've ever seen."

Catra raised an eyebrow. "Code?"

"The language that machines work in. It's how you tell them to do things like bring you refreshments or wash your hair." As if on cue, a small, recently repaired robot rolled up with a tray with a drink on it left by the non-robot staff. Entrapta took it and sat back down. She sipped while she looked at the computer, which was spitting out garbage as far as Catra could tell.

“So, what infected your robots was a language?”

“An old machine language, from the First Ones. It’s unique because it takes into consideration what my code has never been able to before- magic.” Her hair moved her chair over to the spot where the chip had been. “You see, I powered down the computer on the first day of the system failure. Normally, that would mean the computer would stop running, but it didn’t. The chip had code to tell it how to pull energy from magic like a sorcerer would, and it just turned the computer back on.”

Catra looked over it all. “So- magical manipulating code. This is starting to make sense. Man, Shadow Weaver would either hate you or love you.” She was pretty sure it was hate. Shadow Weaver loved the fact that she was the only person that could work with magic in the Horde. Entrapta coming in would mean a rivalry, and this lady knew more about technology than Shadow Weaver ever would. Entrapta would win. That made Catra smile. “You know- I’ll bet Hordak would fund you. Join the Horde, and you’d probably get whatever you want. I know they want you to study the sword- but imagine the possibilities.”

Entrapta raised an eyebrow. “I have been impressed with the robots the Horde has put out, but they’re not efficient. Same problem as my robots. Not enough power to keep them going for very long- a few hours at best. They keep having to stop and recharge.” A light flashed on the robot that brought her the drink, and it quickly moved over mounds of its fallen brothers to a charging station in the corner. “Now- if I can figure out how this code worked-”

Catra’s eyebrows raised. “You’d have robots with near-infinite energy. We wouldn’t have to send a single soldier into battle. A whole army of robots could take over the planet on their own.” She turned back to the computer, smiling more at the idea of ruining Shadow Weaver’s plans and taking this war out of her control. The computer changed, and the writing on it made sense. “What’s this?”

“Oh. Well, apparently, my communications channels also went kind of evil along with all the other robots. That beacon was sending out a message, but it wasn’t my message which I guess is why no one came immediately. I’ll have to tell them all it was a system error.”

Catra took a screen with both hands as her brain registered what she was seeing. Names of kingdoms- chains of command. “You have communication channels with the whole rebellion.”

“The whole planet, actually. It wasn’t easy, and most of them don’t appreciate it, but the maker community has really taken it to heart.”

Catra leaned in as she saw a channel for Brightmoon, Queen Angella herself, then Commander Sparkles. The possibilities were endless. Espionage. False reports. Maybe this princess could even find a way to listen in on what the Rebels were telling each other. “Can I- send something?”

Entrapta beamed. “Are you asking me to use my technology?”

“Yes?”

“Of course you can! This is the first time someone who wasn’t a robot was interested in my work. I’ll admit, I have to program interest into the robots in the first place, so it’s not nearly as satisfying.”

Catra’s focus narrowed down to the one communication channel she thought she had a decent chance of success with. She typed something out quick, then closed the channel with a buzzing of excitement in her chest that was very nearly a purr. “How long does it take?”

“It’s instantaneous! Isn’t that great?”

Catra got in close to Entrapta. She ran her clawed fingers through Entrapta’s hair in a way that mimicked the way Shadow Weaver always did. “Oh, I can tell we are going to be great friends.”

Entrapta smiled big. “Friends? You want to be friends?”

Catra smiled big, devious. “Absolutely.”

***

Night fell, and Scorpia stopped their march home and started making a fire. Her pincers, it turned out, were also really good at breaking wood into small burnable pieces. Entrapta was just enthralled. Scorpia had really never had anyone so fascinated about her differences before. It was nice. It was damn near empowering.

Soon, they had a fire going, and Scorpia produced a bag of what she called popcorn. Entrapta squealed and dove into her things to pull out the remnants of a robot head. “You need pressure! The best popcorn is cooked under pressure! Let me show you!” She flipped her welding mask down and produced a torch with her hair. “Don’t look at the light. You might go blind.”

Adora and Catra both put their bags down and decided to leave Scorpia and Entrapta to whatever it was they were doing.

Adora sat down on a log with the sword in her lap. She hadn’t let go of it since the chip was destroyed.

Catra sat down next to her, intentionally pushing her a little.

Adora managed a smile. “Two fights I’ve been useless in.”

Catra leaned back a little, crossing her legs and bouncing her foot. “Three if you count the one with me.”

Adora pushed her back, then breathed in deep. “What’s the point of a lifetime of training if, when it comes down to it, I can’t even beat a princess or stay in the fight?”

“Well, must suck to be a loser.”

Adora turned to look her in the eye and caught that grin that showed she was being playful. It was a challenge, and normally, one Adora would jump at. That kind of challenge deserved an absolute bombardment of tickles and possibly a blow in the ear while pinning her down. The thought of doing either of those two things brought up those ever-complicated world-ending feelings. She sighed instead and put the sword tip down on the ground between her feet.

Catra nudged her.

Adora nudged back.

Catra nudged back harder.

Adora looked up, pretending to be mad, and caught Catra's eyes in the light of the fire. Oh, she forgot to breathe. Her heart skipped a beat. Something vital to her survival didn't happen because, for a moment, Adora was sure she was going to die. Had Catra ever looked so stunning before? Adora forced herself to look away. She pretended to be distracted by twirling her sword in the dirt.

Catra watched, her smile fading. Movement near the fire caught her eye as the seeds started popping, and Scorpia looked up to see them, then nodded, and then moved to put her back to them. Privacy. She was giving them privacy.

That thought made Catra's heart rate go up. Scorpia was right. If there was ever a time, now was the time. They were alone. There was no chance Shadow Weaver would hear. There was just her and Adora. Just her, and the only person she really cared about- just sitting on a log. "Hey, Adora?"

Adora looked at her, and on her face was a mix of hope and sadness.

It caught Catra off guard. It messed with her head. "I wanted to tell you-"

Adora’s face flashed with a moment of pain. She looked away, and she started bouncing her leg like she did when she was nervous. All Adora could think was that Catra was going to tell her that Scorpia confessed. She could hear the words. She felt them coming.

Catra didn't know who to react to that look on Adora’s face. She decided to ignore it and just go on with the plan. Catra was brave. Catra was smart. She was cunning and dangerous and amazing, and she couldn’t fucking say it. She blinked. Why couldn’t she say it? All she had to do was say the words? What words? Her mind blanked. What had Scorpia said? Love? What even was love?

“Tell me what?”

“Your hair poof is stupid,” Catra said while kicking at Adora with her crossed leg. Catra felt like slapping herself. It wasn’t her fault. Her whole life, she had been conditioned to avoid affection. Displays of emotion were weakness, and weakness was equated with death. So every single one of Catra’s mental defense mechanisms kicked in to prevent her from making herself vulnerable. That, mixed with the unexpected but wholly normal feelings that came up when anyone tried to express those feelings to a person they liked- and what you had was one petrified and confused cat.

“Are you ok?”

“Just peachy,” Catra said in a daze as she realized she couldn’t do it. No, she was going to try. She was going to say it. “Adora- I-” They both turned to face each other.

Damn, Adora was gorgeous in the firelight. Her stupid hair. That stupid face. Those stupid gray eyes. *Shit. Shit!* Catra instinctually arched her back. If her mouth couldn’t say the words, then her body would have to do something to get the message across. Her body language was trying to say, I want you. I want you to want me.

Adora kept telling herself it was going to be about Scorpia confessing. Why else would Catra try to talk to her? She was telling herself to make her face neutral no matter what Catra said. She was supposed to be supportive. She was supposed to be happy for her... then she saw Catra stick out her chest and she looked down, then back up to Catra's eyes. *Oh shit. Did I just look at her chest? Maybe she didn't notice.*

Catra did notice, and her heart and adrenaline kicked into high gear. *Oh shit. Did she just look at my tits? This is great. I think I'm going to die.*

Adora realized in a panic that Catra did notice, and her brain overloaded. Her defense mechanisms kicked in, and she stood up and shot finger guns at Catra with little pew pew noises before she realized, *Oh, shit- I'm doing finger guns. Why am I doing finger guns?*

Catra watched with growing horror. *Oh, no. She's doing finger guns.*

Adora stopped suddenly and stood awkwardly straight. "I'm sorry. I have to go get more firewood. I'll be-" She didn't finish her sentence but instead took off running into the dark of the forest.

Catra sat there stunned, her back still arched, unsure of exactly what just happened.

Once Adora ran far enough away, she randomly slashed at plants and bushes in the dark. She had a lump in her throat, and she was holding it back. She hated it. She wanted to shatter the stupid sword. She wanted to wake up in the bed with Catra keeping her warm, only to find out that everything about She-Ra was a dream. She wanted that with her whole heart. Just- a hard reset. *Take me back to that first night and let me live it all again. I didn't know what I had.*

She got far enough from the fire and threw the fucking sword into the woods with all her strength. It crashed through the trees, and

it landed with a thud on the ground. Someone screamed.

Adora snapped out of her thoughts and ran forward as the fear that she may have hurt someone welled up in her. The blade was stuck halfway in the ground, and an old short lady with wild hair was standing near it looking frozen in horror at the near-miss.

Adora moved forward to try to see if the woman was hurt at all. “I am so sorry! Are you ok?”

The old woman looked up at Adora through thick round glasses. “Mara! What are you doing out here? This is not where you're supposed to be.”

Adora relaxed as she realized it was a civilian. Not a princess. Not a member of the rebellion. Just some old lady and it looked like she wasn’t injured.

The old lady shook her head. “You don’t want to lose that sword again- so stop leaving it out in the forest, Mara dearie!”

Adora furrowed her brow. “Who’s Mara?”

The old lady’s magnified eyes blinked. “Oh no! You’re not Mara. You’re the other one. Well, you’re late. Follow me.”

Adora grabbed the sword and yanked it out of the ground. “Late? I’m not late. I don’t even know you!”

The woman stopped and tapped her chin. “Oh, then this must be the first time for you.” She looked around. “Normally, this is somewhere else. Somehow, you got on the wrong path. You got lost.”

“I’m not lost.”

“You’re not? Then where are you?”

Adora stood up defiantly. “About a day's walk from Dryl. Half a day walk to-” She stopped. She would say the Fright Zone, but

there was still a chance this lady was a rebel sympathizer. Instead, she said something safe. "-the whispering woods."

The old lady nodded. "Yes, dearie, where you were supposed to find the sword, because that's where Mara left it, but that's not how it went, was it?"

Adora blinked. "I don't know what you're talking about. Look, I'm really sorry for the sword mishap, but-"

Adora felt a quick hit on her head, and the lady was in her face. "It doesn't matter. The wrong path will still take you in the right direction if you'll stop being so stubborn and just follow it."

Adora hated being called stubborn. She wasn't stubborn. Catra was stubborn. She was nothing but accommodating- giving- almost to a fault.

The old woman rubbed her temple. "I have to think. What am I supposed to say to you in this one? It's so hard to remember."

Adora started backing up slowly.

She tapped her chin. "Was it the part about your people making the sword, but they did not make She-Ra?"

Adora stopped cold. "What?"

The old woman smiled big. "Was that it? Or was it something else? It's so hard to remember when we're not in the right spot. Do you want to pick berries or make a pie? Those are easier for me."

"You said something about She-Ra- how do you-" Adora paused, looking down at the blade. "You recognize the sword. Maybe you can help me. Answer some questions. I really-"

The old woman reached forward, pulling Adora down to her level. "I think I remember. Old Madame Razz remembers. Time gets confusing. The old and the new- different paths- in this one, you

are going to get stuck and when you do, let go of what is holding you back and find your heart .”

Adora stared in shock at the old woman. “That doesn’t make any sense.”

Razz let Adora go and looked off into the forest. “Or was I supposed to say something about Adora? Oh, Mara, this is so confusing sometimes.”

Adora stood up, and for a moment, realized it was weird to hear her own name. Did she tell the old lady her name? Did she introduce herself? She looked up to ask, but the old lady was gone.

Adora stood there looking around frantically at the quiet forest around her. There were no signs that there was ever anyone else with her, but her head still hurt from the broom- so the old lady had to have been real, right?

Maybe it was all just a trick of her mind- a leftover from whatever the chip had done to her. She gripped her sword and headed back to camp but kept an eye out behind her in case the old lady came back.

***

Catra was still reeling on the log when Scorpia looked back with a confused look on her face.

Catra winced. She would have to explain what happened later. No, she didn’t get the words out of her mouth. Adora fucked it up by being weird. Big shock. That’s when she saw Scorpia’s eyes get wide.

Catra was confused by that look until a hand grabbed her shoulder from behind. “How's it hanging, Horde Scum?”

Catra had no time to react before her world was full of purple sparks. In an instant, her stomach was queasy, and she and the

Rebel Commander were fifteen feet up in a tree at an unknown location that seemed to be far away from the camp.

Catra steadied herself against the trunk and managed a smirk despite the disorientation of the jump. “Miss me that bad, hm?”

Glimmer grabbed Catra’s uniform and held her other fist ready. “Do you know how embarrassing it was to get that message in the middle of a war meeting? Now, mom thinks- who knows what- and she gave me a two-hour lecture about how Entrapta is too old for me. So, fucking explain yourself!”

Catra couldn’t stop smiling. This was priceless. “It worked didn’t it? It got you here. You knew it was me. No one else has any idea you’re talking to the enemy. All and all, a success.”

Glimmer’s brow furrowed. “You had better make it worth it.”

“I wanted to talk about your offer, now that my friend is not unconscious on the floor.”

The sparkly princess blinked and let go of Catra’s uniform. She let her fist drop. “To come back with me? Sure- you’d be a prisoner of war though so-”

“So tell me about your prisons? Sell me on this.”

Glimmer’s lip twitched. “Our prisons- right- they’re very big and dark, and cold. Very uncomfortable.”

Catra watched how Sparkles looked uncomfortable, unsure- like she was making it all up on the spot. Catra’s smile was gone. “You don’t have prisons do you?”

Glimmer panicked. “Sure we do. We have so many prisons. Full of Horde people. Just- doing prisoner things and eating prisoner food. It’s very bland and consistent!”

“Wow. Even in your imagination, this place sounds better than the Fright Zone.”

From below, they heard a voice. “Glimmer? Are you up there?”

Both Glimmer and Catra looked down through the branches. They could see the archer walking around in the moonlight.

Glimmer huffed and whispered, “Excuse me for a second.” She leaned over a little. “Yeah! I found a cat up a tree, and I’m trying to get it down. Just give me a moment.”

“Ok! I’ll keep a lookout for the Horde.” He turned and got his bow and arrow ready.

Glimmer turned back to Catra to find her smiling from ear to ear.

“You brought your archer friend? What did you tell him? That you needed to talk to your Dryl girlfriend?”

“Shut up.” Glimmer got in close. “Look, if you want to come back with me, I’ll take you. I can guarantee your safety as long as you give us some information we can use.”

And that ruined Catra’s good mood. “It’s not just me. I have some friends-”

“I can probably convince my mom to let me take one prisoner. We have an extra bedroom we can use as a cell. Two was going to be a stretch, but what happened with the sword, I thought-”

“Speaking of the sword, did you know it summoned some kind of planet goddess? Does She-Ra ring a bell?”

Glimmer went still. “What?”

“Maybe go ask your mom and see what she has to say- and tell me because frankly, I’m tired of being in the fucking dark about this shit.”

“Horde!” The archer yelled as he readied his arrows.

Both Glimmer and Catra looked down then out to hear something crashing through the woods. Catra smiled. “Oh, that’s my other friend who I might want to make part of this deal. Big gal. The strongest person I know. We need to wrap this up, or your friend is going to get pummeled into a bloody pulp.”

Glimmer grabbed Catra’s uniform and pulled her in. “I’ll talk to mom. You spend your time gathering info, you got me?”

Catra shrugged. “Sure thing Princess. I’ll get right on that.”

Glimmer let go and disappeared in a flash of sparks.

Catra crouched down to watch the princess appear behind her archer and grab his shoulder. “We’re out of here, Bow!” And before he could protest or take a breath, they were both gone.

Scorpia, like a tank, burst through the trees and slid to the spot where the Rebels had been, heaving in a panic.

Catra jumped down, landing on the ground in front of her.

Scorpia let out a big breath and grabbed Catra in a big hug that nearly killed her. “I thought you were a goner!”

“Can’t- breathe!”

“Oh, sorry.” Scorpia let go and put Catra down. She hunched over to look Catra in the eye. “Are you injured? Did she hurt you?”

Catra motioned for Scorpia to back off. “I’m fine. I held my own, but thanks for scaring them off.” Catra started walking in the direction Scorpia had come, assuming that was the direction the campsite was in. “We’ll have to pack up and keep moving now that they know where we are. Don’t want to get ambushed while we sleep.”

Scorpia groaned as she fell in beside Catra. “I was really looking forward to camping out again.”

Catra was only half listening as she rolled her thoughts over the possibilities of a tentative alliance with the Rebel commander. Between that and Entrapta, Catra wondered how much of this war she could wrench away from Shadow Weaver. That terrible old woman had done everything she could to make Catra's life one long process of jumping through hoops and doing what she was told. Well, time to get some of that power back.

"Did you tell Adora?" Scorpia asked bluntly.

Catra groaned, sad to be drawn out of the world domineering fantasy that had cropped up in her head. "I almost did, but- it was weird."

Scorpia gave her a reassuring smile. "It's hard for everyone the first time. Don't worry. You've got time. We'll work through it, ok?"

Catra rolled her eyes. No, she didn't want to work through it. It would be easier to defect to the rebels and fight Adora for the rest of her life than tell her how she felt. Couldn't things just go back to the way they were before? They were nice then. No complicated feelings. Just- waking up every morning next to Adora. What was it going to take to get back there?

"Ok?" Scorpia looked at her with such eagerness and heartfelt enthusiasm.

"Whatever."

Friend Zone

It took a night of marching back to the Fright Zone, but they were home a few hours before sunrise.

Adora led them through the quiet and mostly empty corridors and stopped at a door in a section of the Fright Zone none of them visited often. “Shadow Weaver told me to give you this room,” she said with an exhausted smile as she typed in the code.

The door slid open, and the lights clicked on with a fluorescent buzz as Entrapta inhaled a squeal. Her hair propelled her forward, and she was all over the room picking up equipment and examining machinery. “So much is already here. It’s not quite like what I have at home, but this is fantastic!” She stopped at a few discarded large glass containers. She pointed with her hair. “Ok, so someone here is doing genetic cloning.”

Adora’s face scrunched in sudden concern. “Please refrain from deducing Lord Hordak’s experiments based on the contents of his old lab.”

Entrapta smiled big. “Oh! So this is Hordak’s old lab.” Her hair picked up the discarded limb of a battle bot. “That explains the combat tech, and it looks like he was trying to make a portal over there.”

Scorpia, Catra, and Adora all perked up and looked over in the corner. To the three of them, it looked like a pile of garbage.

Adora turned back. “Again, please don’t assume anything. You’re here to study the sword and-”

Catra cut Adora off. “-and to look into infinite batteries for our battle bots.”

Adora glared at her.

Catra glared back.

Adora turned away, not wanting this to turn into a fight in front of other people. “Shadow Weaver said that if you need anything, don’t hesitate to ask her.”

Entrapta had already switched her attention to the computer, which was up and running. “No need. I can order whatever I need directly from this.”

Adora visibly stiffened. “I don’t think you understand. You have to go through Shadow Weaver for requests.”

Entrapta’s hair spun her, and she smiled. “No. I don’t. I’ve already ordered some equipment. This Shadow person is unnecessary for my needs.”

Catra practically purred.

Adora shot her a look.

Catra shrugged with a knowing smile. “I like her. I really like her.”

Adora moved in and whispered, “You could help me out here.”

Catra whispered back, “Why would I help you enforce Shadow Weaver’s stupid rules? The science princess has things covered. Besides, it’s not like you can make her do anything. What are you going to do? Use a stun baton on her and send her to beast island?”

Adora relaxed only a fraction. She turned back to watch Entrapta’s hair clicking away at an old computer and realized Catra was probably right. The tiredness of marching most of the night seemed to hit her. She rubbed the bridge of her nose and started walking toward the door. “Fine. Let me know if you need anything else.” She stopped remembering one last thing. “Shadow Weaver wants me to do my training here with you tomorrow after lunch, so you can see the sword in action. Is that a problem?” She looked back.

Entrapta hummed and said, “Nope!” like she wasn’t even paying attention. Her eyes were focused on the screen, and an absolute waterfall of text passing by it quickly.

“Why do I even bother?” Adora turned toward the door.

Catra started to follow. “I’ll walk you to your room.”

Scorpia moved fast, putting a pincer on Catra’s shoulder. “Or, I can walk you both to your relative beds, you know- for safety sake since we’re all so tired.”

Catra turned a death stare to Scorpia.

Scorpia kept smiling as she was unaffected by the look.

Adora looked between them, made her assumptions, and let her heart break a little before declaring, “I’ll be fine. I don’t need an escort.” She pulled out the sword and kind of awkwardly waved it around. “Remember, I’ve got She-Ra and everything. Kind of like having a bodyguard all the time.”

Catra’s claws extended out, and she grit her teeth while growing, “Are you sure, Adora?”

That question got the sword to stop spinning and Adora to get still and quiet. She looked Catra in the eye.

That look caused Catra’s anger to fade, only to have it be replaced by something else. A feeling she wasn’t really used to. Her claws retracted. “Well?”

“I’m sure I’ll be fine.” Adora gave her a fake smile as she put the sword back in her harness on her back. “I’ll see you-” She hesitated “-you two later.” She turned and left before anyone could say anything else. The door slid shut behind her.

Catra’s shoulders slumped as she turned back to Scorpia, more sad than angry. “Did you have to?”

Scorpia sighed big as she pulled her backpack off and dropped it on the ground. “It’s for your own good. I told you already, no more bed-sharing without being upfront and honest with her.”

Catra groaned. “Then where the fuck am I supposed to sleep?”

“The barracks.”

“I can’t.”

“Why not?”

“Because if I go back, then Shadow Weaver is going to assume something’s wrong with what she *thinks* is going on between *us* , and that causes a whole host of problems.”

“Oh- I didn’t think about that.”

“You can sleep here,” Entrapta piped up from her corner with the computer.

Both Scorpia and Catra looked back, a little surprised.

Entrapta stayed focused on the computer while she added, “All the data shows that this is a part of the Fright Zone that is usually not heavily used. This Shadow Weaver, by her schedule, isn’t planning on coming here until tomorrow after lunch for that training your friend talked about. If you’re avoiding her, here’s a good place.”

Catra stared at her in shock. “You have access to Shadow Weaver’s calendar?”

Entrapta did look back. “Affirmative. The Fright Zone’s cybersecurity is really weak.”

Scorpia and Catra shared a look. Scorpia shrugged.

Catra took a breath. “Ok. I’m filling that bit of information away for later, and for now, I guess I’m fine with sleeping here.”

Scorpia got a small smile. “I mean, or else you could take me up on my offer of sleeping in my room.”

Catra rolled her eyes. “It’s bad enough Shadow Weaver *thinks* I’m sleeping in there without it actually being the case.”

“Ok, sure. We’ll sleep here. Call it a sleepover.”

Catra raised an eyebrow. “Um, no, you’re going to sleep in your room, and I’ll sleep here.”

Scorpia smiled and shook her head. “Oh no, you’re not pulling that one on me. The moment I leave, you’re going to go to her room.”

Catra sneered.

Scorpia threw her arm around Catra’s shoulders, pulling her into the room. “Hey, don’t think of it like I’m keeping you away from a soft, warm bed with your crush. Think of it more like I’m helping you be a better person by holding you accountable.” She grabbed Catra’s backpack with her pincers and helped pull it off. The sleeping bag was an easy thing to pull out and lay on the ground. “Relax. You’ll confess tomorrow and probably be back in her bed by evening.”

Catra found relaxing hard without Adora, and this absolutely wasn’t helping.

Scorpia turned to her own backpack and pulled out her sleeping bag. “Look, we’ll practice. Practice always helped me.”

Catra growled. She hated everything about this.

Scorpia unfurled her sleeping bag, laid it down, and sat down crossed-legged. She patted the spot in front of her for Catra to sit down.

Catra hesitated, then rolled her eyes. “Whatever.” And sat down in a crouching position with her tail wrapped around her feet. Adora

would have recognized immediately that she was insecure, but Adora wasn't there, so Catra just looked like an angry bundle.

Scorpia looked too happy, too awake, for having just spent the night marching home. "Ok, so what are you going to do?"

Catra frowned at her.

Scorpia responded with an even bigger smile. "Come on. You can do this! You're smart- and brave- and cunning- and she's going to say she loves you back. So, how are you going to tell her?"

Catra groaned.

"We'll make this easier by roleplaying. Just imagine I'm Adora, and practice on me."

Catra looked Scorpia over and frowned harder.

"Oh, come on. You can imagine."

Catra rubbed her temples past her mask and closed her eyes. "It sounds stupid."

From the computer, Entrapta chimed in. "Studies have shown that practicing difficult conversations does, in fact, make them easier. I can get the articles for free using a pirated library if you want."

"No, please, no. This is stupid enough already. I don't need to read about how stupid it is." Catra changed her position to sit crossed-legged like Scopria, at least trying to relax. "Ok. I'm pretending you're Adora. Your hairpoof is stupid. You've got a dumb face. Now what?"

Scorpia gave a hopeful smile. "Now, you just say what's in your heart."

Catra blinked as her brain blanked on what she was supposed to say. Something about Scorpia's stupid hopeful face did have a hint

of Adora in it, and it was throwing her off. “Ok- so- feelings- I have them. Do you have them too?”

Scorpia’s shoulders fell. “That’s what you come up with?”

“Wana fuck?”

Scoripa’s eyes went wide.

Catra shrugged and folded her arms. Her tail, wildly flicking behind her, made her aggravation obvious. “Look, it’s easier to ask for that. Somehow it’s less personal.”

Scorpia looked pained. “You can’t say I love you, but you can ask to fuck?” She closed her eyes and shook her pincers. “No, wait. I get it. Shadow Weaver really screwed you both over. I shouldn’t be surprised.” She took in a breath. “Ok- is that all you want from her? If that’s true, you should definitely tell her that before you sleep in her bed again.”

Catra groaned and pulled up her knees. She covered her head with her hands. “No, that’s not all I want. It’s just what’s easy to ask for because it’s- it’s not about feelings.”

Scorpia winced. “You don’t think fucking is about feelings? Ok. Well, we’ll have to unpack that later. For now, try to think about what you really want then.”

“I don’t know. If I knew, this would be easier.”

Scorpia’s look softened again. “Ok. Then- let's think about that. When you think of a future where Shadow Weaver’s gone, and it’s just you and Adora- what do you picture?”

Catra tensed for a moment. She had never actually allowed herself to consider it. “I guess- I want to be around her all the time. I want her attention.”

“Great! Now we’re getting somewhere. Now, pretend I’m Adora, and how would you say that to her?”

Catra looked up. “Uh- Hey, Adora- I- I want- I don’t know. I want to sleep in your bed forever, and I’ll kill whoever tries to get me out.”

Scorpia’s face was smacked with worry.

Catra panicked. “Look, this is fucking hard.”

“It’s ok. You just went too far. Back up a little bit.”

Catra grit her teeth. “You said to speak from the heart.”

“And you go straight to murder?” She closed her eyes for a moment then came back with, “Again, I shouldn’t be surprised. Maybe I should give you an example to work from?”

“Sure. Whatever floats your boat.”

Scorpia sat up straight. “Ok. I’ll be you, and you’ll be Adora.” She reached out her pincer. “Take my hand.”

Catra, awkwardly, put her hand between Scorpia’s offered pincer.

Scorpia closed her eyes and channeled the romantic version of Catra she had always held in her head. “Adora, we’ve been friends for as long as I can remember. Your companionship has been the only thing to get me through these harsh years. But you’re more than that to me. You’re more than just some port in a storm.” Scorpia leaned in. “I want to be more for you- and with you. No more just being friends. I want your heart. I want your body.”

There was a long awkward moment between them.

Catra blinked. “Wow...you sound like an idiot.”

“An idiot for love.” Scorpia pulled Catra in closer. Her cheeks flushed.

Catra slowly pushed away. “I don’t think this is working. I wouldn't say those things- like- ever-”

Scorpia let go and pulled back. “You don't have to say it like that, but you’ve got to say something. Speak from the heart to her heart. Now you try.”

Catra sighed and stuck out her hand. “Ok, fucking take my hand, you loser.”

Scorpia winced but put her massive pincer in Catra’s tiny hand.

Catra’s face twitched. “Ok so, Shadow Weaver sucks, and I want to kill her with you. Are you with me?”

Scorpia shook her head slowly. “Try again.”

“What? You don’t think the murder of a horrible bitch is good enough? You don’t think she’ll fall for me right then and there?”

“Try something else. From the heart, remember?”

“From the heart. Right.”

“Tell her what you want.”

“I want her-”

“Good. That’s good.”

“-to sit on my face.”

Scorpia let out a long slow breath. She pulled her pincer back. “You know what- you’re just hurting yourself by not taking this seriously.”

Catra’s ears plastered against her head. “What’s the point? No matter what I say, she’s going to misunderstand it. If I say I love her, she’ll look me in the eye and say I love you too, as a friend or a sister or something stupid.”

“You don’t know that.”

“If I say I want to be more than friends, she’ll look all excited and say ‘like super friends?’ I can see it so clearly. No matter how I run the scenario, she always ends up being an idiot.”

Scorpia rested her elbows on her knees. “Ok, then maybe you just have to let her be an idiot. Just get the words out and see what happens.”

Catra’s tail flicked. She looked away. “Sounds dumb and vulnerable, and I’m not dumb or vulnerable.”

Scorpia sighed. “Everyone is dumb and vulnerable when it comes to love. It’s part of the whole package. What if- what if she’s an idiot because she likes you but doesn’t know how to express it? I’m sure Shadow Weaver didn’t do her any favors either. She’s probably as helpless with the vocabulary of love, care, and relationships as you are.”

Catra didn’t respond. She was trying too hard to avoid being emotional about it.

“Maybe she needs this. Even if she says no- it might just be because she doesn’t even know what being in love is with someone. Can’t imagine it. She might just need time to accept it, but she can’t start accepting something until it’s on the table.”

She was probably right. Catra could see it clearly. A heartfelt love confession, with Adora panicking because they weren’t supposed to be that way. How were they supposed to know the magic set of words to express a mysterious emotion they had never really been allowed to feel? How were they supposed to do it in a way that didn't feel like they were being dangerously vulnerable?

“I know it’s going to be hard, but it will be worth it. Even if she says no- you’ll at least be free to look for love somewhere else.” Scorpia gave her a hopeful smile.

Catra didn’t notice it. “I’d rather the whole world end than let that happen.” She said it so flatly, so assuredly.

“Ok, again, tone it down. You literally go from nothing to murder in like a millisecond. Can you just say, I love you, and I want to be more than friends with you?”

Catra blinked. The idea of those words, in that order, coming out of her mouth and going into Adora’s ears felt like she was driving a skiff at a hundred miles an hour.

Scorpia put a reassuring pincer on Catra’s shoulder. “Hey, you’ll do ok. You know her better than anyone else. You know how to get the message across better than anyone. Maybe the problem is- I’m giving you all the ways I would do it, but really this is a you and her thing.”

Catra pulled away and started crawling into her sleeping bag. “This is going to go bad.”

“Again, you don’t know that.”

Catra got into the sleeping bag and covered her head, and mumbled, “Yeah, I do.”

“No, you don’t.”

“Shut up and go to sleep.”

***

Adora laid down in her bed in the dark while desperately trying not to think about where Catra currently was or what she was doing.

She reached out and touched the pillow that had quickly become Catra’s, and she pulled it to her chest. It wasn’t much, but it was something to remember her by. She took a deep breath and tried to relax. She never really got to relax before she fell asleep. She didn’t dream that night.

The alarm went off, and Adora startled awake. She reached over and hit the button. “Rise and shine or else you’ll miss-” She

stopped herself as she looked back on the empty bed next to her. She sighed. “Right. Force of habit.” She got up, put on her boots, and decided she had to eat breakfast instead of sleeping in because Catra would want her to eat.

Fifteen minutes later, she was sitting in the cafeteria with a few brown ration bars and all her appetite was gone. Still, she forced herself to take a bite and chew.

Someone hit her back. “Hey, loser.”

Adora straightened up and looked to see Catra with her own tray, moving around to sit in front of her on the table. Adora smiled genuinely. “How did you sleep?”

“Shitty.” Catra slumped down, picking at the brown bars with her claws. She leaned on her arm and avoided Adora’s eyes. “How’d you sleep?”

“Well, considering it was only for a few hours- not great, but I’ll be fine.”

“Great.” Catra seemed distracted by something, but it wasn’t the food she was playing with. She sat up and scooted in. “So, I need to say something.”

“Ok.” Adora put her food down.

Catra chewed her lip, her eyes darting around to take in the room and who was there. She leaned over the table, then met Adora’s eye. “I want to say-” and she hesitated.

Adora didn’t care that she hesitated. She was enraptured by the attention.

Catra glanced down, then up, and faltered. “Can we go somewhere more private?”

“Sure.” Adora grabbed her tray without hesitation and started to get up. “Where do you think?”

"Our high spot. I'll meet you there." Catra got up and bolted, leaving her tray on the table.

Adora sighed and went back to grab Catra's tray as well and take them both back to the trash. It wasn't lost on her that Catra technically skipped breakfast. That wasn't a great sign. She dumped the trays and went the roundabout way to their high spot- the landing that overlooked the Fright Zone.

She stood at the bottom of the spot and looked up. This was how Catra was finally going to tell her that Scorpia had confessed. Maybe she would say she had already accepted the offer of affection. Maybe she hadn't yet, and she was going to ask Adora for advice. Adora set her jaw and started climbing. She would tell Catra to take the offer no matter how much it hurt her personally.

With every grip on the pipes and foothold in the cracks, she assured herself that she would be a good friend. She was going to be happy, or at least pretend to be happy. She was going to make sure that no matter what happened, Catra would be taken care of by someone sweet and strong and privileged- and not someone burdened by some weird world-ending fate.

Before she knew it, she had tears running down her face, and she stopped the climb to wipe them away.

Nope. Can't have that. No crying, Adora. Crying is a weakness .

She steeled herself and kept climbing.

Catra was sitting on the edge on the other side with her back to her when she got to the top.

Adora desperately wanted to turn tail and run. She wanted to avoid this, but Catra deserved better than that. She stood on the platform, and dusted herself off, and squared her shoulders, and marched toward her friend. She sat down next to Catra with the assurance of someone who was forcing every step of the way out of principle.

Catra didn’t look up. She was picking at something with her claws. “Thanks for coming. I couldn’t say anything in that cafeteria. Everyone’s always listening and gossiping.”

“Yeah.” Adora noticed the shakiness of her own voice and hoped Catra wouldn't. She sat on her hands so they wouldn't shake.

Catra looked out on the Fright Zone as the sun rose. It made everything orange. “So- uh- I was going to say something.”

“You mentioned that.”

Catra swallowed. Shook her head. Rubbed her eyes and then tried to act normal. “Adora, I have to ask you a question.”

Adora’s heart rate went up. Adrenaline kicked in. Her ears were waiting to hear the thing she had been dreading. “Sure. Go for it.” She was trying desperately to sound casual. It wasn’t working.

Catra took a deep breath, then let it out before rushing to say, “What are we?”

Adora blinked. Her brain tried to smoosh that into something about Scorpia, but she couldn’t. “What?”

“What are you and I? I mean, I know words and stuff are hard, but try for me.”

Adora started out onto the place they had called home most of their lives. “Friends.”

Catra made a sound- like a little grunt of acknowledgment. “Best friends.”

“Super best friends.”

Catra closed her eyes. “You said you’d always be my friend.”

“And I still mean it. I always will.” Her voice wasn’t shaky. This was the truth. This was easy. No matter what happened, she

would always be Catra's friend.

Catra hesitated. She still avoided Adora's eyes. She looked at everything but her eyes. "I know that. I just- I wonder- would you ever consider-" Catra's words faltered. "Shit. This is so fucking hard."

Adora's stomach dropped. This wasn't what she thought it was. This was something else. For a brief moment, her heart soared. That love she had felt during the fight- this was a brief moment in which it might be that it was returned. Something greater than friendship. Something more. Something she had never allowed herself to want or to hope for. The idea made her dizzy.

For a moment, Adora's brain provided her a possible future. Assume the war was over. Assume Shadow Weaver was out of the picture. Assume the sword had never come to her. It was just her and Catra, waking up in the morning and smiling at each other. Being close. Being soft. Being vulnerable... Touching...

Like a steel trap, reality crashed down around it. But the war was there. Shadow Weaver wasn't out of the picture, and the sword had come to her. She started to get up.

Catra looked up in surprise. "Wait- are you leaving?"

Adora's hands were sweaty. Her skin was pale. "I can't do this." The image of a planet in danger rose in her mind's eye—people suffering because she had been selfish.

"Can't do what?"

"This. I can't do this." She started to walk away. The shakiness was back in her voice.

Catra was up on her feet. "What do you mean *this* ?" The hurt in Catra's voice was palpable. It only made things worse.

Adora's hands were shaking as she stopped herself. She balled them into fists so Catra wouldn't see it. "I'm sorry, Catra. I wish- I

wish things were different.” And she ran. She ran and grabbed the edge of the platform and scrambled down as fast as she ever had.

“Adora! Stop!” Catra was at the edge of the platform, looking down in a panic. “Adora!” Her voice cracked.

Adora didn’t look up, didn’t respond. She didn’t even check to see if Catra was following her.

She landed on the ground and sprinted through the Fright Zone, in any random direction, just to get away. She kept running until she was out of breath because it would all consume her if she stopped.

She came to a sudden stop half an hour later, heaving breath, and bent over. She could pretend that the pain in her chest was from the run. She could lie to herself all day. Shadow Weaver made sure of that. But she couldn't make herself feel something different. She fell against the cold hard wall of one of the Fright Zone’s corridors and felt the crushing pain of it all. She closed her eyes and leaned her head back. She could do this. She had to. And she had to do it in the next few hours because she was supposed to be training with Shadow Weaver in Entrapta’s lab after lunch.

She hit her head on the wall lightly. *Fuck my life* .

***

Scorpia was in good spirits as she headed back to Entrapta’s lab after the morning briefing. She even whistled. She opened the door and was greeted with the quiet constant typing of Entrapta’s hair, and then she saw Catra sitting next to her, curled into herself but staring at the screen. Her smile was gone. “Oh, hey. I didn't think you’d be back already.”

Catra’s focus was undisturbed. “Yeah, well, neither did I.”

Scorpia moved forward slowly. “So, did you uh- get to talk to Adora?”

Catra's whole body went stiff. Her hair stood up. "You could say that."

"And- how did it go?"

Catra didn't look up. Her eyes were scanning the data along with Entrapta. "Badly."

Scorpia looked at Entrapta, then Catra. "So- did she say no?"

"Not exactly."

"Then what did she say?"

Catra tapped on the screen, and Entrapta opened the file. A completely different set of data started running on the screen. "Well, first of all, I never got the confession out. I think she saw it coming and just- shut it down."

Scorpia stopped cold. "Oh... That's- unexpected."

"Exactly." Catra stopped the flow of data by tapping another file.

Entrapta opened it up for her. What pulled up on the screen were reports.

Scorpia looked up at it. "So- what are we doing now?"

Catra stared at the reports, skimming them. "Somethings wrong with Adora, but I don't know what so I had Entrapta here hack into Shadow Weaver's personal files so I could find out what's going on."

Scorpia paused for a moment. "So- you're reacting to this by invading Shadow Weaver's privacy?"

"Yep."

"Is that healthy?"

Catra shrugged and said in a flat voice, “Better than going nuts and trying to end the world.”

Zero to murder. Every time . Scorpia took a long breath, pulled up a chair, and sat. “Ok. I’ll help. Where do we start?”

The Missing Piece

Adora sat with her head against the wall for longer than she wanted to, hoping the knot in her gut and the pain in her chest would go away on their own. They didn't. She opened her eyes, and like a good tactician, thought of her options. She could just go to the training and get a dressing-down from her commanding officer. She could feign sickness and go to her room, missing the training and getting a dressing-down. Neither of those were great options. She started to get up as her only option seemed to be the contraband distribution. Surely, they had something that could make this go away.

She started down the hall in a daze.

"Hey! There you are. We've been looking all over for you."

Adora stopped and turned to see Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio. A small part of her relaxed.

Lonnie saw it immediately. "We heard you came in late last night. You ok?"

"I've had a bad twenty-four hours." That was the best Adora could do. It was true—little sleep. Emotional upheaval.

The three horde kids exchanged looks before Lonnie moved forward. "What's up?"

Adora held up her hand level so they could see how it was shaking. She grabbed it with her other hand. "I can't stop it. I have training to go to in a few minutes. I can't let Shadow Weaver see me like this." She stumbled back into the wall and slid down to the ground.

Lonnie folded her arms. "No, I get that you're a nervous wreck. I'm asking what happened to cause it?"

Adora shook her head and leaned it back against the wall. “Where do I even start?”

Lonnie lifted an eyebrow. “Is this about Catra?”

Adora looked up, half in shock. “What?”

Lonnie shrugged. “I mean if it was anything else, you’d know how to handle it. So, I figure it’s something to do with her.”

Adora looked away, and maybe she blushed.

Lonnie managed a small smile. “Yeah, that’s what I thought.”

Adora startled as Lonnie sat next to her on the wall, and Kyle and Rogelio followed her lead.

“Did you guys break up?” Kyle asked innocently.

Lonnie hit him in the shoulder. “Come on, Kyle!”

Adora watched them stunned. “Broke up?”

“Yeah- weren’t you two- like- together?” Kyle seemed to lose all his steam at once. Rogelio put his arm around Kyle’s shoulders in support.

Adora frowned. “No?”

Lonnie turned back. “Forget him. Just tell us what happened.”

Adora’s defenses were down because she had been running on cortisol for too long. So she let it all out, starting with the fight. That one that made everyone think they were bitter enemies- that was the moment Adora realized it could be love. Adora looked down the line to see their reactions.

The three of them did not react at all. They didn’t even look surprised.

Lonnie motioned for Adora to keep going.

Adora snapped out of it and continued. She went on about emotional entanglements and the end of the world, and Scorpia trying to confess, and then her getting knocked out and having some kind of prophetic dream? And then finger guns and running off into the woods where she maybe saw a hallucination of an old lady that gave her some very cryptic advice. Then, the scare with the rebels, a night of marching. It all culminated in a very detailed report of the conversation with Catra that morning, ending with Adora running away again. By the end of it, Adora was a bundle of nerves pulled tight and ready to snap all over again.

Lonnie shook her head. "I never thought I'd say this, but Catra was right all these years. You're an idiot."

Adora nodded. "I know."

"And you can't keep running away from this. That's not you."

"So what do I do?"

"It's it obvious? Communicate? I realize that's hard with Shadow Weaver's unique style of parenting, but that's what you gotta do."

Adora rubbed her face with her hands before letting them drop to her legs. "You're right. I should- I should at least listen to her."

"And?"

"And tell her the whole emotional entanglements part."

"She's not going to believe that."

Adora blinked. "I know. She's going to think Shadow Weaver is lying. She always does."

Lonnie shrugged. "So, figure out if she's lying."

At first, Adora's reaction was immediate rejection. The idea of questioning Shadow Weaver about it made her feel sick to her stomach. Then, her thinking switched. The training was just a few

minutes away. This particular training with a unique meeting of probably the most gifted scientist on the planet and one of the most distinguished sorcerers. If there was ever a time to get a good sense of exactly how the world could end through technology or magic, it would be then. She started to nod. "Ok. Yeah. Figure out if she's lying, so when I see Catra, I can-" Her brain came to a complete stop. What the fuck was she supposed to do when she saw Catra?

Lonnie saw the panic. "Just listen to her and tell her what you told me, word for word if you have to."

Adora nodded again, frantically. "Ok. Yeah. I can do that."

"You'll be happy you finally talked. I know we were." Kyle said meekly.

Adora hesitated for a moment as she got out of her head about stuff and actually looked at the three sitting next to her. Kyle didn't say "Rogelio and me." He said, "we." There was something in the way they were sitting so close. Maybe she had seen seeds of it before and chalked it up to close friendship, but now things were starting to come together. "Since Catra and I have been out of the barracks-" She used an index finger to gesture to the three of them. "-have you guys..." Her voice trailed off, not exactly sure what words to put there. It was possibly better left unsaid.

Lonnie shrugged. "It's complicated, and frankly, none of your business." Her blush betrayed her words.

Kyle gave back a soft happy smile. Rogelio rolled his eyes but didn't take his arm away from Kyle's shoulders.

Adora slowly got up as a warmth spread in her chest and a smile managed to come to her lips. She looked at her hands and realized they had stopped shaking. She turned back to the three and smiled bigger. "Thanks, guys. I needed this." She started to turn away and stopped. "And... I guess congratulations?"

Lonnie waved her away. "Whatever. Get going before you're late."

Adora ran toward Entrapta's new lab, her heart nearly bubbling over with a strange sort of happiness. She was happy for her friends, for whatever it was they had in each other. She had a plan for Catra, and it all started at training.

***

Shadow Weaver waited for Adora outside the lab, her eyes locked on the clock displaying in the hall. It was unlike Adora to be anything less than five minutes early. Just as the clock slid to three minutes left, Adora came running around the corner and slid to a stop into a salute. "Reporting for duty, Commander."

Shadow Weaver raised an eyebrow and looked Adora over. "I expected you to be earlier." She got in close and, in quiet tones, whispered, "Hordak wants more information on the technology of the sword. We offer this princess nothing else. Do I make myself clear?"

"Yes, Ma'am."

"You will submit to nothing before checking in with me. I approve all inspections and procedures."

"Understood."

Shadow Weaver stood straight and nodded. "Ok. Follow me in and keep quiet." She opened the door and strode in confidently. A lot of fore planning went into her dramatic entrances. She didn't knock first because she was the second in command in the Horde, and this lab was under her jurisdiction. She shouldn't need to knock, and the princess needed to know her place... Except the princess continued typing away at the computer and didn't even look up. Shadow Weaver stopped at the metal table set up between them and cleared her throat.

Entrapta sat still, focused on the computer screen.

Shadow Weaver cleared her throat harder.

“You might want to get that checked. You could be sick.”

“Entrapta, Shadow Weaver is here to see you for the training. She’s trying to get your attention,” Adora said.

Shadow Weaver shot her a look for speaking out of turn.

Adora shrank back.

Entrapta pushed away from the computer. “Oh! Right! So let's see it.” Her hair grabbed the sword off Adora’s back and put it on the table while another thick strand lifted her up so she could look at it.

Shadow Weaver put a quick hand on the blade blocking Entrapta’s view. “You will not touch the sword again without my permission. Is that understood?”

Entrapta, inelegantly, used her hair to push Shadow Weaver away from the blade. “That’s ridiculous. Why would I need your permission to touch it? I’ve already touched it before.”

Shadow Weaver was not used to people openly disobeying her and started to draw energy from the Black Garnet. If this princess wanted to test her, then she would come full force.

Instantly, Entrapta had forgotten about the sword and was instead in Shadow Weaver’s face, her own hand poking at the stone in her mask. “That’s a neat trick. Using a small false runestone to make drawing magic easier, especially for someone who isn’t an elemental princess. I wonder if I could do something similar.”

“Do not touch me!” Shadow Weaver felt her voice lose control. She swiped at the princess to get her away, but her hair had already moved her back.

Entrapta was now completely focused on Adora. “Ok, back to the sword. I want to see it work. Turn big again.”

Adora looked to Shadow Weaver for approval.

“She will do no such thing without my-” Shadow Weaver found herself quieted by a strand of hair on her mask where her mouth would have been.

“Please don’t interrupt. I’m trying to talk to Adora, and it’s hard for me to focus when people interrupt.”

Shadow Weaver roared and slashed at the hair, only to find her nails slid through nothing but strands. How the fuck did her hair work? She moved back, out of the reach of that hair, and breathed heavily.

Adora watched with growing alarm.

Shadow Weaver pulled herself together. Gathering her calm and turning all her burning anger on Entrapta. “You will not touch me again, or I will end your life.”

Entrapta was too focused on the sword. “The moment I saw this, it completely disproved my current theory on runestones. I thought they needed a physical connection to the planet, but this one is free from any physical connection. As well as that one, so two pieces of evidence that disprove me! Isn’t it amazing!” She pointed toward Shadow Weaver’s mask.

Shadow Weaver flinched at the movement toward her. She considered another threat, but the last one hadn’t worked. She had to switch up tactics. She had to at least maintain the illusion of control. She smoothed her robes and tried to act like everything happening was what she wanted. “Adora, transform as she requests.”

Adora hesitated, unsure of the sudden reversal of the order.

Shadow Weaver turned a terrible eye on her ward. “Do as I say, Force Captain.”

Adora grabbed the sword and said the words. The room lit up as magic filled in, and Adora grew to be taller than everyone there.

Her hair lengthened to her hips in thick waves. Her colors were replaced with shimmering white and gold.

For a moment, Shadow Weaver forgot herself. It was like watching the birth of a goddess every time. It gave her goosebumps, and she resented that fact.

Entrapta was unphased. She poked at the blade in She-Ra's grip. "Not what I expected." She turned away and toward the computer.

She-Ra shifted her feet. "I have a question."

Entrapta focused back on Adora. "I love questions!"

Shadow Weaver glared at She-Ra, discouraging any undue inquiries.

She-Ra had Adora's shiver reaction to that look but went on. "Can you, or Shadow Weaver, give me more information about how exactly avoiding emotional entanglements are supposed to help?"

Shadow Weaver intensified her glare.

She-Ra, against Adora's better judgment, stood firm. "So I can avoid problems better."

That caused Entrapta to sit back. "Oh- I guess the translations do say something about that, but I've never understood it. There's nothing technically about the sword that would-"

Shadow Weaver couldn't let this go on. She cut in. "Adora, now is not the time for this."

She-Ra's jaw worked. Behind that face, Adora was struggling to decide what to say.

Shadow Weaver cut her off at the thought. "Later. We'll discuss this after training." That was the end of it, for now.

Entrapta had lost interest in the conversation. Instead, she was getting close to the sword with a magnifying glass that seemed to magically appear out of her hair. She turned around, and typed a few things into the computer, and hastily did some rough calculations, mumbling to herself.

Shadow Weaver watched with growing frustration. “What are you doing?”

Entrapta ignored her and continued to mumble to herself before she suddenly turned back with a wide smile. “This is interesting. I’ve never seen something designed to handle that volume so fast before. Most runestones are designed to only trickle out a little magic at a time, but this, this is like a floodgate for magic.”

Shadow Weaver grunted in a way that she knew was unlike her, but she was getting fed up. “This is pointless. I knew that already. You are not discovering anything new.”

“Oh, but I am. Before you two came in here, I calculated how much magical current and voltage it would take to create and *sustain* a portal, like the kind Hordak seems to be trying to make.” She pointed toward the pile of trash in the corner. “And I thought it was impossible until I saw this. This could do it.” she looked up at Adora. “I’m not sure if we need you for it or not.”

Shadow Weaver’s brain lit with warning at the word *we* , and she moved to put herself between Adora and the princess. “You will not use her or the sword for any such thing.”

Entrapta sat back on her hair. “Again, I don’t see why you think I need your approval.”

“This training is over.” Shadow Weaver’s voice was stern and fast and full of barely held anger. She shut the whole thing down by grabbing She-Ra’s shoulder and dragging her toward the door.

Adora didn’t struggle, even as Shadow Weaver’s nails dug into She-Ra’s skin.

Entrapta didn’t go after them. Instead, she turned toward the computer and her calculations in deep thought.

Shadow Weaver closed the door behind them and rounded on her ward. “How dare you!”

Adora staggered toward the wall, and her form flickered.

“You made me look like a fool in there. I should demote you for that alone.”

She-Ra’s face set in anger. Her eyes shone bright blue. “I am trying to be good. I am trying to avoid problems. I need to know more because what you’ve said doesn’t make any sense.”

“It makes perfect sense.”

“No, it doesn’t, not to me, and I’m the one it has to make sense to.”

Shadow Weaver hated it when a subordinate was right. She tried to calm down. Tried to get back into teacher mode as if it was a question coming from a student and not a subordinate. “The translations are not perfect, but magic is easily influenced by emotions. One of the things I struggled to teach new sorcerers was how to control their emotions in order to focus and get more consistent results.”

She-Ra’s face flushed with a brief moment of hope. It almost made her outshine the lights in the hall. “I can control my emotions. If that’s all it is-”

“It isn’t.” Shadow Weaver set her shoulders, folded her hands. “The story that has survived is that the last She-Ra’s emotional entanglements drove her mad, and for that, she *cursed* the planet. That is when the stars disappeared, and the skies went silent.” She-Ra’s reaction was hard to read. “I know that is not the answer you wanted. We must work with what we have the best we can. Is that understood?”

She-Ra's jaw worked, and the whole form flickered before solidifying into Adora, standing there unsure of herself. Adora struggled to respond, which was uncharacteristic.

"Is that understood, Force Captain?" Shadow Weaver used her commander's voice, stern and strong.

"I don't know what to do with that," she said with a dropping of her shoulders.

"Neither do I, but I know avoiding strong emotions and thus avoiding strong connections is the safest path." She hesitated. It felt wrong to use the term 'safest path' with the potential that laid before them. She had to make a decision. It was only a matter of time before the new Princess put thoughts into Hordak's head about possibilities. While Adora's magic hadn't come out the way she had wanted, it didn't change the fact that it was there finally. Perhaps moving quickly was better than trying to make the situation perfect. Sure, there was a level of risk, but there always had been. "Go to your room until lights out. Then come to my room with the sword. We are going on a stealth mission tonight."

Adora, for a moment, looked disappointed. "I haven't slept. I can't go on a mission that quickly. I'll be a liability."

"You will go because I command it. Is that clear?"

Adora hesitated.

Shadow Weaver felt anger rising in her at Adora's lack of conviction. It only made her more sure of her actions.

"It's clear, commander." Adora's shoulders fell, resigned. "Can I ask where we are going?"

To the end of this and future wars. To my own ascension to power. To your righteous sacrifice if that blade isn't strong enough to withstand the full power of the heart.

All traces of anger in Shadow Weaver were gone. It was replaced with a dull and resolute sadness that she had come to years ago when she took Adora in as a baby. Nostalgically, she touched Adora's hair and moved it behind her ear before straightening up. She was so sure of her words she did falter in their delivery. "We are headed to your future. I'm going to make you the hero you were always meant to be."

***

Minutes earlier, Scorpia and Catra stood in front of the door of the Black Garnet room. Catra had avoided this room at all costs most of her life because what lay beyond that door was nothing but pain.

Scorpia leaned in. "Are you sure about this? We could go back and look through more of the notes after Adora's training is over."

"I have to know what's going on. I have to find it." Catra moved forward to type the code that Entrapta had given her. She was still shocked when the door slid open. She stepped inside and looked over her shoulder at a person she had never really expected to be such a good friend. "The notes won't tell me what I need to know."

Scorpia's shoulders fell, and she stepped back in resignation.

Catra had been considering something and came to a decision right there. "Scorpia."

Scorpia looked up, almost hopeful. "Yeah?"

"Go to your room for an hour. Can you do that for me?"

Hope turned to worry. "Why? Why would you ask that?"

"We don't have a lot of time- and I don't know how things are going to shake out. I don't want you implicated, ok? I might be able to get you out eventually, but for now- for now, I need you to just go to your room and take a nap."

Scorpia hesitated.

“Go.”

“What if she walks in on you?”

“I can take care of it. Go!”

Scorpia pulled back, unsure of herself.

Catra silently cursed Scorpia’s unending loyalty. “It’ll be ok. Just trust me.”

It was the begging for trust that did it. Scorpia’s loyalty wouldn't allow her to reject it. “Ok, but be careful.”

Catra forced herself to give Scorpia a sure smile. “I always am.” That was a bald-faced lie, but Scorpia was idealistic, so she didn’t question it. With that, Catra let the door close, hoping that it would spur Scorpia to go.

When the woman didn’t knock on the door or say anything more, Catra relaxed in the knowledge that at least Scorpia was out of the equation and relatively safe.

She turned her attention to the room.

She moved, sniffing the furniture and the walls. She could still smell some slight hint of the sparkly princess in there from her time incarcerated. She could mostly smell Shadow Weaver, and it was a struggle to get past that stench.

Her nose led her to the two chairs in the middle of the room. One still had a faint scent of Adora. She sat down in that one and took a slow, careful breath through her nose. What she was looking for was close.

A quick search revealed the bottle was tucked under the table with the cork hastily shoved back into it. Catra grabbed it and sat back down. She was still surprised it was real. There had been a

small hope that she wouldn’t find it and so wouldn’t find any hard evidence anything had actually happened to Adora. But instead, there it was.

The notes said it had been used the same night Adora came home talking about contraband. Catra guessed there was an agreement that Adora wouldn't tell her. She remembered that Adora smelled like Shadow Weaver when the bitch was half drunk.

She opened the cork and stuck her nose in it, and fumes went up her nostrils. She coughed for a moment before being more careful the second time. It was, as expected, alcohol but also something else. Herbs? Some kind of magic concoction mixed in? She swished it around, got another good whiff.

Shadow Weaver had made several concoctions over the years. Catra was attuned to all of them she had been exposed to. Shadow Weaver didn’t know much about healing medicine, but she knew how to put a sick child under so they wouldn’t remember how bad they felt. It smelled faintly of that- maybe a bit stronger.

Her brain was working on the parts of the puzzle she had, and it kept coming up that there was one piece missing.

Her ears picked up the distinct sound of someone typing in the code in the door.

Catra huffed to herself, realizing it took a few minutes for Entrapta to completely lose track of the plan of distracting Shadow Weaver for as long as possible. She probably got caught up in the science of it. Catra couldn't even be angry. She had expected as much.

She should run.

She didn’t.

She should have scrambled up to a vent and gotten out, or at the very least, she should have dove for a hiding spot. Instead, she

sat with the bottle in her hands. She'd never get the missing piece if she ran.

She put the bottle on the table near the edge and leaned back in the chair, crossed her legs, and waited.

The door opened, and Shadow Weaver came in. She stopped cold the moment she saw the bottle on the table. She then saw Catra sitting calmly. She hesitated, and Catra could feel her eyes evaluating everything. She was assessing the threat level. Catra kept her claws in.

Shadow Weaver found her tongue. "Clever girl. Somehow, you found my code on the door. I'll have to change that after I punish you for going through my things."

Catra tapped the bottle with her toes. "Five years old."

Shadow Weaver stopped. "Excuse me?"

"Your first note. Five years old. Gave Adora the concoction in apple juice. No emergence. You theorized emotions might be the key to it."

Shadow Weaver stood very still.

"Eight. Gave Adora the concoction in grape juice. Induced happiness. No emergence."

Shadow Weaver's jaw clenched.

"Eleven. If I remember correctly, it was some milk. Induced sadness. No emergence." She tapped the bottle with her toe claw. "I could go on, but you get my point."

Shadow Weaver moved slowly to be able to face Catra.

The two stared at each other like they each were on edge. Neither blinked, afraid to take their eyes off the other for even a moment.

“You’ve read my notes then. How interesting. And what have you concluded?”

Catra’s lip twitched. “Adora would do anything for you. If you told her to jump off a cliff, she’d ask how far. She’d give herself until there was nothing left to give, so there’d be no point in drugging her unless-”

Shadow Weaver cut her off, “Unless there was something I needed to know that I couldn’t risk Adora knowing about herself. You’re clever enough to figure that out.” She moved to sit in the other chair. “But you don’t know what that is, do you?”

Catra’s ear twitched.

“I really thought you had moved on, but I see you’re still obsessed.” Shadow Weaver took a long slow breath before leaning forward. “Did you know that before you joined her squad, Scorpia spent most of her contraband share on protein powder?”

Catra didn’t react.

“Since you’ve joined- cookies, candies, board games, dresses, suits, eggs, bacon, and popcorn. It sounds like you have someone who is willing to put their own needs aside for you. I can’t tell you how lucky you are for that.”

Catra’s jaw clenched.

Shadow Weaver relaxed back into the chair. A smile came through in her voice. “I take my roles very seriously, Catra. When you came here, no one wanted to deal with you. I took you in because otherwise, you’d have died. I took pity on you. You may not realize it, but you have benefited from being under my protection. Octavia wanted you dead over the loss of her eye, but she feared me more than she desired revenge. You have no idea how often something like that has happened.”

Catra said nothing.

“I’ve kept you alive. I even made you strong. I even found you a stable girlfriend with a pedigree and the ability to pamper you. Is she not to your liking?”

Catra fought the instinct to extend her claws.

“Take what you have in Scorpia, and forget about this childish obsession.” She leaned her head back just a little. “Adora is a tool. She always has been and always will be. A key to unlock some door somewhere or a battery for something we have yet to fully understand. I am doing what I can to turn that purpose to the greater good.” She sat forward. “I can’t have powerless runts like you getting their noses in this mess and getting hurt. It would invalidate all the work I’ve done to keep you alive thus far. Do you understand?”

That did it. That caused her to extend her claws. She didn’t care if Shadow Weaver drained every ounce of magic out on her. For a moment, all she could think was murder.

The stone on Shadow Weaver’s mask started to glow.

Catra blinked like she had never actually truly seen how it reacted. She had always been distracted by the fear of it. Until that moment, she never truly noticed how it suddenly grew bright as the Black Garnet next to them sputtered to life. That gave Catra pause.

Shadow Weaver, seeing Catra’s reaction soften, backed off as well.

Catra took it all in. She had the missing piece of the puzzle, even if it wasn’t in full resolution. Shadow Weaver had been testing Adora for doneness. Testing a tool for its viability to do the job. Since age five? Catra blinked, realizing that the woman before her would have used a child for whatever it was she needed her for if the emergence had happened. That filled her with a gray rage. A plan poured into her head. A list of tasks. The order they would have to come in. She had such precious little time.

Catra pushed the bottle off the edge of the table with her foot. It crashed to the stone ground and spilled purple liquid everywhere.

Catra stood up and glared at the closest thing she had ever had to a mother. “I understand completely.” She turned her back and walked out the door.

Shadow Weaver was damn near smug when she called after, “Glad we could have this little chat.”

The Kiss

She should have been trying to sleep.

She should have been lying down and forcing herself to catch up on the sleep she would need to do whatever it was Shadow Weaver's mission was about. The constant machine hum of the Fright Zone was familiar and comforting, and it should have been easy.

Instead, she was awake, running off adrenaline.

Adora turned on the light in her room and grabbed the sword. A quick moment later and it was set up against the headboard, facing out, so she could see her reflection in it. She was acutely aware of how awkward her face was. Was she supposed to smile? Or look serious? No matter what she tried, it looked false and weird in the reflection.

She breathed in and tried instead to imagine the reflection was Catra, and so she made a Catra face. It was instantly regrettable, but she went with it. "Hey, Adora, how's it hanging." She tried to get the voice right. Tried to get the face right, and then she realized she was being dumb. "Hey, I'm Catra. I'm disrespectful. I don't follow the rules. I'm so- limber." Her brain reset a moment at the thought of Catra being limber.

She shook it out of her system. She gathered all her mental resources. "So, Catra. I've been meaning to talk to you." She cleared her throat. Then realized how stupid it was to practice clearing your throat. She reset. "I uh- I wanted to talk about our *fight* ?" Her voice went high on the word fight.

This wasn't working. New strategy. She needed new words. Just do what Lonnie said. Repeat the same thing, just to Catra and not Lonnie. Adora's mouth was dry all at once as she thought of saying those words in that order so that they would go in Catra's ever sensitive ears. It made her heart race.

She mentally dug in.

She was a fighter, and if love was a war, she would plan out the perfect strategy. First off- schedule. She didn't have a lot of time. A few hours until lights out and then some weirdly portentous mission with Shadow Weaver- so she had to get this right and get it right fast. In a perfect world, she'd have a week to plan.

Second, she would identify the perfect location. Either on the high place they always met, or somewhere secluded and hopefully as beautiful as the Fright Zone got.

Third, her strategy. She'd plan out her argument and then come up with counterpoints to all the points that might be brought up. She'd do research and bring that to the battle. In an absolutely perfect world, she would have a presentation lining out her argument of why Catra should consider dating her, and then a whole slide dedicated to the possible world-ending scenario that might cause.

She was so tired.

She wasn't thinking clearly.

Maybe she should start with the warnings from the previous She-Ra, the madness that apparently had planet-wide implications, and *then* get to the argument about why Catra should take a chance on her anyway. Who knew? Catra might even be into the whole danger aspect of it.

So tired.

This would be so much easier with a few hours of sleep and a few days to plan.

No, instead, she was going to have to do this quick and dirty.

She looked into her own eyes in the reflection and imagined they were Catra's. "Catra, I- I think I lo-" The word 'love' felt like it was clamped shut in the back of her throat. It had been easy

enough to tell her friends that what she felt could have been love, in a very clinical kind of way, like discussing how a particular position could be advantageous in battle. But saying it out loud to the person it was about felt like a completely different thing altogether. Had she ever heard anyone use that word? Yes. In terms of 'I love your enthusiasm for wrist locks', or 'I love your aggression with the staff', or 'I love that you showed up early to these timed trials'. Never 'I love you'.

She tried the word out on her tongue alone, without the sentence to muck it up. "Love. *Love* . loOoVe." It still felt weird to say. She scrapped it. If it felt weird to say, then Catra would find it weird to hear. She would probably tell her to stop being weird.

She took another breath and tried again. "Ok, so, Catra, I'm sorry about this morning. I was- I was not sure of things." She nodded to herself, giving herself the smallest pep talk that yes, this was going well. This was right. "I'm more sure of things now. We've been friends for a long time and- and if that's the way you want to keep it, then I'm fine with that." She sighed and lowered her head. She should lead with the opposite of that. In battle, you never offer your opponent your weaknesses. You never offer your loss as an option.

No. This needed a more firm approach. She stood up straight, saluted the imaginary Catra in the sword's reflection, and offered, "Good afternoon, cadet Catra." She stood at attention, her hands neatly behind her back. "I would like to break protocol by asking you out- as in dating maybe. I think such an arrangement could be advantageous to both our initiatives and goals." Her demeanor fell through instantly. No, the formal military-style would only elicit jokes and ridicule. Catra was never into protocol and formality. This had to be casual.

She hopped on the balls of her feet and rolled her shoulders in a way that Catra would have identified instantly as her patterned pre-fight warm-up routine. She touched her toes. She stretched her hamstrings and then got a triumphant smile in the reflection before declaring. "Hey Catra, how about we go- hide somewhere

and do things like- like-" her act fell apart. She didn't know what they were supposed to do after they were alone. She couldn't imagine anything more than what they already had. Sleeping in the same bed. Waking up cuddling. What more was there? With all this talk of love and potentially being more than friends, she wasn't all that sure of what that entailed. She tried for a moment to think of any examples of what being "more than friends" was. What had Scorpia intended to do with Catra that she wasn't already doing? Adora's mind came back with a completely empty space. She had no idea.

She finally gave up and sat on the edge of the bed. Her hands gripped the blanket that she and Catra had shared. It was the same one that had started off rough but gotten softer over time so that now it was velvety, practically like the soft fur on Catra's cheeks. She groaned, putting her head in her hands as she let herself slump. "This isn't working." She talked aloud to the sword because she had no one else, and maybe She-Ra could hear her.

She turned toward the sword and tried to imagine what an ancient planetary goddess would say to her. " *Just follow your heart* ," she said in a gruff voice that she imagined was what a warrior princess would sound like. " *Be brave and go take what you want* !" She sighed, then dropped the act. "You're the ancient planetary goddess. Got any advice on how to tell someone you like them?" She waited. She didn't know why she waited. Somewhere in her mind, she wondered if the magical being would send her another vision, or maybe an old lady to bonk her on the head and give her a cryptic message about how to proceed. But nothing happened.

She felt truly alone, and so incredibly tired.

The irony about all of it was that, weirdly enough, it was Catra she would rather be practicing with. This was exactly the kind of thing that Catra was good at, or at least it would be more fun if she were there. It wasn't like Catra was particularly good at feelings, just that she had a tendency to see through the crap (her words) and get to the heart of the issue. She'd tell Adora

she was being a dumbass and then tell her just to say it some other crass and direct way. It would be a stupid suggestion, and Adora would instantly poke holes in the idea, but finding an option between their extremes would be the answer.

Adora nearly laughed at herself as she thought of her asking Catra to help her practice confessing, only to then turn around and use it on her. It made her smile. It was so stupid. Catra would love it.

She sat up and tapped her foot on the floor. Maybe- maybe that was the problem. Everything was more fun with Catra, even being nervous. Being sad, or scared, or happy- it was all better with Catra there.

Maybe that's been the problem the whole time. She realized, in that moment, that she was trying to shoulder the burden of She-Ra all alone. Why? Because she wanted to save Catra from the trouble. But- but... things were easier with Catra. Everything was easier with Catra, even the hard stuff.

She breathed slow, even. A thought was coming together in her mind. She had this all wrong. There was never going to be a perfect plan. There was never going to be a good strategy. The moment she got in front of Catra, all that would melt away, and she'd be as stupid and dumb as she could be because Catra made her that way. Because yeah, Catra made her weak. Catra made her vulnerable, and somehow- despite what she had been taught- being that way around her felt good. It felt right.

Maybe she just needed to allow herself to be stupid, and vulnerable, and weak and stop trying to control the situation so much.

It was not her normal mode of operation, but she was tired enough to consider the idea of just winging it. It would be scary, but maybe this was just going to be scary no matter what she did.

She stood up and clenched her fists. She was going to have to do this. Face her fear and know that whatever came out of her

mouth, Catra would smile, poke her in the forehead and call her a dumbass. And there was nothing she could do about how that touch would make her stomach feel like a thousand butterflies all at once.

She was just going to have to work through the butterflies.

She grabbed the sword, slipped it into her back harness, and walked to the door. Leaving the room was insubordination, but she wasn't going to be silent one more minute. She was going to find Catra, wherever she was. She was going to ask to talk alone, and then she would confess her feelings and let Catra get them out too. Then she would tell Catra everything about emotional entanglements and the total mind fuck that Shadow Weaver had put on her in that last hour.

She put her hand on the door pad, and the door slid up. She started to step out, ready for her quest, only to stop in her tracks.

Catra looked caught off guard like she was halfway ready to knock. She shifted her body quickly, leaning on the door frame. Her eyes went half-lidded as she curved her spine. She licked her lips while looking Adora over. "Hey, Adora."

Adora could not identify the words for the feelings that she felt in that moment under that look. As she expected, her brain went dumb. "Hey, Catra," she said, in a terrible mimicry. She fumbled while trying to lean against the other side of the doorway with her elbow until it slipped, and she had to quickly adjust by trying to look cool and folding her arms. "So, we need to talk."

Another elevator look from Catra, from Adora's legs, up her hips, to her torso, then to her eyes. Catra bit her lip before saying, "Yeah, we do." She tilted her head. "Come on. Let's get somewhere-" She leaned in, placing a finger on Adora's chest, then flicking up to graze Adora's nose when she tried to look down. "-more private."

Adora agreed. They need to talk in private, but damn it- the way Catra said it made her heart beat in places she didn't know she had. "Sure. Yeah. Come on in." Her eyes went wide as she realized, in a moment, the new context of having Catra in her room, in private, where they had a door to protect them from prying eyes. Suddenly, all she could think about was filling in the blank space that was whatever they were supposed to do once they were more than friends. Maybe they could fill in that space together. It was almost too much.

Catra leaned in further, taking the collar of Adora's jacket and tugging it. "I was thinking some place more roma-" She started purring before the word could come out, and that seemed to startle her before she recovered and added, "-roomy. Some place more roomy."

Catra's slight stumble over herself was enough to remind Adora that it was just them. This was just Catra. They could talk. They always talked. That relaxed her. She stepped out of the door, feeling a sudden elation. "Yeah. Ok. More roomy." Space was good. Open air had fewer expectations in it. They wouldn't be so close, so alone, so tempted to do... something.

Catra's look shifted. She couldn't hide that she was happy. "Alright, then race me." She started running on all fours at a sprint.

Adora burst into a run behind her. "Where are we racing to?" It was too late. Catra was already around the corner.

They ran past the forge, past the barracks, past the climb to their high spot, and bounded to the Fright Zone's east side.

Adora couldn't help the smile on her face even as her lungs started burning, and the muscles in her legs felt like fire.

Catra came to a sudden stop at the farthest edge of the Fright Zone, a section of dilapidated wall that had been taken over by the constant shifting of the Whispering Woods. The trees hung

over the wall, giving them some shade as Adora bent over and gasped for breath. “You-” huff, “-cheated.” Huff.

Catra didn’t even seem winded. She just leaned against the trunk of an invasive tree and smiled. “You’ve been doing all the weight lifting without the cardio. Strength is good, but it makes you slow. You should try more *vigorous* activities.”

Adora tried to hide the fact that she was smiling at the way Catra said vigorous. She smiled through the stitch that had started in her side.

Catra watched, and Adora felt those eyes burn right through her, so she forced herself to stand up and look back.

Catra’s tail flicked behind her erratically, almost like she was getting ready to pounce. “So, you wanted to talk.”

Oh, wow. This was it. This was the moment. “Catra- I-” A bit of phlegm caught in Adora’s throat, jostled up by all the running and breathing, and she coughed hard into the crux of her arm for far too long.

Catra’s face looked pained and amused at what was unfolding in front of her.

Adora cleared her throat and did a little “Ah hmmm, ahmmm” to make sure it was all out before she started in again, “Catra I-” Her mind blanked. What had she been trying to say? Feelings. It was something about feelings. “Uh- I have feelings and-” Oh, shit. This was worse than practice. She faked another cough just to try to reset the conversation.

Catra’s eyes got wide as her smile softened.

Adora’s tired brain searched out for an opening. A place to start. In a very literal way, her brain came back with- *It started at the fight, so start there* . “So- you know how we fought the other day?”

“Oh, yes. I remember.” Catra’s voice had gone into a low register. She was letting her words drip off her lip.

Adora noticed the change in tone but did not understand, so she continued marching on. “Well, I *loved* that fight.” She winced. This was not the way she had meant to first say the word love. She wasn’t sure how it was supposed to come out, but this wasn’t it.

“Me too, *Princess* .”

Adora’s heart was beating hard against her ribs. She didn’t know why Catra calling her *that* elicited such a response. “I- uh- would like to-” *Shit* . Again, this was falling apart. Go with whatever you can pull out. “-to fight with you like that *forever* .” She made sure she said the word forever in a soft reverent tone.

Catra’s smile was gone. She looked genuinely shocked. She blinked. Her whole demeanor changed. She dropped the sultry act and kind of squeaked out, “Really?”

Adora nodded eagerly. “Yeah.” Her breaths were fast and shallow as she felt herself gearing up for something. For what, she wasn’t sure. “It was the best fight of my life.” Words were coming easier now. “I’m just glad it was with *you* .”

Adora really expected some level of teasing. None came. Instead, it looked like Catra was on the verge of tears.

Catra seemed to struggle to speak, but when she did- “It was the best fight of my life too. Like, we were both awesome.”

Adora nodded again, a little too eagerly. “You were so fast and... *nimble* .” Saying the word nimble did things to her that she would struggle to describe for years.

“And you, you were so *strong* and *forceful* ,” Catra said that part quietly, taking a step forward.

Adora wondered if this was some new kind of code they were both using. She started to wonder if, when it really came down to

it, they had always used this code. Words that they wouldn't get in trouble for saying to stand in for the words they would.

Adora stepped closer to Catra. "I wish I could be locked in *combat* with you until the day I die."

Catra took another step forward. They were only a foot apart. Close enough to feel the weight of each other's eyes. "I would revel in being your-" she hesitated, "- *nemesis* ."

Now Adora licked her lips because she was getting excited. She wasn't exactly sure what they were saying. She didn't know the exact translation, but she could get the gist of it. She could read between the lines, and that was enough. "But... there's a problem."

Catra moved in a little closer, her eyes on Adora's lips. She wasn't even trying to hide it. She was focused. Determined.

Adora pulled the sword out of her holster. She put it between them, forcing Catra back a half step. She held it like it was the only thing between them and the possibility of being locked in loving combat forever.

Catra looked down at it, then up at Adora. Her face held nothing but hurt.

Adora forced herself to say it. Forced herself to address it. "Shadow Weaver told me that emotional entanglements would put the world in danger because of this."

Catra's face scrunched up in a look that reminded Adora of the first time the kitchen introduced the brown ration bars. Disgust. "That's the biggest bullshit-"

"No. Entrapta said that was a thing in the translations too." She paused, not sure if she could even make sense of Shadow Weaver's answer enough to explain it, but she had to try. "The last person who held the sword- the last She-Ra- she went mad. Crazy. Did something to the planet."

Catra's ear twitched in a way that showed she didn't like what she was hearing.

"She kept telling me you and Scorpia were getting close and that I should let it happen because of this."

"Oh, that bitch! Of course, she'd pull that shit on you! Ugh!" Catra's claws were out. She bared her teeth. "I should rip her a new-"

"I need you to listen."

Catra stopped.

Adora realized her voice was shaking. "I don't know what I'm doing. I don't know what to do. Apparently, I'm the only person who can wield this and-" She looked down at the sword. "It could endanger the planet if I don't do it right."

Catra looked down at it, seething. "Then, throw it away."

"She'd just find it." They both knew that she was talking about Shadow Weaver.

"Then you run away."

Adora furrowed her brow and squared her shoulders. "Shadow Weaver would find me no matter where I went. I can't run. You know that."

Catra rubbed her face with her hands and groaned before straightening up and looking Adora in the eye. "Ok, I have to tell you this. Entrapta hacked into Shadow Weaver's files."

Adora blinked. "What?"

"And we found... notes. Adora, she's been drugging you since you were five- trying to make something happen. I didn't get any details, but- the way she talked about it-" Catra leaned in. "It sounded like she was going to use you for something dangerous."

For a moment, several odd times in Adora's life flashed before her eyes. Times she was in Shadow Weaver's room and lost track of time- couldn't remember what had happened for the last few minutes before she was quickly rushed out. It was often accompanied by the sweetest drinks she could remember. It was as if she had always known, but the memories had been just outside her ability to see them. Now that they came up, they didn't surprise her. "We're her property, Catra. She can do with us what she wants."

Catra's fur bristled at the word 'property.'

Adora pressed it. "She owns us. We're like the tanks or the stun batons. We're soldiers in the middle of a war. Our-" She hesitated before getting the nerve and just flat out saying it, "-our lives are hers."

Catra's jaw worked as she looked back and forth between Adora's eyes. "You're wrong. She doesn't get to own us. She doesn't own you, and she sure as hell doesn't own *me* !"

Adora didn't want to fight about this. She knew she wouldn't be able to convince Catra that they had no choice. Catra had always acted like they had a choice, even when she was presented with all the evidence to the contrary. How many times did she have to suffer at Shadow Weaver's hand to get that?

Catra moved in, getting in close so that they were a breath apart. "Ok. That's it. No more letting her pull the shots. We're taking control right now, right this moment."

Adora stood at attention, out of habit, when someone talked to her in that commanding voice.

Catra reached up to her own face, taking her mask in her fingers and lifting it off.

Adora watched with an equal mix of surprise and alarm.

Catra tossed the mask to the side and puffed out her chest.

Adora blinked. She hadn’t seen Catra’s full face since they were in their early teens. Shadow Weaver had given Catra that mask, saying it was found in the box she came in, and Catra hadn’t taken it off since. Adora couldn’t take it all in fast enough. Seeing her like this brought back memories of their history together. It made her yearn for simpler times.

“Drop your sword,” Catra commanded.

Adora dropped it without even thinking. It clattered to the metal grating of the wall then stilled. Adora couldn't breathe fast enough.

There they were. Not soldiers. Not cadet and Force Captain. They weren’t children, and they weren’t Shadow Weaver’s wards. It seemed like, for the first time in their lives, they were just themselves, and they were themselves in front of each other.

They looked at each other as if seeing each other for the first time.

Catra took a deep breath. “Close your eyes.”

“What?”

Catra moved in, her eye’s closed, putting her lips on Adora’s and grabbing her face so she couldn't leave.

Adora kept her eyes open because she didn’t know better until her brain caught up with what was happening. It all hit at once. Endorphins. Dopamine. Oxytocin. Her eyes fluttered shut as she felt the warm softness of Catra’s lips and her hands holding her head. Adora, her brain soaked in feel-good chemicals, put her hands on Catra’s waist, and Catra made a moan against Adora’s lips that shocked them both.

Up until that moment, Adora had never imagined kissing anyone. It just never occurred to her that it was something that could happen for her- to her- and now that it was, she couldn’t believe she never thought of it before. Why hadn’t they *done* this earlier

when they were alone in her room all those times? It made her whole body feel good, possibly for the first time in her entire life. Her brain was alight with the thought that this... this is what she always wanted... always needed. Someone to love her and make her feel good. She got lost in that thought along with the kiss.

They had both been holding back so long that when the floodgates finally opened, they both thought they were going to drown, and yet neither wanted to stop. Catra came up for air and pulled slightly away, her lips moistened to a glossy shine, and her eyes half-lidded and dilated.

Adora was gone. Her mind had ceased to function rationally. All she wanted was to kiss again.

“Damn,” Catra said breathlessly. “That was better than I thought it would be.” Her fingers touched Adora’s lips, a stand-in for her own at the moment. She touched her almost as if checking to see if her lips were real.

All Adora could do was grunt in agreement. Now she couldn't stop looking at Catra’s lips, thinking about what they feel like. Thinking about all the things they made her feel. She didn’t let go of Catra’s waist. The world made sense now. Life made sense. All their time together, trying to touch as much as possible, it all looked so clear and juvenile. How could they have ever imagined it was anything else? Why hadn’t they done this all those nights they slept in the same bed?

Catra looked pained. She winced as she let her finger slide off Adora’s lip onto her cheek.

Adora couldn’t help but worry. “What? Did I do something wrong?”

Catra ran her hands down Adora’s face and looked on the verge of something. “I didn’t know we’d get this far.” She stood back, pulling herself out of Adora’s grip and letting go of her face. “It’s going to make it that much harder to betray you.”

Adora blinked as that word made its way through all of the hazy goodness in her brain. Her first thought was that this was part of the code they had developed, but a moment later she came up with nothing it could potentially mean. “What?”

Catra pointed down to Adora’s feet.

Adora looked. Vines stretched along the ground and wrapped themselves on Adora’s boots. Adora blinked again. “Perfuma?” She then looked up at Catra.

Catra smiled.

Adora’s tired, happy brain switched gears and started pumping adrenaline. “You didn’t.”

Catra looked damn near smug. “I did.”

Before Adora could yell, or move, or act, the vines had overtaken her. Her arms were pinned to her sides. They crossed her mouth so she couldn’t talk. All she could do was angrily grunt.

“I had to.” Catra’s smile was still plastered on her face, but it was false. It was a smile that showed she hated every second of this. “She was going to sacrifice you, Adora, and you’d let her, so I had to stop it.”

Adora tried to scream, but someone grabbed her shoulder, and the world was full of purple sparkles. She was no longer on the wall with Catra. She was somewhere deep in the Whispering Woods.

Back on the wall, Catra shook off the vestiges of that kiss. She bent down, grabbing Adora’s sword, and casually tossed it over the side. It was caught mid-air by an arrow that snapped into a net before it disappeared in the leaves and brush of the wilds of the Whispering Woods.

Catra bent down, grabbed her mask, and stoically slipped it back on her face.

Catra's whole body buzzed. She touched her lips as the feel of that kiss lingered, and she said to the forest where she knew Adora no longer was. "I'll find you, baby. I just got to go end a bitch first." And she turned away with her claws out. She walked resolutely back toward the Fright Zone, back toward their tormenter, commanding officer, and the person who was going to hurt her girl.

For the first time in her life, Catra felt alive. She felt powerful. She felt invincible. Adora loved her back. With that knowledge, she felt like she could end the world or save it.

No more self-control.

It ended today.

Shadow Weaver didn't know what was coming for her.

Guilt Trip

"I'll distract her. I'll get the sword out of her hands so she can't transform." The catgirl paused. She looked nervous. Scared. Something. "Wait an hour if you can. If things go right, I'll be back on the east side ready to go with you with a friend- if I can convince her to go with us."

Glimmer grew still to watch Catra's face. Something was off, but she wasn't sure what. "Ok. We'll be there, and we'll wait."

Catra's voice wavered as she said, "Hey, Sparkles?"

Glimmer was caught off guard by the sudden vulnerability, even if she didn't particularly like the nickname. "Yeah?"

The catgirl gave a false smile. "If things go wrong, tell me you'll take care of her."

Glimmer was not expecting that.

Catra must have seen the concern on her face. "She's not like the others here. She's... weak in the same way you guys are."

Glimmer lifted an eyebrow. "Gee, thanks."

"Earnest, naive, ridiculously easy to manipulate." Her smile was gone. "She's a sitting duck here. Just- promise me that if things don't go right- you and your stupid friends will help her move on... to be happy."

Tears. Glimmer saw tears starting in Catra's eyes. Oh, shit. This just got serious. "We're all getting out of this. It's a good plan." Glimmer couldn't help wanting to fix this, to soothe the girl's obvious distress.

Catra grew stern. "Promise me."

Glimmer's whole body stiffened at the demand. She tried to look relaxed. "I'll be your captor. Promises from me shouldn't mean much." She gave a shy smile, trying to show she was uncomfortable with addressing the idea that this might not work.

"Yeah, but you're part of the goody-two-shoes side, so you'd actually try to uphold your promises." Smile gone. "So, fucking promise me."

Glimmer didn't know how to convince her that they would all be in and out before anyone noticed. So, instead, she placated. "Fine. I promise, as long as you promise not to take any unnecessary risks."

Catra smiled at that with a thin veil hiding turmoil under the surface. "Sure, I promise. No unnecessary risks. All my risks are absolutely necessary. See you in a bit, Glitter."

"Glimmer," she corrected as the communication feed shut off. She sighed and looked up at Bow, who gave her one of his 'what's up' smiles. She handed him back the communicator pad. "Are you still in for this?"

"I'm with you, no matter what." His smile got a bit bigger. "I really never thought I'd see you care about a member of the Horde. You're really worried about her."

Glimmer grumbled and pulled her knees up. She was insecure. "I don't know if I'm doing the right thing, but if this girl is She-Ra- then this is more important than the war."

Bow put a reassuring hand on her hand. The touch felt overly tender.

"Yeah, your mom's talk about how She-Ra was supposed to reappear at the planet's hour of greatest need was kind of a mind trip. Why didn't you tell her we may have found her?"

Glimmer moved to run her thumb over his knuckles. "I don't know. Because she wouldn't believe it. Because she wouldn't want

me to risk it. She'd want to do what she always does- nothing. She has to see She-Ra before she'll accept it, which means getting her here in one piece." The movement of her thumb stopped. "Bow- this is really dangerous. I'm not sure I want you to go."

"It is dangerous, so I am absolutely going. I'm not letting you be dangerous all by yourself."

At that, Glimmer smiled. She squeezed his hand.

"And we'll bring Perfuma."

Glimmer's smile was gone.

She didn't hate Perfuma. She really didn't. Despite the burning sensation starting in her stomach, she thought Perfuma was just swell. She was just swell when she and Bow went to princess prom together. She was so *glad* that Bow had found a new *friend* . It *certainly* wasn't something that drove her into insane jealousy that caused her to pick a fight with the Horde at the All Princess Ball.

Perfuma was just swell when Bow kept asking her to tag along on missions. It was a miracle he hadn't asked to take her to Dryl. Glimmer hadn't let him. She told him there was no time and teleported.

It wasn't that Perfuma wasn't nice. She was super nice. Almost annoyingly nice.

Perfuma was the first and only princess to join Glimmer's burgeoning princess alliance. Of course, it wasn't like she had much of a choice. She was, after all, seeking asylum at Bright Moon, so she might as well join an alliance that hadn't really done anything yet.

And sure, she had some sympathy for the woman. Glimmer couldn't imagine what it would be like to lose her ancestral home, her runestone. So she hadn't said anything. She was trying to be nice. But damn it, she wished Bow would stop bringing her up.

She didn’t know how to handle sharing him. She didn’t know how to cope with not being his whole world- his only friend.

Bow winced. “You're hurting my hand.”

Glimmer let go with a quick apology.

He pulled his hand back and rubbed it with the other and gave her the softest smile. “If we are kidnapping someone who might not go willingly, I’m sure her vines will be useful, and she won’t even have to break her non-violent thing.”

That was the other thing. Sure, it would be useful to have another princess along, but someone who was not willing to fight was kind of dead weight. Another person Glimmer had to teleport who wouldn’t be useful in a battle. Her shoulders fell. He was probably right, though. Binding someone with growing vines was a lot faster than trying to hogtie them like Glimmer had initially planned. “Ok. Sure.”

She regretted agreeing the moment she had to teleport back to grab Perfuma after already getting Bow to the wall. She had lost track of how many teleports it had taken to get them all there, but it was too many—a bad start to a perfect plan.

They were early, and she was glad for it because she was exhausted. She leaned against a tree while Perfuma made some extra cover for them by growing the branches and leaves in their spot.

“It’s kind of neat karma. I was her prisoner, and now she’ll be mine. I’ll get the chance to show her the same kindness she showed me.” Perfuma said that in her overly cheery voice.

Glimmer knew she shouldn't feel this way. She should be nice. She should thank Perfuma for being there- for risking her life. Instead, she settled on, “We need to keep it down. They could be here any minute.”

It all went down exactly the way Catra had planned.

Catra looked happy running up to the wall with Adora trailing behind her. Still, Glimmer thought she could see the emotions behind the facade. Catra had been so sure she could lure Adora to this specific spot, but nothing was guaranteed. She was probably elated that it worked at all.

They started talking. Catra was moving to position Adora's back to the forest, so she couldn't see them. Catra was doing it all so subtly. Adora was distracted, fumbling over her words. Catra had her in the palm of her hand.

Perfuma was supposed to be looking for when the sword was out of Adora's hand. That was step number one because the last thing they needed was a fight with a seven-foot-tall warrior goddess with a legendary power set.

They heard bits and pieces of the conversation. Something about a fight. Something about She-Ra.

They all saw Catra take off her mask. They all heard the thing hit the metal of the wall. They all heard, "Drop your sword!"

They were all stunned when Adora dropped it like it was nothing-on command. It was like watching magic.

Glimmer thought *They must be good friends. Such good friends.*

Glimmer tapped Perfuma's shoulder, and she started the vines moving toward Adora's feet.

For a moment, Catra and Adora looked at each other as if they were both a little surprised by what they were seeing. Then Catra saw the vines and panicked. "Close your eyes."

Glimmer was not prepared for them to kiss. None of them were, especially not Adora. Adora looked shocked and then totally melted into it. It looked like a first kiss. Neither of them really knew what they were doing but wouldn't stop.

Glimmer's inner dialog screamed. *Oh, shit. They're not just friends... Shit.*

Catra wasn't trying to protect the planet. She wasn't just trying to get She-Ra out of the hands of the Horde. She was trying to get someone she loved somewhere safe.

Glimmer's body felt heavy as she realized they were about to kidnap someone right after a love confession, a first kiss. Her eyes fell on Bow as he readied his arrow to capture the sword once it was thrown. It would suck to do that to him- even if he didn't feel the same way- to confess as a way of manipulation- it felt wrong. She felt immediately wrong doing this, but the pieces were already in motion. To stop it now would be disastrous. She doubled down. It's what had to be done. The plan wasn't perfect, but perfect was the enemy of good, right?

She turned her attention back on the action. Her part was coming next.

Catra pulled away. Pointed down. Adora looked at her feet, saw the vines, and that meant it was go time. Perfuma pulled magic faster and surged the vines. Once they had their target, Glimmer teleported to the wall, grabbed Adora's shoulder, and teleported her out.

They landed miles away in a predetermined part of the Whispering Woods. Glimmer misjudged the distance a little, and they fell a little onto moist soil and knocked the air out of both of them.

Adora got her breath back and struggled against the vines with every muscle in her body.

For a moment, Glimmer wasn't sure if Perfuma's vines would hold. "Calm down. It's ok. We're not going to hurt you."

No amount of assurances were going to calm her down. The girl responded by screaming against the vines, eyes nearly popping

out. She looked like the personification of rage. Glimmer didn't blame her. This was shitty.

"I'll be back. Try not to have an aneurysm." With that, looking into the face of an enraged horde soldier, Glimmer teleported out. First, she got Bow because Bow was supposed to have the sword, which was the second priority.

He was ready for her, gripping the sword against his chest.

A flash of sparkles, and she and Bow were back at the meeting place with their unwilling prisoner. She bent over double to catch her breath.

Bow frowned. "Glimmer, what about Perfuma?"

"Oh-" *Huff* "Right." *Huff* . "Just give me a moment." She took a few breaths and then reluctantly teleported back.

Perfuma was giddy. "We got her?"

Glimmer was still trying to catch her breath. "Yeah, we got her. Now come on." She grabbed Perfuma's hand and burned up another teleport.

Back at their hideout in the woods, she let go of Perfuma and leaned against a tree trunk, breathing heavily. It wouldn't have been so bad, except she had teleported them all the way there. This whole endeavor was draining her twice as fast as normal. She was just so used to only having to worry about Bow.

"So, what now?" Bow asked with a small triumphant smile.

Glimmer slid down to the ground. "We wait, then I go back and get Catra."

Their prisoner stopped screaming, stopped struggling. She sat up, all ears. Her eyes intensely focused on Glimmer.

Glimmer nodded to her. “We’re getting you both out.” A heavy breath. “And another friend if she’ll come. We just- we have to wait.”

And waiting was hard because they didn’t know what they were waiting for. In that long stretch of time, Glimmer realized how much she had neglected in this perfect plan. She should have demanded Catra give her all the details. What was this hour for? Was there any way they could help? It felt wrong to just sit there, but that’s what she had agreed to do. *Fuck.*

On the hour, Glimmer teleported back to their hiding place near the wall and waited.

The sun was starting to set in deep jewel tones that her mother had always told her was from the pollution from all the machines the Horde used. Still, it made for a brilliant sunset full of bright pinks, deep oranges, and blood reds. It all faded into Etheria’s pitch black starless sky, which made Glimmer think of She-Ra and the potential power of the woman they had bound and gagged in the forest. As the minutes ticked by, she wondered if maybe this hadn’t been such a perfect plan.

She waited for the sun to completely set- and no Catra. No other large, strong friend looking lost- ready to be kidnapped.

The weight of it all landed on her shoulders. She had approved the plan. She gave Catra the time. She agreed to all of it- and it had gone wrong. All wrong. What was she supposed to do? Go back and tell the most powerful being on the planet that her newly minted girlfriend is missing? *Fuck. FUCK!*

She bit her lip, contemplating staying longer. Maybe Catra was just running behind. As the jewel tones faded into shadows and twilight fell, she knew she was just delaying the inevitable.

Catra’s words echoed in her head- about promising to help Adora move on. Help her be happy. Glimmer’s chest hurt. This felt wrong. This felt so very wrong. She should have grabbed Catra

when she had her back on the wall. Then she would have been safe, and they wouldn't be in this mess. *Fuck.*

She took a deep breath and readied herself. She wasn't a coward. She was going to go back, and she would face the music and go from there.

She teleported back and avoided looking at Adora. Instead, she focused on Bow.

His eyes darted in the dark. It wasn't hard to tell she was alone. Worry crossed his face. "What happened?"

"Nothing. I waited. No sign of her or anyone else."

Perfuma frowned as she sat on a bed of flowers. "What now?"

Glimmer looked directly at their prisoner, and she was not prepared for the look in those big blue eyes. Pain. Overwhelming sadness. A strange resignation. It was heartbreak.

Heartbreak that Glimmer let happen. She knelt down in front of Adora. "I swear the plan was to get her too. She said she'd be there." Glimmer's voice was shaking. She forced herself to make eye contact, to face her mistake head-on.

Adora closed her eyes in a painful grimace. She was trying not to cry. Trying to hold it all in.

That was it. That was all Glimmer could handle. She decided what to do. She stood up, clenching her fists. She took the sword from Bow. He let it happen. She moved in closer to Adora. "We don't leave people behind, Adora. That's just not the way the Rebellion works. That's not the kind of leader I am."

Adora looked up with shock in her eyes. Maybe some level of hope.

"If it were Bow instead of Catra, I'd stop at nothing to get him back."

Bow was caught off guard by that and put a hand to his chest before he asked, “So- I guess we’re going in to get her?”

Glimmer nodded.

Bow turned to Perfuma. “Can you watch the prisoner while Glimmer and I go in?”

Perfuma was about to enthusiastically say yes.

Glimmer cut her off. “Bow, you’re not going. I don’t have a lot of juice left. I have to travel light.”

Glimmer sometimes hated herself. Hated what she was willing to do. Hated how similar she and Catra were. This wasn’t fair to Bow. This wasn’t fair to Perfuma, but Glimmer was the Commander, and she couldn’t risk them.

She reached forward. She grabbed Adora’s jacket. She needed someone who knew their way around the Fright Zone.

Bow saw what was happening. His reflexes were fast but not fast enough.

Glimmer teleported her and Adora in a flash of blinding sparks. The last thing she saw was Bow’s face. His mouth gaped. His eyes were wide in surprise. He was tense, trying to reach out to her.

She should have talked to him, but she knew he wouldn’t listen. He would never let her do this. Just like her mother, he was overly protective.

They were back at the wall in an instant, and she used the sword to cut the vines off Adora.

Adora didn’t get up immediately. Instead, she looked at Glimmer- astonished.

Glimmer already felt bad. That look was making it worse. “He’d follow me right off a cliff- and normally that’s fine, but-” If she

didn’t watch herself, she’d start crying. “But when I’m out of power, I can’t easily save him from cliffs.” She chewed on her own words for a moment and finally admitted out loud, “This whole plan was shitty, and I can’t risk it hurting him.”

Adora said nothing. She closed her mouth and nodded in silent understanding.

Glimmer offered her a hand to help her up. “So, you and I are going to go into the belly of the beast and get your- *friend* back.”

Adora looked at the hand and took it.

Glimmer pulled her to her feet.

Adora dusted herself off and offered, “Thank you- I guess. I wasn’t expecting you to be so- I don’t know.”

Glimmer managed a small smile, recalling Catra’s words. “Earnest, naive, ridiculously easy to manipulate.”

Adora frowned. “No? I was going to say understanding, brave- something.” She looked back into the forest. “Are they going to be mad at you?”

Glimmer nodded quickly. “Oh, yeah, but that’s a problem for future Glimmer. Now how do we get inside?”

Adora’s body language switched. She became focused. Her posture straightened—a well-trained soldier addressing a commanding officer. Glimmer smiled. She thought it was cute.

“There’s an entrance not far from here. There will be a guard. We can take their uniform for you.”

Glimmer put the sword in the holster on her back. “Lead the way, prisoner.”

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Adora walked with all the assurance of a Force Captain. She specifically didn't run, despite wanting to. She had to act normal. She had no idea what had happened, but she had an excuse. She was supposed to have been in her room this whole time. She was supposed to have been dead to the world asleep.

Just thinking that made all the tiredness come back. It hit her like a brick, and she pressed through it. Shadow Weaver's training taught her to ignore physical pain, tiredness, hunger, and any other distractions and complete the mission, so that's what she did.

Glimmer did not look perfect in a Horde uniform. She was shorter than the guard they tackled. A little thicker, so the uniform was baggy in places it shouldn't be and tight in places it shouldn't be. But the overall effect was good enough. At first glance, no one would notice a problem. Another reason to walk briskly. If Adora looked like she knew what she was doing, people wouldn't question her.

That is if there were any people around. Even for the night shift, the place seemed sparsely populated.

Still, she walked toward the only place she could think to go- the Black Garnet chamber.

Adora had an hour to think about what happened. To think about why Catra did it and why she planned it all that way. The only thing that bubbled up to her brain after all that time was Shadow Weaver.

They had just talked on the wall about how Adora couldn't run away. She couldn't hide. Shadow Weaver would find her the way she always had. Shadow Weaver seemed to always know where she and Catra were, ever since they were little. Catra was well aware of that. She would have been the first to realize that a plan of getting Adora out would mean neutralizing Shadow Weaver as a threat.

Adora was, in that moment, forced to confront a thought she had been avoiding her whole life. She knew Catra and Shadow Weaver hated each other. She didn’t know why- but it didn't matter. Catra was going to take Shadow Weaver out- and Shadow Weaver wouldn’t go down easily. Adora was faced with the possibility that she would find either Shadow Weaver dead or injured, Catra dead or injured, or both. She had never wanted to imagine what the two of them would do to each other if they finally let loose. She had hoped, if it ever happened, that she’d be there to stop them.

In her youth, she worried about what Shadow Weaver would do to Catra. Finally, use too much magic and fry her to pieces. That thought had filled her nightmares. As they had grown older, Adora saw how Catra’s claws developed into razor-sharp permanent weapons that could cut through practically anything. She started to worry what Catra would do to Shadow Weaver if push came to shove.

Now, headed toward a room where she was sure to find the result of that fight, Adora was not surprised that she hoped Catra won. Her whole being wished for it. It was like a weight lifted off her shoulders. It was a clarity that only came in the worst circumstances. When that door opened, she wanted to find Catra alive. She didn’t care about anything else.

Her whole body, her mind, her very being focused down to a single goal. Find Catra alive. Get her out.

If Catra wasn’t alive... Adora refused to plan for that scenario.

So Adora didn’t plan for what she would say if she opened the Black Garnet room and found Shadow Weaver there. Uncharacteristically, she had no backup plan. She ran through no scenarios.

She reached the door to the Black Garnet and just typed in her Force Captain emergency code and stepped in.

The room hummed with the subtle pulsing energy of the Black Garnet. Nothing moved. There was no one there. On the floor was just a broken bottle with a familiar smelling liquid seeping into the crevices between the floor panels. In the corner, Shadow Weaver's stone cauldron turned over on its side with the contents spilled on the floor. No other sign of a fight. Nothing else out of place.

Adora froze on the spot just in front of the broken bottle. She stood there for too long as her brain came to a complete halt.

She startled when Glimmer touched her arm.

Glimmer tried to sound reassuring. "Ok, so no one is here. Is there somewhere else she could be?"

Adora's brain came back online. Sure. Catra was just somewhere else. Maybe Catra was... hiding somewhere. She raced to think of where Catra would have gone first. "Entrapta's lab. We're going there next." She turned sharply and headed out the door.

Her walking pace had sped up, mostly from the fresh new adrenaline pumping through her. Glimmer followed, having to step up to keep Adora's pace.

The corridors that she had grown up in felt foreign and foreboding. Were they always this dark? This open? This empty? She tried to ignore it. Push past it, just like she was taught. Focus on the mission.

They reached Entrapta's lab, and Adora again didn't knock. She opened the door and walked in to find the room also empty. The computer was turned off. That's what was most disconcerting. Entrapta wouldn't have turned it off, would she?

Glimmer looked around. "You know, I knew Entrapta was a little different." She hesitated. "But I didn't think she'd be the type to join the Horde."

Adora pushed down the alarms going off in her head. She couldn't let them distract her. Focus on the mission. "Entrapta only cares

about science. We lured her with the technology of the sword, but- she was really interested in whatever Hordak had been working on."

Adora turned away. She didn't have time for this mystery. "Maybe Catra went to my room. She knows the code, and no one would expect her there. That has to be where she is."

Glimmer gave a small laugh and turned around to face Adora. "She had the code to your room?"

Adora was too in her own head to notice the teasing tone, and she couldn't really handle more complex thinking. "Follow me." This time, she walked so fast she practically ran. Glimmer struggled to keep up with her.

Where were all the guards?

Slightly out of breath, Adora reached her own door. She typed in her code, and for a moment, habit took over. She turned on the lights, fully expecting Catra to be in her bed. She fully expected to get pounced on or be made fun of and to respond to the whole thing with the most sincere laughter she had ever had.

Instead, the room was empty and silent.

She didn't give herself time to respond. Next spot. Next plan. "Scorpia's room. She has to be there. It's close. Just down the hall."

Sure. That had to be it. Catra was currently convincing Scorpia to leave, but maybe it was a hard sell. That scenario jumped into Adora's brain and refused to leave. It was so comforting. So sure.

They were in front of Scorpia's door. Adora knocked. She waited.

She knocked again. No one answered.

"It's me. Adora," she called out. Her voice broke on her own name. She did everything she could to hide it. The cracks in her

facade were beginning to show. Adora was losing her grip on her own emotions. She clenched her fist to keep them from shaking. The war engine of her brain went into hyperdrive to try to imagine what had to have happened for everyone to be gone- not where they were supposed to be. Vanished. Her palms felt clammy. She ignored it. Push on. Push on. Focus on the mission.

Glimmer touched Scorpia's door. "Do you want me to get you inside?"

Adora shook her head. No. If Scorpia wasn't answering, then she wasn't inside.

Glimmer turned to her. "Is there anywhere else? Anyone else?"

Adora blinked. "I have- I have some friends. Maybe they know what happened."

"Lead the way."

Adora followed orders because she couldn't think clearly. It was after lights out, so Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio would be in bed. She headed to the barracks, but this time at a run. Glimmer really struggled to keep up with her, but she never gave up.

Adora found herself in the barracks staring at empty cots while Glimmer doubled over to catch her breath.

The blankets hadn't even been disturbed. They were gone. Everyone was gone. That broke Adora. That broke the last thread she had to her own sanity. "I don't understand."

Glimmer came up behind her slowly. "I hate to be the one to suggest this, but-"

Adora cut her off. "I'm not giving up. I can't leave her." She started breathing fast and shallow.

Glimmer didn't say anything.

Adora continued, talking to herself more than Glimmer. "I'm not leaving until I find someone who knows what the fuck happened. I don't care if I have to ask Hordak himself." That thought- it gave her a goal. It gave her a focus. She turned to walk out. She was going to go ask the man himself. Go barge in on him in his stupid sanctum and demand to know where her people were.

Glimmer put out a hand to stop her. "You're not thinking clearly. We're not going to go talk to the leader of the Horde."

Adora blinked and looked at Glimmer through the helmet. Maybe talking directly to Hordak was a bad idea- a stupid and reckless idea- but she was all out of other ideas, and the fear was taking over.

And that's when she heard the sweetest sound of her whole life.

"Adora! Where the fuck have you been?"

Adora turned to see Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio walking into the barracks. Behind them, a small group of guards passed the barracks as if they were all returning from some meeting. Some big gathering.

It should have unnerved her, but Adora's brain was looking for anything. Anyone. Adora smiled. Ok, so the place *was* more empty than it was supposed to be. Everyone was somewhere. That meant- probably that was where Catra and Scorpia- and yeah, even Entrapa were. Maybe Shadow Weaver was there too. Just- some kind of meeting had been called. She mentally relaxed, just a bit.

Then she saw Lonnie's expression. She looked pallid.

Adora then saw that Rogelio wouldn't look her in the eye, and Kyle was frowning.

"What happened?" Adora asked, her smile fading.

Lonnie took a few breaths. It was rare to see her struggle, but she was struggling. “Adora- why didn’t you come when the announcement was made?”

Adora stared at them as her mind blanked, then it produced a good enough excuse- the one she had rehearsed. “I was asleep. Dead to the world.” She narrowed her gaze at them. “What announcement?”

Lonnie looked pained. Reluctant. “The court-martial.”

It took far too long for Adora to hear those words and understand them. Her heart was suddenly racing as her vision tunneled. “Oh... So, Catra is...”

“Headed to Beast Island,” Lonnie said, her shoulders falling.

Adora took a breath as all the stories of the place came rushing back to her. Blood beetles and trees with razor-sharp knives instead of leaves. Chippits with razor-sharp teeth. Scrufferes, with razor-sharp horns. Razor-fins with razor-sharp teeth. Everything was razor-sharp there, but so was Catra.

If anyone could survive in Beast Island, just for a little bit, it would be her. Catra could at least survive until Adora could make it there.

Adora held onto that hope. Her fear was gone. The focus was back. “Ok.” She turned to Glimmer, who was still very uncomfortable in the Horde uniform. “I guess we’re taking a trip to Beast Island.”

Gambit

It started the moment Shadow Weaver froze her with electric sparking magic that singed her fur. As the woman leaned in and said she would end Catra herself, that was when something clicked in Catra's brain. Someday, this woman would pay.

Thinking of how, exactly, she would pay was one of Catra's favorite pastimes. Sometimes it came out as childish conversation with Adora about taking over the Horde, and ruling it together, and yeah that was a goal as well- but they both knew what that would take. They both silently acknowledged that Shadow Weaver would have to be out of the picture for that to happen. Couching it all in terms of ambition made it socially acceptable. It made it easier to discuss. Even if Shadow Weaver heard them, she was more likely to encourage Adora's ambition than scold her. However, in those talks, Catra could tell Adora was conflicted.

Of course, Adora was conflicted. Her whole personality was built around doing what she was told because she desperately wanted to be loved. She would never say it that way. None of them would, but that's what it was. Adora, more than most of them, had been driven by Shadow Weaver to always strive for an acceptance she could never obtain. To give and give and give herself on the vague hope that she would finally someday earn the right to be worthy of some form of love. Catra watched Shadow Weaver give Adora praise, line out the next goal to be achieved before withdrawing herself again, keeping herself at arm's length physically and emotionally.

It broke Adora's heart every time and it made her work extra hard just to get some attention. She would hurt herself. Push herself too much.

Catra felt it too, the desire to have this crazy woman acknowledge her, but it presented differently. She knew the old lady hated her, so instead of trying to get her love, she sought her anger. At least

when she was angry, she had her commanding officer's full attention.

This was the way Shadow Weaver wanted it, and they played along because there were no other options. No other script to follow. It all fueled Catra's daydreams of one day getting her back.

Every punishment was an opportunity to learn. Shadow Weaver thought she was teaching Catra how to behave. Instead, she was teaching her all about her magical limitations. Every time the old woman used magic on her, Catra took note of how it worked. What its rules were. She knew the relative speed of the old crone's shadows. She knew the range of Shadow Weaver's attacks. She knew how long it took the old bat to draw magic, and the subtle tells that would let her know what attack was coming.

Catra had filed all that away into a special part of her brain to be used on a day that she had no choice.

Today was that day.

The faint sulfur smell that caught on the wind in the evenings of the Fright Zone somehow seemed refreshing. The drab grays and stark reds seemed extra flashy. The dark, somber corridors of the Fright Zone felt damn near cheery as Catra walked.

Catra had something she had never had before, Adora's love. Explicit. Demonstrated. That fact painted everything in a new and glorious light.

Before her, Catra could see a future. A happy one. Being sweet with Adora. Being loving. Being together in a way they never could before. Being each other's safety and weakness.

The kiss had been a panic moment, but Adora had kissed back. Had touched her back.

We're in love.

That word buzzed in Catra's brain as she walked steadily back toward the evil woman who abused both of them in different ways.

They had love. They had the thing they had both been denied all their lives. A love they were trained not to acknowledge. That thought made Catra feel electric. She felt powerful. She felt like she could do anything.

Catra was going to do something stupid. She knew it was stupid, but it was the best plan she had ever come up with after a lifetime of running scenarios in the simulator of her brain. She was going to intentionally get Shadow Weaver to attack her with magic. Yep. She was going to put her body in the direct path of potential doom. Why? Because she loved Adora, and it was worth it.

If this worked, then they were finally going to be free.

It is going to work because it has to work.

Her whole body was coiled tight like a spring under pressure.

As she reached the Black Garnet's door, she smiled to herself. Catra licked her lips, savoring the moment, savoring the last taste of Adora she had. Savoring the calm before the storm. Mentally rehearsing her plan before finally typing the code into the door.

When the door slid open, Shadow Weaver looked up from where she stood in the corner, looming over her scrying cauldron. Her body stiffened as she saw Catra, then relaxed and looked back down at her pool. "Come to clean up your mess?" Shadow Weaver gestured weakly toward the broken bottle still on the floor.

Catra stepped in and closed the door behind her. "You and I have to talk."

Shadow Weaver sighed. "I'm busy at the moment if that's not terribly obvious."

Catra took another step forward. “Believe me, you’re not too busy for this.”

Shadow Weaver huffed as she touched the surface of the scrying pool. “I am trying to plan a trip. It's very important. I don’t have time for your second thoughts about what we discussed earlier. You were the one that said you understood completely, so please leave me be. I have work to attend to.”

Catra opened her hands, palms up. She breathed in, closed her eyes, and smiled. It was hard to say it before, but she could say it now. The word came so easily. “Adora and I are in love.”

Shadow Weaver went still and looked up. Her eyes leveled with Catra’s. She studied her.

Catra knew what this was. Shadow Weaver was calculating several things. She was assessing the truthfulness of the statement. Assessing Catra’s posture. Her mental state. Catra used that to move in. She stepped over the bottle and got to the other side of the scrying cauldron. Her smile was still on her face—still firm.

Shadow Weaver watched with growing curiosity. “In love?”

Catra nodded.

Shadow Weaver then took a deep breath and focused back on the pool. “You are delusional. Perhaps you’re coming down with something. Maybe you should ask Scorpia if she can get you some medication.”

Catra put her hands on the edge of the cauldron and leaned in. Her hair disturbed the surface of the water, screwing up the image. It forced Shadow Weaver to look at her. Catra felt a buzz in her limbs. “Adora didn’t kill Perfuma. She let her go. I helped because I *love* her.” She gave extra emphasis on the word that had been so taboo for the three of them in their unhappy pseudo-family.

Shadow Weaver stiffened at that. “That is a serious accusation. You should stop this before you say something you shouldn’t.”

Catra licked her lips. She stared at Shadow Weaver unblinking because she wanted to see every movement Shadow Weaver made. “And with the sparkly princess- we didn’t go in there to gloat. We went to let her go. That one was my idea. Adora went with it because she *loves* me.” She was suddenly enjoying that word and the way it made Shadow Weaver look uncomfortable.

Shadow Weaver’s hand gripped the edge of the cauldron. Her eyes narrowed at Catra.

Catra had to keep pushing. Keep prodding, and she enjoyed every second of it. “Ever since Adora was promoted, I’ve been sleeping in her bed. We’ve been sleeping together.” Her smile got wider. Unhinged because she was absolutely delighted by the implication.

“Scorpia-”

Catra shook her head. “-is naive and very loyal. She unwittingly helped me keep up appearances. It’s your fault for assuming. Poor Scorpia really had no idea what you thought was going on.”

Shadow Weaver’s shoulders fell slightly.

Catra waited. She let the silence linger. She let that long stretch be filled with the slight hum of the Black Garnet and the beating of her own heart in her ears.

Maybe Shadow Weaver was going through the evidence presented. Trying to decide if it was true, and if it was, what that would mean. Shadow Weaver finally settled on, “I have been too generous with you as of late. I hoped you had moved on.” She swiped her hand across the scrying pool, cutting off the magic that fueled it. “Haven’t you hurt her enough?”

Catra wasn’t expecting that.

Shadow Weaver continued. “You have acted foolishly. You have taken something that was already going to be difficult for Adora and made it worse by giving her something to lose. Pouring salt in an open wound, and why? Because you’re horny? Because you’re selfish?”

Catra bristled at that.

Shadow Weaver leaned in. “Go back to Scorpia. Admit your indiscretions, and maybe she will forgive you.”

Catra’s jaw worked.

Shadow Weaver leaned back, looking down on Catra. “I will clean up the mess you made with Adora like I always do. She will, in the end, choose duty over indulgence. She always has. You know that as well as I do.”

Catra started to smile. Her chest felt light. This was it. This was the moment she was waiting for. “You’re not going to do anything with Adora because she’s not here.”

Shadow Weaver stiffened, then narrowed her eyes at Catra. “You’re lying.”

“She’s out of your reach. By now, she’s probably halfway across the planet.”

Catra finally saw it, the shaking in Shadow Weaver’s limbs. It was a sign she was on the brink of magical rage. The old woman just needed something more to tip her over.

Catra grabbed the edge of the cauldron and pushed.

Shadow Weaver startled back as it tipped. It hit the ground, spilling water all over the floor and cracking in the process.

Shadow Weaver’s body posture changed. Her hands curled into claws. “You insolent fool!” The stone on her mask lit up as her hair started to rise.

Catra watched with a wild smile. Wide eyes. This was it. Her moment was coming.

Shadow Weaver had lost control. Typically, this would be a bad sign. An indication that Catra would spend the subsequent week nursing burns and cursing the bitch's name.

Not today.

Not this time.

The room dimmed as the runestone sputtered to life, coaxed into submission by a false owner.

The air went electric with the staticky snap of magic flowing. Shadow Weaver's hair started to stand on end.

Of all the streams of data Entrapta had access to, there was only one that mattered at that particular moment. Turns out, the whole Fright Zone ran off the low flowing current of the Black Garnet. When Shadow Weaver drew power, the voltage dropped everywhere else ever so slightly. The effect, Entrapta had said, was observable in the dimming of the lights whenever the crone pulled magic.

It was a drop that was easily perceivable by Entrapta's equipment. All it took was a question that Entrapta was all too excited to answer. Can you shut off the lights if she pulls too much power? The enthusiastic answer was yes.

So, as Shadow Weaver pulled the magic to probably kill her ward once and for all, she hit the triggering voltage drop.

The whole Fright Zone was plunged into darkness.

Shadow Weaver recoiled, blinded and surprised.

Catra had her night vision, and with it, she could see Shadow Weaver's sudden shock. The stone on the woman's mask glowed like a beacon.

Catra's coiled muscles released, and she jumped claws out.

By the time Shadow Weaver realized she couldn't see, Catra's strike was already coming down on that bright glowing red stone.

It shattered, and Shadow Weaver's mask was ripped in two. The mask fell away, revealing Shadow Weaver's face frozen in fear as the horror of what happened finally reached her.

Catra landed, and the lights came back on as the connection between Shadow Weaver and the Black Garnet was severed.

Shadow Weaver crumpled to her knees, groping for the broken pieces of her power. "What have you done? You fool!" She tried to put the pieces together and dropped them as they refused to cooperate.

Catra smiled down on her, pleased to finally see the face of her tormentor pale with fear.

Shadow Weaver shook as she looked up at Catra and realized that the power dynamic had switched in an instant.

Catra stared at the face that had fueled her nightmares. She and Adora only ever saw it once when they snuck into the chamber as children. To Catra, it was the face of a monster.

But the face that looked at her now was not monstrous any more. The scars were not as dark as she remembered. Shadow Weaver's cracked eyes, which had been so full of hate before, only looked at her in abject terror.

It felt good. So damned good.

Catra knelt down to get on Shadow Weaver's level. To make eye contact. She would never have her love, but today she demanded her full attention. "I bet you think I'm going to kill you." She spoke softly and flicked the pieces of the stone away one by one. With each flick, Shadow Weaver flinched.

Catra could only imagine what must be going through Shadow Weaver's mind. Her eyes darted to Catra's hands- to those claws. Maybe, through her fear, she regretted her actions. More likely, she regretted underestimating Catra all these years. It didn't matter, none of it mattered, because in that moment Catra had the upper hand. "I've thought about it. I fantasized about it. One day just using these-" She lifted her hand to show off her claws. "To do to you what you threatened to do to me." Slowly, she slid her claws back and leaned in. "But I'm not going to kill you. I'm going to do something much- much worse. It's going to be a bit of a magic trick. I'm going to make everything you pride yourself on disappear right before your eyes, and there's nothing you can do to stop it."

Catra watched for the change. The moment Shadow Weaver knew she wasn't going to die, her brain started working on how to gain the upper hand. It was a delight to watch it all painted so plainly across her face. She had gotten too used to wearing a mask, so she didn't even try to hide it. It was like being able to read her mind.

Catra stood up as she saw Shadow Weaver's hand go for something in her robes.

Shadow Weaver stared Catra in the eye as she pulled out her communicator badge and hit the panic button.

Catra smiled and stepped back as the alarm blared. They had maybe twenty seconds before the room filled with guards.

Shadow Weaver slowly reached down to pick up the broken pieces of her mask. "You've made a grave mistake, child."

Catra didn't move. Didn't react.

Shadow Weaver lifted the severed mask toward her face. It fuzed automatically as she placed it on. "I intended to spare you, but I can no longer afford that." She leveled her gaze on Catra. "For what it's worth, this will hurt me more than it hurts you."

Catra never stopped smiling.

Shadow Weaver watched with growing uneasiness. “You’re not going to run away?”

Catra put her arms out.

Shadow Weaver flinched.

Catra licked her lips, savoring the coppery taste of adrenaline on her tongue.

The door opened and the room was swarmed by a few squads of fully armored Horde soldiers in a panic.

Catra stood there with her arms out, letting them grab her. She didn’t fight back, even when they wrenched her arms behind her back to subdue her and forced her to her knees.

Shadow Weaver stood up. Loomed over her. “You’re going to pay dearly for this insurrection. I will deal with you swiftly and publicly, and then I’m going to find Adora.” Her voice got low and deadly serious. “There is nowhere on this planet she can hide from me. She will come back to me, and you’ll never see her again. That, I can promise you.”

Catra breathed in and gathered liquid in the back of her throat before expelling air and spitting it at Shadow Weaver’s face. It splattered on her mask and dripped.

Shadow Weaver made a noise of deep disgust as she used her robes to wipe it off. She turned to a guard. “Take her to Hordak. Make an announcement. We’re having a court-martial.”

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The room buzzed with murmurs and the faint shuffling sound of feet. Everyone was trying to stand still at attention, but they were uneasy. It was hard to stay still when you didn’t know what was going on.

Shadow Weaver held the scruff of Catra's neck the way she had when Catra was small, and the most trouble she got into was biting or scratching someone. A shame. This behavior was an indication that the punishments served out in Catra's youth were not harsh enough. Spare the rod and all that.

She almost felt pity for Catra. The poor girl had not learned the lesson that Shadow Weaver had to learn a lifetime ago. Those who were born without power, without real power, could never fight their way to the top. There would always be someone stronger, more powerful. No, you had to be more subtle. Find out what people want, and find ways of getting what you want out of them by catering to their desires. A shame Catra would never learn that lesson. She had such potential, and it was all squandered for a childish adolescent obsession.

The guards used cuffs that covered Catra's claws. That made her fangs the only real threat left, so Shadow Weaver held firm and stood behind her. "Behave, and maybe you'll just get thrown into prison for the rest of your miserable existence."

Catra smiled back at her, which was odd. To be captured, about to be disciplined, and to be smiling like that. Shadow Weaver took notice and stayed on guard.

Scorpia came in with the last bits of the crowd. Shadow Weaver took note of the look on her face when she saw Catra in cuffs. The dumb oaf was surprised, worried. Shadow Weaver concluded that Scorpia had not known about Catra's plans. That was problematic, as it would mean that Shadow Weaver would have to put up with Scorpia's unending loyalty no matter what happened. She'd have to explain that no, Catra could not be released from prison. No, she was a traitor, and this was probably the best thing that could have happened to her. If you'd like you can go visit her whenever you want. It will be Catra's only comfort in the dark years ahead. Shadow Weaver almost had the speech memorized.

The new purple-haired princess came in, and Shadow Weaver stiffened. Her grip on Catra's neck tightened.

Catra's look turned smug. "Something bothering you, Commander?"

Shadow Weaver forced herself to focus, to bring her attention back to the case in front of her. Catra was dangerous enough to take her full attention. The engineering princess was a problem, but something that could be dealt with later.

The door to Hordak's sanctum opened, and he walked out. He was tired. Probably spent the evening tinkering on his experiments. He would be mad at being interrupted, but this was necessary. You had to make an example out of someone like this, or else you'd have a full-blown mutiny on your hands. No one had time for that.

Shadow Weaver opened her mouth to address him and was stunned to silence when she saw the new princess break rank. Her purple hair propelled her past everyone, right up to Hordak's face.

Shadow Weaver nearly stepped forward to stop it herself. Nearly let go of Catra to do it, but she didn't. Again, the girl in her hand was more of a danger than the one talking to her boss. Besides, any brash moves and she would come across as intimidated to everyone gathered, and that was not something Shadow Weaver could afford. But she *was* intimidated as she saw the look on Hordak's face turn from anger to sudden curiosity at whatever was being said to him.

They kept talking. Shadow Weaver couldn't stand it. She had to find out what they were saying. She nearly let go of Catra's neck, and Catra giggled. Fucking giggled.

"What's wrong? Hate watching someone else become the new favorite?" She said it right as Hordak moved aside and motioned for Entrapta to go into his sanctum.

Shadow Weaver's claws dug into Catra's skin. "I'll deal with her later."

Catra's pupils shrank to pinpricks, indicating a surge of adrenaline. "No, you won't."

Shadow Weaver pushed her ward to face forward and wanted desperately to wipe that ridiculous smile off her face.

Hordak refocused on the crowd gathered before him. He cleared his throat and sat on his throne. "So, why have I been disturbed?"

Shadow Weaver pushed Catra forward onto her knees. "Lord Hordak. I have called this meeting to condemn cadet Catra for treason."

Hordak's eyebrow lifted.

The crowd gathered fell to complete silence.

"She has attacked me and threatened the Horde."

Catra started laughing. Threw back her head and cackled.

Among the crowd, Lonnie groaned and raked her fingers over her face. "Catra, no!"

Catra heard it and ignored it. "That's rich, Shadow Bitch."

The crowd laughed as if the rhyme had broken some tension.

Shadow Weaver turned her gaze on the rest of those gathered, silencing them with a look.

Catra turned to Hordak. "Yeah, I attacked Shadow Weaver because *she's* the traitor."

Both of Horak's eyebrows went up.

Shadow Weaver turned around, in shock, to look at her former ward. Quietly, she asked, "What are you playing at?"

Catra got up from the floor and basked in the attention she was getting. "I have proof that old Shadow Heaver over here has been

lying to you all about the Rebels. She's been submitting false reports about the kingdoms. Why do you think Thaymore was so easy to sack? Why do you think Plumeria just bent over backward for us? It's because she was trying to make her golden child look good. You want proof? Look at the last report about Salineas, then go look at the place. Its famed Seagate is in tatters. The whole kingdom has practically been abandoned."

Shadow Weaver, at first, couldn't believe what she heard. For the first time, for the first real time in her life, she was scared of Catra. How did she know? She blinked as she remembered Adora taking Catra on the trip. She had told her not to let Catra see the shore. That was it. The simple fact of it was almost painful. She had trusted Adora too much. Her fear subsided. She should have been more careful. Lesson learned.

It seemed she had to learn a lot of lessons that day.

Hordak glared at her.

She worked on a counterargument. Something fast. Hordak wouldn't stop everything to go check on a kingdom. That meant she had time to stall. "She is lying- trying to save her own skin by deflecting blame onto someone else." It was, after all, just her word against Catra's.

Catra smiled bigger.

The gathered crowd started to talk amongst themselves.

Hordak's face twisted into a sneer, and he silenced them all by standing up. "What happened to your mask?"

Shadow Weaver startled at that. "I beg your pardon."

He moved down the stairs, eyes never leaving Shadow Weaver. "How about we try something. You can punish your ward yourself with your magic. Go on. We'll all watch."

Her heart started beating hard in her thin chest. *Keep cool. Keep calm.* "I'd rather not kill her. Despite how wretched she is, I am still her caretaker. Call it misguided fondness."

Catra laughed hard at that. "Oh, sure! You just care about me so damn much. One big happy family over here."

Hordak moved with a slight smile on his lips. "You know, I always wondered how it was you were able to coax the Black Garnet to work for you." He gestured faintly at the spot on her mask where the stone had been. "I guess I know now." He turned his attention to Catra. "I believe you. I've had enough dealings with this woman to know she is untrustworthy. But, her connection to the Black Garnet was valuable, so I gave her the tasks I detested and kept a tight leash." He looked back at Shadow Weaver. "But without that connection to a runestone, I'm afraid I have no use for you."

Shadow Weaver couldn't keep calm or cool at that. She felt instant rage. She stepped forward, finally letting go of Catra's neck. "How dare you!"

The whole gathered Horde sucked in a breath, like children watching their parents fight.

Shadow Weaver got in close to her boss. "You shut-in! You ignorant fool! Why would you care about some stupid reports? You never cared about the war, not really." She stood up tall. " *I* kept this place running. *I* made sure the weapons were made. *I* made sure the cadets were trained." She turned away from him to look at the crowd gathered. " *I* made you all what you are today. *I* fed you. *I* kept you safe while he-" She pointed a claw at him, directly at the center of his chest. "-he sat in his sanctum and threw tantrums like a child. You owe your existence to me, so show your respect and arrest *him.* "

The room was deadly silent. The gathered crowd didn't respond.

Catra's peels of laughter cut through the silence like a knife and grated on Shadow weaver's ears. She let her hand fall as she realized no one was coming to her aid.

Hordak stood up straight. "Guards, take her, and remove her badge."

Shadow Weaver didn't fight back because it was pointless. They pulled her hands behind her back and cuffed her. Someone reached into her robes, and found her badge, and removed it. She stood in shock as her world came crashing down around her. In that moment of losing everything, she saw Catra- grinning like it was the best day of her life.

Hordak sneered at them, at all of them, and uttered, "I appreciate your revelation, Catra."

She turned to him, and Shadow Weaver knew what Catra was expecting. She was expecting a reward. She was a fool. Catra was always just a tad too smart for her own good.

"However-"

Catra's smile was gone.

"I disapprove of cadets attacking supervisors, and I won't stand disloyalty. I sentence you both to Beast Island because you both deserve each other. You will be put on the next transport immediately." He turned to head back to his sanctum.

Catra's ears went back. Her shoulders fell. The hair on her tail stood up.

Shadow Weaver addressed her in low tones. "I could have told you this would happen."

Catra stood in complete shock.

Shadow Weaver continued. "But you just had to think you were *so* clever." All the venom in her voice was gone. It hit her all at once

that there wasn't going to be a way out of this for anyone involved. She and Catra were being sentenced to the slow, painful death of being torn apart by an uninhabitable island.

As the guards moved to shove them both toward the docs, Scorpia pushed forward.

"Wait! Your honor- I mean Lord- whatever."

Hordak stopped in his tracks and turned to face her. The corner of his mouth twitched.

Catra fought the guards, tried to get closer. "Scorpia! Don't! Just- Don't you dare!"

Scorpia didn't listen. "I want to go with them."

Catra yelled, "Scorpia! You idiot!"

Hordak shot a finger in Catra's direction. "Shut her up."

Catra screamed at Scorpia, launching into expletives and declarations, something about the east side. One of the guards pulled out a red cloth and gagged her.

Hordak looked at Scorpia, tired more than surprised. "I have no problem with you, Force Captain. It would be best if you-"

Scorpia interrupted him. "Catra's my squad. I'm nothing without her." Scorpia's smile was soft. Genuine. "I want to go with her. No- scratch that, I can't not go with her."

Shadow Weaver looked away. She couldn't stand heroics, especially stupid heroics. Catra whimpered against her gag while they pushed her to Shadow Weaver's side and started moving them both. Shadow Weaver decided to needle the whole point. "A shame you didn't like her. She seems exactly your type."

Catra screamed against the gag, struggling against the cuffs. The guards gripped her harder.

“I suppose you still have some time on the transport and perhaps a few hours until we’re all devoured by pookas to strike up something of a relationship. If you’re lucky, maybe you can get to third base before perishing.”

Catra glared at her with a fire burning in her eyes.

Scorpia raced to catch up behind them. “Well, I convinced him.” She put one pincer on Shadow Weaver’s shoulder and one on Catra’s. “Off to Beast Island we go!”

Shadow Weaver detested Scorpia’s positivity. She always had.

Catra whimpered again, fighting the cloth of the gag and tearing up as she looked up at her Force Captain with pleading eyes.

Scorpia acted like she didn’t notice and just prattled on. “Don’t worry, Wildcat. I’m not abandoning you. I swore I had your back, so if you’re going to Beast Island to face your near assured doom, then I'm going with you, little buddy.” She accentuated that last bit with a gentle shaking of Catra’s shoulder.

Catra’s body slumped. The guards strained to pick her up and moved ever closer to their deaths.

Shadow Weaver sighed. “Normally, I’d say Adora would come after us. But *someone* did the stupid thing and tricked Adora into being away so that by the time she hears what happened, we’ll be dead.” Shadow Weaver gave that a moment to sink in. “I hope you’re happy. I hope it was worth it for your little stunt.” The venom in her voice was back by the end.

Catra frowned as they were dragged into the light of the setting sun, into the fishy smell of the Horde docs.

The transport’s captain that greeted them was Octavia. She took in a deep breath and leveled her one good eye on Catra. “Welcome aboard, you little brat.”

No Man is an Island

“Wait... They’re all on Beast Island? Together?” Adora stood, dumbfounded at the concept.

“Not that purple-haired princess. She’s with Hordak.” Kyle added.

Lonnie nodded.

Adora felt a little lightheaded at that. “Oh,” Her brain whizzed, running through what was probably happening that moment between those three stuck together. “They might not last long enough for me to get there.” She straightened up. “But I have to try to save them.”

“We’re not letting you go. It’s suicide.” Lonnie threw herself in between Adora and the door, and on instinct, Kyle and Rogelio did the same.

Adora’s look softened at her friends. She sighed, and looked back at Glimmer, and held out her hand.

Glimmer looked at Adora’s hand, then snapped to as she realized she still had the sword. In this context, she was a soldier following a Force Captain around. If she didn’t hand it over, then it would look suspicious, so Glimmer did the third dumbest thing she had done in the last 24-hours and handed the all-powerful sword back to her prisoner.

Adora took it and turned toward her friends. “If you don’t move-”

They all winced, closed their eyes, expecting the worst, and they didn’t budge.

They heard Adora transform. Heard the sound of magic rushing into the space in front of them.

Glimmer’s mouth dropped. She had seen a lot of magic between her mom and Casta, but nothing like this. She lost herself for a

moment, watching what she could only describe as something divine appearing before her.

The Horde kids collectively flinched when they felt large arms around them. Adora, as She-Ra, lifted them up.

They opened their eyes cautiously.

The sword was back in the hands of the guard, and She-Ra was hugging them. Adora said quietly, "I realize this is against protocol-" She moved them out of the way of the door and set them down collectively before standing back up. "You guys know I can't come back- If they're exiled... Then I'm exiled too."

Kyle sniffed and wiped at his nose while his eyes grew wet. Lonnie bit her lip. Rogelio watched her with a grave expression.

None of them wanted to be the one that said it.

Adora managed a small smile. On She-Ra's face, it was bright and effervescent and had the effect of making everyone around her feel some small flicker of hope. She managed to avoid crying when she said, "I wanted to tell you three goodbye. Thank you all for being good friends." She transformed back into herself, hesitated for a moment, and then left before losing her composure.

Glimmer fought tears herself as she put the sword back in its holster and took off after Adora.

***

The ship's hull scratched along the sandy beach as the engine pushed the nose of the ship onto shore. It was surrounded by dark, jagged rocks situated among purple fog. Yet, there were faint lights that dotted along things that looked like old technology scattered around through the darkness.

The three pieces of living cargo were hustled off the ship. Octavia went to Scorpia first. "Now's your last chance, Force Captain.

Change your mind and come back with us."

Catra yelled against her gag. Octavia's guards turned their batons toward her while the high-pitched hum of the weapons charging up cut through the night.

Catra fell silent. Her shoulders dropped.

Scorpia shook her head. "I can't."

Octavia shrugged. "Have it your way." She pulled out a key from her uniform and went to Shadow Weaver. She undid her cuffs. "I'd say good luck, but it won't do you any good."

Shadow Weaver rubbed her wrists and never took her eyes off Octavia.

Octavia turned away from them, back toward the ship.

Catra ran forward, holding her cuffs out and yelling against her gag, only to be stopped by guards with activated stun batons.

Octavia looked back over her shoulder with a smile. "Oh, those? If you want those off, you'll have to find a way to do it yourself. Call it payback for the eye."

They all heard Shadow Weaver breathe in like she was about to launch into a commanding officer rant. She managed to hold herself back. "She's trash, but even trash deserves to defend themselves."

Octavia walked up the plank. "What? Do you think she's going to defend you with those? Give you some small chance of survival? You should thank me. If I took them off, she'd probably kill you before the island did."

The guards withdrew back to the boat, stun batons held at the ready.

Catra fell to her knees as the plank pulled back up into the ship, and the boat backed away, disappearing into the fog and into the dark starless night.

That was it. They were going to die here.

Scorpia went to Catra's side. "Hey, don't worry. We'll get the cuffs off." Then, with her pincer, she snipped off the gag.

Catra bared her teeth, her eyes wild. "You fucking Idiot! You damned imbecile!" She yelled so hard that spit flew. "I had a plan to get you out! You just had to fucking listen to me, but oh no! You had to play the hero!"

Scorpia's ever-present smile started to fade. "I couldn't leave you."

"Yes, you could! But guess what? Now we're all going to die!" She gestured her cuffs toward Shadow Weaver. "At least if it was just her, I could rest easy knowing I took her down, but now?" She looked toward the sand where the boat had left a deep groove that was slowly being erased by the waves. "Now, I have to know that you died because of me."

Scorpia's jaw worked at the thought, and instead of saying anything, she grabbed Catra's cuffs with her pincers and started trying to get the damned things off.

Shadow Weaver loomed over them but glared at Catra. "Don't berate her. She's not the cause of all this. You are. You did this to her, to me, to yourself."

Catra's fur went on end all over her body. Her mane of hair turned into a spiky puff. "No, you did this! You were the one who was going to hurt Adora!"

Shadow Weaver staggered back. "Hurt her?" She put her hand over her chest in shock. "I was going to make her a hero. I was going to make her into the person who ended the war. You know as well as I do that's what she would have wanted." Shadow Weaver narrowed her eyes. "You took that from her. Stole it."

“Fuck you!” Catra tried to get to her feet, but Scorpia pulled her down by the cuffs.

“Don’t let her rile you up, Wildcat,” Scorpia said quietly, still trying to focus on the cuffs.

For a moment, Catra struggled, fighting against Scorpia to get out the desire to want to fight the other woman, and Scorpia took it and just let her struggle and growl.

Shadow Weaver turned away, her shoulders falling before she sat down on the beach. “It’s all over. All that time- investment. I held back a war machine to give you and Adora time to grow up, and this- this is how you repay me?”

“Oh no! Don’t you dare blame that shit on Adora and me! You’re a fucking liar!”

Scorpia grabbed Catra’s shoulders, pulled her still, and said quietly, “Hey, we need to keep it down, or something is going to hear us.”

Catra’s ears went flat against her head, and she hissed at her friend. It was a soft one, one that had come out often in her childhood when things didn’t go her way. One that she had tried hard to repress growing up, but things were too real now to worry about decorum. Things were too serious to worry about appearing nice.

Shadow Weaver ignored all of it. “You have no idea what you have done.”

Catra hissed at her harder, baring teeth and working her claws in and out inside the cuffs.

Shadow Weaver went on, the bitterness in her voice growing. “There was a large battle. Both sides lost a lot of good people. All that death and destruction- all the people Hordak threw at one objective- and the Horde gained nothing but baby Adora.”

Catra's vocalizations stopped.

Scorpia sighed, as she now had some stillness to start working.

"Hordak saw her as a sign of his failure. Was going to throw her in with the rest of the orphans." She paused. "I took her in. I raised her because I knew she had a greater destiny." She adjusted, seemingly sinking further into the sand. "Hordak lost his resolve. Retreated into his sanctum and left me in charge."

Catra sneered at the woman. She didn't like the tone she was taking.

Shadow Weaver's voice grew quiet. "I was suddenly the only person looking out for a whole country of people. There was one more good battle after that. The Rebels tried to end the war by throwing everything they had at us, thinking the previous battle had made us weak. They failed so badly it broke the old Princess Alliance and lost them a king. More orphans came, including *you* ."

"Oh boo hoo! Poor Shadow Weaver, the poor martyr." Catra said it in the most annoying nasally voice she could manage.

Shadow Weaver looked up, narrowing her eyes at Catra. "It takes time to raise children, and it's not something easily done while waging war. I was giving you, Adora, and all the other children a chance to grow up. And you- you just used *that* against me, to get me banished. An act of mercy for all the children of Etheria was my downfall."

Catra started to struggle against Scorpia again, trying to get up. "Don't you dare try to make yourself out to be some hero. You abused us!"

Shadow Weaver tilted her head as if curious. "You were well cared for. Fed. You had a warm and safe place to sleep. You had clothes. You had an education. I taught you reading, writing arithmetic. How to fight, strategize, to crush your enemies before you in

battle. I gave you everything I didn't have." She sounded almost calm.

Catra closed her eyes hard, causing hot tears to start dripping into her fur. "Bullshit. You threatened me. Bound me. Hurt me. You had no right- I was just a kid. You never gave me a chance!"

"Do not confuse strictness with abuse. Iron needs to be purified in fire, and so do children. I was harsh on you. That I admit, but I won't apologize. Everything I did, I did to make you strong to survive in a harsh, uncaring world."

"Keep telling yourself that. Maybe someday you'll believe it."

Shadow Weaver growled back. "You are a worthless, spoiled *brat* who threw away everything I gave you. I was a fool. I should have given up on you sooner. I should have let Octavia skin you alive like she wanted. If I had, none of this would have happened, but oh no- I had to be *nostalgic* ." She said that last word with so much hate and bitterness that Catra could almost taste it.

Scorpia was the one that saw it in Catra's eyes. A dimming. A grayness, like the womans' words, were seeping into her. She shook Catra a little by the shoulder. "Hey, don't let her win."

That jostling did shake her out of it, and she wanted to launch into a rage-filled onslaught. She didn't care if she didn't have her claws. She'd use her teeth or her toes. Her thoughts of murderous rage were cut short. A low pulsing sound overwhelmed her. She yelled in pain, and her back arched as the sound hit her sensitive ears. It made her head hurt, and she threw one ear into Scorpia's chest to drown it out and used her shoulder to shield it. It disappeared as fast as it had come on.

Scorpia sat stone still with a slight blush. "Um- you ok?"

Catra pushed away from her and looked around wildly for the source of that sound. She knew she looked crazy. Raw and emotional- her filters were gone. Now, a layer of unhinged fear stretched over all of it. "What the fuck was that?"

“What was what?”

“That sound. Didn’t you hear it?”

“Um- No?”

Neither of them were paying attention to Shadow Weaver, but she was paying attention to them. She stood up, expecting a fight. She knew Catra’s senses were greater than hers. If the girl was useless as a weapon, then at least she could prove to be useful as a warning- the canary in the coal mine as it were.

Catra looked around and heard a scratching in the forest behind them. It had a rough insect quality that made her skin crawl. “Something is here,” she said quietly.

That made them all look in the direction Catra was staring at.

Something rustled in the dark, pulling out of the forest, snapping black vines as it brought its pincers out. It had big bug eyes and a body like a blue coconut crab. It stood up to its full height, standing over Scorpia’s height by a few feet.

Scorpia swallowed and whispered, “No one move. Maybe it won’t see us.”

The beast seemed to look straight at them then and let out a monstrous high-pitched squeal of a cry before rushing them, moving unnaturally forward on its finger-like legs.

Catra froze, watching what was sure to be her death charging toward her in the sand. Scorpia grabbed her, throwing her under her arm, and bolted towards Shadow Weaver, who got thrown over Scorpia’s shoulder while she sprinted.

Scorpia was not a runner. She knew she didn’t have a lot of time before her legs gave out. She ran into the forest anyway, jumping over what looked like broken pieces of tech and black vines that seemed to shudder and move when she passed.

The whole world rushed by her as she tried her darndest to think quickly.

She never got the chance.

She came to a complete halt as a wall of rock appeared from the dark before them. It was too tall to climb, and it stretched out to the sides in both directions. She put her two pieces of cargo down and put her own body between them and the bug. She had pincers. She had an exoskeleton. She had a stinging tail. She would fight. Maybe she would win. Her knees nearly buckled from the combination of running and adrenaline. Still, she stood firm as she watched the thing barreling toward them.

She readied herself for the fight of her life. Put up her pincers and opened them wide to start ripping and tearing as best she could.

A disk of purple light burst through the darkness, striking the beast in the face. It screeched in an unnaturally high-pitched voice.

Scorpia blinked. Someone else attacked it. Her first thought was Shadow Weaver, but then someone new jumped out into the forest in front of her.

He moved fast, with a glowing bug staff and tattered clothes. She could barely keep up with his actions, seeing nothing but flashing magic attacks. She desperately tried to catch her breath while she watched just in case she needed to intervene.

He didn't need the help. Something he did hurt the bug badly. Some big magic circle of pain that made it stagger back.

The new guy stood ready and jerked his hands in a gesture to let it know there was more where that came from.

The best started to move back before turning tail and disappearing into the night.

Scorpia couldn’t believe what happened and fell to her knees in shock.

Their savior turned back to them, throwing back the hood of his cloak.

***

Adora found Scorpia’s ship and crew, already getting ready to take off. She asked to talk to the captain. They recognized her as Scorpia’s friend, so they brought the captain out to her. The Captain, a woman with horns and a stern look, offered, with lots of warnings and caveats, that Adora could come along if she wanted. However, the captain looked concerned. “We don’t think she’ll come unless we take the others too.”

Adora knew what that meant. “So, you’re all defecting- just to save her?”

The captain and the crew that was gathered on the deck looked at each other before the captain spoke for them. “Anyone who didn’t want to go could stay ashore.” She took in a deep breath, eyes started to tear up. “Not a single member of the crew left.” She tried to gather herself before saying, “You have to understand, Scorpia is- was the only good thing about the Horde.”

Adora smiled. She understood that sentiment. “I’m coming with you.”

The crew seemed to brighten up at that. They would have back up. They wouldn’t be alone.

Adora turned to Glimmer, still in uniform, while the rest of the crew broke and started getting ready. “I appreciate what you’ve done for me- letting me come back.” To Adora, this was the beginning of another goodbye.

Glimmer took off her helmet, shook her hair, and looked around to see if anyone was going to sound off an alarm. The crew focused on getting ready to go. No one even looked up. She looked back

to Adora. “Yeah, yeah. Let's get going. Thank me later when they’re safe.”

Adora blinked. “You- you’re going with us?”

Glimmer rolled her eyes. “Perilous suicide mission to a monstrous legendary island? I’m in. Besides, you wouldn’t get very far without the sword.”

Adora looked at Glimmer in amazement. “Your friends- they’ll be worried if you don't return.”

Glimmer shrugged. “That happens a lot.”

For a moment, Adora didn’t know how to react. She had no experience with how to respond to kindness, bravery, and unearned devotion.

Glimmer smiled. “You’re still my prisoner, so I have to keep an eye on you.”

Adora couldn’t help herself. The overwhelming desire that boiled in her heart was to show gratitude and happiness. She had no words for it, so her body did the work. She hugged Glimmer. It was fast, a product of desperation and lack of sleep, but there she was, embracing the enemy. Then she realized what she was doing and backed off before clearing her throat and declaring, “Sorry. I got- overwhelmed.” She adjusted herself, straightened her back. “Thank you.”

Glimmer, with a slight blush, nodded. “Yeah. No problem.”

***

Back on Beast Island, the three travelers were stunned at being saved from a monster.

Tired, breathing heavily from the fight, the group’s savor threw back the hood of his cloak. He had a salt and pepper beard. Long unkempt hair. His shoulders and body were covered in scars. Yet,

despite all that, he had a kind face as he looked at Scorpia and Catra.

Scorpia didn't know who he was, and she didn't care. She was about to thank him profusely for saving them when-

"Micha?"

His face drained of color as he looked up as Shadow Weaver stepped from out behind Scorpia. He blinked and took a step back before muttering to himself, "This has to be a nightmare. I'm asleep. That's it." He, in desperation, slapped himself and then looked up like he was executing things to be different. He frowned when he realized nothing had changed.

Shadow Weaver pushed past Scorpia and stood before him. "Micha, we all thought you were dead." Her voice held a tone that Catra had never really heard before like the old woman was very close to being happy or surprised in a good way. Her eyes narrowed at him. "You've been using dark magic. It's clinging to you. Is that how you survived?" Her voice was full of hope then.

Catra watched the man for his reaction. First, she saw a look on his face that she recognized as one Adora had quite often. A mix of pain, heartbreak, and resignation. Then, a look of anger. She knew instantly that this man knew Shadow Weaver in the way she and Adora knew her. Shadow Weaver hurt him. She was sure of it.

He brought up his hand, making a magic circle with his finger and thumb. "I should strike you down right now. If not for what you did to me, then for what you did to Norwyn."

Shadow Weaver didn't budge.

He hesitated. Looked at Catra, then Scorpia. "Aren't you going to try to stop me?"

Catra laughed. Scorpia shook her head.

He held the magic disk there for a moment. He looked Shadow Weaver over. “You don’t have any magic, do you?”

Her eyes narrowed at him. She didn’t answer, which was answer enough.

He let the disk dissipate. “You have no magic. No allies. You won’t last long here.” He took a deep breath and looked Shadow Weaver in the eye. “I won’t have you turn me into a murderer. You’ve tainted me enough as it is. I’ll let you live and let the island take you, but you stay the fuck away from me.”

Catra stared wide-eyed and in wonder at him. She couldn't believe her own luck. Of all the people to find on Beast Island, a sorcerer that hated Shadow Weaver had to be on the top of her wish list.

He looked at Catra and Scorpia. “You two, if you’re not her allies, then you can stay with me. I’ve survived on this island for... I have no idea.” He lost his composure for a moment. No one else would have seen it, but with Catra’s eyes, she saw his eyes dim ever so slightly before he shook his head and smiled at them. “It’s hard to keep track of time here. Doesn’t matter. I know how this place works. I can keep you alive. And... It’s good to have company.” The smile on his face was genuine. It made the creases in his eyes more pronounced and made him look older, more tired.

He waved for them to follow. Scorpia got to her feet.

Catra stuck her tongue out at Shadow Weaver as she passed.

Shadow Weaver didn't budge.

Even with her claws covered, Catra climbed Scorpia’s body and half hung on her shoulders as Scorpia fell into walking behind whoever this Micha was.

Scorpia looked back.

Shadow Weaver stood alone, staring at them like she had seen a ghost.

Micha looked back too before quickly focusing on the forest in front of them. “Forget her. She’s not worth it.”

Catra didn’t look back. Instead, her eyes were trained on him. “Not to bring up old memories, but how do *you* know her?”

He sighed and trudged forward. He glanced back once more to make sure she wasn’t following. “She was my- mentor. My teacher at Mystacor, back when she went by Light Spinner. She- uh- nearly got me killed trying to use me as a battery for a dark magic spell.” He hesitated. “She told me I was special. Important. That I was destined for great things, and then she turned all that against me for her own needs.”

Catra huffed and perched higher on Scorpia’s shoulder, keeping an eye out for anything coming at them, including the bitch behind them. “Sounds like she hasn’t changed much. She either uses kids as a battery for spells or as target practice for them.”

He looked back at her, his eyebrows knit in worry.

At that moment, Catra saw someone in his face. She couldn’t shake it. That was the same concerned face Sparkles had made in their last video chat. “Who are you again? She called you Micha?”

“Of Brightmoon.” He looked forward, his brows knitting. “I was a king once.”

Catra took that in with a breath. This was Glimmer’s dad. The long-dead king whose death had been touted as a victory for the Horde in their bedtime stories. Shadow Weaver refused to tell that one. Now she knew why.

It was a short walk to a place where the King said he could set up a protection spell. “It only lasts an hour and a half.” He looked so tired as he set the spell, implying he had only slept in an hour and a half increments during his years on the island. The magic glowed with calming blue energy around them. He looked drained as he sat down. “Maybe with you two here, we could take turns keeping watch.” He had a nervous twitch about him.

Catra was going to say something about that being a good plan, but she realized she had lost his attention. He was staring at something on the ground intently.

He dove in front of them, grabbing at something that moved in the dark. Scorpia and Catra watched with mild fascination and a little concern as he scrambled back to his seat and held a bug over his mouth. He stopped when he saw the other two watching him. He gave them a sheepish smile. “I’m sorry. Where are my manners? Do either of you want dinner?” He held the bug to Catra.

She looked past it, to him, to the broken shell of a man. “I’m fine.”

He held it to Scorpia.

Scorpia huffed, and winced, and looked away. “Sorry. No. My family doesn't eat bugs. It’s a little- too close to home, you know?”

He frowned. “Oh, I’m so sorry.” He hesitated. “Do you... mind if I?”

“Go for it.”

He chomped down on it without hesitation. It squished and crunched in between his teeth. He looked around like he was expecting an ambush any moment. After doing a quick parameter check, his eyes landed on Catra’s cuffs while his teeth ground out the last bits of the beetle’s shell. He picked his teeth with an overgrown nail and offered, “I can try to get those cuffs off.”

Catra nearly cried in joy as she gave him a big smile. “If you do that, I’ll pay you back somehow. I promise.”

He gave her a soft smile that felt very close to a smile Adora would have given her before he turned to Scorpia. “Maybe you take the first sleep while we work on this.”

Scorpia looked between Catra and Micha, then the protection spell around them. “Sure thing. You guys take the first watch, and I’ll just-” She didn’t finish her sentence before she laid down on the ground on her back. Took a deep breath, put her pincers across her middle, and finished, “-I’ll just catch up on some sleep.” With the lack of sleep the night before, plus the sprint, her body was already exhausted.

Micha turned his full attention on Catra’s cuffs. With both hands, he summoned a circle of magic. “So- you seemed pretty happy to be leaving- What do you call her?”

“Shadow Weaver.”

He huffed. “How very apt.” He moved the circle closer to the metal, and it vibrated before the corner that touched the circle of light started to melt. He stopped. “We’ll have to take it slow so we don’t cook your hands.”

Catra shrugged and tried to get comfortable. “I don't mind taking the time if it gets me my claws back.” She looked up to see his face beaming. He looked just like Adora- wearing his stupid heart out on his sleeve.

“You have claws! That’s fantastic!” The dude looked like he had just won the lottery.

Catra would never acknowledge how much she craved approval. That look on his face made her heart sore. It made her want to protect him and help him. It made her want to make him make that face again. All those things she knew she wouldn't get from Shadow Weaver, she held out hope she might get from Glimmer’s Cool Sorcerer Dad.

He made the circle again and pressed it into the metal. “So- How do you know Shadow Weaver? Is she your teacher at the Horde or something?”

Catra’s ears went back. She shrank into her shoulders. “I guess you could say that. She was our commanding officer... She raised

me.”

He frowned. “Oh- I am so sorry.” He focused back down on the cuffs. “I can’t imagine anyone letting that woman raise children. It must have been hell.”

His saying it so plainly, Catra never felt so seen or understood. For all the feelings she had about it, all she managed to say was a mild, “Yeah.”

He worked for a few minutes, taking more of the metal out before those words slowly made their way through his brain. “I don’t mean to pry but- how long has she been your caretaker?”

“I guess I was about four when she took me in.”

He blinked, and she looked into his eyes. Again, they seemed to dim ever so slightly before he shook it off and forced a smile. “Oh. Four, and you’re... how old?”

She sighed. “You’re trying to find out how long you’ve been gone.”

“Maybe.”

“How old was your daughter when you were sent here?”

“Four.”

Catra frowned.

His eyebrow knit, and his shoulders fell. “So you know her- she’s- old enough to be meeting with Horde soldiers on the battlefield.”

“She was my co-conspirator to take Shadow Weaver down. She saved my-” Catra hesitated as the words in her brain got mixed up. What was Adora to her now? What was she even allowed to call her? Friend? Girlfriend? Lover? “Saved someone very important to me... Shadow Weaver was going to do something with her and-, and your daughter trusted me enough to help me get her out.” She kicked at the dirt a little. “And maybe Adora’s

sitting in Brightmoon right now, eating good food, and worrying about me. She doesn't know I'll never see her again."

He moved fast, dissipating the magic disk to free his hands. He grabbed her face and forced her to look him in the eye.

She flinched at the touch.

"You can't think like that." He sounded desperate. "The island- it dulls your resolve. Exposes your weaknesses. If you give up hope, it pulls you in, and if you go too far, you can't come back." Tears were in his eyes again. He seemed to realize he was touching her suddenly, and he pulled back. "I'm sorry. I haven't been around people in a long time- not real ones anyway."

She muttered something about it being ok while she wondered if she'd end up like him, a nervous wreck on a cursed island, eking out survival for over a decade.

"Promise me you won't talk like that. Won't think like that. You *will* see her again." He all too easily slid back into making the magic disks and cutting into the metal. His tone shifted like he was talking to himself and not here. "Forget the fact that your daughter's all grown up now. You missed all those birthdays- all those smiles. She- she's-" His jaw clenched in resolve. He dropped the thought, and he worked.

They didn't talk for a while as he slowly made the way through the metal, avoiding her hands. When it finally cut through, the cuffs fell away from her, and she was able to flex. She held her hands before her claws out and marveled at the way they glistened in the moonlight. They never looked so gorgeous.

Catra felt hope grow in her again. She looked up at Glimmer's dad, a man once used by Shadow Weaver the same way Adora was, and she smiled. "We will get off this island, old man. You, me, and Scorpia. I'll see Adora again, and you'll see the cool badass person your daughter has become. Ok?"

He gave a small hopeful smile back, but it didn't reach his eyes.

***

Adora sat on Scorpia's ship, staring out into the fog that hung over the waters.

Glimmer came up to her, putting her hand on her shoulder.

Adora flinched.

"Sorry. Didn't mean to scare you."

"No. It's fine. I'm fine."

Glimmer gave her a worried look that she had no idea she shared with her father. "You should sleep. It's not like staying awake is going to make the boat go any faster." To make her point, Glimmer sat down on the deck and leaned against the side.

Adora, her eyelids heavy, looked between Glimmer and the ocean.

Glimmer smiled and patted the deck next to her. "At least sit down."

Adora hesitated.

"Look, you're still my prisoner," she whispered. "And your safety and wellbeing is my responsibility, or I could be accused of war crimes."

"War crimes?" Adora repeated sleepily.

Glimmer nodded and patted the deck again.

Adora didn't know why she did it. Maybe it was just exhaustion. Perhaps it was a sense of not wanting to get her captor in trouble, which was an odd thought, but she didn't question it. Instead, she sat down next to Glimmer.

She leaned her head against the side of the boat, and for a moment, slipped quickly into sleep before her head fell and woke her up with a start.

Glimmer cautioned an arm around Adora's shoulder. "You have to lay down to sleep."

For some reason, Adora expected the girl to call her an idiot or a dumbass at the end of that because that's what Catra would have done. But, at that moment, the fact of everything hit her a little too hard, and she was either going to fall asleep or cry, and she wasn't going to cry in front of the enemy. So, instead, she let the Commander of the Rebellion guide her to put her head on her shoulder.

Adora blinked and found it even harder to keep her eyes open. "Shadow Weaver told me you princesses were bloodthirsty. Unhinged. Dangerous." She blinked, but her eyes didn't open back up. Instead, her body relaxed in a way she wasn't used to. "But you and Perfuma and Scorpia are nothing like that."

Glimmer was going to respond. She was going to say something about learning a lot about the Horde too. Something about all her life she thought the Horde were bloodthirsty murderers, but no- Adora and her friends were brave and sad, and sometimes in love. They were just people, and they were on the wrong side of a war with adults making them do shit they didn't want to do. She could feel that. She could understand. She was going to say all that quietly, but she was cut off by Adora's snores.

Let Go

Adora knew she was on a boat, which made the sand beneath her bare feet an odd feeling. She was in the shallows of a nice beach, looking out on a vast ocean. For a moment, she breathed it in.

She could have stood there and watched the waves coming in forever, but something made her turn around.

That's when she realized it was a dream. It had to be.

A seven-foot-tall glowing embodiment of magic stood behind her on the beach, holding the sword with its point toward the sand.

Behind the woman, a darkness Adora couldn't comprehend. Dark, jagged rocks with lights on them. A sound she couldn't quite place, but it hurt her ears.

"Is this Beast Island?" She asked out loud, not really expecting an answer.

She-Ra started to glow stronger. Light started to come out of her eyes. She opened her mouth in a soundless scream.

Adora wanted to help but didn't know how. "You're trying to show me something."

The warrior goddess brought up the sword.

"I don't understand." Adora's tone was desperate.

She-Ra drove the sword down hard and fast with magical assistance.

The sword shattered, and Adora woke up.

Adora woke as the ship hit land. Glimmer was snoring, drooling down half her face. Adora realized that she had somehow slipped off Glimmer's shoulder and ended up with her head in her lap.

Embarrassed, she moved slowly to shift her weight without waking Glimmer up.

Glimmer started stirring, yawning, as Adora stood up.

“Are we there yet?” Glimmer said as she rubbed the sleep out of her eyes.

Adora pretended not to notice as Glimmer found the drool and wiped it off. She instead looked out over the island, and her breath caught. The beach, the sand, the island behind it, was exactly as it had just been in her dream, minus the glowing magical lady standing in the water. Adora had no idea what to do with that.

The captain called the crew to put down a plank.

Adora forced herself to breathe. Maybe the dream meant something, maybe not. There was no time for uncertainty. She was going to find Catra and take her home, wherever home happened to be.

Glimmer got up and groaned, rubbed her back, and looked at the island. She frowned. “It’s all tech... Bow would have loved it here.”

Something crashed in the woods off to their right, and they looked. Birds flew out as something big came rushing through. It appeared for a brief moment, a giant crab-like thing with a bug face. It looked like it was running from something. It trudged through the sand, obscuring any signs of her friends, and disappeared.

Glimmer cleared her throat. “Ok, maybe he wouldn't like it.”

Adora watched the beast with two feelings. One was apprehension. Everything in her screamed not to go on the island she had been warned about since childhood. The other feeling was hope- hope that Catra was still alive and ready to be saved. Adora started toward the plank.

Glimmer stopped her by the shoulder and pulled out the sword. She handed it to Adora. “You’re not going without this.”

Adora looked at the sword and took it with a growing sense of appreciation for someone who was fast becoming something more than a captor. “Thank you. This means a lot to me.” She stood at attention and saluted. “I’ll return it when I get back.”

“What do you mean? I’m going with you.”

Adora’s brow furrowed as she came out of the salute. “We need someone to protect the boat.” She looked back at the crew on the deck, the captain in the cabin, as they all stared in horror at the beast that had just appeared and vanished. She turned back to Glimmer. “The only way I can do this is if I’m sure this boat and everyone on board are going to be safe.” She put a hand on Glimmer’s shoulder. “Can I trust that you’ll do that?”

Glimmer chewed on her lip and looked at the crew. “They’re not really soldiers are they?”

Adora shook her head.

Glimmer huffed, then looked Adora in the eye. “Ok fine. Go and get them out fast. I’ll keep the ship safe until then.”

Adora gave her a warm smile. “Thank you.” She turned, took a breath, and went against her better judgment, and walked down the plank.

The crew brought the plank back up once she was onshore. “To keep anything from crawling up,” One of the crew said with a shrug.

Adora swallowed and turned back to the island. She started toward the forest, in a random direction, when the captain called out, “Wait! Scorpia still has her communicator.”

Adora turned back and found the captain leaning out the window of the cabin.

The woman tapped the chest of her uniform. “Scorpia wasn’t exiled. She went on purpose with permission. They didn’t take her badge.”

Adora started to smile. Every Force Captain badge had a locator on it. She turned back, hit her communicator, and declared, “Force Captain Scorpia, this is Force Captain Adora. I’m here to get you guys out.”

And she waited.

The crew leaned over the side of the boat to hear.

The communicator sparked to life, and they heard Scorpia breathing hard. “Adora-” *Huff* . “Hurry. The vines- I-”

Adora’s smile faded as the feed cut out. Scorpia wasn’t ok, but she’d have to activate the homing beacon for this to work.

Adora strained her ears to wait for the signal.

Her badge started slowly beeping, and hope filled Adora’s heart. The homing beacon was on. All Adora had to do was head in the direction where the beep got faster and louder. Simple. Easy. She ran with the sword in her hand.

***

Hours earlier, in the dark of night, Micha and Catra sat back to back on the ground, their eyes trained on the forest in front of them.

The low sound of the island sat behind higher-pitched calls and rustlings. It was like the island was teeming with life at night. Any one of those sounds could be something coming to get them, so they talked in low, hushed tones.

“They tried to make me feel better about it.” Micha paused, chewing on his lip in a way his daughter would hours later. “Told me all kinds of things they thought I wanted to hear. Things like,

she didn't really mean to hurt me. That she was driven mad by something." He pulled his knees up and leaned his elbows on them. "But I still have nightmares about what I saw her do that day. Hands reaching out of nowhere, trying to grab me. I watched her kill Norwyn by sucking him up? I think she absorbed him."

Catra listened, as she had most of the night. The image of Shadow Weaver just absorbing a man was stomach-churning. "So, she was already a murder before I knew her. *Shit* ."

He took in a breath. "Dark magic isn't like normal magic. It takes something from the user. Every time you use it-" He hesitated, gathering himself. "-you lose a little bit of your joy- love- anything good inside you." He toyed with a piece of grass in the dirt. "And she used so much that day- we all thought she was dead. We couldn't imagine someone living after having that much taken out of you." He shifted to cross his legs and put his hands together. "If they had known she was alive, they would have gone after her and tried to help. No one deserves to live like that."

Catra adjusted.

"No one deserves to be raised by someone who *can* live like that."

Catra took in a deep breath and looked up at the sky. "Suddenly, a lot of her decisions about food make a lot more sense. Only some joyless, loveless shell of a person could make us eat that shit day in and day out."

Micha couldn't help himself. He smiled. "She was in charge of your food too?"

"Yeah."

"I can't believe the rest of the Horde hasn't defected yet."

Catra smiled a little. "We probably should—the whole lot of us. Imagine Hordak leaving his sanctum, and everyone's just gone. His war machine up and dismantled itself while he wasn't looking."

Micha chucked at that.

Catra smiled. For all the horrors of Beast Island, this wasn't so bad.

The faint blue light of the barrier flickered before it faltered, leaving them in the slight purple glow of the island's corrupted tech.

Micha got to his feet and wiped the dirt off his tattered clothes. "I'll set up the barrier again. Wake your friend. It's our turn to sleep."

Catra didn't have to be told twice. Without his stories, she felt the weight of sleep in every inch of her. She crawled over to Scorpia and stuck a claw into her side, enough to feel it but not enough to hurt. "Hey, It's time to switch."

Scorpia woke suddenly and sat bolt upright. She looked for Catra's cuffs, and when she found the claws that poked her, she smiled big. "You got them off!"

Catra nodded and started to lay down in the spot where Scorpia had been because the ground was warm there.

Micha looked at Scorpia. "When the barrier flickers, wake me up. I'll reapply it and go back to sleep. You got that?"

Scorpia was on her feet, saluting like the soldier she was trained to be. "Sure thing, Boss- King- man."

He knelt down, made the barrier circle again, and set it before moving some debris into something the shape of a headrest. He laid down and groaned as he did, as all the tiredness and weariness from the last decade all caught up with him at once.

Catra laid on her side, and closed her eyes, and tried to relax. She wanted nothing more than to keep Adora away from that island while desperately wanting to have Adora there with her, sleeping by her side. She closed her eyes tight and tried not to think about

it because when she did, the low sound of the island hurt her ears.

Catra slipped into dreams quickly, but her system wasn't ready to relax. It was prepared to practice. So it threw everything at her at once.

She dreamt the bug attacked them, and she had to fight.

She then dreamed she was back in the Horde, and Hordak gave her a promotion instead of exiling her. In that dream, she got Adora back from the Rebellion, and they made out on Hordak's throne.

Catra was yanked out of that dream by the flickering of the fading barrier spell. The sun was up, and her vision was blurry. She saw Scorpia sitting and Shadow Weaver behind her. As often happens in dreams, Catra couldn't yell. Couldn't move. Couldn't warn Scorpia as Shadow Weaver stepped on Scorpia's tail and grabbed Scorpia from behind, doing a perfect coke hold.

Catra blinked as her vision became crystal clear.

Scorpia slumped over into the dirt, and Shadow Weaver moved toward Micha as he snored softly.

Catra's brain came online. This wasn't a dream. This was real. She scrambled to her feet and threw herself between the king and his disgraced mentor.

Shadow Weaver froze, and her eyes fell on Catra's hands. "I see you got the cuffs off."

Catra growled.

Shadow Weaver put up her hands. "I can use his magic. Micha is talented, but he's not clever. Step aside, and I will get us off this island."

Catra's anger- unbridled hate, woke the island up, and it was hungry.

Catra was too caught up in the woman in front of her to see the black sprouts starting to take over Scorpia. Catra's brain was focused, sharpened like a knife. She extended her claws. "I'd rather die than let you touch a hair on his head." The spike of dark emotions in Catra caused the island to send out its signal.

The signal hit Catra's ears hard, and she yelled, throwing her hands over her ears and falling to her knees.

That yell woke Micha up. He blinked and saw Shadow Weaver. Years of survival had taught him how to react fast when woken up, how to defend himself from a dead sleep. He had a disk of magic in his hands and tossed it the moment he was conscious enough to aim. The disk hurdled toward Shadow Weaver.

She dispelled it with a wave of her hand, perfectly timed. She staggered back, having second thoughts about her ambush.

Catra forced herself to stand up, even as the sound throbbed in her ears. It accentuated her hate. Her rage. She lunged at Shadow Weaver, teeth bared and claws out. The product of a lifetime of abuse came out in that fight—all tearing claws and desperation.

Scorpia started to wake up, started to push herself up before she realized she couldn't. Something was holding her down. With a throbbing headache, she looked up to see Catra and Shadow Weaver fighting-struggling- and grappling with each other, and Micha getting to his feet.

Scorpia was disoriented, but she saw the black vines around her and realized, in horror, that more were growing around Catra, Shadow Weaver, and Micha. They had no idea they were surrounded.

Over the sounds of the fight, hissing and screaming, Scorpia heard her communicator.

“Force Captain Scorpia, this is Force Captain Adora. I’m here to get you guys out.”

Scorpia couldn’t believe her ears. She struggled against the dark bands to tap her communicator. She breathed hard with the effort. “Adora-” *Huff* . “Hurry. The vines- I-” A tendril grabbed her pincer and pulled it away, shutting off the feed.

While Micha tried desperately to control the brawl, Scorpia used every ounce of strength she earned doing bicep curls in the gym to pull her pincer to her badge and hit the homing beacon before she collapsed.

***

Once Adora got the feel of how the homing signal worked, she ran hard, jumping over anything in her way. The beep was the only thing she could think of. She passed by a selection of monsters on the island. They all stopped to watch her pass but didn’t follow. They knew better than to run toward where the island’s signal was most potent.

The beeping grew stronger, faster until it switched the call-back sound, indicating that she was there. Adora slid to a stop as she came across black vines covering everything in front of her. The homing beacon sounded, and Scorpia’s sounded back faintly from the mess. It took Adora a moment to realize the response sound was coming from a large bundle of vines on the ground.

Adora fell to her knees, tearing at the vines with her bare hands, trying to get to the badge underneath and the person it was hopefully still attached to. She got to barely see some of Scorpia’s uniform before the vines surged and swarmed over where she had worked.

Adora fell back, breathing hard. She grabbed her sword. She needed She-Ra. She stood up with it. She raised the weapon up over her head. “For the Honor of Grayskull!” She froze. Nothing

happened. She stared at the sword held in her hand and grit her teeth.

For a moment, Adora hated She-Ra. She took the vision as a sign that She-Ra didn't want her there on the island. Didn't want her to try to save her friends. She had no idea how wrong she was, but she didn't really care. She was in panic mode.

She brought the sword down and started trying to cut through the vines. If She-Ra wouldn't help, then the edge of the weapon would.

The black things snapped and fell away, revealing Scorpia, laying on her stomach, her head to the side. Her eyes were open and dull.

"No, no no no." Adora put down the sword to grab Scorpia's neck to check her pulse. She was still alive but unresponsive.

She saw movement out of the corner of her eye and caught her sword just as the vines started to go for it. She grabbed it, yanking it away from them, and as she did, they covered Scorpia back up, claiming her again.

She staggered back, not realizing she was falling deeper into the dark, tangled grove.

Her back hit something, and she spun around to see Shadow Weaver's mask peeking out of the dark tendrils.

"Adora?" Shadow Weaver's voice was hoarse, faint.

Adora froze, unsure how to feel about what she saw when the vines grabbed her sword and pulled.

She grabbed the hilt hard on instinct and pulled back.

"Adora? You came." Shadow Weaver sounded like she was talking in her sleep. "I knew you would come for me, my child."

Adora didn’t respond and just put her effort into struggling to get the sword back. The cables swelled, hungry for this little piece of perfect First One’s tech.

Shadow Weaver watched as she slowly came out of a haze. “You’re not trying hard enough. Put your back into it!”

Adora did as told.

“Forget freeing the sword! Just transform.”

“I can’t!”

“What do you mean you can’t?”

Adora heaved, pulling the sword only a few inches. “I mean, I tried. It didn’t work.”

“You need to focus! You need to be calm. Breathe, Adora.”

Adora tried to breathe. She tried to calm down. She gripped the hilt tightly and for a moment silently begged She-Ra to come back, to help her. “For the honor of Grayskull!”

Nothing happened, but the strands tugged harder.

She groaned and tried one full-body pull. Some of the vines snapped, but the victory was short-lived. They multiplied and pulled Adora forward, nearly tripping her.

“Don’t let go of that sword!” Shadow Weaver hissed. “It’s our only hope.”

“I know!” Adora used every muscle in her body to pull, and it only dragged her further in.

Shadow Weaver watched as her golden child was failing. “You’re no use to anyone, me or the planet, if you’re dead. For the sake of every soul on Etheria, transform!”

Adora lost her footing, and the dark fibers dragged her forward. She fell on one knee and yelled back, “I can’t!”

“Your emotions are blocking you. You’ve entangled yourself. We need She-Ra right now, not Adora, and if you can’t call her, we are doomed.”

“You’re not helping,” Adora whimpered as her arms started to shake with effort.

“She-Ra is a being of pure magic. To unleash her full strength, you must be focused, clear-headed. Stop struggling and focus!”

Adora hated when Shadow Weaver told her to focus. It was short for, you’re failing. You're not meeting my expectations. Try harder. She was already trying as hard as she could. She muttered one small “For the Honor of Grayskull,” hoping against hope that it would just magically work that time. It didn’t.

Adora looked back to her deposed commanding officer and saw Catra tangled in the vines just past her. She was gray-eyed and frozen mid-step, her hand outstretched as if it was snatched mid swipe.

Adora nearly rushed to her on instinct.

“Don’t you dare fucking let go of that sword!” Shadow Weaver roared.

Adora flinched at the volume, at the command. Despite herself, she turned back and tried again to wrench the weapon away. She had to free it. Had to transform because Catra was there. Catra was alive. Catra needed her. They all needed her.

The sword, in response, got pulled ever deeper into the tangle.

Adora put both hands on the hilt and dug her feet into the dirt. “I hate this thing! I hate everything about it.” She grunted, trying to dig it out of the hold it was in.

“Stop complaining!”

Adora wasn’t listening to Shadow Weaver anymore. Her mind was bent toward the sword, and she loathed it. She wished at that moment she had done what Catra wanted and just destroyed it. With that thought, her vision came back in full force, of She-Ra shattering the sword. Looking like she’s in pain. Adora’s eyes went wide. While the vines started pulling the sword harder and harder, Adora said quietly to herself, to She-Ra if she was listening. “What if you hate it too?”

“What are you saying?” Shadow Weaver’s tone was desperate, accusatory.

What if She-Ra hated that thing as much as she did and was just stuck with it like Adora was stuck there trying to get it back.

They were both stuck. That word hit a memory in her brain.

Adora blinked. Madam Raz’s words came back to her in a rush.

You are going to get stuck, and when you do...

She looked at the sword. Adora blinked again as the words came to her tongue. “Let go of what’s holding you back-” She turned to look at Catra, “- and find your heart.”

At the time, those words had meant nothing. They hadn’t made sense, but now- everything clicked. Was the old woman a vision preparing her for something, or was she just some random old woman in the woods? Adora wasn’t sure, but her heart was searching for anything to make sense, and this finally did.

Shadow Weaver’s eyes widened as she saw what was happening. Saw Adora’s hand slipping off the hilt. “You fool! You’ll kill us! Don’t let go of that-”

Adora let go.

The sword disappeared into a mass of writhing dark bands.

Shadow Weaver was stunned to silence as she watched their only hope disappear. Horrified at the failure of her project child.

Adora, finally free, moved forward. “Catra! I’m here.”

Catra’s gray eyes fluttered in faint recognition.

Threads grabbed at Adora’s feet, her arms. She pushed through, ripping them, and marched forward.

Shadow Weaver cursed and swore and spat the vilest insults- the ones she usually reserved for Catra.

Adora didn’t care. She put her arms around the bound Catra as she quietly told her, “It’s ok.” Her voice cracked. “I’m here. I have you.”

Catra flinched a little, barely tilted her head. “I’ll never see her again,” she said quietly, to herself like she was in a dream.

Adora held Catra close. “I’m right here.” The vines started wrapping around her ankles, her elbows. She didn’t care. As long as she was with Catra, she could handle anything. “Nothing bad can really happen, as long as we have each other.”

Catra’s eyes cleared a little. She looked up. “You promise?”

Adora, tears streaming down her face, smiled. She would go wherever Catra was because Catra was home, so she was home now, and that made her happy. “I promise.” And despite the island’s evil threads, she leaned in, closed her eyes, and put her lips on Catra’s.

Catra’s body stuttered at the feeling. Her eyes opened wide and cleared of their haze at the realization that the Adora in front of her was real.

Adora was glowing. Catra quickly closed her eyes and leaned into the kiss.

Adora would never fully understand what happened at that moment, but mentally, she stepped out of the shallows and dove headfirst into the depths of a magical ocean.

She freed something that had been bound for a thousand years, and Adora was too busy thinking about that kiss to even notice.

Catra felt the static cling of magic on Adora's lips, and the vines fell away so she could put her hands on Adora's face as it lifted. Catra leaned up and stood on her toes to keep the connection as if letting the kiss end would make Adora disappear.

Adora felt a tingling warmth all over her body, and only some of it was the magic filling her.

Catra pulled away from Adora's lips and opened her eyes to her love, glowing like the morning sun, her blue eyes gleaming brightly as magic filled the air.

The island's bands crumbled around them. Faded. Receded.

She-Ra, with Adora's shocked face as her magic radiated around them, banished the darkness and purified the land they stood on.

The vines around Micha fell away, letting him fall to his knees.

Catra blushed at the woman before her, somehow still Adora while also being someone else, someone bigger. Her hair was still in a fucking poof. Her tiara was... Catra blinked. It looked like her own fucking mask but with wings. *What?*

Catra had no way of knowing this was She-Ra's first attempt at communication with the outside world for over a thousand years, and- frankly- she was a bit rusty. She was trying to say, *I know you're important to Adora, so you're important to me too.* But instead, she made Adora's tiara into Catra's mask.

A few months later, Catra would notice elements of their new friends added to the look- a heart on the chest, wings on the boots, and she'd pick up on what the tiara had been about, or at

least have a really strong guess. But right then, it was just really unexpected, but Catra was too taken to make a deal of it. "Adora, you're- stunning."

Adora, as She-Ra, blinked and then started to smile as the reality of the situation hit. That smile was radiant. She had Catra in her arms. She was safe.

Scorpia blinked as her own haze faded, and the vines fell away. Scorpia smiled against the dirt before pushing herself up.

Shadow Weaver gasped as she was released and looked back at where the sword should have been. It was gone, swallowed up by the island. Possibly devoured. She looked back at She-Ra and frowned.

She-Ra, with Adora's dumb smiling face, grabbed Catra and pulled her into another kiss, and Catra threw her arms around She-Ra's neck.

Shadow Weaver turned away before witnessing Catra desecrating the ancient goddess's face with her flagrant wantonness. In a clinical voice, Shadow Weaver muttered to herself, "Emergence successful with-" she sighed, and her shoulders fell. "-love." Defeat clung to her. Of course, it had been the one emotion she never considered.

***

Glimmer brought a ball of light to her fingertips and yelled as she threw it, "Take that, you stupid bug!"

The ball hit the beast's face, and it staggered back, barely moving away from the boat.

Glimmer screamed as she threw balls of light in rapid succession until the beast was a good ten feet away. She nearly crawled over the edge, nearly jumped onto the beach herself, to scare it away further, but something else spooked it.

It stopped and turned away from her, and she breathed heavily, glad to have the break.

The beast screeched and turned and ran into the forest.

Glimmer swallowed and got her hands ready for more sparkes because she knew better than to relax. Whatever would scare a big bug like that was probably much worse. She focused on the beach, ready and willing for a fight.

A tall woman walked out of the forest, dressed in white and gold, her hair pulled back. Glowing, despite standing in full sun. Glimmer blinked, barely let down her hands. “Adora?”

Catra jumped on the woman’s back, grabbing her neck, and looking directly at Glimmer. She smiled big and waved.

Glimmer, dazed, waved back.

The crew rushed to put down the plank as the large woman who, at Dryl, nearly bulldozed her and Bow, appeared from the forest and ran ahead of the party toward the boat laughing.

Behind them, a man walked with a magical rope tied to some evil-looking woman’s hands. Glimmer’s brow furrowed as she watched the man with some level of suspicion. That rope was an advanced spell. Even her aunt Casta would find it difficult to maintain for any length of time.

Scorpia ran onto the boat, and the crew swarmed her. She laughed harder and gave them the biggest hugs.

She-Ra, with Catra still clinging to her like she would disappear if they lost contact, climbed onto the ship.

Glimmer looked her over. “Where’s the sword?”

She-Ra gave Glimmer a soft smile. “I’m so sorry. I promised to return the sword, but I lost it.”

Glimmer looked over her in wonder. “So She-Ra-”

Adora swelled with pride. “I don’t need the sword to call her, apparently.”

Glimmer started to smile. “Well, hot damn.”

Catra jumped down off She-Ra’s back. “Hey, Sparkles. I got someone you might want to meet.” She stepped aside, bowed a little, and gestured toward the man coming up the plank behind her.

Glimmer watched him as he handed the magic rope to She-Ra and pulled down his hood.

Glimmer was young when her father disappeared, but with him standing there in person in front of her, as real as his mural, she knew him instantly. “Dad?” Her voice sounded small, like she was four years old all over again.

His eyes fell on her. She was all grown up with a little of him and a little of his wife peaking through her features. He stood, stunned at her. “Glimmer?”

Glimmer threw herself into him, wrapping her arms around his neck without hesitation. She held tight as the sobs came.

He relaxed for the first time in over a decade. He wrapped his arms around his daughter, comforting her as she lost her composure, as his vision went blurry from tears. “I’m going home. I’m finally going home.”

Mission accomplished

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The wind rustled the leaves of the Whispering Woods, and it wasn't until that moment, looking at the forest in the orange light of the sunset, that Glimmer realized how long she had been gone.

She could see where Perfuma had made a make-shift shelter with large leaves and soft moss as bedding. There were two shelters, five feet apart. But the beds were now empty, and Glimmer stared at them, not knowing what to do.

Her dad came up behind her and looked at the same thing she was looking at, the beds with absent friends. He rubbed the back of his neck. "So, we're looking for your boyfriend, right?"

Glimmer looked up at her dad, mortified. "What?"

"Beau. Your beau. That means boyfriend."

It took her a moment to realize what he was saying before she looked away from him, back down at the empty beds. "His name is Bow."

Micha visibly relaxed and gave her a warm smile. "Oh, thank goodness. This whole time, I thought you had grown up fast."

She glared at him.

He gave her a grin. "I mean- more grown-up. I don't know. The last time I saw you, you were still trying to figure out how to sing itsy bitsy spider. Now you're-" He turned away from her because she was still glaring, and he looked down at the beds again. "-All grown up and trying to find your friends, and I feel helpless."

Glimmer's shoulders dropped. "Me too." She rubbed her face. "I should have talked to them about what I was doing- so that we could have coordinated what to do if we got separated. Ugh! Why do I do this?" She pulled her hands down and focused on the campsite.

Micha, desperate to be of some help, offered, "We'll look for clues. Don't get discouraged. If I've learned anything from surviving on an island is that you need to keep up hope." He knelt down and started turning over rocks, leaves, wood- looking for anything.

Glimmer, for a moment, watched him. It was endearing, but she didn't expect him to be successful. She considered telling him to stop.

Micha's face lit up. "Does the guy named Bow happen to be an archer?" He held up an arrow with a cartridge on it.

Glimmer instantly recognized Bow's message arrow. He must have hidden it in case the Horde came. She let out a breath and took it from her dad. The moment she touched it, it snapped open.

Micha jumped back, a disk of magic already in his hand, ready for use.

Glimmer pulled the paper out of the cartridge and looked at her dad with growing concern. "You ok?"

He dispelled the disk, overcompensating to try to make it look like he didn't panic conjure a deadly magical weapon. "I might need some time to adjust, but- yeah- I'm fine. You?"

She turned her attention to the note. On the corner of the paper was a doodle of a sad-faced-Bow. That made Glimmer feel even worse. "They waited here all night, then left for Bright Moon to get reinforcements." She threw her head back. "Thank goodness. I'm so glad they didn't try to come after me. Going into the Fright Zone would have been dumb."

Micha watched his daughter get his determined look in her eyes.

Glimmer dropped the note, knitted her fingers together, and stretched them. “Ok. It’s far, but I bet I can get us back to Bright Moon in one jump.”

His brow knit.

She scowled at him. “What?”

“That’s a long way. Shouldn’t we walk some? Just to get closer?”

She shook off the concern and focused her attention in the direction of Bright Moon. “It’s moving toward the stone instead of away, which is always easier.” She shimmied her shoulders, then held out her hand to him. “Come on. I’ll show you.”

He looked at her hand, then slowly took it, with all the apprehension of a father letting his daughter drive for the first time.

Glimmer took a deep breath and focused all her energy on the war room. It was the only place her mother would be after hearing about her daughter going missing yet again. She focused on the distance, on the position on the globe. The height of the castle and that exact location she had known her whole life. Her magic was like a rubber band, pulled tight and then let go- flinging her and whoever she had with her across space.

Micha audibly gasped when they landed, purple sparkles dancing all around them. He stepped back to look up at the door to the war room.

He turned toward her, his eyes beaming with pride. “That was some impressive magic. The control was astounding.”

Glimmer forced herself to straighten up despite how out of breath she was because, damn, she loved the attention. It had been years since her mom had commented on the impressiveness of a particularly long teleport.

“With that kind of talent, you’d be a natural at sorcery.”

She blushed a bit and waved it off.

“I’m not joking. I should give you lessons.”

Glimmer was about to respond when she heard voices on the other side of the door. She grabbed the handle, pulled it, and stopped the moment she could hear Bow talking.

“I should have been faster. I should not have let her teleport out like that.”

Angella responded in a quiet voice, “Don’t blame yourself. It was her choice, and she’s as stubborn and pigheaded as her father.”

Glimmer looked up at her dad with a look of concern.

He smiled at her. “I guess you take after me a little too much,” he whispered.

Glimmer had a feeling at that moment she had not had her whole life. A kinship with her father. There they were, two stupid, reckless jerks who went off and got themselves in trouble, coming back to beg for forgiveness.

Micha motioned for her to go on in.

She took a fortifying breath and opened the door further.

Bow and Angella looked up, and Glimmer saw the looks on both their faces. Her mother- instant relief. Bow’s face held a look of relief and sadness.

“Hey, sorry to make you guys wait. I got- a little sidetracked, but I found dad.”

Bow and Angella’s expressions shifted to the same one. Confused. A little worried.

Glimmer stepped aside.

Micha puffed out his chest and walked in like a king before immediately losing it as he saw his wife. There was no pretending. Over a decade of fighting, of struggling, and just barely surviving, and there he was in the same room as his love. He clutched his chest as he eked out, "Angie-"

Angella sat stone still for a long, agonizing moment. Then, "Bow, do you see what I see?"

Bow nodded.

Angella stood up from the war table. "How is this possible?"

Micha, after having been strong for so long, couldn't hold it in any longer. Tears started dripping down his face. He was trying to say something, trying to explain, but he couldn't get the words out.

Glimmer put a hand on his shoulder and said what he couldn't. "It's a long story, but- Dad's been surviving on a deadly island."

Angella's brows went up. "This whole time?" She whispered it to him. It was a private and personal question.

He nodded and tried to regain himself. He didn't get the chance. Angella could move fast when she wanted to, and her wings helped. She nearly knocked him over as she threw her arms around him.

He hugged her back. What he couldn't say, he could show, and they naturally fell into an awkward kiss full of everything they had held back for so long.

Glimmer looked away, and she realized how lucky she had been to avoid having to watch her parents kiss growing up. Turning away meant turning toward Bow. She didn't shy away from him. If this was going to mean anything, it would have to be direct. "I'm sorry I didn't talk to you first. I'm sorry I made you stay out in the forest all night. I'm an idiot."

Bow looked at her with a sad, soft expression before standing up.

She expected to be yelled at. She certainly deserved it. Instead, he hugged her, and that was so much worse because it meant he had been distraught. “No more surprises like that, ok? Next time, just talk first. I’ll listen. I promise.”

She closed her eyes, and pressed into his shoulder, and nodded against him. They had always been close. They had always hugged, but this felt different. Magnitudes different, as if she had almost lost him.

Behind them, Micha pulled away to breathe but put his hands on his wife’s face as he found his voice. “Angie- I love you.”

“I love you too.”

“I need safe passage for a Horde boat.”

She pulled back, stunned. “What?”

“I have some new friends. Oh! And do you still have a spare room? We have a prisoner.”

***

Adora, Catra, and Scorpia waited on a bench outside the Bright Moon throne room as the Rebellion's top brass had their emergency meeting. The three of them would be called in, any minute, for their part.

They should have been nervous, but they were all so taken by Bright Moon at night that they never got to the being nervous part.

Scorpia watched a bird land on a bush in the garden outside the window and turned to the other two. “Did you guys know that Bright Moon was so-” She gestured with her pincers back to the scene in front of them- nothing but high ceilings, bright lights, and gardens outside teeming with life, “Magical?”

Adora and Catra both shook their heads no.

Their enjoyment of the scenery was interrupted by a band of guards headed their way. Between them was Shadow Weaver with her hands bound. The guards stopped at the door, waiting for their turn to take the woman in for her sentencing.

Shadow Weaver tilted her head toward the three on the bench.

Adora folded her arms and looked back out the window.

Catra stuck out her tongue.

"Don't give her the satisfaction," Adora whispered.

Shadow Weaver turned a bit toward her former wards. "Oh, good. I was worried I wouldn't get to talk to you before they locked me away."

Catra hissed at her.

Adora was trying desperately not to look.

Shadow Weaver went on. "Unsurprisingly, Catra has done a foolish thing. She gave a man looking to make a portal someone smart enough and stupid enough to actually make one."

Everyone on the bench shifted uncomfortably.

"Maybe it will be days, weeks, months. If we're fortunate, it will be years or decades- but it is inevitable, and when it happens, you will need me. Whatever hole they decided to put me in, I'll be waiting for you to come crawling to me, begging my forgiveness."

Adora stood up as she felt a tingling in her chest, elbows, and knees. It was a feeling she was starting to recognize as She-Ra wanting to come out. Begging to emerge. She looked Shadow Weaver in the eye and let the magic take her. She felt a heat burning in her like a sun. Light filled the room, and she coalesced into She-Ra.

Shadow Weaver shrank back from it.

“We don’t need you. We never did. We never will,” Adora said firmly before finally seeing the woman before her. Through She-Ra’s eyes, unthrottled by the sword, she could see the same black hole in the universe that was Shadow Weaver- but there was something else. Something living in that darkness. She stepped forward.

Catra grabbed her arm. “What are you doing?”

Adora hesitated, but her vision coalesced into seeing the shadows that were swarming the woman before her. “I don’t know.”

Catra held on for a moment before letting go and stepping back, curious about what would happen.

The guards shifted as She-Ra came closer. They weren’t about to stop her. That was over their pay grade.

Shadow Weaver tried to back away.

Adora felt like she understood something she hadn’t before. Why Shadow Weaver hadn’t been able to use her like she had Black Garnet. They were like oil and water. Light and dark. Things that couldn’t mix. But it wasn’t Shadow Weaver who was the other half. It was whatever had latched onto her. As She-Ra got closer, it receded.

Adora got a feeling, the slightest hint of communication from She-Ra. Shadow Weaver was dying. She always had been- but managed to keep it in check with whatever magic she could like someone with a chronic illness that just refused to die. She-Ra thought maybe she could heal her. Adora was beside herself at the idea.

Shadow Weaver squirmed under the scrutiny.

Adora could, if she wanted, just let the woman be. Let her deal with the consequences of her own actions. Let her struggle in vain with the beasts she had attached to herself. She could let the woman be as she was and let her struggle for her own existence-

living basically because she knew too much magic to die. Would that be fitting? Would that be justice? Or would that be cruel?

Adora turned back to Catra and looked her in the eye. “Am I cruel?” she asked quietly.

Catra locked on to She-Ra’s glowing blue eyes. “What?”

Adora took a deep breath in She-Ra’s large lungs. “You once told me not to let her have the satisfaction of making me cruel.” Adora leaned toward Catra, a pleading expression on a face that was so different, yet so very much Adora. “Am I a cruel person?”

Catra searched her face for some explanation, but when she found none, she said what she had said before, “Adora, you’re the kindest person I know.” It was a simple truth.

Adora felt that as a pain in her chest. To be cruel would be to let Shadow Weaver win. To be cruel would be to not be herself. “I’m going to heal her.”

Catra’s ears went down. “Why?”

“Because I think it would be cruel not to.”

“After what she did to us?” Catra’s volume was barely escaping a whisper but growing in intensity.

Adora nodded.

Catra stood back with a look of bafflement on her face.

Adora pleaded, “Is that ok?”

Catra sighed and rubbed her face with her hands before groaning and turning to the side. “Do what you gotta do.” She chose to focus on the garden out the window instead of watching what was about to happen.

The moment she got approval, Adora felt the magic flowing like a switch was turned on. It was like a fire. Whatever she had before with the sword had been nothing but a small flame. This was an inferno, and as she stepped closer, the shadows moved to get away from her until the guards held her so she couldn't move anymore. Adora advanced, putting a cautious hand out while Shadow Weaver tried to back away. The shadows swarmed. She finally touched Shadow Weaver on the mask with her hand. The woman screamed and fell back, and shadows scattered from her.

Months from that moment, Adora would go fishing for the first time. She would have the strange and surreal experience of catching a fish with a parasite sucking on its gills. She would be filled with pity. The poor thing was suffering and couldn't save itself, so she would pluck the parasite off and toss the fish back into the lake. She would then realize, with sudden horror, how similar that was to what she had just done to Shadow Weaver.

But at the moment, in front of Adora, for the first time, was a normal woman who had been a bad parent and a bad guardian. There was no scary magic. No weird shadow spies. She was no longer a black hole in the universe. Adora stared in wonder as she realized Shadow Weaver was just a person- a flawed and horrible person, but a person nonetheless. Not a looming danger. Not a scary tyrant. She wasn't all-knowing or all-controlling. She was just who she was and nothing more.

The guards pulled Shadow Weaver up. "What- what did you do?" Shadow Weaver said in a rush.

Adora looked at She-Ra's hand that had done it, the one that touched the woman. "I don't know."

"What do you mean you don't know?" Shadow Weaver's voice grew into a panic.

The door opened, and the guards were called in. Shadow Weaver was dragged, screaming about what had happened, and the door slammed behind her.

Adora turned back to Catra.

Catra was still intently looking out the window.

Adora didn't know what to say or if she should say anything. She wouldn't apologize if she did because she would have been haunted by the idea of whatever had been clinging to that woman if she hadn't done it.

Catra cut through Adora's thoughts. "You know, it's fitting-"

Adora turned back to watch Catra.

"-All this time, she was trying to raise a soldier- tried to turn you into an executioner- and what did you end up being? A healer." She looked back at Adora. "It fits you better."

That made Adora smile, and She-Ra responded by glowing just a bit brighter.

A moment later, and the door opened back up. The three watched as the guards dragged Shadow Weaver out, half dragging her as she tried to stop them by being dead weight. "She cursed me! Put *her* on trial! Find out what she did!" Shadow Weaver screamed.

Catra raised an eyebrow. "Only she would see being healed as a curse."

A woman with a scar across her face and nice armor turned to them from inside. "You three are up."

She-Ra had Adora's worried face and wiped the hand that had touched Shadow Weaver on her clothes like it was dirty. Then, she steeled herself and walked in with Catra close by her side.

Scorpia got off the bench and started to follow.

***

See, the thing was, Scorpia was supposed to go in with them. She was supposed to stand with them and maybe pledge her allegiance to the rebellion, but instead, she ducked out. She went in when the door opened and stepped to the side while She-Ra and Catra walked up to the king and queen.

And boy, did they look great. All grown up. All ok. There wasn't any scary lady lording it over them. Instead, they were being welcomed and honored. It was more than she could have hoped for.

The thing was, Adora and Catra didn't need help anymore. They didn't need Scorpia, and Scorpia knew that.

She wasn't going to cry about it. She was happy for them, honest.

With that cool new form, Adora knelt down and started making new promises about getting Thaymor back and Plumeria. It was then that Scorpia shuffled through the crowd and started going toward the exit that led to the garden.

And yeah, she stood head and shoulders above most of the audience, so this was not a covert procedure. Still, everyone was distracted by the show, so she figured she got out with minimum disruption. The king guy got up and started talking, and she turned and headed out because, before she got back to her boat and set a course to go back to the Horde, she wanted to see the Bright Moon garden in person...up close.

So she stepped out of the crowd gathered, and out the front door of Bright Moon, and into the lush, growing, sweet-smelling garden. Somehow, it still looked vibrant even with the sun gone. Made sense that Bright Moon would have a garden designed explicitly for nighttime strolls in the moonlight. Scorpia sighed and stopped next to a bush with large white buds.

Mission accomplished. Catra and Adora were ok. They had, apparently, talked and said what they were going to say. That was

great for them. They had a nice place to live, with friendly people. Scorpia felt a pang in her chest because, hey, she was going to miss them, but she was obligated to the Horde. It was where she belonged- on her family's soil- doing the job her grandfather decided she would do.

She wouldn't rat them out. She wouldn't lie either. She'd say they got stuck in the vines on Beast Island last she heard, then her ship came to get her. If the two of them showed up on the opposite side of the war, Hordak would assume they escaped independently. It wasn't her fault if he assumed. It wasn't a bad plan.

One of the large white buds in front of her unfolded as if by magic. Behind her, the crowd cheered at some declaration. To Scorpia, it almost seemed like they were cheering for the blooming flower. That seemed fitting.

That was the one thing she hated about what the Fright Zone had become- so few flowers. A while back, there was that brief moment where flowers bloomed everywhere right after they took Plumeria, and that was the best. Cheered the place up a bit. It had been hard to watch all those plants die.

She was crying before she realized someone was behind her. "Oh, sorry. I was just-" She tried to act like she wasn't tearing up over a flower, and when she looked back, she realized that the blooming flower probably wasn't a coincidence.

The flower princes smiled at her. "I saw you leaving."

"Kind of hard to hide that." Scorpia turned back to the flower in front of her, hoping beyond hope that the princess hadn't been standing there for long. Hadn't heard her about to lose it.

"Don't you want to come back and join the party? There's going to be food."

Scorpia sighed. "No. I'm fine. I'm just- taking a moment before I leave."

“Leave? But you only just got here.”

Scorpia was about to explain herself. She’d go into the arrangement her family made with Hordak or the fact that she was a princess but not even one with powers. How, really, they didn’t need her. She’d only be a burden. The point was, her place was in the Horde, and that’s where she should go. She was interrupted by the woman touching her pincer, wrapping her hand around it to hold her there for just a second. Scorpia’s brain came to a complete and abrupt stop as she realized the woman was holding her pincer like a hand- without hesitation.

Perfuma looked at the flower with her. “You haven’t even seen the other gardens or the fountains or the atrium.” She moved her other hand, causing half a dozen of the white flowers to bloom. “If you want to stay for a while, I can show you around. Make you feel comfortable and at home, just like they made me feel when I got here.” She smiled up at Scorpia. “Us exiled princesses have to stick together, right?”

Scorpia nodded in agreement while her brain was focused on not moving that pincer a single bit. People often avoided her because, as she found out, they thought she’d snip their fingers off. It was rare to have someone just casually touch her, and she didn’t want to frighten this princess off. She begged, pleaded with her tail not to just randomly sting the woman beside her because sometimes it had a mind of its own and if she was thinking about someone too much and let down her guard-

“If you want, while you’re taking in the scenery, you can stay in my people’s encampment. We have the best yurts- and campfires. Do you like popcorn?”

Scorpia looked away from the flower and down to the woman beside her. “I do.”

Perfuma beamed. In the moonlight, she looked bright and lovely like those flowers. “Great. I happen to be an expert at growing great popping corn. Come on. Let me prove it.”

Scorpia let herself be dragged out of the garden. She let herself think that maybe she'd indulge a little and spend some time in Bright Moon after all. You know, see a few things, and maybe enjoy the company a bit longer.

***

"Normally, the kitchen staff are dismissed by now, but they offered to make you all a special meal," Angella declared as she sat down at the head of the dining table next to Micha. "I've been told none of you have eaten for quite some time. So you must all be quite famished."

The dining room stretched on for what seemed like forever. Maybe it was designed for large state meals, but at the moment, it held a small intimate table with one empty seat.

Adora's stomach rumbled on cue, and everyone was very polite not to mention it. She tried to deflect, looking toward the empty seat. "Does anyone know where Scorpia is?"

"Oh, I saw her leaving with Perfuma. I guess they got distracted," Catra said while wiggling her eyebrows.

Adora looked at her with confusion.

Catra signed and sat back. "Nevermind. I'll show you later."

Adora had no idea what that was about, so she dropped it and looked eagerly toward the kitchen door. "I wonder what kind of ration bars they have," Adora whispered low enough that only Catra would be able to hear.

"At this point, I'd eat anything that isn't a bug."

Adora sat back. "Bug?"

Catra nodded and pointed to the king. "How else did you expect him to survive on Beast Island for this long?"

Adora shivered at the thought.

The kitchen door swung open. Adora was expecting trays of either gray or brown ration bars. Maybe, if she was honest, she was expecting a different color ration bar filled with potential. What came out instead were carts full of hot steaming food. Large piles of buns. Dishes of meat and sauce. Bright greens, reds, and yellows. Things smothered in cheese. Other things baked into crusts. Smells wafted through the room that made her lose herself for a moment.

Angella smiled at her reaction. "I hope our food is as good as what they feed you in the Horde."

Catra muttered back, "That won't be hard."

The staff set down dish after dish, and Catra was going to try to be gracious and thank the queen for her hospitality when she was interrupted by the very awkward sound of Adora stuffing her face the moment food was in front of her.

The look on the queen's face turned to slight shock.

Catra nearly pulled out all the stops to halt Adora and then apologize, when... Micha was grabbing handfuls of food and sucking it down without even barely chewing. Big gulps, like his life depended on it.

Angella turned to him with concern.

He froze- mouth full of food- sauce spilling down his beard. He smiled at her and forced himself to swallow his current bite, and offered, "Sorry. I- forgot my manners." He started to put down a handful of food onto the plate while his other hand awkwardly went for his fork.

She stopped him. "This isn't a fancy meal. This is about sustenance. Eat. Enjoy however you like, my love."

He whimpered with thanks and started stuffing his face again.

Adora was too distracted to have seen that exchange. Instead, she'd grab a handful of something, tasted it, and then her eyes would widen in wonder. She grabbed more. Each new dish was a symphony of new flavors.

Bow made a point of pushing new dishes her way, telling her why she might want to try it. "This is kind of sweet. Oh, and that one is kind of spicy."

Everything was tried. Nothing was rejected.

While everyone got into the meal, Catra leaned toward Glimmer sitting next to her. She whispered, "So, mission accomplished?"

Glimmer wiped her mouth with a napkin and nodded.

"Feel like another?"

Glimmer looked up, a little alarmed, and made sure no one could hear them before leaning in. "I'm supposed to talk to Bow first before pulling something but- what have you got in mind?"

Catra got a devious smile. "It was your dad's idea- actually. Do you know how many Horde soldiers would sell their left leg for a good meal?" She gestured wide at the table filled with food in front of them.

Glimmer's eyebrow raised. "What's your point?"

Catra leaned back in her chair. "Let me and Adora talk to some of the cadets on patrol- offer them hot home-cooked meals if they defect. We know some people we can start with- and then they could convince others. Before you know it, half the Horde is gone within the week."

"Mom would love that. No combat." Glimmer glanced up at Bow, who was watching her with a worried look. She gave him a thumbs up and a smile and turned back to Catra. "Bow will like it too. Doesn't put me in any unnecessary danger."

"Good. I'd rather do that before trying to take back Thaymor, or Plumeria. You leave it to Adora, she'll go barreling into both of those places and just fight every single person there. Better if half of them are gone before she gets to them." She tapped the table with her claws. "Without their second-in-command, there's no telling what kind of disarray the whole Horde is in at the moment. So we need to strike fast- take advantage of that chaos. We'll do more damage in this first week than we ever will, so we start soon. Maybe even tomorrow."

Glimmer nodded eagerly. "I can start talking to the other kingdoms about taking in defectors. If we spread them around, I'm sure we can accommodate it." She put a proud hand on her chest. "Between my teleportation and Bow's lines of communication with the rest of the kingdoms, I'm sure we can get the word out within a few hours."

"You guys need to warn Salineas that they know they're weak. They need their sea gate fixed. Need to show a front of strength." She tilted her head back and forth. "Initially, they just need to *look* strong. I kind of told Hordak they were weak before I was exiled, so make it look like I lied."

Glimmer nodded in absolute agreement. No questions asked.

Catra gave Glimmer a soft look normally reserved for Adora, but she couldn't help it. She felt like she and Glimmer were on the same page- eager to win this stupid war. End it once and for all. "I think we're going to do great things together, Sparkles."

"It's Glimmer."

Catra ignored her as she put her hands back behind her head and leaned back, "Yep, great things."

***

Adora closed the door to the room they had been assigned. She wasn't surprised no one even suggested getting a separate room for Catra.

Catra went straight to the overstuffed plush bed and sat down with a low moan that caught Adora's attention.

Catra looked back, a weird look in her eye that Adora thought maybe looked like hunger- but there was no way she was hungry.

Catra groaned as she laid back and snuggled into the sheets. "Oh wow- This is nice."

Adora tried to focus on something else. Anything other than her friend writhing around in their bed like she was trying to scent mark it. Through the years, Shadow Weaver tried desperately to break Catra of her scent marking instinct, but it was futile. Adora pulled off her jacket and looked around for a hook or something to put it on. Finally, she gave up and folded it, and put it next to the bed. "I don't know. Looks really- fluffy. How are we even supposed to sleep in it without being suffocated?" She started to turn toward the door. "I can ask them for a more firm bed."

Catra's hand shot out, grabbing Adora to stop her. "No. Absolutely not. You are not turning this luxury experience into barracks."

Adora stopped. If Catra wanted the fluffy bed, then sure, they'd keep the fluffy bed. She sat down on it and started to remove her boots. Her instinct was to go through the motions of her former life. What else did she have?

Catra flopped down next to her on her stomach, supporting her head with her hand while she half watched Adora getting ready and half watched the lights. "I wonder when curfew is."

Adora looked up at the lights then too. "It is late, isn't it?" She looked back to Catra and was caught instantly by the look of her on the bed. Specifically, the curve of Catra's lower back as it raised into the curve of her... She half expected the lights to cut out right then to prevent her from enjoying the view and when they didn't, she looked away out of respect.

"What if they don't have automatic lights out," Catra mused as she smiled, knowing full well how Adora had looked at her.

Adora blinked. “That’s ridiculous. You can’t let people control their own lights. They might leave them on. It’s a waste of energy.”

At that, Catra smiled wide and started kicking her legs against her butt, intentionally drawing attention to herself. “I think you’re going to have to turn off the lights yourself if it bothers you.”

Adora got up and went to the golden string with a metal handle next to the door that the guard had used when they entered. She grabbed it and looked back to the bed. She heard the faintest purr start up as she looked.

Catra instantly looked away, pretending to be distracted by some feather that had come out of the pillows.

Adora pretended like she didn’t hear the purr to be polite. She couldn’t express at the moment that she knew precisely what Catra was feeling. An excitement. Anticipation. If Adora could purr, she’d be rumbling like an engine.

There were no other cadets around, no curfew, no morning muster. There would be no alarm to interrupt their warm engagement in the morning. They could be soft, and sweet, and, yes, even weak with each other. There was no end of the world looming over them or strange, vague warnings of emotional entanglements. It was just them.

Catra slowly took off her mask and leaned over to lay it down on the floor by the bed. Neither of them knew if she would ever wear it again. That, and so many other things, were still left to be figured out in the aftermath of their exile.

Adora felt lightheaded as she realized the blank space in her mind about what exactly people were supposed to do when they were more than friends would be filled. She’d figure it out, and she had the chance now to figure it out with Catra.

As if she was thinking the same thing, Catra’s purr grew to a rumble. She blushed as her tail flicked back and forth.

Adora started to smile and pulled the string as the lights went off.

Chapter End Notes

> The next chapter is going to be an intimate moment that will earn that Mature rating. If that’s something you want, stay tuned for one more chapter. If not, then I'm so happy to be able to share this story with you! It was fun to write. I hope you had fun too.
>
> For those of you who are interested in the next chapter, I might need some extra time.

A Gift

The lights went out, and Bright Moon lived up to its name as light blue moonlight streamed in from outside.

Catra watched Adora stare at her with a look in her eye that reminded her of the first time they learned how to do full contact sparring. There was an eagerness there that comes from knowing she was leveling up and ready for the challenge.

Adora was always ready for the challenge.

Catra was happy to finally be the challenge.

Catra wanted to be the confident one. She wanted to show Adora how much she knew, even if technically she never had the chance to practice on anyone but herself. But, all noble intentions aside, under that look, Catra melted. A lifetime of being hurt, pushed aside, and told that her feelings didn't matter, and Catra had no defense at the sight of the object of her affection looking at her like she was the next achievement. The next course to race. The next opponent to defeat. Well, Adora was too late. Catra was already defeated, already conquered. Her purr displayed that enough for both of them.

Adora had that same eager confident smile as she moved toward the bed.

Catra sat up on her knees to meet Adora as she came in.

Adora took Catra in her arms, and this time, when their lips met, it was soft. None of the urgency like before. Both of them were awake. Both of them knew it was coming. They could finally enjoy it.

Catra moaned against Adora's lips, and Adora froze.

Feeling Adora go stiff, Catra asked, "You ok?"

Adora grunted, then recovered. “Sorry- I just- the noise you made was- um-”

Catra leaned back in. “You’re overthinking, Princess.” She pulled Adora back in to taste more of her.

Pet names, or terms of endearment, were forbidden among their little squad. The fact that it was taboo only made it that much more potent. The power of saying it hit Catra in the traumatized part of her brain and soaked it in dopamine.

Hearing it did the same to Adora, or at least Catra hoped it did because she whimpered against Catra’s lips.

Catra decided she would have to develop a stable of pet names and terms of endearment to try. All the ones she had ever heard whispered in the halls. All the new ones she would learn in the coming weeks. She’d use every single one of them and see what made Adora crumble.

But tonight, Catra took it slow. It was just a start at removing the first few bricks off the walls each of them had built around themselves. Catra didn’t know how far they would get, but it didn’t matter. They had time to figure it out.

Catra started with touch to reprogram their brains to accept contact that wasn’t grips, strikes, or roughhouse play. As they kissed, she put her hands on Adora’s face.

Adora let it happen and kept kissing.

Catra moved her hands to Adora’s shoulders and put her lips to Adora’s jaw.

Adora leaned her head back to allow it and let out a long slow breath.

Catra started to kiss down Adora’s neck, and she was stopped by the edge of Adora’s shirt.

Adora shuddered.

Catra kissed at the nape of Adora’s neck, over the shirt, but she desperately wanted to kiss skin- to feel its warmth.

Adora cleared her throat. “Do you- want me to- uh- take it off?” Adora’s voice shook.

The tremble in Adora’s tone only made Catra feel a quiver in her core. She nodded.

Adora dove right into the task like it was the purpose of her existence. She stepped back enough to get some room, grabbed the bottom of her shirt, and ripped it off so fast that it got tangled in her ponytail. Adora struggled to get the damn thing off, and Catra watched with growing amusement. The shirt came off along with Adora’s hair band, and she was left hair down, shirtless, but still with her undergarment on.

Adora wore a binding that held everything down. It was all part of Shadow Weaver’s plan to turn Adora into the perfect fighting machine. Extraneous budding lumps didn’t fit into her image. It was a symbol of Shadow Weaver’s underlying control and invasive authority. Catra flexed her claws. “It looks uncomfortable.”

Adora didn’t say anything, but the worry on her face spoke volumes.

“Do you want to wear it?”

Adora’s brow furrowed deeper.

“She’s not around anymore, and it looks uncomfortable. You don't have to wear it.”

Adora shrank, all confidence gone. “I don’t know...”

Catra took a breath in and tried to calm herself. Maybe asking Adora to give up on something she had accepted as part of herself was too much for one night. The Fright Zone wasn’t built

in a day. It would have to be enough that Adora knew it was ok to take it off- that the offer was on the table. "I'm not going to force you to do anything. You can wear whatever you want."

Adora flinched at the word *want.*

The change would take time. Maybe talk was the wrong way to go. Adora was always more comfortable in action. Catra decided to show her it was ok. She motioned for Adora to come back into her arms.

Adora moved in, gaining some of that confidence back as she put herself back into Catra's hands and closed her eyes.

Catra retraced her steps. Hands on Adora's face, then shoulders. Kissing her jaw, back down her neck, and now reaching the bare skin of Adora's collarbone. Her hands moved to Adora's waist. She soaked in the warmth of bare skin on her fingertips and the heat growing at the skin under her mouth.

Adora leaned her head back to let it all happen the way she had when Catra was younger and hadn't yet been disciplined out of marking behavior. Adora was always willing to satiate Catra's instincts.

A plume of red started to grow from Adora's chest, above her binding outward. Catra placed a kiss at its epicenter, right on the crest of Adora's sternum.

Adora's breathing went ragged.

"You ok?" Catra asked in barely a whisper.

"Oh, fuck yes," Adora blurted out.

Catra smiled and licked Adora's skin. She was tangy and salty, mixed with a musk all her own.

Adora groaned loudly as she closed her eyes and muttered something.

“I didn’t hear you?” Catra said before she licked her again.

“Oh fuck- I-” Adora had a nervous energy about her. “I don’t know how long I can-”

Catra pressed gently, “What, Princess?”

Adora twitched at the effort. “I want... I want to...” She stalled out.

Catra stopped her with a kiss to the lips. Her hands went back to Adora’s jaw. This, she hoped, let Adora have her brain back for a moment. She pulled away from the kiss and looked Adora in the eye. “You want to touch me?”

Adora nodded, relieved.

Catra’s whole body went warm. She started leaning back, pulling Adora by the jaw along with her.

Adora followed, obedient, until they were laying on the bed with Catra on her back and Adora on her hands and knees above her.

Catra rubbed herself into the blanket, into the plush fabric of the bed, and smiled wide. “Touch me however you want, please.”

It must have been the word please, because something changed in Adora’s body language. She relaxed a little and leaned in. She mimicked Catra’s actions, kissing her on the jaw.

Catra rumbled with pleasure.

Adora trailed her kisses down Catra’s neck to the collar of Catra’s uniform, and then she waited.

Catra hooked a claw into the hidden zipper of her uniform, and opened her eyes to see how Adora would respond to the quiet offer.

Adora said nothing but sat back with eyes wide and unblinking.

Catra maintained eye contact as she pulled. A few quick motions and it was off, and she was back on her back.

Adora's look changed as she took in the sight. Anticipation had melted. Her eyes went half-lidded. The flush on her chest deepened and spread. "You're beautiful," Adora breathed as she leaned in.

Catra wasn't expecting to be called beautiful. It was such a simple thing, and yet there she was about to cry over it. She fought to keep her composure as Adora's lips touched her, then she licked her.

That simple touch sparked something in Catra. The warmth she felt before was starting to turn to heat.

Adora kept kissing and licking until she reached Catra's Horde-issued bra. She paused, hovering over the fabric, her lips so close to Catra's nipple that she could feel hot breath through the fabric.

Catra licked her lips and reached for the bottom band. A tilt of the head, a raised eyebrow, all to offer one more layer of intimacy.

Adora's eyes turned into dark pools as she nodded slowly.

Catra pulled off her bra.

It was one thing to change clothes in front of bunkmates as fast as you could. It was a completely different thing taking off clothes slowly so that the other one could look at you. Catra wasn't expecting her heart to beat in her ears- for her pulse to show up between her legs in a way it never did when she was pleasuring herself.

As the bra was tossed to the floor and she leaned back, it hit Catra harder than she expected. Her tits. Adora was staring at her tits, bare and on display. Her heartbeat kicked up a few notches, and so did the pulsing between her legs. *Fuck, I'm going to die.*

Adora dipped her head in without hesitation. She latched onto Catra's nipple, and suckled.

Catra moaned into the feeling. It was unlike anything she had felt before, a deep and primal pull. The motion grabbed something from her toes all the way to her chest. Of all things, it made her jaw tingle like somehow that little spot was connected to everything.

Adora's hands pulled around Catra's back, pulling her ever closer.

Years of lacking the simple comfort of touch had made both of them deep wells of desire to be needed- wanted. In this simple act, they both felt the pull of that need finally release.

Catra was out of her depth. It wasn't like the older Horde kids talked about gently sucking on nipples in the locker room. No, that talk was all about fucking, sitting on faces, sticking things in other things, and getting off. All that talk was aggressive- demanding, selfish- and this felt like something completely different. Was this... making love?

She hadn't been lying to Scorpia when she said it would be easier to ask to fuck. It would be like asking to eat or asking to bathe. It was a need. Needs were easy. But at that moment, she understood why Scorpia was horrified. Sex could be about more than just getting off. It could be making someone you love feel good. Letting them explore. Maybe it affected you more than you thought it would because of who they were and how you felt about them. Catra was, for the moment, stunned at this revelation.

Adora shifted her weight to make everything easier, which resulted in a knee going between Catra's legs.

That pulled Catra out of her epiphany and back to the idea of getting off. "Adora-" The word came out whiny.

Adora stopped suckling and looked up- mouth still attached.

Catra realized she must have looked pathetic, but she needed this. She needed this more than she needed food or oxygen. “I need to rub on your leg... ok?” Her voice squeaked at the last bit.

Adora looked dumbstruck.

“Is that a problem?”

Adora, still with a nipple in her mouth, tried to shake her head no.

Catra’s eye rolled back at the feeling, and she cursed the fact that Adora was accidentally good at sex, or at least Catra was so pent up that it didn’t matter. She started rocking her hips against Adora’s thigh, moaning as her body finally found what it was craving.

Catra was halfway gone and halfway there before she realized she should be giving as well as receiving. It was the only polite thing to do. She raised her leg, the one on the inside of Adora’s, and elicited a deep guttural moan from Adora as it made contact.

Adora let Catra’s nipple fall out of her mouth. “Fuck- Catra- that’s- Uh-” She grunted. Her hips pushed forward for more friction- more contact- like the connection from her nub to her brain got lit up for the first time. It switched on a whole new set of feelings drenched in urgency.

It was that reaction that made Catra wonder if this awkward shirtless dry humping was going to be Adora’s first time and she would have the honor of providing it. She grabbed Adora’s hips, pulling them closer, getting a better angle for contact.

Adora’s eyes went wide for a moment as the feeling hit her. She rolled into it- happy to be guided into a better way to satisfy this new and sudden hunger.

Catra used one hand to grab Adora’s head and pull her back into a desperate kiss while using her flexibility to deepen the contact below.

Catra was on edge. If she stopped thinking for a moment- let go at all, it would all be over. She wanted to give that to Adora first- so she fought it. Tried to focus on something else. The moonlight. The feel of the fabric. Anything but thinking about what was going on and who it was with.

Adora had to break the kiss to breathe, and she paused the motion and looked down at Catra. “Is this- ok?” She whispered.

Catra knew inherently what was going on. Adora was overthinking it. Adora was falling into a shame spiral, thinking she wasn’t allowed to feel this good. Anything this good had to be wrong. Catra had one answer for that. One cure. “Please,” Catra begged. “Keep going.”

Those words were like a key to unlock the chains binding Adora’s brain. They gave her a command, and she was so good at following orders. She dove right back into the motion and groaned as she lost herself to it.

A moment later, Catra felt Adora tense up in a way she wasn’t expecting. It put all Adora’s well-trained muscles on full display- her arms, chest, and abs tightening as she grunted. She acted like she was holding in a breath before she let it out in a long slow moan that sounded like it was the first natural breath she had ever taken.

Catra watched in absolute awe as Adora finished the race. She was distracted long enough to forget she was trying to hold back, and the residual thrusts of Adora’s hips finally hit their mark. Catra was surprised by her own orgasm, and so she made noises she usually didn’t make- grunting and mewling, but she couldn’t stop it once it started. All that pressure- all that heat- finally broke over and spilled between them.

Adora slowly stopped thrusting, and with a smile, finally collapsed onto Catra in a puddle of sweat and heaving, her face landing between Catra’s breasts.

Catra was still trying to catch her own breath when Adora's full deadweight landed on her. She grabbed Adora to hold her where she landed as they both recovered.

They lay there for a long moment, catching their breath- riding the residual tides of the tsunami that had crashed into them.

After both their heaving settled, Adora tilted her head to the side and managed, "What was that?"

"Did it feel good?"

"Yeah. Good." Adora went back to trying to catch her breath.

"Take all the time you need. We have all night."

Adora paused for a moment. "What do you mean we have all night?"

Catra's smile went wild as she went from holding Adora to petting her. "We can do whatever we want."

Adora froze there for a moment, then slowly pushed herself up so they could look each other in the eyes.

Catra didn't stop smiling as Adora searched her over.

Adora's face was childlike in it's sudden interest and curiosity. Both things Catra wanted to encourage. "You want to... do that again? Maybe differently?"

Catra turned into another puddle of a mess as she looked at Adora's eager eyes.

She couldn't help but think pragmatically. She was tired. Adora was tired. They had been going off of little to no sleep for a few days now. They had a mission to do. They had lands to win back. A war to end. If they were going to be good little soldiers, they'd take what they had been given and go to sleep to get ready for the next day.

But...

Neither of them were playing the good little soldier anymore.

Catra licked her lips and nodded because some things were more important.

End Notes

Thank you all so much for reading! Have a wonderful day.

FYI, the related works below that are mine are mostly explicit, and deal with indulging in explicit what-ifs about different situations in the fic.

Works inspired by this one: What are friends for? by pencilxpaper, A Brush with Intimacy in the Horde by pencilxpaper, Kneading a Massage to Relax in the Horde by pencilxpaper

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!